# bite down (into me)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34625704.

**Rating:**
Explicit

**Archive Warning:**
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

**Fandom:**
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Catra & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Mara (She-Ra)

**Character:**
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Mara (She-Ra)

**Additional Tags:**
Vampire Catra (She-Ra), Magicat Catra (She-Ra), Werewolf Adora (She-Ra), Alternate Universe - Modern with Magic, semi-graphic depictions of pain, werewolf transformations are gnarly, Blood Drinking, Explicit Consent, idiots to lovers, Hurt/Comfort, Slow Burn, Happy Ending, Beta Read, A handful of other character appearances that aren't substantial enough to be tagged, Eventual Smut, (and lots of it)

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English

**Series:**
Part 1 of bite down (into me)

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Iorek's Catradora Unputdownables

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by sunstardust_

Summary

"Okay. Then tell me what you do remember."

Adora wraps her arms around herself, hugging her elbows, and winces. "I remember changing...It hurt. Worse than this," she nods her chin towards the ripped carpet. "And I wanted it to stop...I just wanted it to *stop*. And I knew there was something that could do that. I didn't know where it was but I knew it would help, so I went looking for it."

Catra waits for her to continue, but she doesn't.

"And?"

"And then I found you," Adora says tightly. Her voice is deeper, calmer than before. She almost sounds a little angry. "And I felt better."

-

When Catra receives a call from her sister Glimmer asking her to help catch a runaway werewolf during the full moon, she's expecting it to be a one night deal. But when the next full moon rolls around and the wolf comes looking for her, she realizes she may have attracted a stray.

# Bad Moon Rising

Chapter Summary

Catra begrudgingly joins a search party and gets more than she bargained for. Adora Goes Through It.

CW: this chapter begins with a description of intense pain

Chapter Notes

~~Please note this fic is rated M, and may increase in rating later on (for fun spicy reasons).~~ This fic *has* increased in rating for fun spicy reasons, and is now rated E for eventual explicit sexual content. Each chapter that contains sexual content will have a warning at the top.

The werewolf changes in this story are *not* simple or pretty, and as such this fic will contain varying degrees of graphic descriptions of pain and physical transformations. Catra is also a vampire, so there will be descriptions of blood down the line, but nothing excessive or gorey. I will include CWs for each chapter and it will be pretty obvious when these things are coming, but if you'd like more detail or in-fic markers for any of these or anything else, just let me know in the comments.

All of that said, this will not be a heavy or angsty fic. This story is still just about two lesbians in love whose biggest obstacle to being together is that they're giant fucking idiots.

POV changes will be denoted by *, while the passage of time is denoted by ---.

The playlist for the fic can be found here!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Pain rips through her body and everything else ceases to exist. She is on fire, burning alive, and there is nothing but the flames and their smoke. She chokes on it, her lungs made of ash and her body heaving for air that doesn't exist. The roar of the fire fills her ears, every crack of the flames a ricocheting explosion through her body. She can't feel her limbs anymore, can't feel the ground underneath her ~~ca~~n't feel anything at all. Only pain, and the ***fe***, and the ***fe***. The fear that she is dying...and the fear that she isn't. The fear that this will go on forever;a raging wildfire that consumes the entire world in its wake and still refuses to yield. That refuses to be satisfied. That refuses to end.

But after an eternity, it lessens. It ***le***.

The pain turns into a throbbing, aching thing. Feeling returns to her limbs, but it isn't quite right. She asks them to move and they move wrong. She tries to find the ground, but the world is upside down. She tries to see, but she is still blanketed in smoke. She has found air, but every breath burns. Her body wants ash, not air. It wants fire. When everything was ***pa***it made sense. There was logic to it. Now everything is just ***wr***~~h~~er skin crawls and shadows move around her and she can't hear anything but this terrible rushing static sound that ***just won't stop.***

Is this the end of the world? Is this all that's left once it's gone?

Something touches her back and anguish rips through her body. Noises begin to penetrate the static ~~h~~orrible yelps and yowls and it's ***so*** much worse than the rushing. Than the roar. It is worse than anything she's ever heard.

She needs to get away from it. She cannot bear it, the screams rattling against the inside of her skull like a drill. Something touches her side and she wrenches away ~~s~~he pulls hard and then suddenly her arms are free. She didn't even know they were bound. The yowling is getting worse so she pulls with her legs, and then

they are free too. She realizes she can leave. She realizes that there is more than the fire and the scourge it left behind, and she can leave.

So she runs.

*

When Catra's phone rings, she considers that she might actually have a guardian angel after all.

The Black Eclipse is fairly empty tonight, all things considered, but the few customers they do have are a crowd of clan members and Catra is simply not in the mood. They haven't had a lot of humans in lately, she hasn't seen Scorpia in a week, and if Kyle and Lonnie are her only choices...she might as well not have choices at all. They're annoying on their best days and insufferable on their worst. She doesn't want to spend any more time with them than she has to, even if it means going hungry. She's *not* doing well, half of the clan already thinks they're superior to her for feeding in public (as public as this bar is, anyway), and if she has to deliver one more Bloody Mary to them while they laugh along with the human they dragged in…

Well, whatever happens, it certainly won't be pretty. It would *definitely* get her fired. So when her phone rings, she grabs it like the saving grace that it is.

Except it's not an angel calling her – it's just Glimmer.

She answers the phone with a frown. "You know you're not supposed to call me at work," she says, her tone clipped.

Glimmer makes a noise of offense, and Catra knows she's rolling her eyes. "*Yeah*, so I wouldn't be calling you unless it was an *emergency*," she snaps.

Catra suppresses a groan and sighs. She really doesn't have the energy to put out whatever fire Glimmer's started, but her sister has been pretty respectful of her *break* policy before now. "It's busy tonight and there are a bunch of assholes," she supplies in lieu of an apology and takes a deep breath. "Are you okay?"

"Yeah, I'm fine," Glimmer answers, her voice softer.

"Is Angella okay?" Catra asks.

"Yeah, she's fine too."

Catra's irritation returns. "So why are you calling?

Glimmer sighs, and Catra knows that means she's not gonna like her answer. "We need your help," she says.

Yup. She already hates it. "Who's *we*?"

"Me and the Grayskull Pack"—

"The wolves?" Catra starts, her face contorting. "Why are you calling me about the wolves?"

"Well if you'd let me speak for longer than *two seconds*," Glimmer bites, "I'd tell you!"

Catra pulls the phone away from her ear and clenches her jaw shut, chewing on her irritation. She resists the urge to say that Glimmer had plenty of time to tell her as soon as she picked up the phone, knowing that admonishing her would do absolutely nothing but draw this out further. Plus, she could feel her annoyance from the night spilling over—she wasn't being fair to her.

"Sorry ," she manages to mutter . "Go ahead."

"Thank you," Glimmer says pleasantly , and Catra vows to strangle her the next time she sees her. "I just got a call from Mara – they had a couple of wolves that changed for the first time tonight and apparently one of them was *a lot* stronger than they expected. She broke out and we need your help to find her."

Catra blinks. "She *broke*?"

"Yeah. Mara said she ripped right through the chains and ran out the door."

Catra blows out a long breath. She's never seen the setup for herself, but it's common knowledge that the wolves restrain themselves during the full moon until they're old enough to be able to control it. They built a whole chamber for it a few decades back, and they've never had a problem with it during Catra's lifetime. They've certainly never had any runaways. "And none of the others could stop her? How fucking strong *is* she?"

Glimmer returns the sigh. "Very, I guess. Mara said they expected her to be more of a handful than usual but...nothing like this."

Catra nods slowly. "So now she's just what – running around the streets?"

"More or less, yeah."

"So you called *me*? To go and catch a stray werewolf?" Catra's voice raises in disbelief.

"They've only got a few wolves who can resist the moon well enough to join the search – everyone else is a liability ," Glimmer says. "And you've got a better nose than all of them combined anyway, so..."

Catra's eyes narrow – flattery was never freely offered by Glimmer. She glances over to the back of the lounge, where the open floor

plan split off into curtained rooms and she could still hear the bloodsucking patrons laughing. "Why don't you call the clan?"

"Because you're nicer than they are?" Glimmer asks sweetly, and Catra rolls her eyes.

"Because they'd want you to pay them and you think I'll work for free," she supplies, turning around to rest her hips against the bartop.

"Because you're my sister and you love me?" Glimmer tries again.

Catra sighs, weighing the option of joining a manhunt for a fucking werewolf against working here for the rest of the night. "Is she dangerous?" she asks.

"What," Glimmer scoffs, "are you scared?"

Catra glares at the wall behind the bar. "I'm just wondering if I'm going to have to pull her off of a dead body or something."

Glimmer gasps, and Catra wonders if she even considered that this girl could hurt someone. "Oh my god, no, Mara doesn't think she's a danger to anyone but herself. She's just scared, and she doesn't know what's going on. She can't process it yet. But she doesn't want to hurt anyone—"

"People hurt each other all the time without meaning to," Catra says.

There's silence for a moment, and then the connection crackles as Glimmer sighs. "Then I guess we better find her before something happens," she says.

Catra sucks her teeth for a moment. "So, I'm looking for a bear-sized wolf with her tail between her legs?"

Glimmer perks up. "Mara said she's pretty big and like a golden-blonde color...she should smell pretty powerful since it's her first

change. Her name is Adora, and she should still recognize it...Does this mean you're helping us?"

Catra's mouth twists – she hadn't smelled many wolves on their first change, but she'd caught the scent lingering on them around town in the weeks after. It wasn't a bad smell, all of that power, but it was *definitely* strong. She was better equipped than them to hunt it down, too. As much as she hated to admit it, they were right to ask her for help. "Sure, yeah, whatever," she says. "Anything to get me out of here. You owe me, though."

"Yeah, yeah," Glimmer brushes her off.

"What should I do when I find her?" Catra asks, pushing off the bar and looking around for Bonnie.

"Give me a call, I'm gonna head out to help too. Once we know where she is, I can call Mara to come get her."

"Okay," Catra says.

"And Catra?" Glimmer asks, and her tone stops Catra.

"Yeah?"

"Be nice to her," Glimmer says softly. "She doesn't understand what's going on – she's just scared. She needs a friend."

Catra holds her tongue from reminding Glimmer that they were talking about a one hundred and fifty pound *wolf*, strong enough to break out of restraints made *specifically* for this reason, that nobody has ever broken out of before, and instead says, "I'm not gonna be an asshole, Glimmer. Thanks for the vote of confidence."

Glimmer ignores her. "I'll call you if we find her first."

Catra hangs up, and sighs.

---

She gets out of the bar with no issue. Netossa isn't working and Bonnie doesn't have any authority to stop her when she calls out that she's leaving to deal with an emergency and strides right out the door. It's not like she'd be in trouble even if her boss was working; she's pretty sure keeping the humans in the town safe from a rampaging werewolf was more important than mixing blood cocktails for rich leeches that brought their own lunch anyway.

The pack's commune is out at the east edge of town by the forest, about halfway across town from the bar. It's likely the other wolves are following her trail from there, so there's no need for Catra to go that way. Glimmer likely set out from the estate near the town center, so she'll have that covered. Catra heads to the west side of town; with no idea how far the wolf could have gotten, she should check everywhere she can.

The area near the bar smells as usual: liquor and humans and blood and wine - the scent of other vampires mixing with the living. No hints of wolf or magic, so Catra darts forward and dashes to the next street over.

It took a long time for her to learn how to dash ~~as~~ a hybrid some vampiric abilities came easy to her and others were more difficult. There were some that simply never came at all. The full vampires could dash easier and go farther, but she only needed it for the convenience of it, not the hunt, so she worked on it until she could use it to travel a little quicker.

Catra inhales deeply, sorting through the street's smells for any hint of wood or smoke or power or fear. The scent of the wolf would carry better on the breeze, but the girl's emotions and magic would radiate out farther all on their own. But still, there's nothing.

Catra goes deeper into the west side of town, dashing past her apartment and away from the other homes. She's almost reached the diner when she finally smells the wolf.

A rolling, rippling wave of pure power washes over her ~~–so~~ strong that it feels like the air is *h* . She smells the change like wet earth: raw and distinct and sharp. There's only a hint of fear embroiled in it, far less than she expected. She can smell curiosity and confusion adding weight to the air, and as she follows it, she smells the wolf herself.

She smells like petrichor and clay and ash: sweet and smoky and damp. It tickles the back of Catra's mind, tugging at something it just can't reach. She follows it for three blocks, the scent becoming so strong her head swims, before she finally sees her.

A massive, golden-white wolf is loping down the street away from her, sniffing the pavement and bushes outside of the businesses and following some sort of trail. For a minute Catra just stands and stares ~~–sh~~e's only seen one changed werewolf in her life, and she doesn't remember her being this *b* , or smelling this strongly. But the power smells familiar, somehow, like a tune she finds herself humming without realizing she knows it. A story she finds herself finishing, without even knowing how it began.

She strides forward, trying to catch up without flat out running or dashing to her. It smells like the wolf's calm for now, but she's heading back towards the residential district and the last thing they need is her stumbling upon some poor human out for a late night stroll.

Catra opens her mouth to gently call out, but the wolf stops dead before she can make a sound.

The wolf turns on her suddenly , her ears perking and her hackles raising. She stares Catra down with eyes that are far too bright and intense for the darkness they're shrouded in, and Catra doesn't like the feeling growing inside of her.

She raises her hands slowly, hoping the human inside of the wolf will recognize the gesture as one of peace. "Hey , Adora?" she says softly, and waits for a reaction.

Adora blinks at her, and she doesn't step forward but she also doesn't run.

Catra takes it as a vote of confidence, and eases forward. "Hey ...I'm here to help, okay?"

Adora's ear twitches to the sound of her voice, and Catra tries a smile. She knows the werewolves don't process thought and logic the same when they're wolves as they do when they're human, at least not until they get a handle on their transformations, so she has absolutely no idea how much human language Adora can even understand right now. But she isn't running, so Catra keeps talking.

"I'm a friend, a friend of Mara' s...I'm just here to help. I'm gonna help you, Adora, okay? I'm gonna help. Y ou just gotta let me."

Adora tilts her head, and Catra stops. They're only two yards away from each other now, and she could probably jump on Adora if she ran, but she certainly wouldn't be able to restrain her. Not if the pack's chains couldn't do it. She's running through better alternatives when Adora takes a step forward.

And then another.

And then Adora is walking towards her and Catra doesn't know what to do – this is what she wanted, but not what she'd expected.

"Y eah, hi," she says to fill the silence and let Adora know she was making the right choice. "I'm gonna help you. Okay , Adora?"

Adora's tail gives a short, quick wag, and Catra blinks. Did she just imagine that? But Adora is watching her , waiting on her, and whatever it was that she said...it worked.

But Catra's not sure just how long that will last. Even if she calls Glimmer now, it would take time for her to call Mara and for them all to arrive. If something spooks her and she takes off again they'll have to do this all over again, and if she got this far the first time they might lose her completely a second time.

They need to get somewhere safe.

With a sinking wave of frustration, Catra realizes where they have to go.

She leans down just a little, feeling a bit like the world's most awkward babysitter, and plasters a smile onto her face. "You understand me, right? At least a little bit? You seem to know your name and the word *help*, right? Okay. Great. I need you to follow me. And then I can help you. But you have to follow me."

Adora blinks at her.

Catra sighs. "Okay, sure, let's hope you got that then. Come on."

She straightens up and takes a few steps backwards, watching Adora closely. As soon as she steps backward Adora moves forward, following after her with her full attention. Catra takes a few more steps and Adora continues after her, so Catra nods and turns back around.

Adora immediately catches up to her, trotting forward until they're walking together and looking back up at her for direction.

"Good ~~uh~~" Catra starts before she can stop herself, cutting off as she realizes Adora might understand more than she's giving her credit for and finishing that sentence could be embarrassing for both of them. This would be a hell of a lot easier if she could talk back to her, but if she could do *that* then they probably wouldn't be in this mess in the first place. "Yeah...good," she finishes lamely.

Adora's unfazed by her awkward behavior, continuing to follow her with no issue all the way until they reach Catra's apartment complex. She doesn't quite understand how a werewolf so terrified from the change could be so calm now, but even her confusion has subsided, at least in scent, since they've been together.

Maybe she really does just need a friend.

The complex is quiet when they get to it, and Catra motions to Adora to keep it down and stay close before she starts up the stairs to the second floor. She makes it halfway up before she realizes Adora isn't following her anymore.

She turns around to find her at the bottom of the stairs, sniffing every inch of the first step.

"Come on, let's go," Catra whispers, waving a hand at her.

Adora looks up and then back to the step, and then back at her.

"What?" Catra descends a couple steps quickly, looking the bottom stair over. It held her weight just fine and there wasn't anything obstructing it—what was the issue?

Adora's attention flickers between them a few more times, and then she lets out a quiet whine.

"Are you *kidding* me—" Catra mutters, jumping down the rest of the steps and shaking her head. Her tail lashes with annoyance. "Do you not know how to walk up the fucking stairs?" she stage-whispers. They need to get inside before one of her neighbors comes out and Adora decides she's hungry.

Adora whines at her, shifting around on her feet, and Catra is seconds from tearing her own hair out. She caught the damn runaway werewolf only to find out she doesn't even know how to walk up a fucking staircase. Catra takes a deep breath, and then steps onto the first step. "Look. Look, you just step onto it. Okay?

You just step. One foot in front of the other. You have four, so that should make this really easy."

Adora creeps forward, sniffing the stair and Catra's bar shoes and then very gingerly resting the corner of her front paw on the step.

"Yes! Good, great, now *come*!" Catra growls.

Adora whines and backs up, eyeing the staircase suspiciously.

"Don't you dare make me push you," Catra warns, following her retreat and pointing back to the stairs. "Go up them! Now!"

Adora takes a step back towards the stairs, and Catra steps behind her to cut off her exit.

"Go! Up!" she orders, crowding in behind Adora and hissing.

Adora yelps in surprise, jumping up the stairs and scrambling halfway up them before she realizes what's happening. For a second she pauses and looks down at the staircase under her paws, and then her big furry tail wags and she races up the rest of them to the landing. Catra's hurrying to catch up to her when she turns around and, furry chest puffed out, lets out a loud bark.

Catra's going to scream.

"*Shh!*" She hisses, waving Adora out of her way and towards her apartment door. Adora follows her and stays quiet, and Catra lets out a small breath of relief that at least she seemed to understand those words. She unlocks her front door and ushers the gigantic wolf through it, and then locks every lock on her door once it's closed. Werewolves can't undo locks as wolves...right?

Catra sighs, running her claws through her long hair and telling herself to *breathe*. She's cranky because she's hungry, and this isn't as bad of a situation as she feels like it is. The wolf is safe, the town is safe, and now that they're home she can call Glimmer to come and

pick her up so she isn't babysitting all night. And she can probably just stay home afterwards—it's not like anyone would know or care that the emergency was over before her shift at the bar was.

She takes a deep breath, the reassuring smell of home just barely detectable underneath the overwhelming scent of Adora that's still consuming her senses. At least the girl's alive, so she can feed off of her until Glimmer arrives.

Catra digs her phone out of her pocket as something crashes in the distance, and she spins around to see that Adora is nowhere in sight. "Fucking *dog*," she spits and dashes to the bedroom, stopping beside the closet to see Adora half inside of it with her nose buried in a box of clothing.

*Hey!* Catra growls and Adora jumps back, looking up in alarm. "Out!" She commands, pointing at the door, and with no protest but a dejected whine Adora retreats to the living room.

Kicking her belongings back into the closet to deal with later, Catra slams the door and then strides out of her bedroom and slams that door closed as well. Adora's off sniffing around a lamp in the opposite corner, but just for good measure Catra closes the bathroom door too.

The phone only rings once before Glimmer answers. "Did you find her?"

"Yeah," Catra replies, watching Adora carefully as she sniffs the carpet.

"Holy shit," Glimmer breathes, and Catra hears her call to someone in the distance. "Where are you?"

"I got her to follow me to my apartment."

Glimmer pauses. "...You let her inside your apartment?"

Catra frowns at her tone. "Isn't that what I just said?"

"Yeah, but you barely even let *me* inside your apartment."

"Because you spilled wine all over the carpet as *soon* as I moved in."

"Well I'm just saying it's *surprising*."

"*Hey*."

"What?"

"Are you guys gonna come and get her? I'm not a dogsitting service."

"Oh, yeah," Glimmer deflates. "I'm already on the way with Mara and a couple others. I can't teleport them all but I promise we'll be there soon. Hang tight and don't give her any wine."

Snorting, Catra hangs up the phone and drops it onto her kitchen counters. *Thanks*.

She leans around the kitchen island to see Adora sniffing the couch, snout buried under one of the cushions. "*Hey*," she calls out, and Adora immediately snaps to attention. She stares at her for a moment and then, seeming to realize she's not in trouble, trots over to sit in front of her.

Catra blinks, unsettled by the easy obedience. She's never spent much time around dogs, but she thinks they should be a little more unruly than this. Even if there's a person inside...this is still her first change. Her trust shouldn't be so easily won, especially by a vampire hybrid.

"Uh," Catra clears her throat. "Your people are gonna come get you soon. We're gonna wait for them here."

Adora continues to sit and stare up at her, offering no sign of recognition *or* confusion.

*Fine.* Catra dismisses her, crossing the small apartment and dropping onto the couch. It would be at least a few minutes before they got here, depending how they were travelling. Catra has barely a moment to wonder if the other wolves are *also* wolves right now, or if they'll show up as humans, before Adora follows her and plants herself right in front of her on the ground.

A long moment of silence ensues as they stare each other down, and then Catra quirks a dark brow. Adora...*pouts?* and drops her head forward to rest on the edge of Catra's knee.

"What do you want?" Catra exclaims, shooing Adora's big head off of her leg, but Adora chases her hand and butts her head into her palm.

Catra blinks.

Adora blinks.

Catra narrows her mismatched eyes. "Are you asking me to *pet you* right now?"

Adora lets out a small, pathetic whimper and nuzzles against Catra's palm.

"You know that you're a *person*, right? Like, a full on human being?" Catra asks, pulling her hand back and staring. And if she gives Adora a gentle tap on the head as she pulls back, it is *not* a pet.

Adora just stares at her, and Catra doesn't know if she doesn't understand her or if she doesn't remember that she's a person, or if she understands it all and just doesn't have the means to say so.

"Whatever , just lay down or something, okay? They'll be here any second." *Bow* , she thinks hard, but no one arrives at the door.

Rather, Adora suddenly stands and leaps onto the couch. Her giant body shoves Catra into the side of it and without thinking she shoves back, pushing Adora's giant fluffy butt away as hard as she can. Instead of falling off as she intended, Adora simply stumbles and spins around, wagging her tail and shoving her muzzle against Catra's cheek.

"DID YOU JUST LICK ME?" Catra shrieks, jumping off the couch and wiping furiously at her wet face. "OFF , NOW!" she roars, pointing at the floor, and Adora immediately scampers down and cowers.

"Are you *fucking*" Catra wipes her sleeve over her face for good measure and stares down at the giant fucking werewolf that just licked her .

Adora whines loudly, tail between her legs, and then they both spin to a noise just outside the door .

"Oh, *fuck*," Catra growls and stomps over to undo the locks and wrench the door open.

Glimmer's in the front of the group, and just over her shoulder is a tall and *very* strong woman with a long brown braid — Mara. She' s only seen her a few times since she grew up and has still never formally met the woman, but she works closely with Angella, and Catra and Glimmer had seen her around the estate a million times as children. Even if they hadn't — everyone knew who she was, her reputation preceded her.

She-Ra herself;the leader of the Grayskull Pack.

Catra can't see much over Mara's tall shoulders, but it looks like she brought two more wolves with her, both big and strong and clad in the stupid matching jackets everyone in the pack wears. Mara' s was

red while the others were black, probably to make her easier to find. Guess they were showing up as humans, then.

"About damn time," Catra swears and steps back to let them inside. She gets a whiff of each wolf as they pass her, and they all smell like burning wood and dirt and power, but it is nothing compared to Adora's scent. They smell muted in comparison...lesser, somehow. More foreign. Perhaps it's because they're not changed, or perhaps Adora really is that much stronger than the rest of them.

One of them shuts the door, and suddenly the energy inside shifts.

The air feels electric again, rolling with the raw power Catra had first felt when she found Adora, and the sharp smell of anxiety and fear are filling the place.

Catra steps around the other werewolves to see Mara standing in front of Adora as Adora stares back at her rigidly. For a moment they size each other up, and then Mara glances behind her.

"How was she when you found her?"

Catra shrugs, wrapping her arms across her chest. "Fine? Seemed a little spooked but she was just wandering around sniffing stuff."

Mara nods. "Was she scared of you when you approached?"

"Not really." Catra recalls the easy way Adora had listened and followed her. "No."

Mara frowns, her eyes flickering towards the other werewolves, and then turning back to Adora. She kneels carefully and starts murmuring, so low that even Catra's ears couldn't pick it up. The air starts to calm.

Something knocks against Catra's shoulder, and she turns to see Glimmer looking up at her. "She wasn't scared of you?" she whispers.

Catra shrugs, glancing towards the other women, but they aren't paying them any mind. "No," she says lowly. "Why?"

Glimmer sizes her up curiously. "They made it sound like she was scared out of her mind...I didn't really expect her to like you."

"I didn't say she liked me," Catra snaps, pointedly trying to forget the affection Adora had shown since she'd brought her home.

"Just weird is all," Glimmer shrugs and sweeps her cape behind her shoulders.

Catra shrugs back. "Yeah. It is. You alright?"

Glimmer raises a thick purple eyebrow at her.

"You didn't teleport here," Catra offers.

"Oh, yeah," Glimmer rolls her eyes and nods towards the wolves. "Just tired after popping around town—I checked the whole area around the estate and covered half of the north side before I ran into Mara and started following them. We thought we found Adora for a minute, but it was a false alarm. I have about enough juice for one big tag-along before I'm too tired, so Mara told me to save it to get them all back to the commune from here."

"You gonna be okay to get home?"

"What, do you wanna chaperone me, Mom?" Glimmer snorts.

Catra snorts back. "Fuck no, I just don't want her calling me to complain when you don't make it home safe."

Glimmer laughs, "I'll be fine. Thanks for the concern."

In front of them, Mara stands and waves to Glimmer. "We're ready to go if you are."

Glimmer moves to join her and so do the other women, and Catra stays where she is. They reach for each other's hands and from between Mara's legs Catra catches Adora peeking out. She sees her and immediately starts whining, and the anxiety in the air rises immediately.

Adora looks back at the people surrounding her and then to Catra, and she lets out a strangled bark like she's in pain. Something in Catra's gut drops, and a horrible feeling fills her up. It tastes like dread.

Mara stops, turning to look at Catra with a look she can't decipher. Adora sticks her head out from the circle, letting out another noise of distress and stretching her neck out like she's reaching for her.

Catra crosses her arms tighter, and plasters a smile over her face. "It's fine," she says to Adora, unsure why the words feel like a lie. "Go on."

Adora doesn't move again, but she doesn't look away from her either. Her eyes are bright, too bright, and Catra can't look away from them. She sees Mara lean down in her periphery and grab a handful of Adora's scruff, and then Glimmer grabs them both. The others grab Glimmer and with a soft pop, they're gone.

Catra closes her eyes and two blue spots flash under her eyelids, impressions of Adora that refuse to fade. She takes a deep breath and it still smells like her, and Catra has the distinct feeling that she's made a grave mistake.

---

Catra's in a bad mood.

Again.

She'd woken up with the ghost of Adora still haunting her apartment ~~her~~ smell lingering in every room and her bright eyes making an appearance in every single one of the dreams she'd managed to have. The long panicked whine she'd verbalized when she realized Catra wasn't going with her echoes through her mind every time she has a moment of silence, and she's fucking sick of it. To make matters even worse, she'd actually woken up feeling well fed. She was barely with Adora for twenty minutes and it felt like they'd spent the whole day together. Felt like she'd had a full fucking meal.

Somehow, the satisfied feeling filling up her body only makes her mood worse.

She's grumbling as she wipes down the glassware at work when the front door opens and a gust of fresh air blows in, and her heart nearly stops.

The air is fresh, but it doesn't smell like the street.

It smells like rain and clay and charcoal, and the wet earth is sweet instead of sharp as it washes over her. She knows exactly who is stepping through that door before they ever cross the threshold, and she is utterly unprepared for any of it.

Seeing Adora again is not something she'd considered. It's not something she'd *let* herself consider. Crossing paths in town was always a possibility, but not a likely one. Certainly not without knowing they would, out in the open air where she'd smell her long before she saw her, and Catra lives on the opposite side of town from the pack anyway. She doesn't frequent the estate much anymore, so even if Mara brought wolves with her to any political meetings, running into each other there was unlikely. Now that they knew what they were dealing with and Adora would be able to process it, the full moons shouldn't be a problem again.

It's unlikely they'd see each other again without one or both of them intentionally orchestrating it, and why would they do that?

Except here's Adora, walking into her workplace ~~a~~ vampire bar the pack *the bar* avoids ~~a~~nd…

Oh, *fuck*.

For as much as Adora has haunted her since last night, she hasn't given much thought to what she would look like when she wasn't a freakishly large four-legged wolf.

That was definitely a mistake.

She's at least as tall as Mara and the other two were and she's easily as bulky as well, even though she's considerably younger. She's wearing one of their stupid varsity jackets too, except hers is red like Mara's, and for some insane reason Catra thinks that she might *be* be pulling it off. It emphasizes her wide shoulders and hangs open casually to show off a plain t-shirt and tight blue jeans. The bright red compliments the long golden hair that's spilling down her back, pulled up into a high ponytail to show off her strong jaw. Her jaw works to show off her cheekbones, which frame her dark eyebrows and warm blue eyes and *gah* ~~C~~atra knows that she's staring but she just can't *stop.*

Adora's eyes fall on her, and she brightens immediately. A gentle smile crawls across her face, her beautiful lips twisting sweetly, and for a moment, Catra almost returns it.

Her pained whine echoes through her ears again like a screaming ghost and Catra finally looks away, gripping the glass in her hand tightly. What was she doing here? And why was she smiling at her? And why was she *sorry?*

Adora moves towards her, and even if she couldn't smell it, she can *see* the nervous anticipation in the bounce of her step. "Catra?" she asks, and she has the voice of a fucking angel.

Of *course* she has the voice of a fucking angel.

Catra crosses her arms over her chest, but she can't stop the way her tongue caresses her name. "Hey , Adora."

Catra wonders if she imagines the way Adora's breath falters at her words.

"Y ou know you guys don't have to wear those stupid jackets, right? We can smell you a mile away," she snaps dryly to cover the way her own breathing is stuttering.

Adora smiles, slipping her hands into her pockets to pull the jacket close and show it off. "Maybe *you* can, but not everyone else can."

"T rust me," Catra starts, her eyes dragging over Adora' s thick frame. Not a single muscle was on display, but not even a human would be able to look at her and miss the pure, raw power lurking just underneath the surface. Catra wonders briefly just how strong Adora *is* – could she bench press a car? A building? "There' s no question that she could definitely bench press *a* , vampire strength and all. "They know what you are," she finishes lowly .

Adora chuckles awkwardly and sets her arms onto the edge of the bar. "Good to know ," she says.

Catra gestures to the wall of human liquor behind her . "Can I get you anything?"

"No thank you," Adora answers without even looking. "I'm not staying, I just wanted to talk to you. Glimmer said you work here."

"Oh, are you and Glimmer friends now?"

"No, no...maybe? I don't know . I ran into her on my apology tour and...she seemed nice."

Catra shrugs. "She is, sometimes."

Adora cracks a smile. "Glad I caught her on a good day , then."

Catra chuckles and crosses her arms again, waiting.

"Um, I wanted to say thank you...for helping me last night," Adora starts, her face twisting uncomfortably. She still looked ridiculously delicious despite it. "Y ou didn't have to, and I really appreciate that you did."

"Y eah," Catra says, resting a hip against the bar . "Do you often make a habit of *b* the people that try to help you?"

Without missing a beat, Adora answers: "Only the ones that take me home."

Catra can't fight the smirk that crawls up her lips, and the sight of it makes Adora realiz what she just said.

"Um, I'm sorry , uh," she chuckles softly and blushes as her eyes drop. Catra can smell the spike of anxiety in the air. "Th at' s not what I'm here for. I'mu.h, I'm here to apologiz, too. For last night. And, uh, apparently tonight as well," she winces.

Catra can't deny her a small smile. "Nothing to apologiz for tonight, but I will *h* take an apology for last night. You're a lot more trouble than you look like."

Adora tries to smile, but it doesn't qite reach her eyes. "Y eah. I'm *s* sorry you had to deal with me...like that. I hope I didn't do anything irreparable, and if there's anything I can do to "—

"How much do you remember?" Catra cuts her of f.

"Uh...some?" Adora says like it' s a qestion and chews on her lip. "Th e memories don't feel qite the same yet, so it' s mostly sensory memory, and some emotion. I remember that you found me...and I think we went to your home because everything smelled like you? But it's hard to sort out the small details."

"So you *do* remember licking me?" Catra asks, quirking an eyebrow.

"No." Adora winces. "...But I'm not surprised I did. Again, I'm *so* sorry."

It's only by reminding herself how full she'd felt after last night that Catra manages to hold her tongue from propositioning Adora. This girl was trouble, no matter how hot she was and no matter how many places Catra would like to offer up for her to lick now that she has hands instead of paws. No one should feed Catra that much, that quickly. No one should have that much life inside of them. It wasn't natural. It wasn't normal. It was bad news.

So instead, she dampens the heat inside of herself and shrugs. "It's fine. Just chain yourself up better next month, yeah? The next person that finds you might not be so forgiving."

Adora's expression hardens, and she nods. "Yeah. It's not gonna happen again, I promise."

Catra's lips twist. "I don't need your promises," she says before she can stop herself.

Adora jerks back like Catra slapped her, and then pushes herself away from the bar entirely. "Got it," she says quietly. "Thanks again."

She turns and walks back to the entrance without waiting for a response, and even as Catra hears someone walk up behind her she can't look away. She has that feeling in her gut again, like she's done something wrong. Fucked something up, made some big mistake. Ruined everything. It sits in her stomach like a lead ball and it makes it hard to swallow.

Arriving beside her, Netossa leans over the counter and looks at the door as it swings shut. "What the hell did that wolf want?" she asks, shooting a glance at Catra. If she hadn't heard it, Catra certainly wasn't going to be the one to fill her in.

She shrugs, ripping her gaze away from the exit and down to the glasses she's supposed to be cleaning.

"Nothing," she says easily. "Just a lost dog."

Chapter End Notes

If this story was a TV show, it would start with a gnarly dramatic scene of Adora transforming for the first time and escaping, and then as she started running wild through the streets Bad Moon Rising by Creedence Clearwater Revival would start playing in irony and the title sequence would begin. :)

For anyone who played TLOU2, Adora has the approximate muscle mass of Abby. You're welcome.

As always, leave me some kudos and a comment if you enjoyed! The next chapter will come before Halloween, but the rest of the chapters may take a while. If that bothers you, feel free to stop reading and just wait for it to be finished in a few months. The updates will come when I have the time and no sooner.

Again, the playlist for the fic can be found here! It will be updated as the fic goes to avoid too many spoilers hehe :)

<3

# It Will Come Back

Chapter Summary

> History repeats itself, and Catra does what she thinks is best. Adora Goes Through It...again.

> CW: this chapter begins with a description of intense pain, and later on features a graphic depiction of a werewolf transformation.

Chapter Notes

> Title is from [It Will Come Back by Hozier](#).

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The pain starts like a fire, a tiny spark to gentle kindling that burns sweet and warm in her chest all day long. And then the sun sets and darkness falls and the moon rises, and that beautiful ache turns to biting pain, snapping at everything it can reach and devouring her from the inside out. It feels like someone's dumped gasoline on her tiny flame, turned it from a giving friend to a raging disaster and every inch of her is consumed in the fallout. Every piece of her burns. The world she knows disappears. The self she knows disappears. Everything is fire and pain and ash and she doesn't exist anymore, not as a person. Not as a being. She is a pile of bones burning for something, something she can't remember. Something bigger, larger, *more*. The only thing there is. She is kindling for the Fire, the only thing that exists, and she just wants it to *stop*.

She doesn't know how long it is before there is a break in the Fire — time is not a concept she can process anymore. All she can identify are the flames and the heat, and as she endures them they begin to flicker. For a moment — just a moment — cool air hits her. The

flames crack and the air cuts through them, and it caresses her body and she remembers that she has one. That she exists. That she existed before this fire, before this pain. She can't remember what it was like, but her mind is trying. Reaching, grasping, fumbling to hold onto something that refuses to solidify. A tickle, a whisper, something she can feel that she yearns for but just can't identify.

And then she realizes, it must be a release. An end. A cool rush of air through the flames, a misting of water. It must be her way out.

She stops chasing it and lets it come to her in whatever way it will, and it comes in a rush. Her senses are consumed. She's swimming in a heavy fog of wine and roses, the rich waters of amber and catnip, and the sharp taste of iron. She doesn't understand it but she knows it, she knows it...and it doesn't hurt and she wants it.

She realizes suddenly that she can go to it. She can find it, and leave the Fire. She can find it.

So she goes.

*

It's been twenty-nine days since Catra helped Adora.

She's done a good job not thinking of her in the last four weeks, ever since she showed up to the bar to apologize and Catra shoved that apology right back into her face. She's barely thought of her at all since she vacuumed her couch and made Glimmer stay over so the scent of her magic would cover Adora's ghost that refused to leave. She thinks erasing her from her mind and her smell from her apartment is enough to finally give her peace.

But then she steps outside at work twenty-nine days later and makes the mistake of looking up and catching the moon rise—and realizes it is a full moon.

And now? Now Adora is all she can think of.

*[illegible]* The questions flood her mind before she can shut them down, and the most infuriating one feels like it's branded across her brain, haunting the specifics of every other question she thinks of: *[illegible]*

It doesn't help that she's hungry again, every thought plagued with irritation and the empty ache inside of her. She'd woken up so cranky that she'd actually considered cracking open one of the drinks from Entrapta that she kept in the back of the fridge. But after staring it down for a long moment, she just shut the door and walked away. It wasn't worth enduring the aftertaste when she was working tonight anyway. She'd just have to hope that they got a lot of patrons that were actually *[illegible]*.

But now that her thoughts have crossed the self-imposed forbidden line of thinking about Adora, she can feel the edges of hope creeping in as well. The memory of how fresh and new she'd felt after both times that she'd seen her last month digs into the pit in her gut, and there's no chance of shutting down the yearning it begets—but she tries anyway.

And then her phone rings, and her attempts cease.

Catra's mismatched eyes narrow at the name on her screen as she accepts the call. "Glimmer?"

"She broke out again," Glimmer huffs, already out of breath.

Catra's heart thunders. *[illegible]*

"Adora," Glimmer pants. "She broke out again. Mara said last time it was just fear but this time...it was like she *had* to? We're going out now to find her."

Catra stares at the door to the bar and blinks. She doesn't have a word for the feeling inside of her, but she knows that she doesn't like it. She doesn't *know* it, and she doesn't want it. She frowns, and fills in the rest of Glimmer's request. "You want my help again."

"You found her pretty fast last time," Glimmer reasons, and Catra knows that she's not wrong. It's smart for her to look again. It's smart for Glimmer to call again. So why is she so hesitant to say yes?

"Do you know why she wanted to get out?" Catra asks instead.

"No. We're just hoping it wasn't for a bad reason."

"You're *hoping*?" Catra's tail lashes into the side of the bar. "That's not reassuring."

Glimmer sighs. "Mara's still sure that she doesn't want to hurt anyone, and she seemed really nice when I met her. Mara thinks she might just be overwhelmed."

"*Being* nice and *being* nice are different things, Glim," Catra snaps even though she agrees. She *did* seemed really nice, going out of her way to apologize to everyone that had helped her. Her promise pulls to the front of Catra's memory, and none of it makes sense.

*"I'm not going to hurt anyone."*

She had seemed so serious, so determined. Why would Adora *have* to break out again?

"Catra," Glimmer warns.

Catra grips her phone a bit tighter in her claws, but she manages to hold her tongue. "Whatever. Do you know where she went?"

The question leaves her mouth before she realizes she's asking it, and she thinks she might hate herself more than she ever has for agreeing to go looking *for* . For a wolf she doesn't trust;a woman she doesn't know. Doesn't *have* to know. But it's too late to take it back now.

"No, no one knows. Mara's trying to follow her tracks, and the rest of us are going to cover where we did last time. She ran all over the city before she made it to that diner, so who knows where she could be this time."

Catra nods despite herself. "Okay . I'll call if I find her."

---

Catra finds her.

On a hunch, a nagging thing in the back of her mind that tickles and then scratches at her, she decides to start with the diner and retrace their steps. The second she dashes into the neighborhood she smells her, and it feels like a punch to the gut that the itching hunch was right. She forces herself to walk forward, to go find her, and she's already got her phone out and Glimmer's contact up when the smell grows so strong it consumes everything else and she finds her.

The plan was to call Glimmer as soon as she saw her , get her to come as soon as possible;get her to stop this before it could really start. If she called her quickly enough, maybe she wouldn't have expended too much energy yet and she would just pop over to them.

That *was* the plan, but then Catra sees her.

They're on Catra's street, half a block down from her apartment complex, and Adora is sniffing the ground like she's on the trail of

something. Catra freezes, mismatched eyes narrowing to try and decipher if Adora is on the truth, and her hand tightens around her phone but she doesn't lift it to make the call.

Adora is sniffing but then she stops, lifting her head and sampling the air and then spinning to face Catra. Her body language is indecipherable for a moment as they both stop and stare each other down, and Catra's heart is slamming into her ribs. She can't smell any of the confusion or anxiety in the air that was present the last time, and she could swear Adora's blue eyes are darker this time. More focused, dialed in ~~more~~ present. She shouldn't be in full control of herself by her second moon, Catra at least knows enough about werewolves to know that, but it makes the intensity of her stare all the more unnerving.

And then she opens her mouth and she barks, and launches herself at Catra.

Catra ~~by~~ dodges her ~~sh~~she's faster than Adora regardless of how many legs she has now, but Catra's surprise roots her to the spot until the last possible second. She wrenches back and Adora misses her, landing where she was just standing and swiveling immediately to seek her out again. Catra unsheathes her claws and readies for Adora's jump, but it doesn't come. Instead she just knocks herself into Catra's legs, smushing against them with her giant head and then rubbing the rest of her body along her knees. She lets out another loud bark and her tail smacks against Catra's thigh, and Catra blinks.

Adora's not trying to attack her. She's fucking hug her.

Catra steps back before Adora dares to try and lick her like last time, and she holds out her hands. "Get of f me," she orders. "Sit."

Adora backs off immediately, her tail still wagging so hard her entire body is wiggling as she stands in place and watches her.

Catra looks down at the phone in her hand and pauses, staring at it for a long moment before locking it and putting it back in her pocket. The clawing in the back of her mind has turned to roaring, and the strange feeling she doesn't want is filling her up again, but this time it's joined with dread. Adora is on her street, basically at her apartment. She's happy to see her. She broke out again.

*Adora is at the door. What do I do?*

Catra stares Adora down and she knows, she just knows, that she is at the root of this. She doesn't know the why or the how, and she certainly knows she doesn't have to be, but she is. But she also knows that this ends tonight. Whatever the fuck is going on here, it isn't going to happen again.

Adora is still watching her pleasantly, but her tail has slowed into a calmer wag. Catra narrows her eyes. "Follow me," she orders, and heads down the street to her apartment.

Adora follows at her side the entire time, betraying nothing but a placid happiness in her movement. She doesn't bark and she doesn't stray ~~in~~ fact she seems to be completely satisfied now that she's with her, and that only hardens Catra's resolve that she's right. This is about her.

When they get into her apartment she locks the door and tells Adora to sit and stay in the living room, which she does with ease as Catra closes the bathroom door and then goes into her bedroom. She digs her phone out and closes the door for the image of privacy, although it's incredibly likely Adora can hear her right through it anyway. She hopes she won't understand it all.

Glimmer picks up on the first ring. "Catra?"

"I've got her."

"What?" Glimmer starts. "It's been like, ten minutes! Where was she?"

"Right where I expected. Look, Glim, um...I want to keep her this time."

A long moment of silence passes. "...What?"

"Until she turns back human," Catra explains. The sick feeling of watching Adora disappear last month, whining for her, pins the rolling dread and undesired emotion clouding her chest, and she frowns. "I don't think it's a coincidence I found her again, and last time she was fine until you guys came to get her. She wasn't a problem. I just need to talk to her, once she actually can talk. Okay?"

"Are you sure?" Glimmer asks, her voice thick with doubt. "I mean, she has to be *how* to turn, I don't think"—

"She has to be chained down to turn *into* a wolf so she doesn't escape and run wild. But that obviously didn't work, and it's not like she's gonna be *more* dangerous when she's a human again," Catra scoffs. "Certainly not more dangerous than I am."

Glimmer sighs. "I don't like this, Catra."

"I'm not asking if you *like*, Glimmer. Look, she's fine, alright? We're both fine."

"You could just find her tomorrow"—

"*No*," Catra refuses, her eyes darting to the closed door. "This ends *today*."

"Okay, well just...hang on," Glimmer says, and then a loud noise sounds, like Glimmer's holding the phone against her clothes. Apparently, she doesn't know about the mute button.

She hears Glimmer talking quietly, the words muffled just enough that Catra can't be sure about them, but she can certainly guess

what was said when the phone changes hands and it's Mara on the other end.

"You're going to keep her?"

Catra bites back a growl. "Yeah, just for tonight. I'll send her back once she's got two legs instead of four."

"Are you sure? What's her mood like?"

Catra sours, and she spits the words from her mouth. "Calm. Happy, almost...look, she's feeling like she was last time, before you guys came."

Mara pauses. "...Okay. If you need us to come, we're just a call away."

"We're fine," Catra assures her lowly.

"Take care of her," Mara orders, and Catra can feel her fur bristling.

"Fuck off," she grits out, and then hangs up.

Looks like Adora is hers for the night.

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It turns out that the full moon lasts twice as long when you spend it sitting around waiting for a werewolf to turn back into a human. Catra's not really sure what she expected, but multiple times she considers giving up and calling Glimmer and just having this talk tomorrow. Or the next day. Or never.

But then Adora fixes those sad baby blues on her again and she knows this has to happen *now*.

She manages to keep Adora off the couch all night, getting her to lay down on the carpet and telling her to sleep and sitting and watching as she tries to. Sometimes she manages to drift off and her breathing slows, and other times she pretends to sleep until she thinks Catra isn't looking at her and then she peeks an eye open. But Catra is always watching her, so she shuts her eye again quickly and pretends she didn't get caught.

Catra's watching her to make sure nothing changes, that her mood doesn't suddenly shift, and to try and figure out what the hell she's going to say to her once she's back to being a person. Everything she can think of she knows Glimmer would scold her for because it's too rude, but frankly she thinks the situation calls for it. She's not a fellow wolf, and she's *not* a friend. This girl's transformations are her own responsibility. Catra doesn't want any part of it.

Once Adora actually falls asleep for good, Catra reads through an entire book and half of another one. She's flipping the pages when Adora wakes up with a start, her entire body jumping as she bolts up in alarm.

Catra hears Adora's heart speed up as she stands and whines, her eyes darting around the apartment. Her ears pin back so flat against her head they almost disappear. The curtains are closed tightly but the light coming from around their edges is undeniable – the night is ending, and the day is beginning.

The full moon is over.

Catra puts her book down and straightens, but she's not sure what else to do. Adora's started pacing, tail tight between her legs and more whines erupting from her mouth. Anxiety and fear are so sharp in the air that Catra tastes them on her tongue. She's never seen a werewolf transform before, either into a wolf or back into a human. She was pretty confident earlier that the transformation back *did* require chains, but the pained howl that Adora cries out sinks doubt deep into her body.

Adora stops pacing in the center of her living room and looks at her and her fur bristles —no, it *ripples*. Like a wave from the ocean, or a burning flame, her entire coat ripples and then something inside of her snaps, and she cries out. Her eyes burn into Catra, blazing, so bright it's like they're on fire, and they are pleading with Catra to please, please stop this.

But there's nothing she can do.

Her hands are open and her eyes wide and she wants to help, but she can't stop this. She can't do this for her. She can't do anything except watch as it happens. Bear witness.

Adora finally looks away from her as another loud snap ricochets through the apartment and her body jerks, like she has no control over it. She shudders and stumbles and whimpers and more snaps come, one after another after another and her head whips from side to side and it's *big*. Her entire body is, her coat shivering and receding and her limbs altering, and Catra doesn't know what she expected to happen but this is so much worse than anything she could have imagined. Adora's entire body is *big*, shuffling, changing itself to be something else.

And if the cries and yelps escaping from her are any indication, it *hurts*.

Adora's back snaps and she screams a scream that is more human than wolf as her body struggles to decide which it is, and Catra can't stop herself. She falls to her knees at Adora's side, her hands hovering as Adora shakes and writhes on her carpet. She looks horrible, unrecognizable, caught between wolf and woman and Catra cannot believe this is what the change looks like. From the smell of it, the power and the magic embroiled in it, she had assumed it would be easier. Not *easy*, but...not this. This? This might be the worst thing that Catra's ever seen.

Adora lets out a strangled noise, something between a plea and a sob, and her gnarled, confused body rolls so she can dig her —

claws? fingers? into the carpet. It tears as they sink in but it seems to help, her body steadying now that she has a purchase in something, and she manages to prop herself on all four of her limbs as they struggle to become human again.

Her fur has almost completely receded now, her skin starting to remember what it's supposed to look like. She's still shaking, but the snaps are sounding with less frequency and her limbs are looking more normal. She's sweating, and shivering, and Catra chances to reach a hand out and spread her fingers across her shoulder. Adora is burning up, the heat so strong it's uncomfortable to touch, but Catra tightens her grip.

"You're almost there," she says, the soft words escaping her mouth before she realizes she wants to say them.

Adora lets out a low whine, almost a whimper, but she shifts and leans into Catra's touch. She turns her face away but inclines her head towards her, still trembling. Catra immediately moves her hand, stroking over the top of Adora's head and through her hair, which still feels strangely like fur but is growing rapidly to it's normal human length. Her ears look almost completely normal. Adora shudders and groans as a few more snaps sound through her body, but they seem to come easier each time and Catra finds herself whispering assurances under her breath.

*t' so a t' sg a .Y o g' s o e ."*

With one last cry Adora shudders, and then she finally stills. Her hair feels normal when she pulls away from Catra's hand, steadying herself on her human hands and her human knees, and she spends a long moment on all fours just breathing. The heat radiating off of her is dimming and the smell of the change, the sharp, wet smell of earth, is already turning sweeter as well.

It's over.

Catra pulls her hands into her lap and considers backing away to give her a bit more space when Adora finally looks up.

She takes in the apartment, the ripped carpet, and Catra. Her eyes fall heaviest on Catra, back to their normal light blue and full of confusion and something that looks like guilt. She doesn't speak, still breathing deeply, and casts her eyes back down to the carpet before she thinks to consider herself.

She is hot and sweaty and Catra imagines she must be aching with pain, but the piece that has now become impossible to ignore is that she is also very, very naked.

Catra has been pointedly keeping her eyes from straying beyond Adora's face, but the gentle flush that fills her cheeks when her eyes dart between the two of them is the opening Catra needs to turn away completely. She leans backward to the couch, yanking up the blanket she keeps across the back and shaking it out to cover Adora up.

She accepts it gratefully and opens her mouth and Catra can already hear the apology primed and realizes suddenly just how much she doesn't want to hear it. At least, not for this. So she stands abruptly and cuts her off. "Just...go sit on the couch. I'll be right back."

She can hear every movement Adora makes as she struggles to stand and cocoon herself in the blanket and plop down on the couch. She tries to ignore it as she moves around the island that divides the living room from the kitchen to fill a glass with cold water, but nothing could stop Adora's hammering heart from filling her ears and bouncing around her skull.

When she turns around and looks at her over the counter, Catra realizes that the blanket was a mistake. A very, very big and brutal mistake. Because it is just big enough for her to curl up under, it is also just big enough to wrap over Adora' s shoulders and torso and hips...and absolutely nothing else. Which means the entirety of her legs are on display, going on for days and covered in silky blonde

hair. She has a gentle tan on her wide calves but her thighs are pale and strong. So strong, in fact, that Catra is positive they could suffocate anyone who might have the luck of finding themselves between them, and —

*Yeah*. The blanket was a mistake.

Catra walks stiffly back, thrusting the glass into Adora's face and staring at the window behind her shoulder. "I'm gonna get you some clothes. I don't know what'll fit you, so...just wait here."

Adora takes the glass from her with a bit of confusion, but tilts it up easily and starts to chug the entire thing. Catra knows she watched her get it, so she'll know how to get more if she needs it, and she takes the presented opportunity to escape into her room and get a fucking handle on herself.

She'd asked her to stay so they could talk ~~so~~ they could end this. Whatever the hell *this* even was. She didn't want it. She wanted to end it.

That's what she reminds herself, shoving aside all of the leftover sympathy from watching that horrific change and the traitorous part of her that's thinking about reconsidering because of it to dig up the part of her that *knows* nothing good comes from people with this much power. The part of her that knows how to keep herself safe and her life stable, and knows that means sending away this strange and beautiful werewolf that came looking for her.

It takes her a long minute to find anything that might fit her, but that's good, because it gives her time to figure out what to say. Eventually she digs up a sweatshirt and some loose athletic shorts that should fit over Adora's monstrous arms and legs, and makes her way back.

When she returns to the living room and shuts her door pointedly, Adora's holding her blanket tight with one hand and nursing a new glass of water with her other. Catra doesn't have to smell the air to know how nervous Adora is ~~it~~'s written all over her face.

“Here,” Catra says, offering the clothes and keeping her eyes above Adora’s shoulders.

“Thank you,” she says, her voice small in the empty air. She sets her water aside and accepts the clothes, and Catra points her to the bathroom.

“Help yourself to whatever you find in there,” she mutters, before remembering she was supposed to be stoic and cruel.

Adora only takes a few minutes, and when she emerges from the bathroom Catra is back on the couch, sitting and waiting and she knows it looks weird but she doesn’t know how else to do this. They need to talk.

“We need to talk.”

Adora twists the blanket in her hands nervously, but slowly makes her way back to the couch as well. She’s moving like she might spook a skittish animal if she isn’t careful, but Catra isn’t sure which of them she thinks is that animal. She offers the blanket to Catra and the clothes *do* fit her...at least more than the blanket did. Unfortunately, they don’t do much to help Catra’s sanity when Adora sits down and the shorts ride almost all of the way up her thighs.

Catra tries to take a grounding breath but the blanket that’s now in her hands smells as strongly of Adora as Adora herself does, and she’s definitely going to have to fumigate her house after this if she ever wants to function again. She tosses the blanket to the side to run through the washer later and sets her jaw.

“You came looking for me,” she starts.

Adora shifts around on the other end of the couch, but she doesn’t deny it.

“Why did you come looking for me?” Catra asks, turning to watch her.

Adora shifts again, glancing to meet her eyes quickly and then turning back to stare into her lap. "I..." she tries, her fingers twisting into each other and she cuts off with a deep frown.

"You what?" Catra snaps, something that feels like fear twisting it's way into frustration. "*Why*" she asks again.

"I don't know!" Adora says, her hands twisting faster. "I..." she shrugs helplessly, "I wasn't looking for you last time."

"But you were looking for me this time?"

Adora falters, looking pained. She still won't meet her eyes.

"Why *then*?" Catra pushes.

Adora shakes her head, shrugging again. Her sweaty golden hair falls over her shoulders. "I don't know, I...I didn't realize it was *you* that I was looking for."

Catra crosses her arms tightly. "Well what the fuck does that mean?"

Adora sighs, running her strong hands through her hair. It looks like they're shaking. "I just...I don't...I'm not in much more control than I was the first time," she offers, risking a glance at Catra. She looks scared. "I still can't...process thought the right way. I don't remember what I was thinking, if I was even thinking at all. If it was just instinct." she drifts off.

"Okay. Then tell me what you do remember."

Adora wraps her arms around herself, hugging her elbows, and winces. "I remember changing...It hurt. Worse than this," she nods her chin towards the ripped carpet. "And I wanted it to stop...I just wanted it to *stop*. And I knew there was something that could do that. And I didn't know where it was but I knew it would help, so I went looking for it."

Catra waits for her to continue, but she doesn't.

"And?"

"And then I found you," Adora says tightly. Her voice is deeper, calmer than before. She almost sounds a little angry. "And I felt better."

The fear in Catra's chest stops masquerading as frustration and takes a hold of her as it truly is, shooting panic through her veins and wrapping a chokehold around her throat. She grips her arms tighter to stave it off, but it doesn't ease.

"Why the fuck did *I* make you feel *that*?" she asks, and her voice is shaking.

If Adora notices, she doesn't show it. "I don't know," she grits out, "I just...it's like I recognize your smell, or something. Like I know it."

Catra shoves away the tickle in her mind that is now screaming nonsense at her, begging her to understand something it can't tell her. She also shoves away the knowledge that the tickle only took root after she'd smelled Adora. Not the wolf...but *her*. "Of course you do, I smell like a vampire," she bites.

"No, it's...it's *you*," Adora insists.

Catra's resolve snaps. "Well I don't fucking know you," she growls. "And you sure as *hell* don't know me."

Adora's face drops, and then twists with hurt.

"You're not my responsibility," Catra continues, while the words will come, "and I don't take in charity cases. You're a fucking *stray*. And you're not welcome here."

Anger pins the hurt contorting Adora's face. "Then why did you let me in?" she snaps.

Catra's eyes flash as she fumbles for a defense. She exhales sharply, and replies, "...Everyone makes mistakes."

Adora recoils, turning her whole face to the wall but they both know it's useless. Even if Catra couldn't hear her sniffling, she could smell the salt from her tears on the air, feel the heat rolling off of her as her blood pumps faster.

"Figure your shit out," Catra says, getting up and striding to the door. She flips the lock and yanks it open, and Adora looks up at the sound. Tears are streaming freely down her face, and the sight of it turns Catra's stomach. The taste in her mouth turns sour. When the words come out, they leave her tongue raw.

"Leave me alone."

Adora's bottom lip wobbles, and she rises from the couch to her full height. Catra feels dwarfed in her shadow. *"I'm sorry,"* she whispers, the words gravelly and haunting, and she leaves the apartment.

Catra feels sick.

Chapter End Notes

I still promise this fic will *not* be heavy with the angst, but we do need a little bit of conflict to get us started! Chapter 3 will come soon so hang tight, but then please expect a bit of a hiatus while I work on a few of my other projects, fic and non-fic.

Playlist is here!

Let me know if you enjoyed, and happy Catra day! <3

# I Was An Island

Chapter Summary

> Catra confronts her mistakes. Adora struggles to keep her promise. We finally learn some lore.
>
> CW: this chapter features a description of intense pain, and later on describes a werewolf transformation.

Chapter Notes

> Title is from I Was an Island by John-Allison Weiss.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It's been twenty-nine days since Catra chased Adora out of her apartment and out of her life.

~~It's been twenty-nine days since she's seen Adora or heard anything about her one quick exchange with Glimmer about it (that ended with Catra snapping at her and Glimmer rightfully ignoring her for the entire week after) had ensured that no one else spoke to her about Adora. And Adora hasn't paid her any other nightly visits to the bar, and Catra hasn't ventured into the east side of town at all, and somehow that's all it took. That's how easy it was. Two simple conversations, and she was gone as quickly as she'd come.~~
~~...Except she wasn't. She still isn't.~~

Her smell has sunk into the apartment like smoke, infiltrating everything it finds, and lingering with no relief. No matter how much time Catra spends airing out the apartment, washing her blankets, and vacuuming the carpet, nothing has lifted the smell of fired clay

and sweet, damp ashes from her home. The tears in the carpet still stare her down, taunting her, but the thought of replacing the whole thing seems wrong. It feels like weakness. Catra's been too angry to ask Glimmer to come over to flush the scent out, and she hasn't wanted to risk asking anyone else — if they questioned why or saw the carpet, she knows she would have to explain it to them or lie, and none of her friends deserve anything less than the truth. But when she thinks about telling it, shame boils in her gut.

She doesn't regret what she did or what she said. She doesn't. Adora is dangerous in more ways than one — and a stranger — and Catra doesn't owe anything to her or to the pack. There's no reason to help her, and more than a dozen reasons not to. She doesn't regret turning her away to keep herself safe.

Except maybe she does, just a little bit, when she thinks of the hot tears spilling over Adora's cheeks, and the fact that she was the one to put them there.

And maybe she still feels sick when she thinks about Adora's last words as she left, low and quiet and raw, like a ragged knife slipped between Catra's ribs.

*poise*

Twenty-nine fucking days, and she's still thinking about it.

She hasn't been able to stop counting the days either;hyperaware of each night that passes and how much closer it brings them to the next full moon — the full moon when Adora would actually make good on her promise and stay the hell away from her and Catra would wonder why the fuck that doesn't make her feel better. Why the fuck it just makes her feel worse.

It's been twenty-nine days and the full moon is so bright that it's spilling into her apartment even with the curtains drawn and Catra has nowhere to go to distract herself. Nowhere to go and nothing to do but sit around and hate herself for doing what she had to.

She's been staring at the ceiling for hours, barely sleeping while the sun was up and not getting a wink since it sunk below the horizon. Hunger buzzes through her like static, a constant background noise to her thoughts and movements and existence. It begs her for relief, poking her nervous system like a burning stick and bemoaning the same cry over and over and *over* again.

She knows that the hunger is only making her mood worse, making this moon worse, but it doesn't really matter what she does. Even if she satiates it now, it'll only return, clawing its way back like it does every time, taking a hold of her like a leech on her back. A spot she can never quite scratch. A record that skips no matter how you care for it, because the original pressing was wrong.

Like an ailment with no cure, except for —

She stands abruptly, angrily scraping her claws over her scalp in a futile attempt to chase the itch away, and makes her way to the kitchen. Maybe she *will* have something for it, even if it only lasts so long. Any sort of relief would be worth it. Anything to help endure this night.

Catra stares into the fridge for a long moment, bare except for a stick of butter, a single egg, and the five glass bottles lining the back wall. The bottles stare back at her, haunting her memory with their beloathed aftertaste and the guilt of what she is. They taunt her to pick them up. Drain them. Accept it.

She snatches one of the bottles and growls at it, shutting the fridge again with far more force than necessary.

She wouldn't even *need* the drink if the bar was doing better, but as of late it seems like they've hit a dead season. Like all the humans in town have found a better place to go, another one that lets them drink and eat for free and isn't crawling with vampires looking to feed. If they have, she wouldn't blame them. Working at the bar wasn't always a sure thing, which is why she had these in the first place. That's why Entrapta made them.

Catra appreciated the effort, and she loved Entrapta for wanting to help, but it wasn't the same. It was a cheap, sick imitation, no matter how much she refined the recipe. It was like living a half-life, but worse, because Catra was already doing that.

She walks her stupid drink over to the stupid door, and grabs the stupid lock in between her claws. Sick with guilt and shame and the horrible feeling that she made a mistake, she hadn't locked it when she got back yesterday. In case she slept through the moonrise, and Adora…

Well. Just in case.

She had turned her phone off and shoved it in her bedside drawer before she attempted sleep though, unwilling to listen as it laid silent and reminded her of the isolation she had sown for herself, and now that the moon is up and beaming and her apartment is quiet and empty, she knows she got exactly what she wanted.

She's alone.

Catra sighs and moves to flip the lock, and then freezes.

Her door smells like dirt.

Why does her door smell like that?

Catra leans forward and inhales deeply, and the sharp scent of power and petrichor and smoke and clay fill her lungs, and Catra's face twists. Adora's scent has lingered in her apartment, yes, but much in the way that a ghost does. Tickling the mind and twisting around the ankles like fog, appearing only from the corner of an eye. Sitting in the background of her life, casting a shadow over the moon.

This is Adora's scent, there's no question about it, but it is not a ghost's scent. It is hers.

She can hear the heart it belongs to beating softly.

Catra seizes the doorknob and yanks it open, half-expecting Adora to be standing outside her door waiting. But she isn't;there is no one darkening her doorway but her. She frowns and whips her head around looking for her —and then she sees her .

Curled into a tight ball of fur, nose tucked under her tail and her whole body shoved against the wall just beside her door —Adora. Fast asleep and dead silent, barely moving beside the gentle rise and fall of her breathing.

*Ada*

*

Adora is not going to return to Catra.

She's *not.*

She promised her and she promised herself, and she absolutely, irrevocably, will not bother her again.

But then the change comes.

Mara is kneeling in front of her, looking into her eyes, guiding her. Trying to talk her through it. The last two moons had proved she needed more to ground her, more to keep her calm and sane during the change than what they had done for her previously. But when the fire rips through her, it just doesn't matter .

The pain bursts into an inferno that consumes her as soon as it starts, taking a hold of her body and mind and rendering everything else unrecognizable. The scent of her pack and the other changes do not console her with familiarity —they fan the flames and raise

her alarm that this is inescapable. Unending. That her destiny is just *pain*.

She has enough cognitive thought to remember that there is an escape, an end. An alternative.

But she also remembers that she's not supposed to take it. She doesn't know why – she just *knows* she shouldn't.

She remembers that sometimes, the pain subsides on its own. She remembers it can get better, but she doesn't believe it. Minutes pass, and it hurts, and she doesn't believe it. An hour passes, and it hurts, and she doesn't believe it. What feels like *years* pass, and it *hurts*, and she *doesn't* believe it.

So she dreams of the escape, and she prays for it to find her, accept her, consume her instead. Help her. Do *something*.

She knows she's not supposed to take it but the more she thinks about it the more the pain begins to lessen, the more conscious she becomes of her body and mind and being. The escape helps, so she takes it.

It isn't until she's on that familiar street that the pain has cleared enough for her to realize what she's done.

She knows the escape is a person now, and she knows she's going to their home. She also knows she's not allowed to be there, but she can't remember *why*. She feels the guilt and the fear of doing something wrong weighing down her limbs, but the stronger the smell of wine and iron and roses gets, the less she hurts. The more she feels like a person, and it is not even a question that that relief is worth whatever consequences may follow.

So she follows the scent to the apartments and up the stairs and up to the door that smells like catnip and amber and that's where she settles, refusing to ask for more but unwilling to deny herself the comfort that just being there offers.

She has the thought to make herself small, to curl up so she's as little of a bother as possible, and she huddles down against the wall and out of the way. Before she knows it, she's drifting off.

And as she does, she thinks she hears a soft, steady heartbeat that sounds like home.

*

Catra blinks down at Adora, ignoring her own hammering heartbeat, and reaches out a foot to nudge her furry butt. "Hey," she says, softer than intended.

Adora doesn't move, her muzzle still tucked under her tail and her eyes closed.

Catra shoves her toes further into Adora's soft fur and nudges her harder, hissing. "Hey!"

Adora stirs, her tail twitching and her head raising slowly. She blinks, and then looks up at Catra, and then she scrambles to her feet.

Catra crosses her arms, patently ignoring how adorable Adora's clumsiness in her wolf body still is, and raises an eyebrow. "What are you doing here?" she snaps, as if she hasn't been pining for her to show up all day and all night.

Adora's tail sinks between her legs and she whines, and Catra knows she's trying to say she's sorry.

Catra wants to tell her that's not enough, that she'd still broken her promise to her, but where would that leave them? With Adora crawling home, and Catra alone again and sick to her stomach with regret?

That's what it is, isn't it? That feeling like she's made a mistake, that guilt kicking around in her bones when she thinks of how she made Adora cry. She regrets it, because it hadn't been what she wanted...not really. And she knew that. She knows that.

She *knows* what she wants.

She's just scared of the consequences. The horror that follows.

Adora whines again and drops her head even lower, and Catra can't stand doing this to her again. She can't stand doing it to *herself* again. She steps outside before she can overthink it and wordlessly motions to the open doorway. *Come on.*

Adora stares at the door and then back at her, and her tail sways gently. Cautiously. She doesn't move.

"*Ugh*, come on," Catra groans, glaring at Adora. "Don't make me say it."

Adora's head raises higher and her tail gives a light wag, and Catra urgently gestures at the door. Adora's mouth opens and her tongue lolls out, and with an excited bound she reaches Catra and rubs her side against her legs. Her head knocks against the bottle in Catra's hand, and Catra yanks it out of her reach before she can get a good sniff at it.

"*Go*," Catra growls, and Adora heads inside without any further complaint.

Once the door is closed and locked Catra returns the bottle to the fridge, praying Adora won't remember enough to ask her about it later. She certainly won't need it now that Adora's here.

Adora's sniffing gently around the carpet and the couch, her tail still lazily wagging.

“Don’t jump up there,” Catra warns, pointing a claw at her and the couch.

Adora’s head lowers a little, but she returns to sniffing the floor without any complaints, and she doesn’t jump up.

Catra frowns, realizing she’ll have to host Adora for the entire night again, which means giving her a place to settle that isn’t on her furniture and waiting and —

Catra stops, processing that if Adora is here again, then that means she isn’t at the commune. It means she broke out again. It means she should have gotten another panicked call. But she didn’t get it...because she was the asshole that had turned her phone off.

“Stay,” she tells Adora, striding into her room and digging her phone out of her drawer to turn it on. As soon as it comes to life, it dings with 10 texts from Glimmer, 15 missed calls, and 4 voicemails. She grabs a spare quilt from her closet and then calls Glimmer back, dropping the quilt in the living room in front of the kitchen island. It’s ringing as she grabs the couch blanket that still smells like Adora even after a million washes, and she dumps it unceremoniously on top of the quilt.

“Catra!” Glimmer screams as she picks up, and Catra yanks the phone away from her ear.

“Holy shit, Glimmer,” —

“I’ve been calling you all night! Where have you been?!”

“Wait, —is this about Adora?”

“Yes, and the other two,” —

“I have her, Glim. She’s here.”

“I can’t believe you’ve been with her, —wait...what did you say?”

"I have her . She's with me." Catra glances over to find Adora sitting patiently and watching her. "I'd tell her to say hi, but she can't exactly *spea* —"

As if to prove her wrong, Adora immediately lets out a loud bark and wags her tail. Catra glares at her, but Adora just smiles at her . As much as a wolf can smile, anyway.

"...I stand corrected," Catra mutters, turning her back on Adora and leaning onto her countertop. "I'm gonna keep her , so you don't have to worry about her for the night."

"Thank heavens," Glimmer sighs. "I was hoping she'd go to you — we haven't even *tri* to look for her with the other two on the loose."

"Wait, what other two?" Catra asks.

"The other wolves," Glimmer says, like it' s the most obvious thing in the world.

"What other wolves?" Catra asks again.

"The other ones that —you didn't listen to any of my messages, did you?"

"...No."

Glimmer groans. "Adora let out two *oth* wolves when she escaped. Both new to changing too, but less powerful. A *bit* more clueless, so a lot more dangerous."

Catra shoots a glance at Adora, who's clearly eavesdropping. Catra raises an eyebrow at her and her head sinks a little as her ears droop, and Catra figures that's probably as close to ashamed as she can get right now.

"Well, did you find them?"

"Not yet, but almost. We had one of them cornered but then some *idiot* came out of the pub on the corner and tried to go *pet* them — the wolf nearly chewed his hand off and then ran away again before we could stop them."

"Fucking idiot," Catra murmurs.

"*Yeah*. He was dressed like a stupid sailor or something too; probably just a tourist who's never seen a werewolf before in their life."

"A *sailor*? I don't blame them for trying to bite him."

Glimmer laughs, and then sighs. "I should go, they need me to keep looking."

"Do you guys need help?" Catra asks before she can stop herself.

"What, like you're offering?" Glimmer teases. "That's okay, we're getting close. It's better if you stay with Adora and sort out whatever's going on so this doesn't happen again. I'd ask *how* you're letting her stay"…

"But you know I'd tell you it's none of your business?" Catra finishes.

"...I was imagining something meaner, but yeah."

Catra chuckles, and spares a glance at Adora, who pointedly looks away as if she isn't still listening. "Good luck, Sparkles," Catra says.

"Fuck off, Whiskers," Glimmer grumbles, and then hangs up.

Catra rolls her eyes. She doesn't even *have* whiskers, but their stupid playground insults had lingered after childhood and turned into affectionate nicknames for each other. She drops her phone onto the counter ~~-ri~~nger on in case they do end up needing her ~~-a~~nd turns to regard Adora.

She's watching her quietly now, and she seems a bit more subdued than the last two times she's been here. Catra's not sure how aware she's supposed to be by the third moon, but it certainly seems like she knows that she isn't supposed to be here. She's being far too polite this time, as if she's scared of overstaying her welcome.

And that's no one's fault except Catra's.

She sighs and tries a small smile. "You're gonna stay again this time, okay? We need to talk once you turn back."

Adora whines softly, her blue eyes widening as a hint of fear hits the air.

Catra frowns and hugs herself, resting a hip against the counter. "You're not in trouble — hey, not with me. You might be in a bit of trouble with the pack."

Adora whines again, her head sinking towards the ground. Catra feels like she's kicked her.

"Hey, it's alright. I'm sure it won't be too bad," Catra says, hoping to ease the pained expression on Adora's furry face.

It helps, a little, and Adora raises her head a bit.

"Here," Catra steps back and motions to the blankets she dumped on the ground. "You can make a little bed here and sleep for the night. You don't have to worry about anything until the morning."

Adora blinks at her and then walks up to the blankets, sniffing around their edges and investigating them.

Catra's trying to stifle the deep and very inconvenient desire she feels to take care of Adora inside of her, but it feels almost impossible. It feels uncontrollable, like this great clawing thing that has risen up from the depths of her insides and taken hold of her body and mind. The harder she tries to fight it down, the harder it

fights to stay. And when Adora buries her face in the blankets, sneezes, and then throws herself down onto them and starts to roll around, it makes Catra feel like she might burst with affection.

She doesn't know if she's ever felt this way before ~~if~~ she's ever even let herself care about anyone this much. Glimmer, *maybe*, but she hadn't had much of a say in the way they were forced into each other's lives. She would take a silver bullet for her in a second and she'd *only* kill for her, but...just take care of her? Do everything she could to make sure she didn't feel fear or discomfort? Feel sick to her stomach with the knowledge that those things are out of her control?

No, she's never felt this for Glimmer, and not even for Scorpia or Entrapta. And that's it, isn't it? That's the list. Those are all of the friends that she's let herself have.

No wonder she's always starving.

Catra turns around from Adora's display so she won't have to keep digging for why she feels like this, and heads back to her room to change and grab a book. It probably isn't the biggest deal now, with Adora as a wolf, but eventually she'll turn back and be naked again and they'll need to talk and none of that feels like something Catra can confront in her pajamas.

She changes into her favorite ripped leggings and a loose dark red button-up: comfy enough for the couch but nice enough to feel put together and prepared. She goes hunting for some clothes for Adora, too, and finds her last large sweatshirt and a pair of shorts Scorpia had left the last time she visited, and she carries them with her back into the kitchen.

Catra grabs her phone off the counter and settles onto the couch with it and her book, appraising Adora as she looks up from where she's snuggled herself into her makeshift blanket nest. She opens her mouth and her tongue lolls out and she looks happy and

comfortable and it's doing things to Catra's insides. She feels like a pile of goo.

She drops the clothes off to the side and turns to her phone to distract her. Opening her voicemail she starts to play Glimmer's messages, half to be sure she didn't miss anything important and half to fill the silence so she won't have to find something else to say that Adora won't even *be* able to respond to.

"Hey , we have a bit of a situation — why aren't you picking up your phone? I'm going to keep calling in case you're at work...Adora's loose again and so are a few other wolves. They got out with her . We *really* need your help — *PLEASE* call me back!"

Catra clicks on the next one.

"Hey Catra, I REALLY need you to pick up your phone! I think we can get these two but there aren't enough of us to go after Adora. We think she might just go to you, so I need you to go home and find her! And then call me back! I don't have time to come find you — PEASE answer me!"

Catra winces, and plays the next one.

"CATRA WHERE THE HELL ARE YOU? You cannot *possibly* be ignoring me right now WHY aren't you picking up? You better not be in trouble yourself because we do NOT have time for that! Answer me! *Answer* me!"

Catra clicks on the last one and spares a glance to Adora — she's curled up and resting her head on her paws, but she's watching Catra and her phone with interest.

"Heeeeey , Catra! My darling dearest *sister* of a sister," Glimmer's sugary voice rings out. "I don't know what you're up to right now, but *we've* been roaming the streets for an *hour* now trying to chase down two! Runaway! Werewolves! Your girlfriend is *also* on the loose so make that *three* , and we have absolutely *no* idea where

she is. So if you could give me a call back and help us out a little, that would be *oh* so kind of you. And if you don't and you keep ignoring me, *I'm* going to call *Mom* and have her force you to come back and live at home again and sit through all of the ten thousand diplomatic meetings that *I* have to sit through every single day and *you* can be nice to crusty old clan members who think they're better than everyone else just because they've been alive for five hundred years and *I'm* going to get to go live on my own and work on my own and IGNORE MY SISTER WHEN THE T OWN IS FALLING AP ART AND SHE NEEDS MY HELP! Call me the *B* ”

Catra snorts lightly and glances back to Adora, who is still watching her with the same expression of mild interest as before. She doesn't seem to have had any reaction to Glimmer's aggression (or to Glimmer calling her Catra's *b* ), so Catra switches to check her texts. Ten messages with varying words but all in the same vein of her voicemails, and once they're marked as read Catra closes out of them and sets her phone to the side. She knows Glimmer's threats are empty – there are a few reasons that Glimmer is the one forced into diplomacy while Catra's allowed to lead her own life, and they all start and end with blood in one way or another – but she still feels bad for being so inaccessible. It's more than luck that Adora had ended up at her apartment, but they don't know that, and she easily could have wreaked havoc while they were busy searching for the others and Catra was ignoring them all and laying in bed.

Hopefully once they get a chance to talk, they won't have this problem again.

Catra settles in with her book for the rest of the night, curling into the corner of the couch and pretending to read while she watches Adora.

She's already fallen asleep, her body rising and falling gently while she breathes, and she looks largely at peace. More comfortable than she was outside, and more relaxed than she was when she slept last month.

Her words are still lingering in Catra's mind, but not her last ones.

*‘[illegible]’*

*‘[illegible]’*

The words are deadlocked in Catra’s head, repeating over and over again as if thinking of them more would make them more understandable. But it doesn’t—it just adds more confusion.

There’s no reason that being around Catra should make her feel better, no reason that she could possibly be making this easier for Adora. Her feeding doesn’t affect the way the other person feels when it happens like this, and there’s no known side effects to just *[illegible]* in the presence of vampires. And there’s certainly no effects for hanging around Magicats...

*‘[illegible]’*

But she doesn’t. Adora doesn’t know her, and she doesn’t know Adora, and Catra *[illegible]* come up with any feasible reason why she would feel *[illegible]* to Adora. They didn’t have any mutual friends—Catra barely had any friends at all—and they’d never inhabited the same spaces. Adora lived in her commune with the wolves, and Catra hadn’t gone over there *[illegible]*.

Catra spends the next few hours running the words over in her head and continuing to come up empty. She’s trying to read her book but she’s only half-processing it, and the distraction is enough that she doesn’t notice Adora has woken up until she moves.

She shifts onto her side and stretches, her long legs extending and her toes spreading as she reaches. When she’s done she sneezes, and then looks up at Catra.

Catra sends her a small, tight smile, and then turns back to her book before it gets weird.

Adora apparently takes this as an invitation, because she gets up and pads over to the couch and drops her big, furry head onto the other cushion.

Catra turns to raise an eyebrow at her. "I told you not to jump up here earlier," she reminds her .

Adora blinks and sits, as if to imply she isn't jumping up. Just resting her head.

Catra narrows her mismatched eyes, but she turns back to her book.

Slowly, very so slowly, Adora inches closer to the couch and lays her neck against the cushion as well.

Catra glances over and Adora blinks innocently and stops moving. Rolling her eyes, Catra rearranges – turning her body to lean her back against the arm and her side against the back, and stretch her feet out a little to rest on the other cushion. They push Adora's head out of the way, and Catra props her book back on her bent knees to keep reading now that she's claimed the couch for herself.

Or so she thinks.

In this new position she can't see Adora moving behind her book but she can certainly sense her, and when she moves her book to peek Adora has successfully maneuvered one of her front legs onto the couch with her head in the small space Catra's feet aren't taking up.

Catra flips her book half-closed and lets out a frustrated sigh. "Ad a —"

Before she can say anything else Adora leaps onto the couch, knocking Catra's knees into the back of it as she tries to spin her body around in a circle when there isn't enough room. Catra pulls her knees against her chest before Adora inadvertently kicks her in the shins, and she opens her mouth to scold her right as she

finds enough room and plops down into a tight ball. She looks up at Catra with her gigantic, sad baby blues and Catra groans loudly.

"You are an asshole," she says, shoving her feet under Adora's body so she isn't crushed against herself and accepting that she can't tell Adora off again without feeling like a complete monster. Adora is already far too good at the puppy-dog eyes for someone who's been a wolf for less than thirty-six hours in total. They'll have to talk about furniture privileges later, too.

Adora blows air through her nose and then tucks her head against the couch arm and settles in to sleep.

Catra turns back to her book and tries to ignore how calming the warm, steady weight on her feet is.

She fails, because without even realizing it, she falls asleep too.

---

It's not until the couch shifts underneath her that Catra wakes up again. She startles, blinking blearily until she finds Adora pacing across the floor, the air ripe with anxiety as the change rises from within her.

It's coming.

Catra sits up straight and sets her book to the side, but then she pauses. Much like last time she doesn't know what to do. She doesn't know what's helpful, and what's useless. She doesn't know if anything even helps at all.

'Fuck.'

Catra shifts uncomfortably, watching Adora walk back and forth across the carpet. A soft whine escapes her.

"Can I do anything?" Catra forces herself to ask, hands open and empty and useless.

Adora looks up immediately, her eyes already beginning to burn bright blue, and opens her mouth to let out a long twisted yowl. She hurries over before Catra can try to interpret her noise, and shoves herself against her knees and waiting hands. She keeps pushing into Catra as hard as she can until Catra finally gives in and sinks her fingers into her fur, pulling her close and stroking over her side. She's shaking, Catra can feel it immediately, and Adora turns to shove her nose into Catra's armpit. She lets out a long, pitiful whine before Catra can protest, so she gives up the fight and just pulls her closer.

"It's okay," she says uselessly, carding her fingers through Adora's soft fur. "It's alright."

Adora lets out another small whine and wiggles her face under Catra's arm, but before she can do anything else, her body jerks and the cracks begin.

They come quickly, her body jerking against Catra's chest and she rearranges her hold on Adora, moving off of the couch and onto the floor so she can act more like a steadying wall than a smothering barricade. Adora leans into her completely, losing her footing as her limbs start to grow and shift. Her fur coat is rippling underneath Catra's hands and she can feel it, receding from between her fingers and struggling to rejoin with Adora's skin. Something in her back cracks hard enough that it reverberates all the way through Catra's chest and Adora screams a horrible strangled scream and this is the first change.

Catra thought that this change would be easier, now that she's seen it once and knows what to expect. She thought this one would be

easier because it was another month closer to Adora learning control, and because they were together.

But this is not easier, not for her. It is not any easier to stomach or to witness, and as Adora cries out again and turns her gnarled face away Catra cannot fathom that this is becoming any easier to endure either. She cannot fathom that this kind of horror ever becomes something that is *easy*.

And what kind of monster did that make her, for turning away Adora's only chance at comfort?

A worse monster than her birthright could ever make her.

Adora shakes in her arms, and Catra hugs her against her chest as tightly as she dares. She is still jerking, snapping, sweating and crying, but she almost has skin again. The cracks are slowing. Her hair is growing out.

She feels Adora strain for a deep breath and loosens her hold, shifting a hand up to pet over Adora's head and she hears herself shushing her. *It's okay, you're safe,* she whispers.

Adora whimpers in response.

Catra skims a hand down her back, hot and sweaty but completely covered in human skin. It feels like the heat is beginning to alleviate, and there are only two more cracks before Adora finally shudders and stills.

She slumps against Catra, putting all of her weight onto her and Catra takes it easily, holding her up and against her chest while she struggles to catch her breath. Adora shifts, turning into her and tucking her face into Catra's neck, and Catra freezes.

Adora's breath ghosts across her shirt collar, dipping into the gap between open buttons to leave a warm tickle on the hollow of her throat, and it feels strange. Catra can feel Adora's chest rising into

hers and falling away, and it feels strange. She can feel Adora's heart, slamming into her ribs and crying out and she can feel hers doing the same, and it feels strange.

She kind of wants to cry.

Adora pulls back first, still breathing hard and blinking as she looks around. She takes in the room and herself and Catra, and her eyes fall as soon as their gazes meet. The heat that faded from her body rushes back into her cheeks, and she turns away quickly and struggles her way out of Catra's lap.

Catra lets her go.

Once she's extracted herself, Catra gets up, grabbing the blanket off the floor and holding it out to her, turning her face away. She knows Adora must be embarrassed, and it is only that knowledge that keeps the shame boiling in Catra's own gut from surfacing. At least one of them has to keep it together.

Adora covers herself with the blanket and Catra gestures to the clothes she'd gathered, and Adora snatches them up without a word. Catra keeps her face turned away as Adora stumbles to the bathroom, and the silence feels far more condemning than any words ever could.

Catra hears the door shut and she wishes that was the end of it, but she can hear everything that Adora does and that includes the quiet sob that escapes her ~~t~~he sob *so* quiet Catra knows she didn't want her to hear it.

She feels sick to her stomach, and the hollow of her throat feels cold as ice.

She listens to Adora sniffling and shuffling around for a long moment, until it finally abates and the apartment grows silent once more. Catra tries to practice what she wants to say ~~w~~hat she made Adora endure this entire night for ~~b~~ut the words won't come

out of her mouth. Her tongue is heavy and clumsy and her guilt sits in her gut like bile, poisoning anything that tries to rise from her. But she has to say *something*, so she forces herself to approach the bathroom door and gently knock on it.

She hears Adora sniff again, but she doesn't answer or move to open it. Catra blows a slow breath out and leans her head forward, resting her temple against the wood and wondering why this was so *fucking* hard.

She opens her mouth and it takes another long moment, but she finally gets some words out. They're not the ones she wants, but they're something.

"I didn't mean it," she says.

She strains to hear Adora's answer, but none comes. She can't hear anything besides Adora's heartbeat and slightly unsteady breathing. Catra frowns, digging for any other words that her tongue is willing to pronounce.

"I shouldn't have said...what I said," she manages. She crosses her arms, and uncrosses them. She rolls her head against the door. "You didn't deserve that."

She hears Adora shift, a gentle swish of clothing, and then, "You weren't wrong." Her voice is soft and small and it twists Catra's heart.

"That doesn't mean you deserved it," Catra argues. "I was just"…

The word *sad* rises to her lips, but refuses to pass through them. It sits on her tongue with the same sour taste that she felt when Adora left, and she lets out a bitter laugh instead.

"*Whatever*, it doesn't matter. You didn't deserve it."

She hears Adora sigh, and then step up to the door. Her voice comes through the wood softly. "Can I come out?"

Catra snorts, grateful for the reprieve of pressure, and steps back. "Of course," she says, twisting the door handle and swinging it open. "You're not locked in there."

The shadow of the door passes over Adora's frame to reveal her body clothed, her face blotchy and wet, and her eyes sad. "Sorry," she murmurs, wincing, and the apology feels like a punch to Catra's gut.

"Don't be," Catra says stiffly. "That's...that's supposed to be my line."

The space between Adora's eyebrows wrinkles. "...You're trying to *apologize*?"

"*Yes?*" Catra asks, annoyed with herself and annoyed with how cute Adora looks when she's confused. "Obviously."

Adora snorts, loud and ugly, and the corner of her lips tip up. Somehow, it makes her even cuter. "You're really bad at it."

Catra makes a noise of offense and throws her hands up. "Well not all of us are used to apologizing just for *existing*," she snaps.

Adora's lips turn up into a full smile, and she laughs softly. "Have you ever apologized for *that* before?" she teases, and Catra cannot believe this.

"Ugh!" Catra turns away, irritated, and rolls her eyes. "Yes, I *have*," she snarks, glancing back over her shoulder. "But I don't do it very often...so. It's something that I'm working on."

Adora's face softens as her eyebrows pull together and raise up, and she makes a noise akin to cooing. "That's so *cute*," she says.

"I am not *cute*," Catra shrieks, spinning on her heel to glare head-on at Adora.

Adora is undaunted, fully cheered up from her prior embarrassment and grinning at her.

Catra sighs, crossing her arms tightly over her chest and leaning back against the kitchen counter. "Look, this isn't what I wanted to talk about."

"Okay ," Adora softens, matching Catra' s pose and leaning back against the wall.

"So...I know this sucks. And apparently I...help? Somehow . So..." Catra drifts off, staring the floor down as if it can give her the words she needs. "If you want to come by , for the next few months or something...it'll only be a few more moons until you can control it, right?" She looks up and quirks an eyebrow , and Adora nods. "Great. So. It's fine...if you want to."

Adora frowns. "You don't have to do that."

"I'm not doing it because I *have* to—"

"I won't show up again, I can keep my promise—"

Catra scoffs, "I think we both know that' s bullshit, Adora."

Adora opens her mouth to argue, so Catra cuts her off.

"*Be* don't make me keep saying it. You're welcome if you want to be here. It's not the end of the world to deal with you for one night a month, and I shouldn't have acted like it was."

Adora looks conflicted. "I don't want to be a burden," she says quietly , and Catra hugs herself tighter.

She wants to say that she isn't one, but that wouldn't be true. But getting her through her change will feed Catra, so it's also not like Adora's only taking from her without giving anything back. And Catra knows how many times *she* has taken things without giving back

throughout her life, so fair was fair. Everyone has their time to be a burden.

So Catra shrugs, and tries to smile. "Sometimes you have to be."

Adora tries to smile back but they both fall a little flat. And then, as if Adora can read her mind, she perks up. "You can feed off of me, if you want."

Catra narrows her eyes.

"It's the least I could do, and then fair is fair, right? You scratch my back, I scratch yours?"

"I'm not scratching your back," Catra rolls her eyes.

Adora laughs, "Well you can have my blood, regardless."

*the blood* surfaces in Catra's mind, but she doesn't speak the words. "Your blood?" she asks, to confirm.

"Sure," Adora shrugs, "what else do I have to offer? I mean, if you need things fixed I can"—

"I appreciate the offer," Catra stops her, realizing that she doesn't know that Catra can feed off her without taking any of her blood. A problem now solved with Adora coming by every month anyway. "But I have my meals sorted out."

"Okay, well, if you change your mind the offer is open," Adora says lightly. "I've always wondered what it feels like."

"...You've never done it, and you're offering?" Catra quirks an eyebrow.

Adora's cheeks heat to a gentle pink, but she doesn't back down. "Well, it's not like it's some horrible ordeal or something," she rolls her eyes. "If you were going to drain me and kill me I'm positive you would have done it by now."

"Maybe I'm waiting for my opportune moment," Catra teases, even though there hasn't been a vampire-related murder in this town for decades.

Adora unfolds her arms and smirks. "I think that would have been when I was naked and crying in your lap twenty minutes ago."

Catra scoffs to cover the heat flooding her own cheeks and turns away. "Whatever , dog. You can come next month, free of charge, just bring your own clothes because I'm *la* out of monster-sized apparel."

Adora laughs easily and nods. "Seems fair ." Her stomach growls loudly, and she winces. "I'm starving"…

Catra looks back and blinks at her, wondering where this is heading. She doesn't have nearly enough food to fill Adora's stomach, and she's certainly not *cook* for her.

"If you don't want to eat me, do you eat human food?" Adora asked, her tone light and innocent. "W e could get breakfast, if you want? I can put it on the pack's tab, it's the least I can do if you won't let me pay you back any other way."

Catra scrutinizes her for a moment, but Adora doesn't even seem to notice her Freudian slip and the filthy fantasies it raises in Catra's head.

"...Y ou can, uh, eat human food, right?" Adora asks, doubt beginning to seep into her expression as the silence stretches. "Oh, fuck...can you even go outside right now?" Adora' s alarmed gaze darts to the sunlight streaming in through the curtains.

Catra bursts out laughing, her claws gripping her sides as they shake. Adora sputters as she laughs, but it takes a good few cackles before she can draw enough breath to calm down. "*Yes,* Adora," she says in between giggles. "I can go outside, and I can eat normal food. Just for that doubt, I'm getting a double order ."

Relief floods Adora's face and she joins Catra in laughing as she shakes her head. "Order whatever you want, asshole."

Catra cackles. "I will, *asshole*."

Adora's smile is beaming, her whole face bright with sweet amusement, and if Catra's resolve was any weaker this sight alone would be all she needs in repayment. But she's holding strong and making sure this relationship is purposeful. Negotiable. Controllable. Not based on flimsy things like attraction and the wills of the heart.

So. Breakfast it is.

---

They go to the diner. It's the closest place to Catra's apartment and she isn't letting Adora drag this out for any longer than is necessary, no matter how much she may or may not be finding herself wanting to spend more time with her. This is a transaction, a payment for Catra's shelter, and that is it.

But of course, going to the diner comes with drawbacks. Namely, the waitress that has her entire head up the clan's asshole and as such, hates Catra's guts.

Catra hasn't been to the diner in almost a year now that Glimmer doesn't come visit as often, and she completely forgets about the waitress until they're sitting down and she smells Charlie arriving with the menus and coffee.

She smiles pleasantly at Adora, her eyes dipping all over her face and body and Catra is already glaring at Charlie long before she even pulls her gaze away from Adora to see who else is sitting at the table. The excitement in her eyes dies immediately, and her

expression twists to match Catra's. She dumps Catra's menu onto the table and then gently places Adora's before her, and looks pointedly at Adora only when she asks if she'd like coffee.

"Oh, no thanks," Adora smiles, and Charlie smiles sweetly back.

"Can I get you something else to drink instead?" she asks.

Adora glances from Charlie to Catra, confusion apparent on her face as to why their server is completely turned to face her and her alone. Her hesitation opens the floor for Catra.

"I'll take a sasparilla," she interrupts loudly .

Charlie spares her a glance, but doesn't turn to face her. "Oh, no blood today?" she asks, her tone anything but innocent.

"Hm, not today . I'm not thirsty," Catra says, her voice hard.

Charlie makes a noise high in her throat and mutters, *"Done yet,"* before looking back to Adora. "Drink, hun?"

Adora blinks. "Just water?" she says, her voice tipping up to make it sound like a question.

"You got it," Charlie smiles again and walks off.

Adora watches her go, her eyes lingering so long Catra feels a growl start to stir in her chest, and then she finally turns back. "What was that?"

"That was Charlie," Catra offers a wan smile. When Adora just blinks at her, Catra rolls her eyes. "What, you couldn't smell it on her?"

Adora's brow furrows. "Smell what?"

Catra frowns. "She's the clan's little lapdog. She hangs around them so often she always smells like stale wine and rusty blood. I think she thinks if she sucks up to enough of them they'll *change* turn her."

Catra looks in the direction she disappeared —there was no chance they would *e* turn Charlie, not with her being half-horned moth. It was more than likely they were just using her while they could, and banking on outliving her before they had to deal with any fallout from misleading her.

"And you know each other?" Adora asks, still looking at her intently .

"Barely ," Catra shrugs, "most of our dislike for each other is just on principle." She turns back to face Adora, who nods in what looks like relief and stops leaning forward on the table.

"Oh, okay ...why would she dislike you?"

"...Adora, seriously?" Catra asks. "She hangs out with the clan...do you live under a rock, or something?"

"No," Adora shrugs defensively , "but it' s not like I've hung out with a lot of vampires, either. What happened?"

"*Hyp* Catra laughs, but there's no humor to the sound. "I was *bn* that's what happened."

Adora's eyebrows come down and she shakes her head, still not understanding, and Catra is almost impressed. She's never found anyone before who hasn't already known all about her and preemptively determined how they feel about her.

Catra leans back and crosses her arms, sighing. Time for the cliff notes, then. "The clan hates me," she summarizes, "and I hate them. So all of their lapdogs hate me, and I hate them back by proxy."

"But why?" Adora presses.

"How much do you know about vampire hybrids?" Catra asks. Adora must know *sotg* , even if she was only taught it by the pack.

"Um," Adora shrugs, "not much? Human hybrids are pretty rare, but not unheard of. One human parent, one vampire...It makes things

easier...they can eat normal food, daywalk, they don't have to feed as often."Adora drifts of f and gestures vaguely at Catra, who was sitting inside a diner in broad daylight, as if to prove her point.

"It doesn't make things *eas ier* , it makes them more *pow erful* . And I'm no human, am I?"Catra asks, feeling hesitation start to rise in her chest. She wants Adora to understand, but she isn't sure *how* she does, and sharing too much is never smart. Especially this soon.

Adora stares at her for a long moment, her expression changing as the gears in her brain turn, and then she laughs. "They're scared of you,"she says quietly , and her voice is reverent.

Catra stamps down the blush it threatens to raise, and nods. "Ding ding ding."Human-vampire hybrids were more powerful than vampires, and as a *hy brid* -vampire hybrid she was more powerful than any of them. Two predator instincts were stronger than one, and being strong made her dangerous.

"What, do they think you want to take over , or something?"

Catra shrugs. "They figured out I didn't soon after they found out about me, but...it doesn't matter. I'm a threat whether I want anything to do with them or not. I'm a threat just for existing."

Adora straightens. "W ell, you're not in danger, are you?"

Now it's Catra's turn to laugh. "Fuck no, they're way too scared for that. They'd never risk their necks *or* Angella's fury."If one good thing had come from her adoption, it was Angella's protection. "They hate me because they can't do anything about me except leave me be."

Catra hears the kitchen doors open, and glances over to see Charlie making her way back to them with two cups in hand. Catra nods to Adora's menu and tells her she better decide what she wants.

Adora sees Charlie as well and complies, opening the menu and skimming the pages. She sees something in the middle of the menu and laughs loudly, and then closes it without any further consideration. Catra leaves her menu untouched where Charlie dropped it.

Charlie returns with a sunny smile for Adora and barely a glance at Catra when she places down their drinks. "Decide what you want, sugar?" she asks Adora, pulling out her notepad.

Adora doesn't return the smile. "Give me the Hungry Wolf's Breakfast and the Siren's Sandwich, please."

"Sure thing," Charlie takes her menu with a slightly dimmed smile before turning to Catra.

"Give me a double order of the sausage and egg special, over easy, with a side of sourdough toast," Catra answers the unspoken question.

Charlie scribbles her order down with a frown, and then gathers their menus from the table and leaves.

"Have you ever been to Madame Raz's?" Adora asks, her smile returning.

"No," Catra says, not recognizing the name.

Adora nods, like she expected this. "It's over by the commune, Raz is one of our elders. She themed the whole diner after us, all the plate names and the decorations—it's a riot. Her [illegible] is called the First Moon Special."

Catra offers her a small smile, not sure why Adora's telling her this. This diner had a few dishes with funny names, but it was mostly humans that lived around here, so there wasn't any specific supernatural group for them to cater to.

"I can take you some time, I'm sure you'd get a laugh out of it," Adora continues.

*Do*

Catra isn't sure what to say, so she spends a long minute just looking at Adora. She doesn't seem phased by it, smiling gently and meeting the stare. Catra wants to shut her down, end any notion of them going *by* after this, but the words won't come. She's already gone back on her declarations to keep Adora away, and any more would be meaningless.

So she changes the subject.

"Am I going to need to chain you up next month?"

Adora laughs in surprise, and her face heats to a rosy pink for the millionth time since they've been together. "Uh, no, no I don't think so. The chains are to keep me from running away"…

"...And you just keep running *to* me," Catra finishes uncomfortably . This is not where she wanted to shift the conversation.

"Yeah," Adora cringes and looks down. "I don't think I'll try to go anywhere if I'm...already where I want to be." She tries to swallow the end of the sentence, but Catra would have heard it even if it went unspoken.

"I'm sure the rest of the pack will be happy to see you go," Catra says.

Adora's head whips up and hurt flickers over her face.

"Because of the wolves you let out," Catra rushes to finish, realizing how rude that had sounded. "I just meant because of the other wolves learning to change"…

"Yeah," Adora agrees, softening a little. "I don't know how many more times I can cause that much trouble for them and get away

with it."

"Mara's probably waiting to read you the riot act, huh?"

Adora nods and chuckles, crossing her arms. "I'm sure she'll be grateful to have one less thing to worry about next month. It's always hard when more than one wolf is learning to change at the same time, and right now there's four of us."

"Wow," Catra says.

"Yeah. So. Sooner I can get this under control, the sooner I can be of use instead of just making things worse."

Catra's expression falls, and she's searching for something comforting to say when the kitchen doors open again and Charlie walks out with their food. Adora is just as rude to Charlie as Charlie is to Catra as she sets the plates down, and Catra finds it far more endearing than she should. Adora's order takes up more than half of the table and she starts eating before Charlie even leaves, quite literally wolfing down her food as quickly as she can.

Catra watches in amazement for a moment, never having seen anyone eat human food so quickly, and only after Adora's polished off an entire plate and moved on to the next one does Catra turn to her own meal.

She isn't that hungry, not after being with Adora for so long, but it's been a while since she actually filled her stomach with anything and she couldn't back down on her promise to Adora that she was getting a double order. So she dives in, and the rest of the meal passes with ease.

She finishes before Adora but only just, which is impressive when the Hungry Wolf's Breakfast is at least four times the sausage and egg special alone, not counting the Siren's Sandwich she got as well. The conversation is casual once they've eaten, and Catra

realizes, with a bit of alarm, how easy spending time with Adora is. How effortless.

It's terrifying.

Before she knows it, both meals have been paid to the pack's account (much to Charlie's annoyance), and Adora's yawning as she holds the door open for Catra to step into the sunshine. It's bright and burning and it prickles her skin, filling her with a constant, unrelenting buzz. It's a feeling she used to hate when she was younger, a reminder of what she was and what she had to do to live, but as the years progressed she came to appreciate it. It's a reminder of what she is, yes, but it's also a reminder of what she *isn't*. The fact that she can even stand in the sunlight, feel the rays soaking into her body and the heat warming her to just a few degrees too hot...it's a reminder that she's alive. That her heart still beats. That her life is still her own.

Catra turns her face up to the sun and lets it fizzle over her cheeks and down the long brown hair that spills over her shoulders. She soaks it in for a moment, and then turns to look at Adora.

Only to find that she's already looking back at her, her expression specific and unrecognizable. Her gaze shoots another spike of heat through Catra's body, and the two sensations feel a bit too similar to each other. Both hot and electric and just bordering on overwhelming.

Catra turns toward Adora and Adora flushes, turning away and rubbing at the back of her neck. "So," she says, "I guess I'll see you in a month?"

Catra wraps her arms around herself and nods, even though Adora still isn't looking at her. "Yeah, I guess so."

Adora takes a deep breath and peeks back at her, and her face is still burning. Her hands flex at her sides, opening and then closing into fists, and there's a split second where Catra thinks she might

step forward and embrace her. But then her hands close again and she shoves them into her sweatshirt pocket, and Catra shoves the disappointment she feels back into the dark corner it came from.

Without another word Catra turns toward the sun, closing her eyes to the brightness and starting her walk home alone.

"Wait!" she hears behind her, and she stops immediately.

She hears Adora's footfalls and turns back to find her closing the distance between them. "Um...can I have your number?" Adora asks, wincing as she does. "Just, you know, in case we need to sort anything out before next month. Plus, it seems politer to let you know when I'm coming than to just...keep showing up."

Catra blinks, and then feels a small smirk grow across her lips. "Sure. Give me your phone."

Adora grins, and reaches into her sweatshirt pocket. *Then* her sweatshirt pocket. She comes up empty, *obviously*, and then checks her shorts. And then swears. "I don't have my phone," she starts to explain, fading out at the smirk now wide on Catra's face, "...and you already knew that."

Catra barks out a laugh, and digs her own phone out of her leggings. "Here, just text yourself."

Adora takes the phone sheepishly.

"If you show up at my door unannounced again, I'm not letting you in," Catra teases, even though they both know it's a lie.

Adora smiles as she hands the phone back, and their fingers brush when Catra takes it. The rush that simple touch floods her body with is both unwelcome and exhilarating, and she can feel her instincts screaming that this is a mistake but there is no pit in the bottom of her gut. There is no lead ball weighing her down, and she feels lighter than she has in months.

“I’ll see you next month, Adora,” she says.

“Yeah,” Adora agrees, her eyes lingering as she starts to walk backwards. “I’ll see you.”

Catra turns and leaves, and the heat of Adora’s gaze on her back is hotter than the sun the whole way down the street.

Chapter End Notes

This chapter was far longer than I intended it to be, but hopefully there's enough aftercare for the angst this time :3 Things will steadily get better from here and now we can really get into the meat of things. As I said there will likely be some time until the next chapter, so leave me all your thoughts and predictions on what will happen next in the comments!

Special thanks to Jess for lending me Charlie from Take Me Home, I hope you all hated her as much as I do :)

Playlist is here!

# I Walk The Line

Chapter Summary

Mara officially meets Catra.

Chapter Notes

Title is from Halsey's cover of Johnny Cash's I Walk the Line.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A week before the full moon, Catra texts her.

*[illegible]*

And if that winky face sends a rush down her spine, it doesn't have to mean anything. Besides, this is the opening she needed. Taking a deep breath, Adora composes her message.

*[illegible]*

It takes Catra five very long minutes to reply, during which her typing bubble appears and disappears multiple times. Finally, she sends:

Catra doesn't answer, which is just as well. Adora's a little worried she'll change her mind and say they can't come if she gives her the opportunity.

She doesn't hear from her again, so she goes to The Black Eclipse on Tuesday night with Mara in tow and hopes for the best.

No matter how much she hopes for the best, she's still nervous. She's very nervous.

She's nervous, and she knows that *Mara* knows that she's nervous. She knows that Mara knows that she knows that Mara knows that she's nervous, and she doesn't even know *why* she's nervous. She just knows that she *is.*

"You're gonna knock me out if you keep swinging your arms so much," Mara says, cutting her an amused glance out of the corner of her eye as they walk.

Adora stops swinging her arms and pulls them tight against her sides, so she doesn't disturb anyone.

Mara snorts. "You can move them a little, Adora."

Adora blows out a breath of relief and relaxes them, letting her arms move naturally but taking care to keep them in her own space.

"We're almost there," Mara says, as if Adora isn't keenly aware of this fact. As if she doesn't *know* that Adora is keenly aware of this fact. She waits for a response, but when one doesn't come, she just laughs. "What the hell are you so nervous about?"

"I don't know!" She says, pulling at the hem of her shirt. She hadn't changed out of her daywear, still wearing just a plain white tee and blue jeans, but now she's thinking that maybe she should have. But *why?* They were just going to talk to Catra for a little while; it wasn't a big deal.

Mara looks nice, but not *too* nice, a carefully crafted balance of casually professional in a clean short-sleeve button-up and jeans. Maybe Adora should have worn a button-up too. At least Mara's hair is up in a braided ponytail that showed off her undercut mirrors Adora's own long ponytail enough that she doesn't feel too underdressed beside her.

Adora had grabbed her jacket at first, more for the sake of wearing it than the concern that she'd be cold, but Mara had stopped her. "This

wasn't a business meeting, just a social call, and two red pack jackets in the vampire bar might send the wrong message.

"Catra didn't seem too happy about us coming, is all," she finally settles on for an excuse.

Mara chuckles kindly. "Does she ever seem happy?"

Adora raises an eyebrow, but she can't help the smile that cracks through. "I thought you didn't know her well?"

Mara returns the smile. "I don't, but her personality doesn't seem hard to figure out."

Adora's not sure what to say to that, but it turns out she doesn't have to say anything because they've arrived. As soon as the front door is within sight, Adora darts forward, pulling it open and holding it so that Mara can be the first one through. She sees Mara stifle a laugh as she obliges, striding casually through the door like this isn't a big deal at all.

*Ugh,* Adora reminds herself. It isn't. Her pack leader showing up at a vampire bar to make an assessment of the half-vampire half-magicat woman that Adora had never met before but suddenly decided was her only escape during the hell of her first three changes so she could be sure that Adora is safe to voluntarily be with her on the next full moon isn't a big deal at all.

Okay...*hm* it's a big deal.

Maybe it's a big deal because it feels a lot like a *date* scenario, even though Mara isn't *her* her mother and Catra is *not* not her girlfriend.

And Adora is made acutely aware of that fact when she follows Mara inside and finds Catra peeking up from the bar and meeting her eyes with a tight, almost angry smile. She's only there for a second before

she bends back down and disappears, and Adora's left to stumble after Mara as she approaches the bar.

Catra pops back upright as they arrive, setting two hands onto the bartop and giving them her best grimace. She looks...very uncomfortable.

"Hey . Um, what can I get you guys?" she asks.

Mara inspects the menu for humans on the wall behind Catra, and Adora tries to catch Catra's eye to offer a reassuring smile.

Catra sees her and looks back at Mara without returning it.

"Let's try a blueberry spritzer; that sounds fun," Mara shrugs.

"Sure," Catra nods and then looks expectantly at Adora, who promptly realizes she didn't even consider that she would be expected to order something.

"Oh, uh, um, I'll just, uhhhhhh, y'know , pffft, have a—"

"Water?" Catra offers mercifully.

"Yeah, yes...please," Adora mutters, her entire body suddenly far too hot.

Catra nods and graciously turns away to make Mara's drink, and Adora lets go of a breath she didn't even realize she was holding. Something heavy claps against her back, and she turns to see Mara gripping her shoulder with a grin and shaking her head.

She's having far too much fun with this already.

"You guys can sit wherever out here," Catra says without turning around, and Adora drags Mara away from the counter as quickly as she can.

The entire open space is dead empty, and from the smell and sound of things, all of the private, curtained booths are too. Adora can smell a few other people here, maybe two, but they smell human, and it's likely they're just employees working in the back. Right now, the only people around are them and Catra, for better or worse.

Mara sits quietly while they wait for Catra to come over with their drinks, and Adora fidgets in her seat as she tries her hardest not to be awkward. She can't look at Catra because Mara will see her looking at Catra, and Catra somehow looks even hotter than normal when she's unhappy, which means she looks hella hot tonight. So if Adora looks at her, she might start staring, and if she starts staring, Mara will definitely see it, and Adora knows Mara isn't her mother, and she's a fully grown adult not under any kind of supervision about who she does or doesn't look at, but it already feels disrespectful to look at Catra the way she wants to, and it is far too embarrassing to risk Mara knowing any of that. If the last five minutes have been any indication, she would never let her live this little crush down.

Maybe it's that Mara is the closest thing she can remember to ever having a mother, even though she'd only been through 65 moons back when she took her in, or maybe it's that as her protege, Adora has a lot to live up to. She doesn't want to give Mara any reason to doubt her abilities. No more reason than the last three disastrous full moons, anyway.

Finally, Catra comes over, so Adora has a reason to look at her, and Catra sets the two drinks down with a practiced gentility. "Do you guys want anything from the kitchen?" she asks, quirking an eyebrow. "I can't promise he won't burn it – he almost set the place on fire last week just making a sandwich, toast."

Catra's irritation pulls her lips down into a frown, and her pout somehow makes her face even more beautiful. There's a tiny little wrinkle between her eyebrows, upsetting the short, thin fur there, and Adora has the overwhelming and extremely inappropriate urge to smooth it out with her thumb.

"That's fine," Mara says, startling Adora out of her reprieve. "I don't want to bother you any longer than I have to."

"Yeah. Right," Catra says, the wrinkle between her eyebrows growing as she folds her arms across her body. Adora's grateful she no longer feels underdressed next to Catra's bar shirt and black jeans, but she's extremely [illegible] about how attractive the lean muscle that ripples under the furry stripes on Catra's arms is, without even getting into the slice of hip and stomach that appears under the edge of her tied t-shirt. Adora wants to pour the entire glass of water Catra just served her right over her own head just for the hope of getting through this evening alive. Why does the solution to the hell she's going through on the full moon have to be the hottest fucking person she's ever seen in her entire life?

"Give me a few minutes to sort some things, and then I can sit down with you guys," Catra offers, backing away from the table. Mara nods, so Catra turns, and Adora finally looks away only to find Mara staring her down.

"What?" Adora asks, as if she doesn't know exactly what the smirk on Mara's face is all about.

Mara just shrugs. "I didn't say anything."

Adora glares at her and considers that her attraction to Catra feels like so much more of a burden tonight than usual because she's finally having it witnessed. And by someone who knows her even better than herself, at that.

"What are you gonna ask her?" Adora tries to direct the conversation.

Mara leans back, her smile softening, and she shrugs. "This and that," she offers unhelpfully.

Adora grumbles, and Mara rolls her eyes.

"Nothing bad, I promise," she says kindly and then quirks her head a little to the side. Adora follows her glance to Catra at the counter, bent over and writing in some book and not looking at them. Her right ear twitches ever so slightly, and Adora understands what Mara means.

If *they* can hear across the room, then so can Catra, no question. She can hear everything they're saying. Mara's only being difficult because she doesn't want to drop the suspense for Catra yet by having her overhear.

Adora considers telling her she's being mean, but she doesn't really want Catra to hear that either, so she just frowns at Mara again.

Mara winks.

Before Adora can yell at her anymore, the door to the bar opens, and a woman even larger than Huntara shoves her way inside. She's a scorpioni, that bit is immediately obvious from the tail and claws and gigantic pauldrons sprouting from under her black vest, but Adora doesn't think she's ever seen her before. She would definitely remember someone like this. The door closes behind her, and Adora takes a whiff of the air as the woman's smell spreads through it, but she doesn't smell like a vampire or any bit of supernatural besides being a hybrid.

"Catra!" The woman calls, far too loud and cheerful for how absolutely empty the place is, and Adora follows the call to see Catra straightening up and cringing and then glancing over directly at her.

Adora feels heat rush into her cheeks, even though she knows she shouldn't be embarrassed about looking over while something is actually happening.

Catra rips her gaze away and strides down the bar, reaching the corner closest to the entrance and leaning onto the countertop to hiss at the new woman.

"Hey!" She snaps quietly, obviously trying to keep their conversation private from Adora and Mara, even if she knows that they know that any attempt to do so is pointless. There is no keeping any secrets in this room, not with all of their hearing as good as it is.

There's the no keeping any secrets when the woman responds back at the same loud volume she started the conversation with. "Oh, I just finally had a free night and thought I'd bring your jacket over and see how business was! I feel like it's been forever; I can stay, and we could hang out if it's a slow night?"

The woman's voice is full of hope, and the way she approaches the counter and leans a claw onto it is a too casual for someone who doesn't work at this establishment.

"Uh, it's not really a good night, Scorp," Catra answers, her voice still low.

"Oh," Scorp answers, turning her head a little to glance around the empty place. With her back to their table, she doesn't seem to notice the two wolves. "Is it inventory day or something?"

"Shh!" Catra says meaningfully.

"Okay," the woman says, the excitement finally dropping from her voice. She lifts a claw across the counter and hands over a small black jacket. Or maybe it just looks small when she's so large. "Maybe we can hang out later this week? I really miss you, Wildcat."

The woman sounds heartbroken, and it twists Adora's stomach. What's this?

There's a moment of silence, and Adora can't see Catra's expression now that the woman has blocked her from view. But when she speaks, it's quiet and sincere. "I miss you too, Scorp. It's just not a good time tonight. I'll call you later this week, okay?"

"Okay!" the woman agrees, a bit brighter.

"Thanks for bringing my jacket," Catra says quietly.

"Anytime! I'll go now, but...do you feel up to a hug?"

There's another long moment of silence before Adora hears the quietest *yes* and then the woman is leaning bodily over the counter to crush Catra against her. It takes a moment for Catra to return it, wrapping her small arms around this woman's gigantic shoulders and tucking her head into her neck, and then the strangest thing happens.

Someone starts to growl.

Adora whips toward Mara, wondering what the hell she's going on about, only to find Mara stifling laughter with her hand.

"*What*" Adora whispers, and the second she opens her mouth, the growling ceases.

And she realizes it was *her*.

Heat floods her entire body, and Adora sinks deep into her seat, wondering if she could simply hide under the table for the rest of the night. Maybe for the rest of her *life*. No fucking way did she just *growl* at some stranger that's friends with Catra. Maybe more than friends. No fucking way did she just growl at what might be Catra's *actual* girlfriend.

Adora can't stop her eyes from flickering back to them, and when she catches Catra's eye, she officially wants to die. That's all the confirmation she needs to know that Catra *definitely* heard that.

Adora sinks further into her seat until she's just shoulders and a head above the tabletop and looks anywhere but at Catra or at Mara, who is now shaking vigorously with the effort of not laughing.

Mara is going to make fun of her for this *forever*.

Adora stares at the table and listens to Catra pull away and say goodbye to the woman, and she hears her start to walk out and then stop dead and gasp.

"*Oh my gosh* Are you Mara?" her voice calls, and Adora looks up to see her rushing over with one giant claw over her mouth.

Mara turns politely and smiles, ever the face of diplomacy. Adora realizes abruptly that she's supposed to take over that diplomacy one day when Mara retires and quickly straightens in her seat to sit like a normal person again, pretending that nothing weird had just happened at all.

"I am. Can I help you with something?" Mara greets the woman.

"*Oh* this is so cool! This is probably so weird, but I'm *such* a big fan. You're like the best She-Ra the pack has *ever* had," she gushes.

Mara chuckles and brushes the compliment off the way she always does, and Adora watches Catra close the book at the counter and make her way over. She looks at Adora when she does, and Adora promptly looks away and back to Mara.

"And you are?" Mara asks.

"Oh, ohmygosh, I'm so sorry! I'm Scorpia; I've done a lot of work with the archives at Bright Moon Estate, so I'm a bit of a nerd about the local history," Scorpia says sheepishly .

"I think *nerd* is an understatement," Catra says in lieu of a greeting. The affection in her voice is glowing, and Scorpia bends her head and blushes, and it's a strange look on a woman so imposing.

It twists something sick and ugly in Adora's gut, and she hates it.

"*Pfft* ," Scorpia agrees with a humble smile.

"Well, I'm sure your work is greatly appreciated by the estate," Mara says warmly. "Things really fell apart in the archives after the

Necrosis, and it's so important to keep all of our records. Thank you, Scorpia."

Scorpia blushes even harder and shrugs. "Oh, it's nothing. I love doing it but thank you for saying that. You're just as nice as everyone says!"

Mara chuckles and waves her away before motioning to the rest of the table. "This is Adora, by the way, my protege."

Adora grits her teeth and tries to smile at Catra's girlfriend (who's already so in love with Mara's She-Ra that Adora will clearly never have a hope of living up to the title when she takes over). She extends a hand, and Scorpia catches it in her pincer, shaking it so vigorously Adora considers she might actually be trying to hurt her.

"Oh wow! It's so great to meet you, I've heard so much, but I didn't know you were in training yet! That's so exciting!"

"Yeah," Adora agrees tightly, extracting her hand as politely as she can and sparing a glance at Catra. She looks excessively uncomfortable again and seems to be pointedly avoiding her gaze.

She's not surprised she wasn't recognized without the jacket – she won't start officially shadowing Mara until she's got her change under control, but if Scorpia didn't know it had even started, then she certainly didn't know that she'd been spending her full moons with Catra.

Her girlfriend.

Adora hadn't questioned why Catra had clothing big enough to fit her after the last two moons when Catra was notably smaller than her and wasn't privy to the same height and weight fluctuations that normal humans encountered...but it would sure make a lot of sense if that hadn't even been her own clothing at all.

Had Catra withheld telling Scorpia about her for the same reason she'd withheld from Adora that she'd given her Scorpia's clothes to wear? Why was that something to hide? What was going on, and why did Adora suddenly feel so sick trying to figure it out?

"Didn't you need to go, Scorpia?" Catra asks, not even trying to sound polite.

"What?" Scorpia turns to look at her , pauses, and then looks at the wolves around the table. And then she looks back at Catra and blinks. "Oh. Is there something going on?" she asks, her face twisting in confusion.

"Y eah, *kf* I can call you later, okay?" Catra of fers.

Scorpia's confusion only seems to grow, and she looks back at the wolves, and Adora almost feels bad for her. Whatever was happening between her and Catra (which was *ot*g , she reminded herself), Scorpia didn't know anything about it.

"Sure, sure," she excuses herself and with one last gushing goodbye to Mara, Scorpia leaves.

Catra doesn't relax until the door has fully swung shut behind her. "Sorry about that," she grumbles as she takes a seat at the table. "I didn't know she was coming by."

Mara shrugs and smiles and Adora tries to relax her jaw . Whatever that was, it's over for now.

"Not a problem," Mara says. "She was very nice."

"T oo nice for her own good," Catra agrees, setting her elbows onto the table and curling her tail around the back of her chair. "So. Let' s get this over with."

Adora wasn't expecting her to be excited about this, but her dreadful tone just adds to the pit in Adora' s gut.

"Sure," Mara obliges, leaning one arm onto the table casually. "We'll start easy."

Adora tries to shoot Mara a warning glance (what the hell was *that* supposed to mean?), but it's like she and Catra have entered a zone where Adora no longer exists. They're both staring each other down like a challenge, except Mara looks excited about it, and Catra looks like she might be sick.

"Do you work here full-time?" Mara asks.

Adora blows out a breath she didn't know she was holding, but Catra just seems to tense further.

"Yeah," is all she offers as a response.

"Netossa's great," Mara says, as if she was just making conversation. But Adora knows better. "I've known her and Spinerella a long time."

"Yeah, they're great," Catra says flatly. Guarded.

Mara nods, like she's appraising her. "If Adora hurts you, are you prepared to deal with that?"

"*What?*" Adora exclaims, startling forward. What kind of question was that?!

Neither woman spares her a glance, their eyes still trained directly onto one another. "Why would she hurt me?" Catra asks, her tone even.

"Maybe we've got it wrong," Mara shrugs. "Maybe she just runs from whoever she's with when it starts, and it's not about you at all. Maybe she'll try to run home to us instead this time."

The crease between Catra's eyebrows returns. "That doesn't make her violent."

"It could make her careless, oblivious," Mara continues, like Adora isn't right there in front of her listening. "What if she hurts you?"

"I'm not going to *let* her–" Adora cuts in, leaning hard onto the table and wondering what the hell Mara is playing at. Had she gotten this wrong? Was Mara trying to scare Catra away on purpose? What reason would she even have for doing that?

"Then I guess I'm the perfect candidate," Catra answers, not even acknowledging Adora's outburst, "since I don't hurt easily. She might be stronger than me, but she's certainly not faster."

"Can you guys not talk about me like I'm not even here?" Adora yells, even though Catra isn't wrong. She'd never be that fast, not even as a wolf.

When Adora looks back at Mara, she's smiling. "You'd get hurt to keep her from running?"

Adora's head swivels back to Catra, only to find that she's...blushing? Her cheeks are blooming with a darkness Adora's never seen be so violent before, and it doesn't make any sense until she mutters, *"Only."*

Something light and fluttery flips in Adora's stomach, and it is a welcome reprieve from the dread that's been locked in there all night. It feels nice, even if she doesn't fully understand it.

Mara's smile widens, and she leans back with a shrug. "That's all I wanted to hear."

Catra scoffs loudly but relaxes as well. "You couldn't have just asked that outright?"

"And pass up the chance to have some fun?" Mara asks, as if it's something completely outrageous. *"Rude."*

Catra rolls her eyes and folds her arms over her chest, but she's smirking hard enough that one of her fangs is peeking out.

Finally, Mara acknowledges Adora. She looks over and nods toward Catra in the most obvious and approving manner, and Adora hadn't thought she could make this night any more embarrassing, but somehow, she just managed to. And in case that wasn't enough, Mara opens her big, loud mouth, too.

"I like her ."

Adora can feel her face burning bright red, and she wants to sink under the table for the second time that night, but she hears Catra giggle with a squeak and looks over to see her smiling at her , and if embarrassment is the price she has to pay for a sight that beautiful, then so be it. She would pay that price every night of her life.

Mara starts shuffling around and pulls out a wallet Adora didn't even know she owned and produces a couple bills from it.

Catra straightens up and holds a hand out, shaking her head. "Humans drink free," she says.

Mara just shakes her head and places the money on the table. "We're not humans, and if you think Netossa would ever let me come and drink here without paying, you don't know her as well as you think you do."

Catra chuckles and takes the money after another moment of hesitation. Adora knows Mara is just being nice—she can't attest to her relationship with Netossa as she's never formally met the woman, but she knows the pack doesn't have an open tab here like they do in most of the establishments through the city. Sending a bill to them later this week just for one drink would be a big hassle. None of the wolves commonly carried that much cash on them because of their open tabs and the labor they usually offered as payment, but there was little they could offer to the vampires here except to stay out of their business. So for Mara to go out of her way to bring it, just

to pay for one measly drink...it was a very big and considerate gesture.

Which is likely *why* why Catra was being so awkward about it.

"Thanks," she finally says, nodding.

Mara nods back and then promptly downs the rest of her spritzer and stands.

Adora fumbles to stand as Catra does too, and then she realizes she never even took a single sip of her water. She grabs it and downs half of it before she catches Catra's raised eyebrow and stops. She sets it down with a wince, and Catra rolls her eyes, and Mara clears her throat.

"Thanks for having us, Catra, and thank you for offering to help us like this. Sincerely...it means a lot." She nods and then offers her hand.

After a moment, Catra takes it. She doesn't say anything back, but she shakes Mara's hand firmly and *almost* smiles.

Mara takes that as the win it is and starts to make her way to the door. Adora tries to convey with her own pathetic smile that she's *so* sorry Mara was so harsh but really glad that it ended as well as it did. She knows the look lands well when Catra just snorts at her. Seeming all too aware that Mara can still hear them, she bites back a retort and just says, "See you Friday, dork."

And for some reason, it feels like a promise.

"See you Friday," Adora agrees and then hurries after Mara.

As soon as the door swings shut behind them and there's a hint of a chance that Catra won't hear it, Adora shoves Mara as hard as she can.

"*WHAT?*" she exclaims quietly.

Mara bursts out laughing and recovers enough to slam her shoulder into Adora's side even harder. "Consider it a rite of passage, pup," she says with a smirk.

No wonder it had felt like Catra meeting her parents; Mara had meant for it to. "I hate you," Adora scowls.

Mara scoops a thick arm around her neck and yanks her down, mussing up her ponytail with her other hand. "Then I guess I'm doing this leader thing right!"

"Get off!" Adora complains, hip-checking Mara and then ducking out from her grasp.

"Get back here! You're not done with initiation!" Mara laughs, making another playful grab for her.

Adora twists out of the way and laughs back, her anger fading a little with Mara's good mood. "What's next, giving me a swirlie in the toilets?"

"Of course not," Mara stops, straightening up with a look of grave offense. "It's helping Old Razz clean her toes."

Adora shudders, shaking her head and backing up. Mara was older, but she was also a little slower. If Adora made a run for it, she *might* beat her back home. "Absolutely not," she refuses.

"Then I guess you won't pass," Mara shrugs seriously, ambling closer. "Unless," and then, as if she's read her mind, she takes off sprinting. "You can beat me back home!" she shouts over her shoulder, but Adora is already racing behind her, and before the end of the street, she's passing her.

They sprint the entire way home, and right before the finish line, Mara comes out of left field with a final burst of speed. She wins by the length of her braid, and when Adora collapses onto the floor and

struggles to catch her breath, Mara just laughs. She kicks her thigh gently and shakes her head.

"Guess it's Raz's toes for you tonight. You can get started after dinner."

Adora groans loudly as the other wolves passing by overhear and start laughing, and she lays there for a few minutes until her lungs remember how to work again.

Only two more days until Friday.

Chapter End Notes

> Hope you liked this update! This is one of my favorite chapters, and it goes out to everyone who waited very patiently for the update; y'all are my favorites <3 I have a lot I want to do with this story, and it takes time to get it right. I also increased the chapter count so that I can pace the story beats more evenly.
>
> The next chapter will come soon-ish, life permitting. Thanks for reading!

# Water Under the Bridge

Chapter Summary

Friday arrives. Adora goes through it again. Catra confronts the truth.

CW: this chapter describes a graphic werewolf transformation.

Chapter Notes

Title is from Water Under the Bridge by Adele.
(and yes, I did the body-ody dance approximately a million times while writing this chapter.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra barely sleeps Friday morning, too focused on the upcoming moonrise and figuring out why she feels so anxious about it. She's bought everything she could think that Adora might need tonight, and the other moons have gone by without any preparation, but for some reason, the anticipation is knotted into her stomach like a tangle of razor-sharp wires. She's not even hungry enough to blame her nerves on her vampire side — seeing Adora just a few days ago has been enough to take the edge off the discomfort of her hunger and lessen it into dissatisfaction.

Seeing Adora just a few days ago had definitely also contributed to this, though, at least with Mara's interrogation.

Catra likes Mara. She's always respected her, and she might even admit to liking her out loud now, but their meeting only served to emphasize what a big choice she'd made last month in extending her hand to Adora. Now it feels like a commitment — a promise — and it scares her how much she cares about not fucking it up.

So, Friday passes in fits of tossing and turning, and she's up long before the sun goes down. Adora had texted her yesterday that the moon was rising not long after the sun would set, so it was best if she came over during daylight hours. If that was alright with Catra, of course.

Catra had rolled her eyes and texted back that that was the entire purpose of this, so yes, it was fine. But now, it's got her sitting on her couch before sunset and counting the minutes down on her phone.

Most of the other residents in the apartments around hers are humans, which was why she had moved in there a few years ago, but it was also why she'd soundproofed her entire apartment as well as she could. Humans are alive, which is helpful, but they're also noisy as hell, and she can only stand hearing so much when she's trying to sleep. Her soundproofing means she can easily tune out most of the noise beyond her apartment walls most of the time, which is usually a big relief.

Except for now, when she's straining to hear one specific set of heavy footfalls climbing her stairs.

She considers opening the door or waiting at the bottom of the stairs for the fifth time in the last five minutes, but she hates how eager that makes her look, so she resolves ~~-a~~lso for the fifth time in the last five minutes ~~-th~~at she is going to keep her ass planted on this couch until Adora makes it to her door and knocks.

And then someone knocks on her door.

Catra shoots up, ears twitching and straining, and as she approaches the door, she can hear a familiar heartbeat and a loud exhale of air. That's it. Adora ~~-w~~why the hell didn't she hear her coming?

Catra twists the lock and yanks the door open to find Adora standing right outside the doorway, a nervous smile on her face and a small backpack thrown over her shoulder. She's not wearing her jacket

and is *fucking* wearing a shirt, some sort of muscle tee monstrosity with the sleeves cut off so her bulging biceps are on display like a fucking feast. Catra's eyes drip down her body to find some mercy at her shorts, which are big and loose and gracefully cover the entire expanse of her thighs.

Well, now the stupid tan lines make sense.

Catra keeps looking because she can't *stop,* but her eyes halt when they land on Adora's shoes.

"What...the *fuck*," her gaze flickers up to meet Adora's eyes, "are *those*?"

They both look down at Adora's feet, clad in the most atrocious things Catra has ever seen. She's not even sure they can count as *shoes*, even though that's clearly how Adora is treating them.

Adora picks up one foot and surveys the unidentifiable material covering it. "What?" she asks, her head tilting in confusion. "You don't like my crocs?"

The *crocs* in question are black all over, except around the soles, where a too vibrant striped fucking *yellow* patterns the perimeter of the "shoe." The stupid little strap thingy is around the back of her heel, and Catra can see her fucking *foot* through the holes in the top. Catra doesn't know *how* is punishing her, but she knows this is the cost of something she's done. This is payment for her atrocities.

"Those are staying outside," she announces, wrenching her gaze away from them and shuddering.

"What?" Adora exclaims, looking affronted. "What if someone steals them?"

"You think someone's gonna steal from *us*?" Catra asks, crossing her arms tightly. None of her neighbors would *dare*.

Adora falters at her look. "W ell...what if it rains?"

Catra raises an eyebrow to the clear, bright sky. "Not in the forecast. And aren't they meant to get wet anyway?"

"Not these!" she protests, her lower lip jutting out just a touch. It' s infuriatingly adorable. "These are my dry ones."

Catra growls, staring her down and tightening her resolve. But Adora's lip slides out just a touch more, plump and round and pathetic, and she's a fucking *sl* .

"They go inside the door , and if I see you walking around in them, you're *de*" she threatens and turns on her heel, striding back inside before Adora breaks her down even more.

Adora follows her inside with a noise of delight and kicks them off as soon as she gets the door closed. "*Th* she sings in a light, sweet voice that Catra knows will haunt her dreams tomorrow.

She doesn't answer.

Turning and resting her hip against the kitchen counter to keep some space between them, she asks, "How much time do we have?"

Adora sets her bag down next to her crocs and ambles further into the living room, swinging her arms like she doesn't know what to do with herself. She blows a breath out and observes the window —the curtains are drawn, and the bright light beyond them is starting to change color, warming and dimming.

"Uh...fifteen? T wenty minutes, maybe?"

"Okay ," Catra nods, mind racing as to how they can pass twenty minutes with as little awkwardness as possible. "Do you need...anything...before it starts?"

Adora claps her hands together quietly , fidgeting and snapping and clapping again as she shrugs. "No, I...I think I'm good?"

"You think?" Catra teases, quirking an eyebrow.

Adora rolls her eyes and the tension in her shoulders seems to loosen a little. "I'm good," she repeats more confidently.

"Okay. If you change your mind, um...I picked up a few snacks and stuff," she shrugs, like it's no big deal.

Adora blinks. "You got me snacks?"

Catra can feel heat crawling up her neck and she crosses her arms, willing the blush down. "I can eat them too, dumbass," she snips.

But that's all the confirmation Adora needs, and a smug grin crawls over her face. "You totally got me snacks."

"Whatever," Catra scoffs. "It's not because I like you; I just don't want you passing out in my living room or something," she deflects, but Adora's grin doesn't fade.

She does, however, stop pushing, which Catra greatly appreciates. "What'd you get?" she asks instead, bouncing her way into the kitchen and grabbing for the fridge door.

"No!" Catra starts, dashing over and slamming the door shut before it can fully open. Adora startles and lets go immediately, looking down at her in shock. Catra's eyes widen as she realizes what she's just done and forces herself to ease up her grip on the door before she dents it.

"It's, uh, they're not in the fridge," she stumbles through, nodding behind Adora to the rest of the kitchen. "They're in the cabinet."

Adora looks at her for a long minute, her eyes dragging from her face to her hand still plastered on the door. Catra forces herself to let go of it and relax her hand back down to her side. It's not a big deal if she sees. It's not. She doesn't need to be weird about this.

Adora looks back to her face and blinks, and then graciously nods and offers her a gentle smile. "Okay , sure." she agrees. "Cabinet." And like nothing at all had just happened, she turns on her heel and follows Catra's directions to the snacks.

Catra lets out a long sigh, cataloging the tension in her body and forcing it to release. She could have just asked her not to open the fridge, like a normal person, or like an even better host, she could have shown her where the snacks were before she had to go looking.

Alternatively, she could accept the fact that Adora already knows exactly what she is and that it's not weird at all for her to be stocked accordingly for her condition.

But that's not a step Catra feels ready to take tonight.

Adora gasps, and Catra finally steps away from the fridge to see what she's looking at. She snatches something out of the cabinet and spins towards her, eyes bright with excitement and affection. "Did you know these are my favorites?" she demands, clutching a tiny bag of fruit snacks to her chest.

On a whim, Catra had perused the section of children's snacks in the store, and when she'd seen packages of fruit snacks in various animal shapes, she'd just had a feeling. Apparently, it had been correct.

"You're not hard to figure out," is how she responds, and Adora just smiles wider. She snatches another bag from the cabinet and then tries to shut it. The door hangs awkwardly at first, and Adora tries again, grinning at it with satisfaction when she gets it to close correctly. She skips back to the couch and then pauses.

"...Am I allowed to sit on this if I only have two legs?"

Catra can't help the laugh that escapes her, and she follows her back around the island and nods. "Yeah, it's fine when you're not

dirty and covered in fur."

"Hey , I'm not dirty when I'm a wolf!" she objects, and Catra crosses her arms.

"Are you aware of how much you *shed* when you change?"

Adora yelps. "My body is *hers*, what do you want from me?!"

"For you to keep your sweat and fur off my nice couch!"

Adora rolls her eyes and plops down onto the couch, digging through her fruit snacks and brightening when she pulls out one shaped like a horse. "Fine," she agrees, popping the snack into her mouth. "Any other rules?"

Catra huffs, but she really doesn't have any besides that one. "Don't cause a ruckus? And try not to break anything," she says, toeing the rips in the carpet that she still hasn't fixed.

Adora follows her gaze and winces. "I can still pay for that," she offers.

Catra brushes her off. "It' s fine; I never liked it anyway ."

Adora nods and then glances behind her. "The light in the window is dimming considerably, and their time is almost up. "The air is starting to charge with Adora's power, and Catra can feel herself feeding off of it.

Adora shakes the rest of the bag out into her mouth and then stands. "I think I should get ready ," she says with her mouth full, bending over towards her backpack and unzipping it. "I can feel it coming."

"Y eah," Catra agrees, watching her . "I can smell it."

"Y ou can smell it?" Adora asks, straightening up and reaching for the hem of her shirt.

"Yeah..." Catra says again, the rest of her explanation vanishing as Adora pulls her shirt right over her head without ceremony and starts folding it in her hands. All she's got on is a black sports bra with a rainbow band that looks unnervingly coordinated with her 'shoes,' and almost everything Catra's been trying to avoid thinking about every time she's gone to sleep for the last *month* is now proudly on display. She knew this would be something she would have to confront again, she *did* hadn't forgotten about that, but she also really hadn't expected Adora to just start stripping down naked in her living room with absolutely no warning.

Thank goodness she kept the curtains closed.

Adora notices that Catra hasn't said anything else and looks up, and then winces and shifts uncomfortably. "*Sorry*, uh, I can do this somewhere else—"

"No, *no*," Catra rushes to stop her, eyes mercifully landing on her face once again. "No, it's—"

"It's just, it's not something I think about with the pack—"

"It's *totally* fine—"

"I didn't even think—"

"*Really*, it's—"

"I don't want to make you uncomfortable—"

"Not like I haven't seen it before—"

Adora stops, bites her lip, and nods. Catra tracks the movement with every ounce of self-control she has. "Yeah, okay, yeah. Sorry...*Uh*"

"It's fine," Catra says one more time, forcing her eyes away to give Adora a modicum of privacy.

"What does it smell like?" Adora prompts, and Catra can see her shucking her shorts off from the corner of her eye. She definitely does *not* look.

"Uh, y'know, *fresh*," she jokes. Adora offers her a chuckle, and she shrugs. "It just smells like power, honestly. Raw, and—" she inhales deeply, the smell of soaking earth filling her lungs. The scent is so strong she can taste it on her tongue. "Sharp," she lands on. "When it's over, it lingers, but it's much sweeter."

"Huh," Adora says, bending a little to take her socks off. "I guess I know what you mean, but I feel it more than I smell it."

"Yeah, I'm sure," Catra agrees, peeking back at Adora when she sees her straighten up and take a few tentative steps closer.

She still has her underclothes on, thank god, but that's all.

"I think I have a couple of minutes now," Adora says, scratching the back of her neck nervously. "It hasn't started burning just yet."

"Why the hell are you so *open*?" Catra blurts, her tone sharp and angry. She doesn't even realize that she's said it aloud until Adora turns bright red.

"*What*?" she asks, soft and confused.

"Just, like, look at you!" Catra fumbles, crossing her arms tighter across herself. Her ears pin back against the sides of her head. "You're gigantic! Why are you gigantic?"

Adora barks out a laugh, and then she has the audacity to bring her arms over her head and flex. "Why? Like what you see?" she asks, wiggling her eyebrows.

Catra can feel her blush burning all over her body, and the growl that comes out of her is instinctive. "No," she lies, like a lying liar that lies.

"It's just, like, all of you guys. All you wolves, you're all, like, gigantic *beasts*. Is it a genetic thing?"

Yeah, that's a good recovery. *Better*.

Adora laughs again and drops her arms, but she still seems far more arrogant now than she did when she first stripped down. "I guess? A little bit," she shrugs. "It's definitely in our genes, but most of it is intentional. We start building up as soon as we can." She slaps a hand to her massive shoulder as if to show it off, as if Catra hasn't been ogling it since she arrived at her apartment.

"How come?" she manages to ask.

Adora shivers and then winces, and Catra can smell another wave of sharp earth hit the air as the change comes closer. Adora eases herself down to sit on the floor. "It's supposed to make it easier," she says, looking down at herself. "The change...it's supposed to be easier to deal with the stronger you are. Easier to recover from afterward."

Catra follows her, sitting down a few feet away and crossing her legs. Her tail wraps around herself. "Does it make it easier?"

Adora looks up at her, and there's a vulnerability in her eyes that wasn't there a moment ago. It hurts to look at, but Catra doesn't look away. "I don't know," Adora admits. "Nothing seems to make it easier." She drifts off, and Catra nods.

*Except you* goes unsaid.

A quiet moment of silence stretches between them where Catra is unsure of what to say, and Adora seems a little lost in her thoughts. And then, she pulls her legs in to mirror Catra's position, and she says, "Can I ask you something?"

Catra nods, eyes tracing over Adora's face to find her question.

It’s not what she expects.

“Who’s Scorpia?”

Catra blinks. “What?”

Adora’s cheeks turn a light pink, and she winces. “Sorry, you don’t, uh. You don’t have to answer that. That’s probably, um—”

“She’s a friend,” Catra interrupts, watching the way Adora’s fingers are fidgeting in her lap. Scorpia showing up had been weird, sure, but Mara hadn’t seemed too insulted by the interruption. Why was Adora asking this?

“Just a friend?” Adora asks, her face pinched and her voice so quiet that Catra wouldn’t have even heard it if she wasn’t a vampire. She almost sounds scared.

Something occurs to Catra, and she can feel her heart pick up;she can feel the light fluttering in her chest. It’s warm...and confusing.

“Is that why you growled at her?” Catra asks, blinking as she puts the pieces together. “It was her you growled at, wasn’t it?” She had heard it loud and clear across the bar Tuesday night, and when she caught Adora’s eyes, there had been no doubt about who it came from. But, no matter how many times Catra re-ran the scene through her head, she hadn’t been able to figure out why it had happened.

Adora’s cheeks darken to the color of an overripe tomato, and she hangs her head a little lower. “I—”

Her embarrassment emboldens Catra into smirking. “Did you growl at Scorpia because you thought we were dating?”

“No!” Adora practically shouts, her head whipping up. “No, definitely not, pfft no, why would I be—?”

“You thought I was dating Scorpia?” Catra shouts back, her voice caught between laughter and outright confusion.

"No! No, I didn't! I just... I..." Adora drifts off, eyes wide while she obviously searches for an excuse, and Catra cackles.

"You absolutely DID, and you *glow* at her for it!" Catra exclaims between deep laughs.

"It wasn't on purpose!" Adora whines, finally breaking down. "I didn't mean to. I didn't even *know* it was me, I just—I'm *so* sorry," she laments, but Catra is still laughing.

"Why did you think we were *here*?" Catra runs the scenario of her and Scorpia being together through her mind for just a second before it becomes so unrealistic she has to laugh at it.

"You hugged her!" Adora starts, and Catra's laughter turns into a roar. "And she brought you a jacket and said she missed you and wanted to hang out, and you didn't," she drifts off and shrugs.

Catra's laughter eases, and she leans forward. "I didn't *know*," she teases.

Adora bites her lip, and the rest of her mouth pulls down into a frown. Her dark eyebrows converge together, and her hands are fisted in her lap.

Catra's laughter stops altogether.

"What?" she prompts, all humor gone from her voice.

"...You didn't tell her about me," Adora says quietly, staring at the floor.

The words sink into Catra and twist into heavy guilt that presses on her lungs and makes it hard to breathe. She *had* told Scorpia about Adora, but it wasn't for the reason she was thinking. It wasn't even for a *bad* reason...it was just because she was scared to admit it. Because she knew Scorpia would treat it like the big deal that it was.

"No," Catra answers quietly. "I didn't."

Adora's gaze flickers up to her before falling back to the floor, and Catra can see the hurt written all over her face. How had she managed to fuck this up *so* *g*?

"I'm not dating Scorpia," Catra starts slowly. "And I didn't tell her about you. I just haven't seen her recently and...I didn't want to tell her then and have her make a big deal of it in front of you and Mara. She's great, but she can be...*obnoxious*...and I was already really nervous," she admits softly. "I didn't realize it would hurt you."

Adora peeks up at her, and the corner of her mouth is raised, the hint of a smile flickering across her lips. "You were nervous?"

Catra shoots her a glare, but there's no bite to it.

A full, soft smile spreads over Adora's face. "You should be careful," she says, and her words are still quiet, but they're teasing, too. "Between that and the snacks, I might start thinking you like me or something."

Catra scowls, ignoring the way that her heart jumps once again at Adora's words. She opens her mouth to let Adora know that she definitely does *not* like her, but as soon as she does, Adora's head jerks back, and she screams.

The change rolls through the air, and Adora comes back to herself, whimpering and grabbing at her body in pain. After a deep breath, she lets go and reaches for her remaining clothing, yanking it off clumsily. She pulls her ponytail out, and Catra freezes in the middle of reaching out, caught between offering sympathy and the absolute eyeful she gets as Adora finishes throwing her things at her backpack and gets onto all fours.

"You don't—" Adora starts, cutting off with a whimper as the first shockwave runs through her. "You don't have to watch this," she says, turning her head to catch Catra's eye.

Catra drops her hand and straightens, frowning. "Adora, that's the thing what I'm here for. Just shut up and tell me what to do," she demands, moving closer and resting on her knees.

"Talk to me." Adora manages through gritted teeth. "Touch me...if you don't mind. Just...keep me calm." She whimpers again, and Catra reaches for her back, rubbing a soothing hand between her shoulder blades. Adora nods immediately, relaxing a little and letting her head hang down. Her hair falls forward and pools on the floor as her fingers dig into the carpet. "If it gets to be too much, you can leave," she says quietly.

Catra rubs a thumb over her spine, feeling the heat rising as her body prepares. "I've already seen this twice," she reminds her gently.

She hears a quick exhale of air, and Adora's head shakes ever so slightly.

"*Nope,*" is all she manages to get out before it starts.

Her entire body shudders, and she cries out in pain, her head jerking up as her spine *moves* under Catra's hand. It's shifting in a way that it shouldn't, and with another cry and pop, her shoulders begin to rearrange themselves.

Catra's hand is frozen on Adora's back, paralyzed in horror as she looks on at the change. It's happening faster than any of the transformations back that she's witnessed, but the pain and heat rolling off of her body are far greater than any of the others as well. Adora's body is shaking with the effort of holding herself up as her limbs rework themselves and her skin turns to fur, and Catra understands what Adora meant when she said she hadn't seen this before. She'd assumed this would just be the reverse of changing back, to change *to*, but it is not. Her body already understands how to become human again, but it is still learning how to become a wolf.

Adora's whimper turns into a scream as something snaps, and it jolts Catra back into action. She was not here to witness;she was here to

help.

"It's okay," she rushes to say, dragging her hand over Adora's back even as the feeling of her morphing skin turns Catra's stomach. "You're okay; you're doing great. You're doing really good," she rambles, not even sure if Adora can hear her over her own cries.

Catra can see her hair shortening as her fur grows instead, and with a series of quick cracks, her neck and shoulders finish restructuring themselves. Catra shifts her hand up to dig her fingers into the fur and rub at the base of her neck, sure it must be aching now that it's done moving.

Adora whimpers loudly and relaxes slightly, shifting her shaking limbs to push into Catra's hand.

"That's it," Catra soothes, rubbing a little harder now that she knows it's appreciated. "You're almost there."

Adora groans, and Catra's not sure if it's an answer or a coincidence; she has no idea how conscious Adora is right now. How much of her mind is thought and how much is just *pain* and Catra shifts closer at that thought. Adora's back end is still cracking and shaking, trying to figure out if it's human or monster, so Catra wraps her arm over the top of her shoulders and buries her hand back into her fur. "You're doing so good."

Adora leans into her with another whimper, but when Catra tries to peek at her face, she turns it away.

"It's okay, you're okay," Catra repeats, willing her voice to stay strong. The change seems to have slowed, but a good deal of Adora's body is still in limbo between human and wolf. Catra wants to ask what's happened, but she's sure Adora's vocal cords are too far gone now to tell her. So she thinks back to what Adora said and pulls her a little closer.

"Can you understand me?" she asks, scratching down Adora's neck and shoulders.

Adora nods immediately, face still turned away and body trembling as she hovers in the middle of the transformation.

"Good," Catra breathes, "good. You're doing so good. Can...can you look at me?"

She can feel Adora tense, breathing hard and hesitating.

"Adora?"

For another moment, Adora stays still; her body paralyzed the way her change is. And then, slowly, she turns her head just enough to see Catra from the corner of her eye.

And Catra can see why she doesn't turn it more.

It's caught in the in-between like the rest of her, her body unable to decide what it is. Her jaw is half-snout, and her ears almost look like Catra's, except the fur hasn't covered them yet, and her eyes look wild and inhuman.

Catra sees the fear in Adora's glowing eyes, and it digs into her heart as her resolve hardens into stone. She cannot show Adora how scared she is too, how terrifying this is to watch. Not now, at least. That's not what she needs.

Catra's fingers tighten in Adora's fur and she straightens her face, nodding at her. "Good girl. Good. You're doing *so* good. You have to keep going, okay? It's not over."

Adora lets out a noise that's hard to distinguish, but it sounds like she's scared.

"I'm right here," Catra says, even though she's never felt so helpless in her life. "You can do this. Trust yourself. Keep going."

Adora stares at her for a long moment, her expression unreadable, until suddenly, she starts to tremble. She looks down, and a low groaning starts in her throat that deepens until it turns into a growl. Catra watches her squeeze her eyes shut and widen her lips into a snarl, and then with a hard shudder, the change picks up again. And it happens faster than it ever has.

The rest of her fur grows rapidly as her limbs finish lengthening and her face sorts itself out. Something hits Catra's hip, and she turns to find Adora's entire back end has finished changing, tail and all. Adora's head starts to shake until her entire body is following, and after a long shudder, her growling fades out and the change is over.

Adora collapses against her with force and Catra laughs, the rest of her fear releasing with the noise. Without thinking, she pulls Adora into her, accepting her urgent nuzzles and running her hands over Adora's sides.

"See?" Catra asks, scratching down Adora's back and letting a heavy sigh out. "You did it."

Adora responds by burrowing her head under Catra's chin and letting out a throaty noise. For a minute, Catra just lets her stay there, her warmth and weight more welcome than she expected.

She's not sure how much Adora can answer her, but she seems to be pretty present, and Catra can't wait until she turns back to find out. "Did that help?" she asks, pulling back a little to look at Adora. "Was that better? Do you feel okay?"

Adora whines, and before Catra can decipher if it's a good or bad whine, a long wet tongue licks up the side of her face.

"*Ah!*" she shrieks, shoving the wolf out of her lap and scrambling to her feet. "What have we talked about?"

Adora is completely undaunted, barking happily and shoving herself into Catra's shins hard, which makes her think Adora is *fine*.

cognizant and knows exactly what she's doing.

"You are *so* annoying," Catra snaps, trying to step away while Adora winds her giant body around her legs like the world's largest cat.

Adora barks again and seems to grin, and Catra can *hear* the smug remarks she would definitely be returning if only she could speak right now. Catra's never felt more grateful that she *can't*.

---

The night passes quickly, and the change back comes just as the first hints of dawn filter through the curtains.

It's the fastest change yet.

Catra barely has time to comfort Adora as her body works through it, and Adora seems to be more focused as it happens. Catra can see the difference in her movements, the usual tension flipped to a willing strength, and when it finally finishes, she is exhausted and sweaty and smiling. Before Catra can stop her, she sits up and throws her arms around Catra's neck.

"Thank you," she breathes, and Catra thinks she continues speaking, but she doesn't hear a single word of it. Adora is on her knees, leaning over her, chest to chest, *burying* her face in Catra's hair and jamming Catra's face into the hot sticky space where her shoulder meets her neck. She smells like the change and rain and *fear*, and the smell is pounding inside her head like it's digging for something. It's submerging her, overwhelming everything, filling her lungs to the top, and there is something she is scared of in the depths of this feeling. Something she is scared to embrace. She wants to gasp for fresh air, but her nose is pressed against Adora's skin, and if she

breathes, it's like she can taste her. If she licks her, she will taste her. If she opens her mouth, she can bite her.

Something inside of her sings, burns, and she wants it.

She wants to taste her.

It takes every ounce of restraint she has, and then some, to shove her hand between her mouth and Adora's neck and wrestle her backward enough to turn her face to the ceiling.

"Adora," she warns, and the word is strangled. "Be"

Adora freezes, then releases her and scoots backward in one quick, clumsy motion. "Sorry, sorry, sorry, oh my god, I'm so sorry."

Catra curls her claws into fists to keep from reaching out for her and shakes her head. She stares at the ceiling as she wrestles herself into submission, the flat white paint an easier sight to digest than Adora's wide eyes and open mouth. She has never felt something like that before, not once. And that isn't even what scares her the most about it.

She breathes in slowly, and she can still smell Adora all around her, but it is lighter, so she screws her eyes shut and just breathes until the monster in her chest quiets its roar to a growl. She can feel Adora's eyes on her, and hear her short, tense breaths, but she will just have to live with the unknown for now. There is no way that Catra can even begin to explain what just happened.

Finally, finally, she opens her eyes and looks back down.

Adora is still sitting with an apology on her lips and caution in her eyes, and Catra can only look at her face for a moment before she has to stare at the wall behind her to keep her eyes from drifting.

"Please don't do that."

"I'm *so* sorry," Adora gushes immediately, cheeks flushing with blood.

Catra shuts her eyes completely and shakes her head once more. "It's fine...Can you please get dressed?"

"Oh," Adora starts, and Catra refuses to open her eyes, but she can hear and feel Adora scramble to her feet and search for her clothes. Catra waits until she closes the bathroom door and starts running the tap to open her eyes and let out a silent scream.

She hadn't thought this through enough when she made her offer. Adora, pitiful and in pain as she turned in and out of being a monster, was one thing to deal with, but Adora hot and sweaty and naked, pressing all up against her to thank her, was another thing entirely, and she was definitely too gay to handle that one.

By the time Adora resurfaces, Catra's gotten her lesbian bloodlust back under control and straightened up the living room. Adora ambles out of the bathroom awkwardly, and Catra's about to reassure her again that it's really fine when she speaks up.

"Could I have some more of those snacks?"

Catra snorts in surprise and nods. "Yeah, Adora, I got them for you."

A wide grin cracks across Adora's face as she skips to the broken cabinet. "I know they were for me," she says smugly, grabbing some gummies and a package of beef jerky.

Catra rolls her eyes and watches her, now in a fresh set of what looks like gym clothes that mercifully cover more of her than the outfit she arrived in. Even as she wolfs her food down, she still manages to yawn at least three times, and by the time both snack packages are empty, she suddenly looks exhausted.

"You okay?" Catra asks, eyeing her carefully.

"What?" Adora starts to ask, but the word is cut off by yet another yawn. Catra raises her eyebrow higher, and Adora chuckles. "Yeah,

yeah, just tired. I usually spend most of the day after the change just sleeping it off."

"Oh." Catra can't keep the surprise from her voice, barely remembering Adora seeming tired at all last month. "Does it usually hit so fast?"

"No," Adora shakes her head, her jaw stretching weirdly as she stifles one more yawn. "I usually have a couple of hours first, but it's really hitting me right now...maybe my adrenaline's coming down early? It didn't feel like I needed as much of it as I usually do."

"Yeah." Catra sees the way Adora's body slumps, shoulders rounding as she leans against the counter and makes an executive decision. "You should lay down."

"No, no," Adora pulls herself up straighter, shaking her head and looking to the door. "I should just head home, get some sleep in."

Catra frowns. "Adora, if you try to walk home right now, you're going to fall asleep on the street."

"No, I won't," she insists, but the lie is so blatant she can't even look Catra in the eye.

"Adora, just lay down and take a nap. You can go home once you sleep the edge off."

"Are you being nice to me?" Adora deflects, painting her face with mock incredulity.

Catra narrows her eyes. "Not if *that's* gonna be your attitude."

Adora says nothing because she's stifling another yawn, and Catra is sick of this.

"Just take a fucking nap, Adora."

Adora sighs like taking a nap is some big, arduous task and stumbles her way to the couch. She tries to plop down, but her head hits the armrest, so she straightens and then shifts down, but now her legs don't fit on the couch.

Catra watches her with her arms crossed for a long moment before she sighs. "*W* are you doing?"

Adora stops trying to arrange herself and blinks. "T aking a nap? Like you're yelling at me to?"

"*W* would you nap on the couch? *Y* our torso is literally the size of the cushions; you're *obv* not gonna fit"—

Adora sits up. "Did you want me to sleep on the floor?" she asks, tilting her head in confusion. "I cleaned myself of f; I'm not that sweaty anymore"—

Catra's going to rip her hair out. "In the *B* Adora!" she exclaims, gesturing wildly towards the empty bedroom.

"But that's your bed!" Adora exclaims back, shaking her head.

"Yeah, duh, we're in *M* apartment!"

Adora pauses and stares at her like she's trying to figure out if this is all a big prank. "...But don't *you* have to go to sleep?" she asks quietly.

Catra sighs. "I'm not the one who turned into a gigantic wolf today. I'll be fine to wait another hour."

"Are you sure?" Adora asks, her eyes darting from Catra to the bedroom.

"Am I gonna have to tie you up to get you in there?"

Adora's cheeks flush a gentle pink, and she rolls her eyes, but she finally gets up from the couch and starts heading to the bedroom.

"What," she tries to joke, "you got some iron shackles lying around?"

Catra follows her with a smirk. "Maybe. You want a muzzle too?"

Even with her back turned, there's no missing the burning red blush that takes over Adora's face. She stops in front of the bed, and Catra joins her, and for a moment, they just stand there regarding it.

"Wake me up whenever you want me out?" Adora asks, not quite meeting Catra's eyes. "I tend to sleep like the dead."

"Don't worry; I know how to kick you out."

"You are really good at it," Adora agrees with a smile and then looks back at the bed. "If you, uh, need to sleep or something...I don't want to kick you out of your own bed," she drifts off and shrugs lamely. "But you could just wake me up, I guess, so…"

Catra nods awkwardly and steps backward. "Get some sleep, Adora."

"Okay."

---

Catra doesn't plan to end up in the bed. And she *definitely* doesn't plan to actually fall asleep.

She settles onto the couch until she starts to get tired, and then she tries to lay down, but the cushions really aren't made for it. She tosses and turns until her frustration grows, and she looks at the time. An hour has passed – that should be plenty of time for Adora to be rested enough to make it home safely. But when she goes in to wake her up...she just can't do it.

Adora looks so peaceful, so bone-tired and thoroughly unconscious, that Catra just can't make herself disrupt it.

She doesn't plan to slide into the other side of the bed, relax into the smell of rest and the steady rhythm of Adora's sleeping heart and close her eyes, but she does.

And she falls asleep.

And she doesn't wake for hours.

When she comes to, it's because someone's kicked her.

She blinks the sleep out of her eyes and squints around the room—there's enough light around the edges of her blackout curtains that it must be midday. She moves to stretch, and something shifts, heavy on her hip, and she blinks at least five times before she believes what she sees.

A warm, thick arm is draped over her waist, clumsy and lazy and foreign, so foreign, but it doesn't feel unwelcome. It's terrifying that it doesn't feel unwelcome.

Catra turns slowly, trying not to shift Adora's arm too far from where it sits now, and she quickly discovers that Adora is so close behind her that she can't even roll over without moving away.

She lifts Adora's arm as gently as she can manage and shifts over, just enough to lay flat on her back and process whatever the hell is happening.

Adora doesn't stir, still sleeping so heavily that a tiny snore escapes her, and Catra struggles to breathe as she realizes Adora has cuddled up to her in her sleep. She'd sought her out without waking, seeking *something* that she must have found, and Catra can't even presume to guess what it is. She doesn't dare.

But, after the warmth in her chest when she realized Adora was afraid that she was dating Scorpia and the overwhelming desire that flowed through her when Adora hugged her, is it impossible to ignore the feeling that Adora's heavy arm and warm body tucked beside her brings her.

Something is blossoming underneath Catra's ribs as she looks at her, something fragile and dangerous, and she can feel the roots of it winding through her heart. She can feel the way they dig and grip. There is something so inevitable about it all, something in the twinges of regret and familiarity she's felt ever since they first met, that has always felt like a speeding train with no windows or lights or brakes. No way to see how she is hurtling toward and no way to slow down or switch the tracks. No way to do anything except hang on and wait while the train lurches and shudders forward at top speed.

Looking at Adora curled into her , her body warm and her expression softer than she's ever seen it, she knows that they haven't hit the end yet. And she's pretty confident that they won't know what that end is until they've collided with it headfirst.

Catra lays in Adora's arms for a long time before she gets up, finally accepting the fragile blossom inside her chest with hesitant but careful hands and tucking it back beneath her ribs for safekeeping.

There's an undeniable truth they must confront if this is going to continue. And if it isn't, then they must confront that too.

She turns and wakes Adora as gently as she can.

But of course, that doesn't work, and it isn't until Catra outright punches her in the shoulder that she finally stirs. Once she's awake and sees Catra sitting close by, she bolts up.

"Oh my god, how long have I been out?" she asks, dragging her hands over her face and smushing her features together.

“Like half the day ,” Catra answers softly .

“Oh, shit. I’m so sorry ,” she yawns.

“It’ s okay.”

Adora looks over at her with surprise. “I really didn’t mean to stay this long,” she apologizes.

“It’ s fine, really.” Catra of fers her a tight smile. “Can we talk?”

She watches the emotion slip from Adora’s face as she turns pale and nods. “Y eah, yeah, what”—

“It’ s not bad,” Catra rushes to assure her , but Adora’s face doesn’t brighten much.

“Okay ...what’s up?”

“W ere you serious about letting me feed off of you?”

The words tumble out of her mouth like somebody else is in control of her body, and she doesn’t know what she’s thinking asking this. She’s probably not thinking at all, she thinks. She doesn’t know if she’s trying to push Adora away with this stupid idea or pull her closer, and it seems like a poor attempt at both. But after the near-miss with the fridge and Adora’s neck earlier, it’s something she has to ask.

Maybe she’s hoping this will scare Adora off, remind her of what she is and what that means, and that it’s nothing she would ever be interested in. Nothing she would want so close to her. Nothing for her to hold so gently as she sleeps.

Maybe she’s hoping Adora will prove her wrong.

She doesn’t have to hope for long.

Adora blows out a breath that sounds a lot like a laugh, and she grins. "Oh, *ha* of course. You want to?"

Catra clenches her jaw to keep herself from expressing just how much she *ha* does or taking the entire idea right back and simply nods.

"W ell, I guess I have to since you did technically scratch my back last night," Adora teases. She brings her hands up and wiggles her fingers. "It' s time for me to scratch yours."

Catra shoots her a stern look at the lame joke. "Y ou *do* have to, Adora, *only* if "—

"I *wa* to," Adora cuts her of f, something like excitement in her bright eyes as she drops her hands and nods. "Absolutely . I'd love to."

"Y ou might feel differently afterward," Catra warns, and as the words leave her, she realizes that she is definitely trying to push Adora away.

And Adora is making it clear that it won't be easy.

"Then I'll tell you," she shrugs, "and we can figure it out."

Catra swallows, nerves swirling with desire and the memory of Adora's skin against her lips. She waits for the feeling of dread and regret, that horrible weight that comes with making mistakes, but she waits, and she waits, and it never comes.

So she nods.

"Okay ."

Adora smiles.

"Okay ."

Chapter End Notes

!

We're finally getting into it folks!It's happening!Not sure when the next chapter will drop, but I promise it's a dooz (in the best way).

A lot happened in this chapter, so let me know below what your favorite part was!

Playlist is here!
Tanks for reading 3

# Treacherous

Chapter Summary

Catra tastes Adora. Adora learns some things about herself.

CW: this chapter contains descriptions of drinking blood (nothing gross) and mild sexual content.

Chapter Notes

Title is from Treacherous (Taylor's Version) by Taylor Swift.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“Are you sure you want to do this?”

“Y eah,” Adora nods, smiling. “Are you?”

“Of course,” Catra answers automatically , ignoring the anxiety screaming beneath her skin.

“Okay .”

“Okay ,” Catra says, and she sits down.

Catra has had many thoughts about how drinking Adora’s blood would go since Adora’s fateful *[illegible]* last week. She’s considered just about every outcome that could result from it, she’s planned the best way to do it, and she’s prepared thoroughly. She’s done a *bt* of thinking. A fair share of regretting, too. Regretting ever bringing it up, ever addressing the elephant in the room that was blossoming between them. And then some more thinking, and some more regretting, and then some more of both.

But absolutely none of her thinking or regretting had considered that it would be this fucking *hard*.

She's the one making it awkward, of course. She knows this. Usually, it's Adora, with her stumbling words and unsure motions, but the tables have turned today. She's trying *not* to make it weird, of course, but it's as if everything she does to try and make it better just makes it worse.

She'd like to say she has no idea why she's so nervous, and that she has absolutely no reason to be, but that would be a *big* fucking lie. That lie would be as big as Adora's biceps. She knows exactly why she's so nervous. She *knows* why she's being so awkward.

It's because she's never done this before.

Well, never like *this*.

When she was thirteen, she drank from Netossa's sorcerer wife, Spinerella. She had no interest in it~~ to~~ be honest, she was scared shitless to do it, but Netossa was insistent that she learn how. She doesn't need it the way fully-fledged vampires do, but there could come a day when she does.

Netossa also tried to impress upon her that she could do it even if she *didn't* need it;she could do it just because she might like it and it was fun and filling, and in that case, she should know how to do it safely.

But, they both knew that lesson was a failure before she even tried to teach it.

So Netossa just taught her what to do in case she needed it, and Spinerella graciously offered her neck and her blood (and, as far as young Catra was concerned, her *life*) for practice. It was clumsy, and a little weird, but Spinerella was kind and patient, and once Catra

figured out what to do, it was rather enjoyable for the both of them. Catra refused to admit how much better blood tasted when it was fresh and warm and human, but Spinny openly detailed the rush of adrenaline and the warm feeling of release she felt during it, and it helped to know that she hadn't hurt her.

That was the first time Catra had ever drank from a human.

The second time was only a few years ago. She had moved out of Angella's estate a few months earlier and wanted to figure things out for herself. Who she was, who she wanted to be. What side of her she wanted people to see.

She ended up at a bar that vampires were welcomed in; it wasn't *for* them, but there was an understanding that some would frequent it and meet up with humans. She found a girl and left with her, and when she offered her blood, Catra accepted.

It was better than with Spinerella: more confident, and the sensation more filling. The girl enjoyed it enough that they parted ways as friends, but Catra never called her again. She never went back to that bar. It was filling—almost *too*—and it was so obvious how easily Catra could simply embrace that side of her. How easy it would be to actually drink from humans regularly and stay fed.

And that was why she couldn't do it.

She's come to accept a lot of things about being half-vampire. The feeling of the sunlight, the intense senses, the hyper-awareness of anything near her that's alive. She's even come to enjoy some of it, like the speed and the efficiency it brings to her life. But other things…the fluctuation of her mood and energy based on her feeding, the dependence on others to feed off of, the thrill that runs through her body when blood touches her tongue…

The shame and self-hatred are still impossible to separate from those aspects, even after trying for over a decade. They had been

woven into the fabric of her mind like thorns, and not even her claws could seem to uproot them.

She'd considered telling Adora she'd only been joking, that she hadn't really meant she wanted to feed off of her, upwards of a thousand times in the last week. But every time she pulled up the text message and tried to send it, she couldn't. She couldn't tell that lie. She *did* want to feed off of her, really and truly, to feel her blood spill into her mouth and the hot shame that came with it. She wanted an excuse to stop wanting Adora and a way to show Adora the cost of being close to her.

With how excited Adora had seemed when she arrived at Catra's apartment to be bitten, it seems unlikely that that last part is working.

Catra turns to face Adora beside her on the couch and regards her. She can see a hint of nervousness in the way she's fidgeting, just her hands moving and the rest of her a bit *too* still, but there's no anxiety or fear in her smell. It's sweet and warm;subdued, but still strong even a week after the change.

Adora had wanted to let Catra bite her right then and there when she'd asked a week ago, but Catra had forced her to wait long enough to recover from her change. She isn't planning to take any substantial amount of blood from her, not even needing much to fill her when just spending time with Adora feeds her so well, but if she's never been bitten before, it could surprise her system. Catra had bought a variety of new snacks and juices just in case Adora didn't feel well afterward, and she'd already set a glass of water down beside the couch if she needed it.

Adora notices her staring and smiles reassuringly, brushing her ponytail over her shoulder. She's wearing an athletic tank top, which is both a blessing for this activity and a curse to Catra's desire. Plenty of space for Catra to choose from, but also plenty of muscle for her to ogle.

"Ready?" Catra asks, choking down her own nerves and shifting a little closer to examine the skin between Adora's neck and shoulder. The neck was a bit sensitive and strong for a first bite, but the top of the shoulder was a good angle for control.

"Yeah," Adora says a little too quickly, twisting her torso as far toward her as she can to make it easier on Catra. They exchange a quick and awkward look, and then Catra leans in.

She can smell Adora's blood, rushing and vibrant just beneath her skin. Her hunger is growing by the second from the anticipation alone. She can feel her shame lurking like a shadow, ready to taunt her as soon as the enjoyment begins. She smoothes a hand over the top of Adora's shoulder, dragging her shirt strap to the side to make room, and she can feel Adora shiver under the touch. It sends a thrill through her own chest. She pauses and listens to Adora's heart, beating violently inside of her chest, but she makes no other sounds besides a long and slow deep breath.

Accepting that as consent, Catra meets her skin, and when she drags her tongue over it to prepare the area, Adora gasps.

Catra freezes immediately, tongue still spread against her salty skin, the taste of it even better than the smell. She waits for any further reactions, but none come.

Adora's heart is now beating so loudly that it's echoing inside of Catra's ears, so she pulls back and tries to catch Adora's eye. "Are you okay?"

Adora nods immediately, meeting her gaze with a tense, determined expression. "Yes," she says, and it is much breathier than Catra anticipates.

She waits for any ounce of doubt to bleed through, but Adora only seems to get more determined with each second that passes. Her breathy *yes* echoes undeniably through Catra's head to the tune of her heartbeat, so Catra nods and leans back in.

She licks over the spot again, cleaning it and tasting her, and allowing herself to inhale the sweet, smoky smell still lingering around her. Adora doesn't gasp again, a little tension in her body like she's purposefully trying not to, but her head tilts ever so slightly to the side.

Catra pulls up just enough to graze her teeth slowly over her skin, the tease of it driving her own body to squirm, and then she bites her.

Several things happen at once.

Blood flows onto her tongue, hot and wet and sweet, *so* sweet. The response to it is instantaneous. Catra's entire body comes alive like there is fire in her veins, and she instinctively sucks, losing herself to the sensation. The taste spreads through her mouth and down her throat like wildfire, bright and burning, and it feels like she is standing in the sun. It feels like she is standing *on* the sun. It feels like the sun is inside of her. It's consuming and overwhelming, and it feels like she has just woken up for the very first time. It feels like waking up and finding out that she's alive, and the life that she thought she was living was nothing more than a wet and dream-riddled grave.

Blood flows onto Catra's tongue, and she sucks, and Adora *moans*. She moans, and it is the only sound that cuts through the drumming heartbeat in Catra's ears. It's like she has no choice but to answer. The sound rises out of her burning throat like an offering to the divine, a plea, a motion of gratitude. Adora moans and Catra returns it, and Adora's hand flies to Catra's arm and clings to it.

Blood flows onto Catra's tongue, and she sucks, and Adora moans and clings to her, and something inside of Adora's body changes.

Catra feels it, smells it, tastes it. The feeling rolling through her body shifts her blood instantly, spikes it, and electrifies the taste of it until Catra's whole body is burning the same. The smell cuts through the air, distinct as anything, and the realization of what it is hits Catra's overwhelmed brain like a church bell, tolling again and again until

she understands it. Until she understands *how* she's reacting to it before she's even recognized it.

It is arousal.

It is arousal, and this is unprecedented. Catra has never felt this when drinking from someone. She has never felt the buzz so violently or felt them enjoying it so thoroughly, and it's making her head spin.

There is nothing Catra can do with this realization except suck again, gentler, and listen for the trembling whimper that escapes from Adora's mouth. Her head has fallen backward, body surrendered to Catra, fingers digging into her bicep. Their pressure matches the pressure building between Catra's thighs, and it's becoming so intense that it's starting to feel dangerous.

Catra loosens her jaw, swallows what she's taken, and licks once across the bite. Adora inhales sharply and shifts, and a fresh wave of arousal hits the air. It acts as a grounding pin, centering Catra's thoughts and desires and bringing clarity to the feelings rushing through her own body and her necessity for restraint. She licks over the spot one more time, laving her tongue across the wound and sweeping the blood from her sweet skin, and then she pauses. Before she can pull back, she presses her lips to Adora's skin, just below the bite. No teeth and no tongue, as gentle as she can, and she wishes she could believe that she doesn't know why she does it.

But she knows.

She pulls back, swallowing the last bits of blood down her throat and savoring the way the taste lingers in her mouth. The way the feeling lingers in her body. The way her lungs continue to fill with Adora's scent. She doesn't think she's ever felt so satisfied, and there is not even a thought of shame in her mind.

Adora comes back slower, her breathing and heart rate taking time to even out, and it's not until Catra smoothes a hand over the side of

her face that she straightens up and opens her eyes. They focus on Catra's face immediately, but her expression is unreadable.

"Are you okay?" Catra asks, her fingers trailing down Adora's cheek until they fall from her face completely.

Adora blinks slowly and takes a few deep breaths, and then she laughs. "Holy *sh*—"

Catra blinks back, unsure how to read her reaction, until a soft, goofy smile spreads over Adora's face.

"I had no idea it would feel like that," she confesses, unabashed, and Catra smiles gently in relief.

"I didn't—" she drifts off, unsure of her wording. If she'd known, she would have warned her, but she hadn't. She didn't know it would be that intense because it never had been before. Not with Spinerella and not with the girl from the bar. Those times didn't even come close to what she'd just experienced. "I'm sorry, I didn't know it *could* feel like that. It never has."

Adora shakes her head violently, then seems to realize she's still holding onto Catra with a vice grip and loosens her fingers. "Don't apologize," she says, a bit dazedly. "That was amazing."

"Yeah?" Catra asks, thinking that amazing was an extremely inept understatement for what that had been.

"Maybe an understatement," Adora says, as if she can hear her thoughts, and grins. "But yeah. When can we do it again?"

*

Catra makes Adora wait a week and a half. She says it's for her own good, and Adora appreciates that, but it's the longest week and a half of her life. She thinks about doing it again every second of every day, her thoughts full of the weight of Catra's mouth on her shoulder and the adrenaline spreading through her body, and the burning flames in her core that licked at every piece of her as sharply as Catra's tongue.

She'd looked into biting after last time, thinking of what Catra had said and how it usually wasn't so intense. There was only so much reading she could do without someone else in the pack finding out, and if they did, she'd never hear the end of the teasing. Still, it seemed that everywhere she looked simply described the feeling as enjoyable and euphoric for the person being fed on. Something about evolution making it enticing so that it was more sustainable, but Adora didn't really care *why* it felt so good. She just cared that it did and that she got to share it with Catra. There was no writing about vampires feeding on werewolves that she could find, so her best guess as to why the reaction was so much greater than usual was simply that she wasn't entirely human. She was a werewolf, and a powerful one, and Catra wasn't exactly a typical vampire. It seemed logical it would be more intense for them.

She had almost hoped the bite marks would linger afterward, that maybe they'd bring her a ghost of that good feeling as they healed, but of course, she had no such luck. Between Catra's aftercare and her own quick healing, they were almost entirely gone just by the time she'd returned home last week. She'd caught a shadow of a mark in the mirror when she first looked, but an hour later, there was nothing there but smooth, unblemished skin.

When Adora arrives for the second bite a week and a half later, the anticipation has her nearly vibrating out of her skin. If transforming outside of a full moon was easier, she would worry about doing it by accident while she waits for Catra to get her water and ensure everything is set before they start. But it isn't, so the only thing

they’re in danger of is Adora breaking the couch from jggling her legs too hard.

“Y ou alright over there?” Catra teases as she walks over with Adora’s water. Well, water*s*. She’d chugged the one glass pretty fast last time, so it looks like Catra is preparing for the same by giving her a second.

“Y eah,” Adora expels some of her excitement in a chuckling sigh and nods. “Just excited.”

Catra gives her a strange look she can’t quite read, but there’s a hint of a smile, so Adora guesses it’s mostly good. She sets the waters down and sits next to her, and Adora turns immediately and swings her ponytail over her far shoulder. Catra chuckles at her but she shifts closer, and Adora can feel her thigh burning where Catra’s knee is touching it, even though Catra is more than several degrees colder than her.

“Ready?” Catra asks, and Adora nods and tries to suppress her body from moving as Catra arranges herself closer.

They’ve been closer than this before, of course, as Adora is transforming, but the pain and varying levels of consciousness have really lessened that experience. They’ve only been this close while Adora was human and in control of herself during the previous bite and the one time she’d hugged her post-change. Both times she’d felt the same thing she’s feeling now – a humming buzz beneath her skin and a warmth in her chest. Her smell is irrevocably distinctive this close, so obviously different than any other vampire Adora has ever come across. So bright and herbal and undeniably *her*. And very, *very* intoxicating.

Catra slides her shirt strap aside with the same gentility as last time, and Adora fights down a shiver as one of her claws crawls along her skin. She feels Catra pose herself over her shoulder and then pause, and after a long moment, Adora turns to peek at her. She can only

turn her head so much without knocking into her, and if Catra turns to meet her, their noses will touch.

As it is, Catra doesn't turn. She peeks at Adora from the corner of her eye and asks again, "Ready?"

"Yes," Adora answers, clear and confident. Catra turns back to her skin, and Adora can feel her breath ghosting over it, warm and tickling, and she looks away and closes her eyes.

Catra's tongue drags over her shoulder and leaves an inferno in its wake, a burning not unlike her change that spreads its way across her skin until it consumes her entire body. Her tongue flicks a little as she finishes, and the movement reverberates through Adora's bones. She barely has a moment to recover before Catra returns and sinks her teeth in.

It's just like last time, except somehow *more*, as if the anticipation of knowing what's coming has made it all the more enjoyable. The feeling washes over her, and she reaches for Catra, finding her and grounding herself with the touch as the feeling takes over. It's like a burning and a cleanse; like a flood on fire as it rushes through her. It's like the change, except it doesn't hurt, not even a little bit. It soothes as it burns, and the burn is not pain. It is just heat. It is just connection. It is just want.

Catra sucks, and the heat pools in Adora's gut, and she lets it. She loves it. It feels like a conversation, like an exchange. Catra asks, and Adora gives. Catra pulls, and Adora pushes.

And as it continues, Adora gets the strangest feeling, as if this is what she's meant to do. As if fulfilling this exchange, playing her role in this trade, is exactly what she's been destined for. She feels it stronger than she has for anything else: stronger than her ties to the pack, stronger than her pull to the moon. Those are the things her body is destined for, that it's been honed for, but this resounds deeper, feels greater than any of those. It feels greater than even any of her carnal desires, being this close to Catra. Being this

connected. Being able to touch her. Being able to give her what she needs.

It is like Adora needs it too.

Catra pulls away too soon. Adora is still burning and full, and the flames are bright, and Catra's final licks feel like a tease. Barely a fraction of what she wants. It is not enough, but it is all she will get.

It takes a long time for the fire and the flood to resign themselves into smolders and trickles. When she feels like she can breathe without reigniting them, she opens her eyes, and Catra is watching her just like last time. Their eyes meet, and something deep in Adora's core flares, but she puts it to rest before it can start up again.

"Okay?" Catra asks softly and her arm shifts in Adora's grip.

Adora loosens her hold but doesn't let go, fingers skimming Catra's muscles and drawing out their time together. "Yeah," she answers, more out of breath than she realized. "Really good. Better," she finally amends, and lets go of Catra to reach for her waters.

"Better?" Catra teases with an air of surprise, and Adora can't even pretend to undermine it.

"Be," she repeats and chugs her water down.

*

When Catra wakes up, it's the best she's felt in a long time. Maybe the best she's felt ever. Somewhere in her dream-riddled brain, she considers that what she's feeling right now is probably what it feels like to be normal. To be alive. This must be how everyone else feels, just by the right of their heart beating and their blood flowing.

It’s so ludicrous to imagine that she almost laughs.

Instead, she rolls over, stretching out and purring with the relief it brings, and then she catches a scent and buries her face in the sheets next to her. It smells like Adora, sweet and smoky, and the scent is still so strong that it brings last night to the forefront of Catra’s mind. Adora’s salty skin, her willing blood, the soft keening noises that escaped her lips as Catra fed. Catra’s head swims with the memory of Adora’s body beneath her, and her fingers wrapped tight around her arm. With Adora’s smell enveloping her, she’s a goner.

She takes a deep, slow breath and drags her hips against the mattress in tempo, savoring the feeling of too much desire and not enough friction. She only makes it one more slow drag before her imagination goes wild, drawing up the million and one ways she and Adora could spend a day together in this bed if that was a line they could cross, and she can’t wait any longer. Catra slips her hand down, imagining that it’s bigger and stronger and warmer, and splays her fingers wide across her stomach. She imagines what stupid, cocky, dumb thing Adora might say if she was in bed with her that Catra would pretend to hate but absolutely adore and chuckles into the mattress. She pushes her fingers down, sliding under her waistband, and—

Something crashes in the kitchen, and someone swears.

Catra snaps up, blinking against the light in the room and pushing the leftovers of sleep from her head. She hears the voice again and focuses enough to catch the familiar heartbeat, and there’s no mistaking it. It’s Adora, scolding something as quietly as she can in the other room.

Adora is here.

Catra remembers that she’d slept over as a precaution when she seemed to crash a little harder last night than after first feeding, and Catra realizes she must have woken up first and left her to keep

sleeping. Why she didn't leave completely and head home is a decent question since it must be nearly noon, and Catra pulls her hand out of her pants and drags herself out of bed to find it out.

She opens the door to spot the top of Adora's head around the far side of the kitchen island, as if she's sitting on the floor, and she peeks up over the counter with a guilty expression. She doesn't say anything as Catra strides over, and when she rounds the side of the island, she finds Adora with the broken cabinet door in her lap and an array of screws and tools on the floor beside her.

"What the hell are you doing?"

"I'm sorry ," Adora cringes, "did I wake you up?"

"Yes," Catra lies. "Are you gonna answer my question?"

"I'm fixing your broken cabinet!"

Catra raises an eyebrow sky-high.

Adora looks down and back up and cringes. "Okay , it looks bad now, but I'm almost done! And then it will be *perfect*."

Catra watches as she turns back to her work and starts messing with the door's hinge. "Do you even know what you're doing?"

"Yes," Adora says indignantly , snatching one of her tools and continuing to work without looking back up. "I do this all the time."

Catra opens her mouth and then closes it, swallowing her sardonic remark as she realizes she doesn't actually know what Adora does with the rest of her time when she isn't dealing with her transformation. The pack as a whole seemed to operate as general support to the town, but there wasn't a defined career path any of the werewolves seemed to follow. There might have been one before the Necrosis, but with how few of them were left afterward, it seemed like they were spread across a variety of professions now.

Leaning against the counter with her hip, Catra considers Adora's back. "So, you're a handyman, or whatever? Handy *girl*?"

Adora turns just enough to cut her a disappointed look at the poor pun, but she continues with no further insult. "Sometimes. I do a bunch of stuff—it's not really worth pursuing anything seriously when I'll eventually just lead like Mara. But I get anxious if I don't have enough to do, so I just help out whoever needs it when I have the time. Juliet does a lot of construction and handy *girl* things around town, and I helped her a bunch a few years back."

Catra smirks and nods. "So, you think you can just dismantle my cabinet for fun?"

"I think I can *fix* your cabinet for fun, so it operates as intended and doesn't hinder your life—or mine."

"Oh, there it is. You just want your stupid fruit snacks to be more accessible!" Catra scoffs.

Adora turns and peeks at her again, this time with an award-winning smile and a wink. "Now you're getting it."

Before Catra can comment again, Adora stands up and starts to re-attach the cabinet door. She does it efficiently and almost silently, and suddenly it's shutting smoothly with no issues. Adora opens and closes it a few times to make sure everything is correct and then turns proudly to Catra and waits.

"I'm *not* thanking you, if that's what you're waiting for," Catra folds her arms and stares Adora down.

Adora turns back to the cabinet and opens it again with a growing smirk on her face. She grabs two fruit snacks and then shuts the door (once again, with no issues) and collects her tools in her big, strong, warm hands.

"That's okay," she shrugs, dancing to the couch. "You *owe* me

---

The next full moon comes and goes a week and a half later without issue. It's the quietest one yet – the change still sends Adora through hell, but it's obviously easier. The change back comes quickly when it's time. Adora is still exhausted afterward but they're ready for it, and when she wakes up after a long nap, she's the most excited Catra has ever seen her. She says she feels great, and she looks it.

Catra feels great too. She feels fed, and strong, and almost alive.

It's not a feeling she's accustomed to, and it's not one she thinks she'll get used to anytime soon. She has the nagging thought that it's one that she would like to get used to, if only that was possible.

Chapter End Notes

:')

We're officially halfway through! Thank you for all of the wonderfully sweet comments and passionate support, it means the world to see people enjoy this fic as much as I do! Woof Adora for the win <3333

Next chapter will likely come in a month-ish, but I make no promises about it happening sooner or later than that. It will happen when it happens.

Playlist is here!
Thanks for reading <3

# Taste of You

Chapter Summary

Adora has some questions to ask. Things escalate.

CW: this chapter contains descriptions of drinking blood and mild sexual content.

Chapter Notes

Title is from Taste of You by Rez & Dove Cameron. This song is SO fantastic and mandatory listening once you finish this chapter. If I had heard it before I started this story, I likely would have named the fic after it instead.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

In the week that follows the full moon, Adora finds several good excuses to see Catra again. She won't agree to another feeding until Adora's had some time to recover from her transformation, but other things around her apartment need fixing, and after Adora spots a book shoved under the couch titled "How To Clean Dog Hair (And Other Tips When You're Dating a Werewolf)" she starts pushing Catra to let her give the place a deep clean as a thank you.

(When Adora had found that book shoved under the couch, she'd grabbed it and started flipping through with the utmost amusement and more than a little bit of heat in her cheeks. Catra had spotted her before she got to the end of the book and, with a shriek, dashed over to snatch it out of her hands and throw it across the room.

Adora opened her mouth to ask what the hell was going on, but Catra looked so surprised at her own actions that her voice failed her, and they simply spent a long moment just staring at each other.

Finally, Catra cleared her throat and her eyebrows descended as she frowned. "Sorry . Glimmer got me that book as a joke, and I haven't had time to burn it yet."

"Don't b  it," Adora laughed. "Did you even read it? It might actually be useful. I'll take it home if you don't want it, there might be some good tricks."

"It was a present from Glimmer ," Catra deadpanned. "It' s b  not useful.)"

Catra never agrees to a full deep clean, but she does agree to let Adora give her poor, torn carpet a gentle patching.

Adora spends the entire day leading up to her visit for the carpet deliberating if she finally wants to use that time to ask Catra about the new moon. Once she decides that she does, she spends the rest of the day trying to hype herself up for it.

Even after all of that, it still takes her almost their entire time together for her to manage to get the words out.

She's finished the carpet, and their conversation is dying out as she realizes it' s now or never.

Well, now or she'll have to wait an entire month before she gets the chance again.

"So," she starts, leaning forward and crossing her legs underneath her on the floor.

Catra raises an eyebrow from where she's curled up on the couch, her expression shifting to something more serious with Adora's leading tone.

"The new moon is next week," Adora of fers, a nervous waver bleeding into her words. She pauses to collect her thoughts, and Catra watches her expectantly.

"Have you, uh, heard of the ceremony we do?"

Catra's suspicious expression relaxes, and she nods. "Yeah, but I don't know much about it."

Adora nods back, breaking eye contact to watch her hands pick at the top of her socks. "Sure," she starts, still addressing her lap. She feels ridiculous being so nervous over something so small, but it's also something big.

If it works, that is.

"So, every new moon, we gather in our ceremonial space, and all the new wolves try to voluntarily transform. We do it on the new moon so that there's no full moon interference over our bodies and minds, and whenever one of us makes a breakthrough and manages to transform, there's a whole celebration, and that wolf is officially named to the pack. It's like a coming of age, I guess?"

"Okay," Catra nods in understanding.

"Um, I've been going and trying each month. I haven't really been expecting anything, but we all just keep trying until we do it. But after this last moon, how easy it was." Adora drifts off, eyes darting from her lap to meet Catra's and back down again. "I was just thinking…"

"You think you might get it this time?"

Adora lets out a breath of relief and nods. "Yeah, I think so."

"Is this usually when it happens?" Catra asks, straightening a little.

"No," Adora shakes her head, continuing to fidget with her clothing. "It usually takes about nine months, sometimes a year or more. Every wolf is different, but Mara said I might master it sooner and I… think I can feel it. It's like it's just under the surface. I think I might be able to do it this time."

"Okay ," she nods again.

Adora swallows heavily and gives an over-exaggerated shrug. "So, I was just thinking it's open to anyone who wants to watch it's not dangerous or anything when the moon isn't in control so, y'know, people come to watch us and it might uh, it might be"…

Adora peeks up at Catra, anxiety twisting her gut into knots as she tries to get the words out. The new moon ceremony is both a casual affair and incredibly important to the pack, and having Catra be there while she tries to transform in front of everyone after the havoc she's wreaked on her first few full moons…

She thinks it could really change things. It could really help her get a handle on her transformation and start doing good for the pack instead of continuing to be a burden.

She's hoping Catra will understand and put her out of her misery, but there's a slight pull on her lips, almost as if she's fighting a smirk. As the silence stretches on, her ear twitches, and Adora realizes that she knows what she's asking, and she's going to make Adora say it.

"I thought it might be easier for me to transform if you were there," she says in one breath, shoving the words out of her mouth no matter how clumsy they sound.

A smile spreads over Catra's face that is half-smug and half-sweet, and it flips Adora's nerves upside down. "Sure, yeah," she says, like it's the easiest thing in the world. "I could probably fit that into my schedule."

Adora rolls her eyes, her shoulders relaxing as she leans back on one hand. "Oh, how nice of you to fit me into your really busy schedule of sitting home alone every night."

"I still have a job, you know!" Catra protests, snatching a small pillow off the couch and launching it at Adora's face.

Adora plucks it out of the air and flings it back, laughing, and within seconds she's being pummeled by an onslaught of throw pillows.

"So, you'll be there?" she calls from behind the pillows.

Catra stops long enough to laugh and says, "Yeah, whatever. I'll be there."

"Cool," Adora grins, waiting for Catra to run out of pillows before dropping her defensive position to look at her again.

Catra rolls her eyes and then pauses. "If you do manage the change this new moon does that mean you'll be fine during the next full moon?"

"*Well*," Adora rushes to say, as if having a handle on her changes all the time would be a *bad* thing. "It definitely makes them easier, but it's not automatic. It still takes some time to learn how to deal with the moon whether you can change independently or not."

Catra nods, and the reassurance that their routine of meeting on the full moon won't suddenly stop after this hangs in the air between them.

It's strange, because just two months ago, Adora was reassuring Catra with everything she had that she wouldn't be a burden on her for too long. That she would have a handle on this soon enough. But now it almost seemed like they were *both* relieved for it to go on at least a little bit longer.

"When you say 'chamed to the pack,'" Catra interrupts her thoughts, "do you mean those stupid nicknames you guys have on your jackets?"

Adora laughs. There was a lot more to it than just being a nickname on a jacket, but of course that's all Catra would know of it. "It's a whole thing, but yes, we get names added to our jackets then."

Catra perks up, a smirk growing on her face that looks like trouble. "Do you know what your name will be?"

"Most wolves choose it when they earn it, but yeah. Mine will be She-Ra."

Catra's smirk falters as one dark eyebrow quirks up. "Isn't that Mara's name?"

"Yes," Adora nods, shrugging. "All of our leaders are named She-Ra. It's an honorary title that's passed down through each generation."

"Do you have to take it? What if you wanted to choose something different?"

"Why would I?" Adora asks, blinking.

Catra stares at her for a long moment, her lips pulling into a frown. Her tail flicks against her leg. "Why are you the next She-Ra?" she finally says.

Adora hesitates, trying to read the question beneath that one from Catra's expression and failing to. "Because Mara chose me to be," she answers.

"Why did she choose *you*?"

"Because." Adora shrugs, shifting uncomfortably underneath the scrutiny. She knows Catra doesn't mean that she *should* have been chosen, but Adora's spent the last decade-plus feeling inadequate and trying to convince herself that she deserves it. "I'm powerful. And I have the qualities she wants. She chose me because she thinks I'm the best wolf for the job."

"What do *you* think?" Catra pushes, crossing her arms across her chest.

Adora doesn't understand. "I think that she knows best," she shrugs.

"Do you *want* to be the next She-Ra?" Catra asks. The crinkle between her eyebrows is deep, and Adora doesn't understand why she cares. Doesn't understand why it *matters*.

"Yes?" she says, confusion growing on her own face as she watches Catra. "That's my destiny. Of course I want it."

The frown tugging Catra's lips down only grows. "You don't even get your own name," she says quietly.

"I don't need my own name," Adora says, but as the words leave her tongue, they taste sour. "I'll be She-Ra."

Catra watches her for a long moment, mismatched eyes pouring over her like they're digging for her soul, and then her frown evens out and she lets it go. "Fine. But don't expect me to call you that."

Adora chuckles, the strange moment they just shared hanging heavy on her heart. "I would never."

*

Adora's words haunt Catra's mind for days. The confidence in her inflection. The certainty she possessed in asserting her future. The easy acceptance of her destiny. Her words echo in Catra's head with a dread that makes her feel sick, and she can't put her finger on why.

With another week, she might be able to change on command. If she manages that, she'll be named to the pack and officially begin her journey of becoming the pack's next She-Ra. With a few more months, she'll figure out her transformations on the full moons as well, and then…

Then she will move on to helping with the pack as she should. She'll be able to help the other wolves learn their changes. She'll probably

shadow Mara as she goes about her duties until she's proficient enough to step in and begin to take them over. And eventually, when it becomes time for Mara to step down, she will step up.

Catra tries to picture it ~~A~~dora in Mara' s jacket, full of confidence and compassionate professionalism ~~a~~nd the problem iss~~.~~he can. She can see Adora leading the pack;she can see the ease with which she'd be able to take over and the virtue in her heart that she'd rule with. She can even see her meeting with Glimmer and the clan, far out in the future when they would be the ones in charge, working together to keep the town safe.

She can see it so easily, and it's that ease that leads to that sight that turns her stomach for the worse. ~~T~~hat ease that digs up the dread and fear that have been so absent as of late.

She thinks she knows why it does. She thinks she knows exactly what is occurring inside of her, and it is exactly why she never wanted this relationship to start. It was why she kept her circle so close and so small, even at the expense of hunger.

All these thoughts do nothing but stir up more hunger, burning through the relief that the full moon and all the nights she's seen Adora since have brought, and sparking the deep, aching yearning inside of her once more.

Adora has been asking for days when she'd like to feed again. With the memory of her sweet blood on her tongue and her warm body against her haunting her mind ~~n~~ot to mention the impending new moon and what it will mean looming over them ~~s~~he is running out of reasons to deny her.

She decides it's safe enough for a feeding a few days out from the new moon, and Adora arrives even more eager than usual. Catra's setting her water down and ensuring everything is prepared when Adora surprises her.

She stops Catra with a hand as she goes to sit down next to her, and instead shifts away from the arm of the couch towards the center and chews on her lip. "Would you, um," Adora cringes and shakes her head, and then tries again. "I was just thinking the angle is kind of awkward, right? When we do it like this? Would it be easier for you if you sat in my lap or something? Or I could sit in yours, or whatever. I just had the thought that it might be less strain on your neck if we were face to face"…

Adora's rambling continues unchecked as Catra blinks at her, her eyes falling to Adora's lap and then back up again. She's wearing shorts today, because of course she is, and the sight of them was already messing with her head long before this offer arrived. From this angle, she can see the tan lines they leave and the pale blonde hair that disappears beneath them.

*Because of course* some traitorous part of her mind whispers. It *would* be much easier if they weren't both twisting so awkwardly. It *would* be more convenient if Catra was on her lap, because then Adora wouldn't be quite so tall, and Catra would have more control. It would also ensure that Adora stayed still underneath her, not that that's been a big issue, but any sudden movements could end up with her hurt.

So yeah, it makes sense. It does.

It's also an idea Catra knows will haunt her every moment, waking or asleep, for the rest of her life, regardless of what she decides. It will drive her crazy if she doesn't take Adora up on the offer, thinking endlessly about what it would be like to sit on her lap. Not just to sit, but to straddle…

And on the other hand, there's a real risk of losing her cool if she agrees to it. And if she loses her cool, she'll fuck this up, and then it will be over even sooner than expected. And Catra really doesn't want it to be over.

Adora is still looking at her with wide, nervous eyes, and knowing that there's at least some part of Adora that could be taking this offer as seriously as Catra is gives her the confidence she needs to say:

"Okay ," Catra nods.

Adora blinks a few times, staring blankly at her as if she's waiting for a follow-up to that statement. But none comes, so eventually, she realizes that and straightens up.

"O okay. Cool. Okay. So, just uh," Adora drops her arms to either side of her hips, leaving her lap open for Catra. After that, she just looks a little confused, like she's not sure if she should help direct Catra down or just sit still, and it' s way too endearing for Catra's sanity.

She is *so* fucked.

Catra drops one knee outside Adora's thigh and then gently takes her shoulder to lean on as she pulls the other leg up and straddles her. Adora's hands come up and hover around her hips as if she wants to help, but she isn't quite sure where she' s allowed to touch. Catra bites her tongue to keep it from spelling out *exactly* where she'd like Adora to touch her. Instead, she lowers herself down onto Adora's lap without help. The heat from Adora' s skin burns right through Catra's leggings and sears the back of her thighs.

She is already on fire and hasn't even bitten her yet.

What she had failed to consider during her deliberation was that this position would, of course, put them nose to nose and close enough for Adora's breath to glance hot and sweet across Catra's lips.

Which isn't a bad thing, necessarily, except that it's making Catra's entire body respond as if she's already drinking her blood. She can feel her heart slamming against her chest in a frantic rhythm, and

she would be embarrassed if not for the urgent drumming that she can hear Adora's heart answering hers with.

For a long moment, the only sounds are their hearts beating, screaming for each other, and the sound of their breathing getting heavier by the second in anticipation of what's coming. Catra feels something brush against her calf muscle and looks down to see Adora's hand fisted on the couch cushion just beside her , knuckles twitching slightly. She looks up to ask her if everything is alright, only to find that she's already looking at her, an unfamiliar and exhilarating heat in her eyes. As they watch each other, it softens, just slightly , and the air between them fizzes with something unnamable, untamable, and dangerous.

And then Adora clears her throat, and it's gone.

"Ready?" Catra asks, her voice quieter than intended as she shifts to hover over Adora's shoulder.

Adora swallows hard and nods, ensuring her hair is out of the way and taking a deep breath.

Catra pauses, catching the tension holding Adora's body tight and leaning back a little. "Are you sure you're ready? We don't have to."

Adora turns sharply, her head almost colliding with Catra as she shakes it. "No, no, I'm sure. I'm just uh..." Her eyes search Catra's face for something, and then she offers a small smile. "I'm sure, I promise."

After another moment of hesitation, Catra nods and arranges herself again. There is no fear in the air , only excitement, and she trusts Adora to be honest with her. Once Adora has settled again as well, she leans down and sniffs her skin. It is salty, and electric, and the smell awakens a deep craving that spreads throughout her entire body. Her mouth waters and her insides burn desperately for her.

She gives in.

Catra licks a long, thick path up Adora's shoulder to her neck, and she can feel her blood singing to her just beneath the surface. She can already taste the arousal through her skin. A hungry growl climbs up her throat, and she bites.

Blood spills into her mouth, and Adora keens, her entire body shuddering as her head falls back and her hand flies up to grab Catra. It finds her hip instead of her arm this time, and the feeling of her desperate grip is almost as overwhelming as the taste of her blood.

Catra sucks, and the blood is as hot as her burning insides. It feels like the entire world is on fire. It feels like they are both made of flames, answering the inevitable call to burn down, to burn *together*, that they were destined for. Adora moans, and Catra can do nothing but answer in kind, her fire drifting lower and lower until it is burning in her core. She can smell Adora burning the same, hot and wet and electric underneath her, and she can taste it on her tongue. It is becoming harder and harder to distinguish the difference between their bodies.

At least, until Catra teases her tongue over Adora's skin and Adora's fingers dig harder into Catra's hip, and it becomes excessively clear where her body ends and Adora's begins. Her fingers dig in and her thumb slides against the top of Catra's leggings;her touch stokes the wet heat pooling between her legs. Her hips jerk on instinct, seeking friction that isn't there, and one of them whimpers.

Catra freezes in Adora's lap, hips poised over her thighs and her core throbbing. Her entire body is trembling with the effort of holding herself back. She can smell Adora's body answering the call that hers is screaming, and she can feel the urgency in her grip, but Adora makes no active movement to acknowledge what just happened. She doesn't even open her eyes to notice the interruption, already so satiated and lost to bliss.

The last clear, sober piece of Catra's mind left that had been shoved to the back when she agreed to this foolish position comes

screaming to the front and forces her to pull back. She shifts backward carefully, a growl escaping her with the loss of proximity, and she swallows the last of what she'll take. She licks over the wound until it's clean and ready to heal, and Catra takes several deep breaths to calm her unsteady hips and racing heart while she waits for Adora to open her eyes.

(It doesn't help that each breath is filled with the joining of their scents, flirting and twisting into one another until they've created something new. It doesn't help that Catra knows this new scent will haunt her as significantly as the feeling of Adora's thighs underneath hers will when she tries to find sleep tonight and every other night for the rest of her life.)

Adora opens her eyes slowly, breathing equally as deep, and her fingers relax and then curl in against Catra's hip to scratch her leggings gently. Her fingers are soft, but they leave a wildfire in their wake.

When Adora's eyes focus enough to see her, they concentrate hard on her lips. They linger there long enough that Catra considers there might be blood on them, a droplet she missed gone to waste. Her tongue darts out to check, but she finds nothing. Instead, she watches Adora's lips part in kind, sees her tongue hovering in the space just behind them, and sees Adora inhale deeply. Catra can't stop herself before she inhales too, wondering what she smells, and then her head is swimming with their joined scents again.

And it must fog up her mind; it must take its hold over her, because there is a heart-hammering half-second where she thinks that Adora leans in. Leans towards her, lips shifting like they were whispering to a ghost, fingers tensing to hold her still. Catra thinks she is finally coming to take what's hers, what has been hers, what Catra fears might always be hers.

Adora's breath tickles against Catra's lips, just inches away, and Catra waits.

And she waits.

And she *hates* for Adora to kiss her, but she doesn't.

She doesn't.

Adora's eyes flicker away from her lips, finally raising to meet Catra's. She smiles softly and leans back, and the moment is gone.

---

After that, things change.

Catra doesn't mean for them to, but they do. It's unavoidable.

Her feelings for Adora have spiraled out of control, and her shame has finally found a place to land.

Nothing could have spelled this out clearer for her than actually thinking Adora might.*Well*. She hadn't, no matter what passed between their hot breaths and wanting bodies in that moment, and from then on, Catra can't help but think that the only place their speeding train is headed is straight off a cliff.

Adora haunts her, sleeping or awake, her smell embedded in Catra's own skin and the memory of her body so vibrant it feels like she is still holding her when she closes her eyes. It feels like she is still underneath her, still keening and surrendering, and—

It is horrible.

It is horrible and infuriating and disappointing and impossibly distracting, and the liveliness that Catra feels inside of herself from the feeding only serves to keep the memories fresh and looping in

her head. It is driving her insane, and Adora's constant texts are only making it more insufferable.

She should have assumed that attempting to preserve her sanity by ignoring them would backfire on her even worse, but she doesn't realize that in time. After several days of radio silence, Adora decides to take things into her own hands, and she strides into the bar before it's officially open for the night with the same false bravado she held the first time she had visited Catra.

She looks just as heart-stopping as she had then, and she smells twice as good, now that Catra knows what all that power tastes like hot on her tongue and willing under her touch. It feels like a joke from the universe when Adora approaches the bar top in her stupid red jacket and swallows nervously . Catra's prior resolve to slow their relationship down softens into putty as soon as their eyes meet. She can see the confusion and fear that Adora's carrying and that she has caused it, and it breaks her down.

She leans onto the bar top to meet her and offers her a small smile.

"Hey , Adora."

Chapter End Notes

I'm SO sorry y'all, but we still have some plot points to resolve before they can make out. Trust me, I am suffering right there beside all of you, but the next chapter is a long and VERY important one and I'm so excited for it!

I want to thank you all so much for all the love and sweet comments and appreciation you've given me and this story through the last nine months, it truly means so much! And in addition to the comments, there has been some AMAZING fanart done for this! The book I mentioned in this chapter "How To Clean Dog Hair (And Other Tips When You're Dating a

Werewolf)"was actually born from EmileeDoodles' art, and was so hilarious that I HAD to find a way to work it into the canon story. So many other pieces have been done since then by so many amazing artists;PEASE go take a look at everything!

Twitter link (most everything is here)

Tumblr link (some stuff is here)
As always, playlist is here!
Thanks for reading <3

# An Act of Kindness

Chapter Summary

Adora goes to the bar and learns more than she bargained for.

CW: referenced and implied canon-typical child abuse

Chapter Notes

Title is from An Act of Kindness by Bastille. This chapter was the hardest one to title so far, but this song really captures the conflict here.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora doesn't understand what she's done.

She knows she's done *something*, because days have gone by and Catra hasn't answered her, and Catra always answers her.

Even if it's just to call her a dummy or some other playful insult, she never lets her messages go completely unrecognized like this. Adora considers that something could have happened, but what? What would make Catra inaccessible by phone that Adora wouldn't have heard? Surely anything town-wide or concerning her family would be relayed to her by Mara.

But for days, there is just nothing. And after seeing her for so many days before. Adora has a distinct feeling that she has gravely fucked up.

She wants to give her time, remembering how she needed time to come around after their first disagreement after her second full moon, but there is no time. The new moon is tomorrow, and with

each moment they spend apart, Adora becomes more and more certain that she will not be able to change without Catra there.

There is just something about her. Something in the way her familiar scent centers her mind and her voice cuts through the madness of the change. Something in the way she makes her feel: trusted, safe, and so distinctly *her*. The last change had been so easy with her, so quick and grounded, and the pain hadn't lingered at all afterward.

Something about her makes Adora feel so sure of herself—so in control of her uncontrollable body—that she just knows she will not be able to command the change well enough to manifest it without her there.

And that's how she ends up at the top of a ladder just inside the Black Eclipse, knuckle-deep in the ceiling as she tries to fix their flickering light.

She'd seen it as soon as she came in, and it had pulsed weakly while she and Catra exchanged the world's most awkward small talk, cementing in Adora's mind that she had *definitely* done something wrong. She's pretty sure she knows what it is now, too, but she has no idea how to express an apology for it without the topic inevitably leading to Catra calling everything off and asking to never ever see her again, so she hasn't said anything yet. Instead, she filled the awkward silence by offering to fix the light and then insisting that Catra let her when she tried to turn her down.

Working on the light gives her something to do with her hands and some space to figure out the best way to mend the harm that she's done before it's too late. Just as she's almost got the apology worked out, she hears someone enter the room from the back.

Adora peeks over her shoulder, and a moment later, when the scent hits her, she realizes it must be the owner, Netossa, joining Catra at the bar top. She looks tough and smells like blood and wine and magic. Adora turns back around as her fingers finally find what she

was looking for, but it's impossible to block out the conversation that ensues behind her.

"What the fuck is that wolf doing to my bar?" Netossa's voice cuts through the air.

Catra sighs, and Adora hears her take a couple of steps away. Her voice is lower than Netossa's when she speaks. "She's just fixing the broken light, don't worry about it."

"Like hell I'll worry about it. This is *my* bar." A few footsteps follow the words, and Adora stops working to peek over her shoulder again. Netossa's walked behind the bar to the corner closest to the door and seems to be sizing Adora up. Adora imagines she would know who she is if she were friends with Mara, but she took off her jacket before she climbed up the ladder, so it's possible she doesn't recognize her.

She tucks the light socket back into place so she can bring her hands down and turn enough to wave at the bar owner. "Uh, hi, I'm Adora"—

Netossa laughs, not unkindly, before Adora can get any other words in. "Yeah, I know who you are, pup. Catra's been dragging your scent around here for months now, stinking up the place"—

"No, I haven't!" Catra protests with a squeak.

Netossa turns to Catra with a dramatic roll of her head. "Uh, yeah, you have." She turns away before Catra can respond and shoots a surprising wink in Adora's direction. "Don't fall or electrocute yourself, alright? Mara will kill me if you get hurt."

"Oh, no worries! I'm very sturdy," Adora assures her, snapping a hand up to her forehead in a salute. The ladder rocks precariously underneath her with the quick movement, but she stays atop it, as promised.

Netossa's gaze lingers on her for another moment, a hint of movement at the corner of her mouth, and then she shakes her head and turns back to Catra. She moves close enough to block her from Adora's sight, and then she drops her voice. Adora strains to listen, and the rest of the bar is quiet enough that she thinks she manages to, but the words she hears don't make any sense at all.

"Oh, you. Are. *Feral*, Wildcat."

And then Netossa lets out a loud laugh and leaves the two of them alone in the front room.

Catra glares at the door to the storeroom as it swings shut, and when she finally turns back and glances up at Adora, her cheeks look darker than normal. She strides over, tail lashing, and Adora quickly tries to make herself look busy.

"Are you almost done?" she asks, tone tense. When Adora risks looking down, her arms are crossed, and she's back to looking hot and mad.

A confusing mix of anxiety and attraction crackle together inside her body, and she pulls the socket back out to keep messing with it. "Almost there," she promises, fiddling with the wires and chewing on her lip. "Just another minute or two."

"Okay."

Catra leaves her to finish it, and, with another minute or two, the socket is back in place, the breaker's been turned on again, and when she screws the lightbulb in, it lights up with no issue. The light is bright and steady, and Adora looks at it with a satisfied grin before climbing down the ladder.

"I guess I'll add electrician to your resume," Catra teases, leaning against the bar and holding Adora's jacket.

Adora chuckles, but she can see the foreshadowed dismissal in Catra's pose. "Can we talk?" she forces out of her mouth and watches as the tense line between Catra's eyebrows appears.

"Yeah," she answers quietly, and it's almost worse than if she had just said no. She inclines her head towards the door, and Adora moves the ladder and follows her outside.

The door shuts behind them with an echoing finality, and a chill gust of wind sweeps through the street. It cuts through Adora's t-shirt, but she barely even feels it, and when she accepts her jacket from Catra's hands, it's on instinct only.

"So," Catra starts, and the words erupt from Adora's mouth before she can stop them.

*"I'm sorry."*

Even in the dark night, Adora can see Catra's face clearly as it blanks with surprise and then twists with confusion.

"What?"

"I'm sorry," Adora repeats, the entire script for her apology gone and only two desperate words left in their place.

"For what?" she asks, her voice full of incredulity.

Adora opens her mouth and then hesitates, confused. "Didn't I do something wrong?"

A look Adora can't decipher passes across Catra's face like a shadow, and then her expression straightens out again. "No, Adora. You didn't do anything wrong."

Another breeze hits them and Catra wraps her arms around herself. Adora holds her jacket out in an immediate offering, but Catra shakes her head and then looks away. For a second, it seems like she might say something, but she doesn't.

The anxiety in Adora's chest grows. "Are you sure? Because it really feels like I did something wrong."

Catra's eyes flash at her, and she almost looks hurt, which makes no sense at all.

"If it was um," Adora tries, "if I made you uncomfortable when"—

Catra shakes her head, sighing. Her dark hair spills around her shoulders and falls forward as she looks down. "I promise you didn't do anything, Adora. Okay?"

"You promise?" Adora teases weakly.

She knows Catra means it when she looks up to catch her eye with disappointed exasperation, and it eases the tangled knot of emotion between Adora's ribs. Catra doesn't say anything else, but that's okay. She can take this for now.

"Does that mean you'll still come tomorrow night?" Adora asks quietly, bracing herself for a negative answer.

Catra's expression tilts into surprise, and then she looks up at the sky. Patterned with stars, it's darker than usual, only a tiny sliver of the moon left before the new moon tomorrow. When her gaze falls back to Adora's face, it's softer and filled with understanding.

"Yeah, I said I would."

Adora nods, Catra's soft voice only so reassuring. "Cool. I heard Mara talking to your mom about it earlier. I think she might be there?"

Catra's face scrunches adorably for a second, and then she lets out a soft chuckle. "Do you think Angella is my mom?"

Now it's Adora's turn to be confused. "Well, I no? Yes? … Technically? It's obvious that Angella isn't her birth mother, being neither a magicat nor a vampire, but it still seems like the best word

to describe her. "There definitely isn't anyone else filling that role in Catra's life. Adora has no idea who her parents are or what may have happened to them, and it certainly doesn't feel like the kind of thing that would be appropriate to ask her now.

Catra giggles, and it's adorable enough that Adora doesn't mind if she's the butt of this joke that she doesn't understand.

"You do call Glimmer your sister, don't you?" she defends her line of thinking.

"Okay," Catra concedes with a roll of her varicolored eyes, "but Angella is definitely not my *mom*."

"What would you call her, then?" Adora raises an eyebrow.

"Angella," Catra deadpans, and as much of a little shit as she's being, it's nice. It feels like they're back to normal.

"That's very descriptive," Adora teases.

Catra frowns, but there's a clear playfulness to how her lips twist downwards. "When I met her, she was Chancellor Angella, and then once I met Glimmer, she was Chancellor Angella: Glimmer's Mom. It's a lot of progress that I cut it down to just Angella."

Adora smiles and takes the opportunity presented. "When did you meet her?"

"When she adopted me," Catra says with an apprehensive expression, like she's expecting Adora to crack a joke. "I never met her before that. I didn't even know this town *had* a Chancellor."

Adora pauses. "You were adopted?"

"Yeah." Catra gives her the same confused look and blinks. "Don't you know this?"

Adora returns the confused look. "I mean, I guessed it was something like that, but…"

"It's so weird that you never heard this stuff."

"What stuff?"

Catra blows out a breath. "I mean, the shit between me and the clan. And now, the orphanage. I guess they might've tried to keep it under wraps when it happened, but"—

Adora's world dims. "The orphanage?" she echoes hollowly.

"Yeah, when it got shut down and everything. It was a pretty big deal; the clan were total assholes to Angella, all the town leaders were involved—what?"

Catra is looking at her strangely. It's likely that *she's* looking at her strangely, but she just can't seem to care. Her brain is putting the pieces together, and the picture that's coming out doesn't make any sense at all.

"You were at the orphanage? When it shut down?"

"Y…eah, I'm basically the reason that it did," Catra mutters. "Cause they found me."

Adora's vision is tunneling, the night's shadows converging until all that she can see is Catra's face.

"*I* was at the orphanage," she manages to get out.

All expression wipes off Catra's face, and her next words are stilted. *"What…a…'sop?"*

Adora can feel herself nodding, but it's like the entire world has shifted under her feet. Everything is off kilter. Something is rushing through her ears. Her heart has climbed into her throat and is doing somersaults.

"What the *fu* do you mean you were at Shadow Weaver's orphanage?" Catra asks, and Adora can just barely hear her voice shaking over the rushing.

"That's where Mara found me," Adora answers, no idea if she's making any sense at all. "That's that's where I was, that's where she found me."

"When?"

"What?" Adora's having trouble focusing.

"*When*," Catra practically growls.

"I don't know , I was like, seven or something?" Adora's trying to answer, but her brain is a jumbled rush of thoughts. Catra was at the orphanage? When *she* was at the orphanage? When Mara adopted her from the orphanage? *Before*?

"Why don't I remember you?" she thinks aloud. "Why don't you remember me?"

"You *did* remember me," Catra answers, wrapping her arms tightly around herself. The furrow between her brows is a canyon. "That's what you said. You said you knew me, but you didn't. You knew my smell. You... ou remembered me."

Adora knows what she said, and she knows that she knew Catra's smell. But they used to know each other? Live together? Adora's scent memory is stronger than her human one certainly, but she can't imagine forgetting someone like Catra even if she was young.

But for Catra, her memory should be better than Adora's by tenfold.

"Why don't *you* remember *them*," she repeats.

Catra avoids her eyes. There's a long pause before she finally frowns and then answers. "I've made a point not to remember

*#g* from the first decade of my life in that fucking houseI'm not surprised I forgot you, if you were there."

The words hit Adora like a slap across the face. But the longer she lingers on them, the more they begin to sink into her skin and drag her down like a weight.

Her time at the orphanage wasn't enjoyable, and she doesn't remember much, but it was never anything that she *had* to forget. It wasn't something she would make a point to *avoid* thinking about.

"What happened?" Adora asks, her mind racing with the possibilities.

Catra's eyes flash as soon as the words leave her mouth, and it looks like a warning. She hasn't seen Catra look at her like this since she kicked her out of her house after the second moon. Everything Adora remembers about the orphanage being shut down – Angella and Mara randomly sitting her down a few years after her adoption to ask about her time there, and then Mara returning a few days later to let her know that the town had suddenly decided to dismantle the orphanage and rehome the children to various places – comes rushing back, and she realizes how little of it adds up. Why had they dismantled it? What had happened? And if Mara had known something was wrong therewhy was everyone else left behind when she adopted Adora? Why did it take so many years to shut the place down?

Adora takes an urgent step forward, suddenly desperate. "What happened?" she asks again.

Catra doesn't back down, but after a moment of staring at each other, her glare softens. "A lot of shit, Adora," she says, her voice hard but not hostile. "It's over now. It's in the past."

The truth grips Adora's throat and makes it hard to breathe. She can only manage a few words. "But it happened and I forgot you."

Something strange flickers over Catra's expression, but Adora's mind is racing too quickly to catch it. It happened, and she forgot her, and Mara knew. She had to know. How could she not?

And she hadn't said anything. She hadn't done anything.

"She knew," slips out of Adora's lips.

"What?" Catra asks, leaning forward, but Adora is already turning away.

"I have to go," she mumbles, even though she's already gone. She hears Catra call after her, but she's already running.

Mara fucking knew.

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Adora sprints the entire way home. She can't slow herself down, numb to the straining muscles in her legs and the burning in her lungs as her feet pound against the pavement. Her pulse is rushing in her ears, but all she hears is a two-beat rhythm, spelling it out to her.

She knew.

She knew.

She knew.

She only gains speed when the commune finally appears in the distance, and she shoulders the front door of the main house open without pausing, the wood flying back and slamming into the hallway

wall. She throws her jacket down and storms around the corner into the kitchen to find Huntara, Juliet, and Starla sitting at the table and staring up at her in surprise, obviously shaken by her entrance. She stomps past them until she can see the stove, following the scent of her trusted leader and scrambled eggs.

Mara looks up as Adora storms into the kitchen, a kind greeting dying on her lips as she takes in the anger rolling off of Adora in waves.

"Did you know?" she demands, rage making her voice tremble. She has never addressed Mara like this, ever.

Mara's eyebrows knit together with surprise and confusion, but there is something else in her eyes that Adora knows is recognition. It is fear. Mara sets her spatula down carefully and turns off the stove before turning back to her, and that is all the confirmation that Adora needs.

"What?" Mara asks softly, and Adora can't help it. She laughs.

Of course, she wants to have this discussion quietly. Of course, she wants to be polite and civil about it. Because she knows that she fucked up. Because she fucking knows.

"Did you know," Adora asks again, her voice only rising in volume, "that she was at Weaver's orphanage too?"

Mara drops all pretense from her expression and instead glances behind Adora at the dining table. Adora doesn't turn, but she hears three chairs immediately scrape backward as the other wolves make themselves scarce.

"Did they know?" Adora asks, her voice quieter but still trembling with anger. "Did you know? And you all just lied?"

"No one lied to you, Adora," Mara replies calmly, leaning a hip against the countertop and crossing her arms.

“A lie by omission is still a fucking lie,” Adora spits, taking a large stride forward. She can feel tears prickling in her eyes. “You fucking lied.”

Mara’s lips press together tightly, but she nods. “Yes, I knew.”

“And you didn’t tell me.”

“No,” she concedes with a small sigh. “I didn’t tell you.”

Adora waits for her to say more, to offer some sort of explanation for her actions, but she doesn’t.

Adora has always trusted Mara. She has always believed that she knew best, that she did her best. That she had everyone’s best intentions in mind when she made decisions. But as the seconds tick on and there is nothing more to answer her but silence, doubt shatters Adora’s trust into pieces.

“Why,” her voice cracks on the single word, anger beginning to falter into desperation. It is becoming difficult to see Mara through the tears blurring her vision.

Mara’s lips twist into a frown, and Adora sees sympathy slip into her expression as she sighs, heavier than before. “I…” her gaze falls from Adora’s face, and she turns to lean back against the counter. “I didn’t want your past to determine your future together. I wasn’t sure if you would remember each other… you never mentioned her to me when you were little, but you obviously know her scent. I thought that if you had been close, sought comfort in each other when you were there… the memories might come back. I have no idea what she remembers, if anything. I figured if you remembered each other, then great. I could fill in the gaps if you needed me to. But if you didn’t remember… and if she didn’t either…”

Adora takes another step closer, fuming anger quieted into anguish as a hot tear rolls down her cheek. “Then why?” she asks, her voice desperate for answers.

"Then maybe that was better ," Mara finishes, turning back to Adora. Her eyes are remorseful, lamenting. The set of her jaw is tense. "Maybe you could both have a fresh start, with each other ."

The way Mara' s voice caresses the last three words stops Adora's reply from leaving her lips. There is so much implication in them, so much weight being carried by so few letters.

"Y ou've had so many things already decided for you in your life," Mara continues, the apology clear in her voice. "I wanted to let you have a clean slate, at least once."

"Except *th* was your decision, too."

Adora isn't even conscious of the thought until it leaves her mouth, but once it does, there is no taking it back.

Mara winces before smoothing out her expression and nodding. "Y eah," she concedes softly . "It was. And I'm sorry ."

The apology hits Adora like a slap, and her anger returns immediately. "Sorry doesn't change the fact that you left her there," she snaps.

Mara's face collapses together in confusion. "*W*

Adora straightens up, crossing her arms together and staring Mara down. "Y ou *l* her there. When you took me, you left her there. For *g* ."

Mara straightens up to match her, but there is no hostility to her posture. "W e didn't know she was there," she says, and Adora scof fs loudly.

"She' s a magicat-vampire hybrid. Was Shadow Weaver just hiding her in the closet or something? How the hell did you find me and *not* *know* *s* " Adora' s voice is rising with each word, but she can't find it in herself to care. Adora could pick Catra out of a scent

lineup from across a hundred-yard field upwind in less than a second —there was *no* chance that Mara could have gone into the house she was living in and not known she was there.

"It wasn't easy to find *you*," Mara defends, frowning, "and if I hadn't made a surprise house call before she could hide you away, I never would have. She had spells up, enchantments, concealing some of you. She must have had a million blocking Catra's smell from me when I went. Do you really think I would have left her there if I'd known?"

Adora's loyalty wants to say no, but the evidence says yes. Her answer stays lodged in her throat.

She sees hurt flicker in Mara's eyes when she fails to answer, and her expression falls. "When I found you there and took you with me, you weren't hurt. You weren't happy there, but you weren't exactly elated to come with me, either, at first. You didn't show any obvious signs of anything *close* to abuse, and it was years before you said anything that tipped us off to how Shadow Weaver was handling that house. And when we heard stories from other residents that were aging out and the things you said off-handedly like they were normal, we went in to investigate. As soon as we found Catra, as *soon* as we got past her spells and realized she had a supernatural vampire *kid* under her care and she hadn't reported it to anyone, we shut the whole thing down."

"What—what did you find? What was Shadow Weaver doing to her?"

Mara's head tilts with sympathy. "What do you mean?"

"She." Adora's voice fails again, and she clears her throat and steels herself. "She said that she didn't *have* to remember anything from that house, that a lot of shit had happened there. What happened?"

Mara hesitates. "It's her story to tell or not tell, Adora. It's really not for me to say."

"Please," Adora begs, not caring how much emotion pours into her voice. "I don't remember. What happened to her?"

Mara sighs, her head hanging forward. "I never talked to her about it; I don't know anything beyond what we found and what was discussed at the council meetings and what you told me. You never mentioned Catra, but it seemed like Shadow Weaver liked you. She treated you a little bit better than level of shitty. She wanted to keep you like a prize, a werewolf pup that survived the Necrosis. She could tell you would be powerful when the change came. But Catra, she's hated the clan for a long time. Hated vampires. She was keeping Catra isolated from everyone else when we found her, starving her of energy, nothing that would kill her, being a hybrid, but—" she cuts off, shaking her head. "It's not my story to tell, Adora."

Adora nods numbly, words still caught in her throat like a rock and her mind racing. Had she even known Catra if she never mentioned her? She tries to remember the orphanage, tries to remember living there, but it's been so long that everything is covered in a fuzzy haze. It's like looking through a window caked with age and dust; she can't make out any of the details.

If Adora hadn't known Catra, had she been hidden down in the cellar like a rat while the rest of them got to play outside and eat together? Had Catra been starving just below their feet? And if Adora had known about her, if she had just said something about it sooner, would they have found her? Would they have saved her?

Another concern strikes Adora's mind.

"What happened to her? To Shadow Weaver? What happened?"

Adora could remember Mara promising her that she would never see her again, that Weaver would never be in her life again, all those years ago. But that was all she'd said, so that was all she knew.

"She was banished," Mara says definitively. "Same protocol as any banishment, she was kicked out, and we added her to the town's guarding enchantments to keep her out."

"But what if she comes back?" Adora rushes to ask. "If she was powerful enough to hide *Catra* from you all, who says she can't get around the town's charms? What good would they even *do* against her?"

Mara turns towards her, a mix of empathy and amusement joining in her expression. "You think she's going to *come back*," she says, and it almost sounds like a laugh. "Now that Catra's all grown up and as powerful as she is? If she didn't kill her the moment she stepped into this town, the clan *would*. And Shadow Weaver knows it. She'd never take that risk; there's nothing left for her here."

"Why would the clan kill her?" Adora asked. She could imagine why Catra would – without even knowing the details of how Weaver had treated her, Adora was feeling ready to kill her herself. At least maim her, if nothing else. But the clan? Was hiding a hybrid really worthy of that punishment?

"They tried to kill her the first time around," Mara said, raising her eyebrows, "but the council wouldn't let them. They tried to claim she was committing treason and something about a conspiracy to murder." She sees the confusion growing on Adora's face and sighs. "They thought she was keeping Catra a secret on *purpose* so she could train her to kill them all off and take over their seat on the council. Maybe even take over the town."

Mara's saying this theory like it holds no water, but it makes a lot of sense to Adora. "Well was she?"

Mara spreads her hands wide and shrugs. "I have no idea. Catra's never confirmed or denied it to us, as far as I've been told. Shadow Weaver was always power hungry and arrogant, sure, but she wasn't stupid. And trying to take out the clan to replace them and take their power? That would have been *very* stupid."

A million questions swirl around Adora's brain as she tries to sort out what she knows from what she doesn't; what she feels brave enough to ask Catra about from what she'll have to live without knowing. The questions eventually shift into what-ifs, and the guilt that comes with wondering what she could have done differently to help Catra when they were younger makes a home on her shoulders and weighs her down.

She leans against the counter to stare at the floor and process it all, and after a moment, Mara shifts over to join her. She bumps shoulders with her and leans down to catch her eye.

"I'm sorry, Adora," she says, and Adora believes her this time. "I really am. Shadow Weaver should never have ended up in charge of the orphanage, but after the Necrosis the whole town just fell apart. I wish we could have known sooner; I wish I could have adopted everyone the day that I adopted you. Believe me; I've done a lot of regretting. But what's done is done. You can't change the past. We can only learn for the future."

The future.

Mara's words from earlier return to Adora's mind; her future with Catra. Their futures with each other. And suddenly, Adora understands what Mara meant by not wanting to say anything, because now that they know, everything has changed.

Her future with Catra is gone. She'd already fucked it up by pushing too much, getting carried away and asking Catra to sit on her lap while she bit her, like that wasn't clearly violating her boundaries. Trying to lean in to kiss her afterward, as if she would ever be allowed to do something like that. And now, this, finding out that the reason Catra was stuck at the orphanage for so long, suffering so much, was because Adora forgot about her. Finding out that the entire reason Adora was even so stuck on her scent those first few moons is just that she learned it when she was young.

A terrifying thought strikes Adora, and she voices it without meaning to. "What if Catra doesn't like me?"

Mara looks at her in surprise, face twisting in confusion. "What?"

Adora's head jerks up, panic setting in as she becomes more certain of this reality. "What if she's only being nice to me and helping me because she knows my scent, even though she forgot it? What if it's just instinct, just a feeling? What if she doesn't actually like me?"

"Adora... why?"

"Well, I knew her somehow, and I went to her because I knew her smell and I trusted her because of that, right? So, what if she did the same? What if she only helped me because instinct told her to? What if that's the only reason she's still talking to me? Or… why is she talking to me."

"Did something happen?" Mara asks.

Adora peeks over at her and blushes gently, shifting uncomfortably. She definitely wasn't going to explain everything to Mara, but a little bit wouldn't hurt. "I just think I pushed too much. To get close to her. I think I made her uncomfortable, and now that we know about the orphanage, she might realize the instinct thing too, and then…"

"Adora," Mara cuts in, her tone commanding. "Stop. Do you like Catra because of instinct?"

"What?"

"Do you like her, like spending time with her, being close to her, talking to her because your instincts tell you to?"

"No," Adora answers without thinking.

She pauses, surprised at herself, but the more she thinks about it, the more confident she becomes in her answer. When she found her

on that first moon, it was instinct that drove her instant trust of her, yes. When she turned on her second moon, she sought her out on instinct again, unaware of what she was doing. But on the third moon…something had changed.

On the third moon, she'd made a decision. She'd chosen the relief Catra brought her over the suffering of enduring the change without her.

And then, after the moon set, when she had turned back, and Catra apologized and made an offer to her to willingly spend time with her…something had changed for both of them then. She had felt it then, and she can feel it now. The beginning of them choosing each other.

She remembers the feeling of sitting at the diner with her the first time she'd let her spend time with her. The easy conversation, the comfortable silences. The genuine joy she'd felt being around her and the comfort of not having to keep up any sort of appearances or performance with her.

She remembers the feeling swirling inside of her chest the last time she'd woken up in Catra's bed after she fed off her for the second time. She remembers how her chest tightened to hold back her frantic heart as she discovered how entangled with each other they'd become as they slept. The hopeful, yearning leap in her stomach when Catra only rolled closer to her as she tried to scoot away, and the dizzying way her skin buzzed everywhere that it touched hers.

The way she'd lingered in her bed just a little bit longer because of that, granting herself a few seconds of indulgence to hold her. Choosing to breathe her in and memorize her and be close to her and pretend like that was something that she was allowed to do.

No, Adora doesn't like her because her *sister* tell her to. She likes her because she is sweet and caring, even though she pretends not to be. Maybe *especially* because she pretends not to be. She likes her because she's smart and witty and so sharp with her tongue that

she can cut right through Adora's chest and slice her heart open with a single word. She likes her because she's resilient and protective, and honest.

She likes her for how she makes her feel—safe and free and alive. And she likes her for what she lets Adora give her—a fixed cabinet, a repaired carpet, and her lifeblood.

She likes her because she opened her door on that third moon, and she chose to let her into her life. She chose her.

"No," Adora repeats. She does not like her because of instinct.

"So why would that be her reason?" Mara asks quietly.

"Because." Adora starts and then immediately pauses, struggling with herself. It would suck if it were just instinct, but it would make sense. But if it weren't that, that would mean that Catra actually liked her for *her*, and that would mean that maybe their future wasn't doomed. That would mean that maybe Catra was telling the truth when she said that Adora hadn't made her uncomfortable by trying to get close to her. And that… Adora doesn't know if she's willing to get her hopes up that high.

As if she can read her thoughts, Mara says, "She told *them*, in front of *you*, that she would let herself get hurt if it meant keeping you safe on a full moon. After only meeting you three times. I can't try to know what she's thinking, but that sure doesn't sound like a *part* she's into to me."

Adora takes a deep breath, trying to calm the nervous hope growing inside her chest. "What if she doesn't come tomorrow night?"

Mara shrugs. "Then she doesn't come. She might need time to process this, but that doesn't mean anything is doomed. And it doesn't mean the change won't come; it's not a guarantee it will if she's there."

Something inside of Adora's head pushes back and insists that it is a guarantee, that she's sure she can get it if Catra's there to help her, but she also knows that Mara is right. She can't know that, not for sure. It's still very early for her to get it on a new moon.

Mara reaches out and spreads a hand over Adora's back, gently rubbing the spot between her shoulder blades. It soothes Adora enough that she closes her eyes and takes a deep breath in and then lets it go and nods.

"I know ," she said tiredly , well aware of what the gesture means and the compassion behind it. "It' s not a problem I can solve by obsessing over it, and I should get some sleep because I'll feel better in the morning," she recites.

Mara doesn't answer, and when Adora opens her eyes to peek over at her, she winks.

"You know my speech better than I do," she grins.

"I've only heard it a million times," Adora mutters back with a smirk, pushing off the counter and stretching her tense body until it cracks.

"You're going to make a great She-Ra," Mara says, following her lead and stepping up beside her. She reaches out for Adora's face and strokes one side of it, cradling her jaw in the palm of her hand and tickling her cheek with her thumb. "And you're going to figure your transformations out. You *will*."

Mara's firm confidence threatens tears in her eyes again, so Adora just chokes down the lump in her throat and nods.

"And," Mara continues, the space between her eyebrows furrowing with sympathy, "you and Catra are going to be just fine. I know this."

"How do you know?" Adora says, her words watery and her tone caught between hope and sarcasm.

Mara smirks. "Call it a *protection*."

*

Adora's face is small. It's small and round, and her cheeks are the perfect amount of full to be violently pinched while someone tells her how cute she is. Her eyes are a bright, light blue, and sometimes when she smiles, they almost look like they're glowing.

She's smiling now, grinning in fact, reaching towards her, and Catra doesn't understand why she is. Why she'd want to.

When her hand touches her, it's small, and warm, and gentler than she expects. Adora is not what she expects.

She smells funny, but it's nice. She's nice. Catra feels nicer when she's around. She feels nicer when she's seen her. Things are better. Things are easier. And she's nice.

Adora giggles and her fingers drag through Catra's fur, messing it up and pushing against the grain of the hair, but it doesn't hurt. It almost tickles. Catra hears a laugh bubble up from her throat and reaches for Adora to push her hair the wrong way when suddenly the lights in the room dim. A darkness, an impenetrable veil devoid of light, sweeps into the room and up to their feet. It begins to creep over them, blocking the light from their forms and overtaking the air between them. A chill washes down Catra's spine. The darkness moves closer and closer, covering more and more of them, and when Catra looks to Adora for help —

She's gone.

And then it is just Catra and the shadow, Catra and the darkness, and it is consuming everything she can see until there is nothing left.

Until so much of the room and the light in it is gone that she can't even see herself. Until she's not even sure that she really exists. And then —

Catra shoots up in bed, a strangled cry escaping from her throat and bursting into the empty room. She searches the dark corners for any signs of shifting shadows or growing darkness, but she comes up empty. All is still. She tugs her knees up to her chest and buries her face, shaking and gasping as she tries to get her breathing under control.

It was just a dream. She's not back there. The orphanage is gone. Shadow Weaver is gone. It was just a dream.

It was just a nightmare.

It was just a memory.

She squeezes her eyes shut tightly, and Adora's round, smiling baby face burns into the back of her eyelids.

She tries not to remember why she forgot her.

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the cliffhanger! Let me know in the comments how close your guesses about their past were to the truth and what you think of it! New moon next chapter xoxo
>
> Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
> Tumblr link (some stuff is here)
>
> Fic playlist: playlist is here!
> Thanks for reading <3

# Wolf Like Me

Chapter Summary

The new moon arrives.

CW: this chapter describes a grizzly werewolf transformation.

Chapter Notes

Title is from Wolf Like Me by TV On The Radio. It's a fucking banger.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra barely sleeps. She only gets a few hours before the nightmare comes;after that, sleep is impossible.

Every time she closes her eyes, Adora's sweet baby face hovers too bright behind her eyelids. And every time she opens them, the shadows cast around the room threaten her from their corners. She feels itchy and uncomfortable in her own skin, and after a half-hour of twitching in her bed, she gets up and yanks the curtains open.

Daylight bursts into the room and erases the lurking shadows, warming her body with a lingering tickle. She climbs back into her bed and curls up in the center of a bright patch of sunlight.

She can still smell Adora on her sheets even though she hasn't been by the apartment in days, and the scent brings as much relief to her as it does shame. It churns thick in her gut and rolls its way through her body, both familiar and infuriating.

She wishes Shadow Weaver was still here, so she'd have someone else to direct it onto instead.

But she's not.

So, she just has to lay with it. She just has to lay with the shame and all the newfound knowledge;that she now has of all of the answers to all of the questions that she'd never even wanted to ask. That she knew better than to ask.

Adora was at the orphanage. She was at the *fucking* orphanage.

As soon as she said it, it was like a dam breaking. The tickle in the back of Catra's mind when she'd met her, the way her scent stuck with her and taunted her so boldly those first few months. The odd familiarity and the sudden trust they'd felt*.* all made sense now . It all opened up from nagging static in her brain into a flood of knowledge and memories.

And she didn't want any of it.

She'd gotten out of that orphanage *half* over a decade ago, and she'd spent every single second since trying to forget that it had ever been a part of her life. But Adora*.* forgetting her along the way had just been a casualty .

Adora was Weaver's favorite, dripping with power even as a child, and she'd been far too kind for that place. Too soft. Catra was glad she wasn't there at the end.

She can remember her now, all too vividly, offering friendship and company in spite of what Catra was. Maybe even because of it. Crossing the boundary Weaver had set that no one else dared to breach, and for what? Why bother?

Catra can remember wondering that back then as well, wondering what was worth the risk in Adora's mind to keep interacting with her. Maybe it was simply that there was no risk, as Weaver's favorite. Maybe it was something else.

It didn't go on for long before Weaver intervened;keeping Catra apart from *pe* , including Adora. It must have been sometime after that that Adora was adopted, but she doesn't know. She didn't know then. The years in isolation blurred together , and by the time the orphanage had been shut down, Adora and the relief she'd once brought her hungry mind were more fantasies than memories.

The more she thinks about it, the less surprised she is that Adora doesn't remember her at all. She wouldn't have expected their time together to mean enough to her to remember, especially after at least a decade and a half since. The back of her mind itches with the knowledge that she *sti* have been worth remembering if she brings Adora so much relief from her pain now, but there are a million things that can make important memories forgettable. After how deeply Catra had buried her own memories of the orphanage, she isn't going to make any judgment calls on Adora forgetting her .

Catra watches the daylight pass for hours, sleeplessly counting down until the new moon arrives. She told Adora that she'd go — and she will, even with everything hanging in the air between them as it is. Their conversation is still largely unfinished, interrupted by Adora's confusion and anger and her sudden departure, and tonight certainly isn't the right time for it, but Catra thinks Adora would still want her to come. She still wanted her to come when she thought Catra was mad at her, so surely she'd still want her now, right?

Catra's vision skips over to her phone, resting quietly on top of her nightstand, and she quickly decides that if Adora hasn't reached out, then everything should proceed as planned. As if their entire relationship hasn't just been flipped on its head. Tonight is more important than that. And if Adora does get it, if the change does come—maybe their fucked up relationship won't even matter for much longer.

It takes her until the sunset begins to drag herself out of bed and realize that she hasn't given any thought at all to what the hell she should wear. Was this a formal occasion? Adora had made it sound pretty casual, with townsfolk going just for the fun of it, but she

wasn’t just another human looking for some entertainment. She was going to stick out like a sore thumb for every possible reason, from her scent to her name to her appearance, and everyone was going to know who she was. Everyone was going to know who she was there for.

Why the hell did she agree to this?

It takes her another twenty minutes to decide on an informal but put-together button-up and vest and pants, and by the time she sets out across town, the sun has sunk below the horizon and the night is as black as coal. She’s only been on the far east side of town a handful of times, but the path to the commune is as clear as day. Even if it wasn’t, the smell would guide her easily.

She follows the path and the stench of power and sweet ash until she finds the property: a large plot of fenced land filled with one gigantic cabin-style house and several smaller dwellings dotted around it. A number of paths wind between all of the buildings, and before any of them is a path that branches off and heads directly into the forest that borders the entire property. Borders the whole east side of town, really, acting as a barrier between their town and the next one over. Catra knows enough to know that their ceremonial space and the bunker they keep the wolves in during the full moon are somewhere inside the forest, so she heads in. It doesn’t take long before she can sort out the lingering smell of the wolves around their property from the smell of live wolves and townsfolk gathered together, and she follows that until she happens upon the ceremonial space.

It’s an amphitheater, or a small arena, more or less. It appears as if they found a natural clearing at a low point in the woods and built up the area around it, setting a stone structure completely around the center of it to be used for steps and seating. There’s an ornate gate acting as a barrier at the top of it, with an open doorway inviting her in. Small lights stand at equal intervals along the gate, illuminating the space below with a soft glow. The trail in the woods leads right

up to the gate, and Catra continues closer and closer until she reaches the gate and can look down into it.

There's a decent amount of people there, maybe twenty, dotted around the seats and chatting quietly amongst themselves. Down at the bottom, about a dozen wolves are seated or moving around in the center circle. But even with thirty-odd people taking up the entire arena, there is an uncomfortable amount of empty space. The evidence that this was built by a much larger pack, with expectations of continuing to grow and attracting more family and friends for these special moments, is impossible to ignore.

The Necrosis happened almost twenty-five years ago now, when Catra and Adora were both only just being born, but it was devastating, especially to the wolves.

Catra's only heard the stories, but Scorpia's told enough of them for some parts to stick. The virus came out of nowhere, like a curse from the beyond, and swept through the town within weeks. Angella did her best, but there was only so much even she could do by the time they understood what was happening. The first wave was bad but not condemning, and when it abated, they thought it was over.

But then the second wave struck.

It was so much worse than they ever could have imagined. It hit the humans and most of the supernaturals like a bad flu, immobilizing them for days until they either recovered or died. It hit the vampires easier, like a bad cold, only transmissible from feeding and not lasting long in their undead bodies.

But the werewolves—the way their cells were meant for rapid healing—it took advantage of that and turned their own bodies against them. It was like a horror manifested especially for them. Over half of them died, most of their leadership and all of their young ones disappearing. Mara was the one to take over when they finally came out of it, the next She-Ra in training and the only one in the whole line to survive.

The whole town was in ruins afterward, everyone simply doing their best to survive, and so much had been lost in the aftermath. So many families, human and supernatural alike, broken apart by death. The orphanage had needed to be expanded and moved, and that's where Catra had eventually been dumped. Adora, too, apparently. Looking at the wolves now, it was a wonder they'd even found as many pups as they had;three ready to change now beside Adora.

The smell is nearly overwhelming here;the plain, lively scent of the mostly human townsfolk getting drowned out entirely by the collection of wolves in the center of the theater. Without the full moon or an active change, the smell is muted into sweet smoke and dry earth, but the power of them all gathered together is charging the air with the same feeling that comes just before a thunderstorm. And at the center of it all, turning the air heavy with her presence, is Adora.

All of the wolves are in long coats ~~-s~~ome hybrid of robe and cloak that covers them down to their calves ~~-in~~ a variety of colors. There's only one red coat, which looks like Mara, but there are lots of black coats and several shining silver coats. Adora is unmistakable in hers, golden hair down and shifting over the silver fabric, flowing around her shoulders in a way Catra's only seen a rare few times.

As always, she looks fucking beautiful.

As if she can hear her thoughts, or like she can sense her, some force moves Adora to turn toward the open gate at the top of the stepped seating and spot Catra. A brilliant smile erupts over her face immediately, bright to Catra's eyes even in the low light, and she sprints for the steps. She takes them two at a time, and before Catra can even realize what she's doing, she's reached the top and is standing before her, grinning ear to ear.

"Hey ,"she says, her sweet voice breathless despite her traversal up the stairs taking little to no effort from her strong body. "You came."

Catra can feel the heat building in her cheeks with the intensity of Adora's joy and all the extra attention she'd brought upon them by

sprinting over to her (Catra was pretty sure there wasn't a single person in the space that wasn't now giving them a curious look) and she wills it down as best as she can.

"Yeah," she answers quietly, shuffling her feet. "I told you I would, dummy."

It's impossible, but somehow Adora's smile gets even bigger. There's a long moment where she just stares at Catra like she can't believe her eyes, and then she seems to realize that she hasn't said anything back.

"Oh, yeah, I know, I just... I wasn't..." her smile falters as she searches for the words, and then abruptly gives up and shakes her head. "It's not important. Thank you for coming."

"Sure," Catra shrugs, her gaze sliding away to see that yeah, everyone was still watching them. "Did I, uh, miss anything cool?"

Adora laughs a bit too much and then shakes her head. "No, no one's gotten it yet. It's just been a lot of standing around naked and grunting so far."

Catra's eyebrows skyrocket. "Sounds like a good time to me," she quips, because she can't keep her fucking mouth shut.

Adora's giggle is a little too high when it comes out, and her cheeks turn a gorgeous shade of scarlet. "Yeah," she mumbles as she abruptly turns around. "Come on. I saved you a seat."

Catra's eyes skirt around the large ceremonial space, but she manages to keep her big mouth shut about the ample availability of seating and the fact that Adora definitely did not need to save her one as they descend the steps. Catra's expecting her to stop somewhere near the bottom and point out a spot for her to watch from, but she continues hopping down the steps until she's reached the very front row, level with the center of the space. On the opposite

side of the center circle, the rest of the wolves are beginning to sit down on that exact same front row. They only span about half of the circle, leaving the entire other half completely empty. Catra sees a couple of them watching them and elbowing each other as Adora points out where she should sit in the empty space. When she complies and Adora sits down directly beside her, close enough for their hips to touch, there is a quiet but distinct wolf whistle.

Catra sees Adora's head snap up and she cuts a nasty glare toward her packmates, her blush visibly darkening. A few of them titter and jostle each other playfully until Mara stands up and cuts them a look. The entire pack falls silent immediately.

Adora leans over as Mara begins quietly inviting one of the silver-clothed wolves to stand up as well, and she speaks to Catra in a low voice that makes her heart skitter.

"Starla's the last one to go," she offers, nodding toward the woman standing up and shedding her coat. As Adora suggested earlier, she is completely naked underneath it. Mara takes her jacket for her and clears the center, leaving Starla alone in the middle. Catra tries hard to process what Adora has said instead of the fact that she is *also* likely completely naked underneath her coat.

After a long moment, Catra's brain finally catches up, and her head whips to the side to look at Adora. "Wait, you already went?"

Adora winces softly and looks over, her expression more than a little bit sheepish, and shrugs. "Yes?"

Catra's heart falls as she realizes Adora's already tried to transform, and she missed it. "Why didn't you say that?"

Adora shrugs again and turns her attention back to Starla in the center. "Mara will probably let me try again, so," she answers quietly.

Catra watches Adora itch under her scrutiny for another moment before turning back to the center as well.

Starla's head is bent, and her fists curled, her body straining as she stands still. Catra can see her muscles rippling and a few low grunts of effort sound, but nothing more happens. The smell in the air doesn't change.

Beside her, Adora is gently frowning, eyes furrowed like she's trying to will Starla to transform with her mind. Across the circle, the rest of the wolves are watching intently, their faces a variety of expressions from concentration to sympathetic disappointment. Catra recognizes two of the wolves in black coats as the ones who paid her a house call to pick up Adora all those many months ago, and a few of the others look vaguely familiar, as if she's seen them around town. As she's inspecting them, she realizes there are two people she didn't notice before. Both clad in deep purple ceremonial garb, there is a child and an old woman mixed into the pack of wolves. The older woman has her eyes closed and is gently swaying in her seat while the kid is leaning forward and concentrating as hard on Starla as if she's trying to transform herself. They both smell of power , the woman muted and her smell mixed with magic, and the child filled with strong, untamed power, but far too young to be changing yet.

Starla's straining cuts off abruptly as she gives up, heaving a long sigh and turning back toward her pack. Mara helps Starla put her jacket back on and rubs the top of her back, speaking to her warmly . The rest of the wolves pipe up and of fer her encouragement and soothing words.

Adora breaks out of her focus and leans back, frown still twisting her lips. She rubs her hands over her thighs for a moment and then glances toward Catra. "I'm gonna go see if Mara will let me try again since we're done early."

Adora lingers until Catra nods, and then she gets up and crosses the circle. Catra listens as she makes her request to Mara. Mara cuts a

look over her shoulder and meets Catra's eyes, not unkindly, and then reaches a hand up to Adora's arm.

"Yes," she says quietly. "But don't try too hard. It'll come when it's ready."

Adora nods quickly, covering Mara's hand with her own and giving it a squeeze. Mara offers her a smile and then helps her take off her coat.

Just as Catra had feared, she is totally and completely naked underneath it.

Trying her absolute best to keep her eyes above Adora's shoulders in the presence of everyone else, Catra watches her step into the center of the circle and gather herself. She shakes out her hands, shakes out her legs, and then closes her eyes and sniffs the air. She takes an incredibly deep breath and then bows her head, balls her hands into fists, and begins.

The straining begins in her forearms, the muscles tensing as it moves up her arms and into her shoulders and her back. Her body lowers as her legs bend slightly, and her thighs and calves bulge. A gentle groaning begins in her chest, growing until the sound is vibrating, and then the air changes. The heavy power in it begins to crackle, moving as if the air itself is alive, and Adora's skin ripples with the shift. There's a sharpness to it, a rawness, and Catra understands what Adora meant when she said that her change was just underneath the surface. Catra can sense it inside of her, can sense her drawing it out, but nothing is happening to Adora's body.

Adora's effort cuts off as she gives up, letting out a loud noise of frustration and shaking her hands out. Behind her, Mara's head tilts in sympathy, and she readies Adora's jacket for her to put back on. Adora looks over and sees the gesture, but doesn't move toward her. Catra watches them exchange a glance, and then Adora turns away from Mara completely, bowing her head as if she's going to try again.

She balls up her fists and moves back into the stance she was in before, but just before she begins to tense her body , her head turns toward Catra.

The look in her eyes is indescribable, something in the intersection of hope and pleading and some desire for *something* that Catra can't identify. The gravity of it is so intense that Catra can't look away , and instead, she finds herself leaning in. *Willing* Adora to find whatever it is that she needs from her to manifest the transformation —offering whatever she can to help her reach it.

And then, she does.

Adora's eyes begin to glow. Gently at first, *so* gently that Catra considers that she might just be imagining it, but then it rapidly increases until both her eyes are dazzling beacons of blue light. Just as they become too bright to look at, Adora closes them, and in the blinding darkness, it happens.

All of her muscles tense and strain until her entire body is vibrating, and then the change erupts from her chest like the beast that it is. Her bones crack and snap at a rate Catra has never seen, breaking almost instantaneously throughout her body like a row of dominoes falling. Loud snarls follow the pain, bursting from her throat without abandon. Fur sprouts immediately afterward, covering her skin in a golden-white wave that ripples from her chest and spreads down her limbs. Her head throws backward as the change rolls through it, distorting her face until it's been reshaped into a snout. She stumbles as the change runs through her legs and rearranges her joints, but it is moving so quickly that by the time she falls and hits the ground, she already has four paws, two ears, and a tail.

And then, with one more rippling shiver, it is over.

Silence falls on the ceremonial space as everyone stares at Adora, a completely changed werewolf, finally successful in her attempts to transform. Adora looks down at herself, takes in her paws and her lupine body, and then erupts into an overjoyed howl.

The stillness of the theater shatters, and within seconds all of the seated, black-coated wolves are launching themselves up, ripping their jackets off, and transforming themselves. Their transformations are unbelievably quick, the bone-cracking process coming and going in the blink of an eye. They surround Adora, and the night is filled with long howls, affectionate barks, and playful growls. Adora is quickly lost in the center of a mass of excited fur.

All of the untransformed werewolves in silver jackets and the older woman and child in purple join them around the edges, whooping and cheering and playing with the wolves near them. Beside them, Mara steps forward, dropping her red coat and transforming instantaneously. As soon as her dark paws hit the ground, the sea of wolves parts for her.

She trots up to Adora, and when Adora bows her head in respect, Mara barks at her. Adora's tail wags and Mara growls playfully as she lunges forward and knocks their shoulders together. She rubs against her, and Adora barks back and nudges her, and then the rest of the wolves join in and the masses of multicolored fur become indistinguishable from one another.

The wolves play with each other for a little longer before Adora eventually shoves her way out of the group and bounds over to Catra. Before she can stop her, she leaps up, paws on the stone steps and tongue slobbering all over the side of Catra's face. Catra shoves her away on instinct, but Adora pushes back, rubbing her big head under Catra's chin and against her shoulders and barking at her.

"Get *off*" Catra exclaims, but she's laughing as she buries her hands into Adora's fur and pushes her down.

Adora lets her and barks at her again from the ground, tail wagging so wildly that it's slapping against the stone steps. A few wolves near them turn away from the group and bark at them both, and when Adora turns and lunges at them playfully, Catra's pretty sure they're voicing the equivalent of another wolf whistle.

She watches Adora rejoin the group and continue celebrating with a dangerous warmth in her chest and the embarrassing knowledge that whoever here *didn't* know how close she and Adora had become over the last few months, sure knew about it now.

---

It isn't until Catra leaves the space with the promise of seeing Adora again in a few days that she smells it and remembers what Adora had told her yesterday.

*[illegible]*

Angella is waiting for her just outside the gate, chatting quietly with her daughter. They're both in their formal ceremonial outfits, though neither has brought their staff for the occasion. They must have arrived even later than Catra and caught the end of things, then. Glimmer spots her first, a giant grin growing over her face, and then Angella turns and sees her as well.

"Catra! How lovely that you came tonight; what an exciting ceremony!"

"Yeah," Glimmer joins in teasingly, "your girlfriend did a really good job."

"*Glimmer*," her mother says sternly, but they all know trying to reprimand Glimmer is a lost cause.

"I guess that book really helped!" Glimmer sings, and Catra fixes her with a glare.

"I burned it," she lies, and Glimmer gasps.

"You wouldn't!"

"I did," Catra shrugs.

Glimmer returns her glare and inhales sharply, but Angella cuts her off with a hand.

"Glimmer, darling, would I be able to speak with Catra alone?" she asks diplomatically.

Glimmer huffs a sigh and rolls her eyes, but smiles sweetly. "Of course," she says, bowing out of the conversation and sticking her tongue out once she's out of Angella's sight line. Catra sticks her tongue out back, not caring if Angella sees or not, and then turns toward her.

"I just wanted to check in on you," Angella says, clasping her hands together in front of her and smiling politely. "It looks like your arrangement with Adora has been working out well for the both of you."

Catra never told Angella anything about Adora ~~–~~ frankly, she's been avoiding the estate the last few months *specifically* to delay this conversation ~~–~~ but she wasn't expecting Angella to stay oblivious to it. But now she realizes her fault: because she hasn't told Angella about it, she has no idea what she thinks is going on.

"Uh, yeah," Catra answers neutrally, wondering how much of what she thinks she knows is from Glimmer. "Yeah, it's going well."

"I'm delighted to hear that," Angella says, and she really does sound delighted.

Catra shifts uncomfortably, waiting for the other shoe to drop, and Angella takes pity on her.

"When I heard about it," she begins, and Catra's jaw tenses as she waits for the end of that sentence.

*attoosthad.'*

*andtyou.'*

*togetheate .'*

"I was overjoyed that you two were finding solace in each other ."

Wait, *what*?

Catra blinks up at Angella, but her face is still open and her smile is warm.

"Wait, you're…*happy* about it?"

Now it's Angella's turn to be confused. "Of course I am, Catra. Adora is spectacular: bright, lively, intelligent, and respectful. I truly believe she'll be a magnificent She-Ra someday. You two make a wonderful pair."

Yeah, she's *really* been getting her information from Glimmer.

"Uh, that's not—" Catra starts, feeling a burning blush across every inch of her skin, but Angella waves off her protests.

"I don't mean anything by it beyond what I said: you two make a wonderful pair. You obviously get on well, and I imagine your different powers and needs complement each other."

Catra crosses her arms defensively at Angella's insinuation;this was *really* as awkward as she'd imagined it would be.

Angella sighs. "Micah is *so* much better at this than I am;I knew he should have come. Look, what I really want to say is:you look *happy*. You look *really*. That's all I've ever wanted for you."

Hearing her almost-mother put the confusing feelings that have been swirling inside of her for months now into such simple and cohesive words does something to Catra, and the embarrassment in her chest

quickly dissipates as tears prickle in her eyes. She blinks them away rapidly.

"Yeah," she answers quietly, nodding. She tries to say *I'm* but the words get stuck in her throat.

Angella raises up an open hand in an offering, and Catra takes it with no hesitation. Angella squeezes it, her hand thin but warm, and she smiles again. "You should bring her over for dinner one night," she says, releasing Catra's hand and then waving hers in the air. "But only if you want to! It is not an order," she adds quickly.

Catra chuckles and nods again. There is still so much to figure out between her and Adora, but she understands what Angella means by the gesture.

Adora can be family, if Catra wants her to be.

"Maybe, yeah," she mumbles.

Angella gives her one last smile and then turns to cast her gaze around. "Now, where did my daughter go"…

Catra starts to join her in the search when one last thing occurs to her.

"You knew, right?" she asks, turning back to her almost-mother.

Angella looks down at her quizzically, but it's only a moment before her expression clears up. "Ah, you mean about Adora? And the orphanage?"

Catra nods.

"Yes," Angella says plainly. "I knew that Mara found her there a few years before we shut it down. It didn't even occur to me when she broke out during the first transformation that it might have anything to do with you, and there was certainly no ulterior motive when I sent

Glimmer after her and she called you for help. You never spoke of her, so I assumed perhaps you hadn't crossed paths before."

Catra understands what she's talking about. Angella found her in isolation, and she had told her so little about her time there when they rescued her before she'd buried her memories of it entirely that Angella had no way of knowing that there was a time when Catra had roamed the orphanage freely. That Adora had sought her out and befriended her all those years ago, before things got bad. So, she had known, but she also hadn't.

Catra nods and Angella continues.

"I know your feelings on discussing that time, and when I heard that the two of you had reconnected I didn't think it was knowledge worth burdening your relationship with. I didn't want that horrible woman to overshadow your future together."

Catra nods once more. This is the answer she was expecting, and it's what she would have wanted from Angella if she'd been given a choice. Strange, but not unwelcome, new emotions twist together inside of her chest.

"Thank you," she says, and a mixture of relief and compassion crosses over Angella's face.

"Of course, Catra."

Swallowing down the emotion in her throat, Catra turns and surveys the dispelling crowd for her sister. "Oh, I think she' s over there," Catra says, pointing.

"What is she doing?" Angella mutters, starting toward her daughter .

Catra tilts her head and watches the way Glimmer's waving her sparkling hands over Starla's body. "I think she' s trying to transform her."

Angella sighs heavily. She pauses for a moment, collecting herself, and then her voice rings out across the clearing.

**A**

Chapter End Notes

Hope you liked it! Just like Bad Moon Rising, W olf Like Me would play during this chapter's climax if this fic was a show, so please imagine that in your head for me.

The next update is likely to be quite large and will take some time to get together, so I appreciate your patience in advance! **EDIT: The next chapter will arrive in early October, with weekly updates for the whole month! Happy Halloween!**

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
Tumblr link (some stuff is here)

Fic playlist: playlist is here!
Thanks for reading <3

# I Belong to You

Chapter Summary

> Adora visits Catra several days after the new moon and has a question to ask.

Chapter Notes

> Title is from I Belong to You by Muse.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora texts her twice in the days between the new moon and when Catra had agreed that she could come over to talk, and Catra's not sure how to interpret the fluttering inside of her chest that the texts create. She was anticipating far more anxiety to surface at the prospect of discussing the history they both now know they share, but her memories of the new moon ceremony seem to be keeping it at bay.

Adora had been so excited that she'd showed up, and so eager for her to be front and center for the proceedings, even with her entire pack there. Catra is still a cynic, there's no changing that, but even *she* can't ignore how openly Adora showered her with affection, even with an audience that made it clear that they noticed. She could still *tell* herself that there was no place for her in Adora's future and that this was the beginning of the end, but it was getting harder and harder for her to actually keep believing it.

Adora arrives precisely when she said she would, knocking politely on Catra's door a half hour after she got home from work several days after the new moon. Catra opens the door to find her so close to the threshold that she's practically already inside, bouncing up on the balls of her feet and greeting Catra with a blinding grin.

"Hey!" she says, her voice a mixture of eager hope and joyful relief.

Catra's voice gets stuck in her throat, caught on the sight of the morning sun illuminating Adora from the side, painting her skin a pale pink and her hair a warm gold. The light holds her form with the exact same softness that Adora's eyes always hold her with, and it takes Catra several tries to even get her mouth to open.

When it does, the words she planned are not the ones that come out.

"What the *fuck* is that smell?"

There's something twisted within Adora's scent, something unfamiliar and unwelcome. It's nestled beside something that smells almost like a wound caught in the midst of healing, and neither scent was there at the ceremony just a couple of days ago.

The sweet smile slips off Adora's face and is replaced with head-tilting confusion. "What smell?" She sniffs the air visibly but doesn't seem to notice it.

Catra's eyes narrow and she grabs Adora by the front of her t-shirt, dragging her into the apartment and kicking the door closed behind her.

"What happened to you?" Catra asks warily as she circles her, scanning her body for injuries and trying to place what the scent that smells so wrong is.

Adora watches as she circles her like prey, standing still and shrugging helplessly. "I don't know what you — *oh*."

She starts as she realizes what Catra's referring to, and she immediately turns away and pulls her shirt over her head.

Catra barely has time to enjoy the skin she's being shown before the source of the smell is revealed and consumes her attention.

"It's my tattoo, isn't it?" Adora asks over her shoulder, holding her shirt loosely over her chest and letting Catra take in the design on her back.

Black line-work decorates most of the space presented to her, sprawling from one shoulder to the other and unfurling down her spine to stop before her hips. It's a sword, primarily, beginning between her shoulder blades and pointing downwards. A large wolf's skull pins the hilt to the blade, and on all sides of the sword are lines that sprawl over her skin. Some of the lines connect to each other, and other small shapes interrupt them, but they all seem to be emanating deliberately from the sword. The skull-and-sword design looks familiar, but Catra doesn't recognize what the lines behind them mean.

The tattoo looks good, in the later stages of healing, and to anyone else it would probably look done. But Catra can smell the ink still settling into its place, still weaving through the fresh skin to take hold and rest there permanently. It mixes with the scent of her healing body in an alien way, and it's definitely the source of the strange smell.

"What is it?" Catra asks, stepping closer and scrutinizing the lines filling up the background.

"It's the sword of power," Adora answers, turning her head to the side to try and see Catra.

Catra shoots her a quizzical look.

"Our sword," she elaborates, as if that is supposed to mean something.

When another beat of silence passes between them, Adora chuckles and stops craning her neck to the side, giving up on looking at Catra. "The pack's sword, the sword of power, it's it's a long story, but it's our oldest relic and supposedly gave us our ability to transform into wolves. It was bestowed upon us a very long time ago to help us

protect those who need it. Eventually, after enough generations of use, the sword stopped carrying the power to transform in its blade, and we started carrying it inside of ourselves instead. It's basically just a rusty old sword in our basement now , but we keep the imagery around to pay respect to our history."

Catra nods, realizing the tattoo looks so familiar because it's a redesigned version of the patches decorating the pack's jackets, except those feature larger skulls with the sword arranged in their mouths to look like the skull is wielding it.

"What are the lines?" she asks, reaching out and tracing a careful finger over a particularly long one.

Adora shivers at the touch but doesn't move away from it. "It's, um, it's an old language the town used to use, a really long time ago. It just says our motto: *through fire and blood*."

Catra wants to laugh at her, but she says the motto with so much conviction that it's actually somewhat attractive. She drags her finger down the blade of the sword while she's still allowed to, listening to the soft hitch in Adora's breath as her heartbeat picks up.

"It smells like shit," she offers, because she is good at nothing if not ruining the moment.

Adora's shoulders relax as she chuckles. "It's not done yet, but we have to work in cycles and with special ink, so our bodies don't just heal over it. I'm not surprised if it smells a bit odd."

"Does everyone get this?"

Adora shakes her head, ponytail slipping over her shoulder and tickling Catra's hand. "No, people get to choose what they want and where they want it, but it's usually some sort of skull and sword decoration."

"Did *you* get to choose this?" Catra asks before she can stop herself.

Adora pauses, and Catra's glad they're not facing each other. "Yes," she answers, and her tone isn't angry like Catra was expecting. Instead, it's shockingly gentle. "Mara didn't choose this for me, if that's what you mean."

Catra isn't sure how to interpret her quiet tone, somewhere between uncomfortable and determined. So she drops her hand, steps back, and nods.

"Good."

Adora hesitates slightly and then pulls her shirt back on and turns around with a furrow in her brow. "So. Um. I wanted to talk to you about something. Well, that's not really right; I just"—

She cuts off with a wince, searching for the words, and Catra tries to ignore the knot of nerves beginning to tangle up in her gut. "Just say it," Catra encourages her anxiously .

Adora lets out a humorless chuckle and nods. Catra can hear her heart picking up, fluttering nervously in Adora's chest, and it's making her own heartbeat faster to match.

"Thank you," Adora finally blurts out. "I wanted to say thank you when I have hands instead of paws and can communicate with more than growls and licks." She laughs in a self-deprecating way , but the seriousness doesn't leave her expression. "I just don't think I've said it nearly enough."

Catra feels her cheeks warm with an embarrassed heat. "Adora, you've said it plenty."

"No," Adora shakes her head forcefully. "No, I really haven't. And I have so much to thank you for; thank you for coming the other night, thank you for letting me stay here during the full moons, thank you for letting me in when you had no idea who I was. Thank you"—

"Adora," Catra cuts her off. "You don't need to thank me for these things. We've already talked about them."

"I know, but I just…" her lips twitch as she searches for the right words. "I need you to know what it means to me. I have so little to offer you, and after what I did to you when we were kids…"

"What do you mean?"

"Leaving you there." Adora looks down, unable to meet her eyes. "Forgetting about you. I could have saved you if I just—"

*"Stop,"* Catra starts, bewildered. She stands and waits for Adora to look at her before she continues, searching her eyes for where this is coming from. All she finds is heaping amounts of remorse and grief. "That's *not* your fault. I don't blame you for that."

Adora opens her mouth and then closes it harshly, squeezing her eyes shut and her fists closed for a long moment before nodding. "I *know*," she finally manages in a strangled voice. "I know. But if things had been different—"

"But they weren't—"

"But if they *had* been—"

"They *weren't*."

The grief in Adora's eyes shifts into a pleading look, her eyebrows pulling together and her lips pressing together tightly. "I'm just… we're—we're supposed to protect people. That's what we're here for. That's what we were made for. And I *could* protect you. *You*." She throws her hands out towards Catra, gesturing as if Catra is supposed to understand. "I don't even know what happened to you! And it's—it's you!"

"It's me?" Catra echoes, failing to grasp what Adora is trying to say.

"*You*" she repeats, gesturing wildly as the pleading in her eyes dials up to eleven. "You're" she trails off as her jaw works, tensing and twitching but failing to form any coherent words.

Finally, she manages just one. "*Be*"

Catra shakes her head, stepping closer. "I don't understand."

Adora's expression falls and one of her hands reaches out desperately. Just before it makes contact with Catra's arm, it stops suddenly, and her fingers recoil back into her palm. She starts to pull away, but Catra catches her hand before she can, and after a moment's hesitation, Adora intertwines their fingers and holds on tightly.

"You're the *only* person I care about protecting," she says, and the words finally begin to make sense. "And I couldn't" she shakes her head and lets out one more empty chuckle, "and it's not even like you need me *now*. You could probably face whatever threat comes up even *better* than I could"—

"*Be*—better," Catra says, but the wit of her sentence is lost with the shaky voice it comes out in. Adora's words have lodged a lump in her throat.

"*Be*—better," Adora agrees with a smile, relief that Catra finally understands making her lips gentle. "So I just" thank you. For keeping me around even when all I have to offer is completely useless to you."

Catra's heart twists. "That's not all you have to offer, Adora." She thinks of everything Adora had done for her since she re-entered her life, everything she did for her when they were children. Everything she's given her, whether Catra wanted her to or not, and she thinks that she could cry.

"It's what matters the most," Adora shrugs. "I'll spend however long you let me trying to find other ways to repay you."

Catra hates the sentiment, but the words Adora chooses grind against her heart even more. *Maybe* "It's not up to me how long you try," Catra mumbles, unable to keep the words from leaving her mouth. "*You're* the one going off to become She-Ra." Her eyes prickle with tears.

Adora's sweet smile falls as her face twists with confusion, and her thumb strokes the back of Catra's hand as she steps closer. "I'm not *going* anywhere—we're just on the east side of town. I'm not *leaving* when I step up."

Great. Now Catra sounds like an idiot *and* Adora can definitely see the tears in her eyes. This is so stupid.

"No," she insists, "but you'll be *Queen*. It's a big job. A lot more important than repaying some stupid debt you don't even owe me." She spits the words out and turns her face away, blinking up at the ceiling and trying to keep it together.

"It's not a stupid debt," Adora argues, side-stepping to catch Catra's gaze again. "And it's not less important to me than the pack; it is *just* as important to me as them." An urgency fills her eyes, and the pleading look returns. "*You* are just as important to me as them. You *are* my pack. Do you not know that?"

Catra searches her eyes for the hidden lie, the falsity in her words, but she finds nothing besides desperate affection. It is too good to be true—too wonderful for her to deserve—but it's all she sees.

She considers that Adora is telling the truth. She considers what that means. She considers that she might have a place in Adora's future after all, and what that place might be.

"It's kind of hard to know things when you don't say them," Catra quips, taking her hand back to wipe away her tears before they can fall. She turns away to compose herself, and Adora doesn't move from her spot.

"Yeah," Adora agrees. "I guess that's a good point. That's why I wanted to say"—

"If you say *thou* one more time," Catra threatens without turning around, "I will drain you."

A beat of silence passes.

And then: "What is it you said?"

Catra peeks behind her to look at Adora with a raised eyebrow.

Her face is full of playful curiosity, and a smirk twists her lips. *Suggestive?*

Catra snorts and Adora breaks into a full-bellied laugh, and the tension in the air eases enough for Catra to turn back around.

"*You* my pack," Adora repeats, and the words sink into Catra and warm her chest. "I'm not going anywhere unless you tell me to. Even when I become She-Ra."

Catra nods, savoring her words and trying desperately to believe them.

"So," Adora starts, threading her hands together and looking down at Catra with something that looks a whole lot like hope. "There was something else I wanted to ask you, too."

Nervous tension returns to Catra's body immediately, seizing her chest and tilting her gut.

"When one of us gets our change on the new moon," Adora continues, taking her silence as an invitation, "there's a whole lot of things that happen. One of them is a celebration, usually just a stupid night out at the bar to celebrate and get drunk and regret it the next morning. But it's tradition, and it's supposed to be fun, and this one's sort of about me, um. I was wondering if you might want to come?"

Well. This is not what Catra had been bracing herself for. "Is that even allowed?" she asks.

Adora shrugs, hesitating like she hadn't really considered that. "I mean I didn't ask, but I don't see why not. It's not like some sacred ritual or something; it's just a party to celebrate. And it's *my* party anyways, and…" her gaze falters, falling to her hands twisting into each other. She takes a deep breath. "I want you to come," she tells the floor, then quickly looks up and adds: "only if *you* want to come, of course."

Catra watches her, waiting until she looks up and meets her eyes for good to see the fear that has crept in and mixed with the hope and the earnest eagerness that carries throughout it all.

Catra is nodding before she even realizes it. "Sure, Adora. I'll come."

Adora's smile is wide and warm and full of relief, and Catra gets the feeling that she has no idea what she's just agreed to.

*

Adora stares into her closet and thinks about how stupid fashion is for the fifth time that night. Why did people even need to wear clothes anyway? Why did there have to be special clothing for special occasions? Why were there so many secret, unspoken rules about clothing when it was all just material that hung on your body for aesthetics? Who even cares about appearances enough for any of it to matter? Why was she suddenly overthinking this when she's never overthought any of her outfits a single day in her life?

Well, she knows why. It's because Starla saw her outfit, asked her with a laugh if that's what she was planning on wearing, and then got politely quiet when Adora said yes.

She knows she didn't mean anything by it, but now Adora's head is swirling with doubt. She wouldn't care at all about being over or underdressed for a pack gathering, especially one that's about her, on any other occasion. But she invited Catra to this one, and she wanted that invitation to mean something, and she knows that everyone else knows that it means something, and what if what she's wearing ruins that? What if she makes Catra think this doesn't mean anything if she dresses too casually? But what if she overdresses and comes on too strong? If that's not what Catra wants, it could ruin everything.

"You alright over there, pup?" Huntara's voice calls, shattering her inner monologue.

Adora hides her nerves behind a frown as she spins, narrowing her eyes. "I got my voluntary transformation, your days of calling me a pup are numbered."

Huntara scoffs loudly, approaching her and clapping a hand against her shoulder, hard. "I've got over 300 moons on you. You'll always be a pup to me."

Adora rolls her eyes and ducks out of the way with practiced ease when Huntara reaches up to ruffle her hair. She watches Huntara chuckle and then look around the space, taking in the various pieces of clothing strewn around Adora's bunk.

"Just trying to figure out what to wear," Adora offers with a modicum of embarrassment, picking up a few pairs of shorts and chucking them back into her closet. She still slept in the room meant for the younger wolves – a large room filled with bunk beds and closets that had been built back when they'd anticipated at least a dozen young wolves growing up together instead of barely a dozen wolves in the entire pack. With only four of them learning to transform right now, the space was easy to share, and having other people nearby made it easier to sleep.

Huntara cracks a grin and welcomes herself to plop down on Adora's bed. She used to live in the main house in the single bedroom next to Mara's, acting as second-in-command after the Necrosis. Once Juliet became old enough to take over that position, she took that bedroom, and Huntara moved out into one of the smaller houses lining the property.

"Nervous about your date?" she asks, a smug but not unkind snicker following her words.

"I don't think it counts as a date if you're there to ruin it," Adora replies, a bit grouchier than intended. The only person in the pack that *hasn't* teased her about inviting Catra along yet is Mara, and somehow that's even worse. If Mara thinks it's too serious to tease her about... maybe it really *does* count as a date.

"Oof," Huntara pretends to be wounded and then starts sorting through the clothing on Adora's bed. She yanks a muscle shirt out from underneath her and then looks up and scrutinizes the shirt Adora has on. "Is that the nicest thing you have?"

Adora looks down at herself, clad in her favorite button-up—the pink short-sleeved one with gigantic, patterned moons. "Y... es."

Huntara slaps her knees and then stands, taking care not to knock her head against the top bunk. "Come on; I'll lend you something. A first date calls for something a little fancier."

"Fine," Adora mumbles, obediently following after Huntara as she leaves the room and starts taking the stairs two at a time. This *is* definitely a date.

"Oh!" Huntara stops short at the bottom of the stairs, whipping around so fast that Adora has to catch herself on the railing to stop from crashing into her. "That reminds me," she starts, raising a thick hand to point at Adora and frown. "Don't get blood on my clothes. That's the number one rule from here on out, no blood on any of my shit. Got it?"

Adora's jaw hangs open, moving uselessly. While she didn't borrow Huntara's things often, it certainly wasn't unheard of. But, "Why would I get"—

The rest of the question dies on her lips as she realizes what Huntara is implying, and panic and embarrassment flush over her skin from head to toe. Denial is the first thing she thinks of, but Huntara's gaze is so knowing that it's like she's already in her head. She watches her expectantly, waiting for confirmation that Adora understands, and Adora realizes that there's no other way to end this conversation.

"Yeah, got it," she mumbles, nodding rapidly. "No blood."

"Good." Huntara nods and then punches Adora hard in the arm. "You can have fun in your own clothes."

Adora turns even redder, if that's possible, and steps forward to shoulder Huntara out of the way. "Yeah, *gtt*. Can we move on now?" she asks through gritted teeth.

"Sorry, pup," Huntara apologizes, catching up to her and wrapping a heavy arm around her shoulders. "We've never had a vampire in the family before, so I gotta make this opportunity count."

Adora nods and stays silent, just trying to let the conversation move on, but by the time they've reached the front door, Huntara is still looking at her expectantly. Adora stops and raises an eyebrow at her, unsure what else she wants.

"Come on. *Odd*? That was hilarious! None of you damn kids appreciate my humor."

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It takes them less than fifteen minutes to find a good shirt for Adora, a crisp white button-up that's clean enough to make her look nice but loose enough to roll up the sleeves, unbutton a few buttons, and feel comfortable in. She's still wearing her own jeans and sneakers that dress it down a little, and it's the perfect balance to say, *"I'm not actually trying too hard."* Huntara dons her own vest to match the formality, gives Adora two thumbs up of approval, and then ushers them out of the house to meet the others.

Adora had asked Catra if she wanted her to walk over and pick her up, but since the bar they were heading to was on this side of town, Catra insisted that she would just meet her at the commune, and they could walk over with the rest of the pack. They're heading to the front gate, where Adora can see some of the wolves gathering, but before they get there, she sees Frosta break off from the group and head towards them.

Adora already knows what she's going to say before she says it.

"Are you suuuuuuure I can't come?" she complains, walking backward in front of Adora and giving her best puppy-dog pout.

"I'm sorry , Frosta," Adora says, as if they haven't already had this conversation five times today. "But you can't come. Y ou can't drink, and they won't even let you in; you're eleven!"

"And three quarters!" Frosta insists, walking backward on her tiptoes to look taller. "They'd let me in if you got Mara to tell them to!"

"I'm not going to put her in that position," Adora answers diplomatically.

"Ugh! Y ou're never any fun."

Adora knows that that's a lie —she' s Frosta's second-favorite person in the pack —but she also remembers what it was like to be the only kid and constantly excluded from the pack's activities before they found Starla and the other pups. Frosta is their only child right

now, and it's lonely, especially when she's stuck living with Razz for a few more years until someone else can move in to keep an eye on the old woman.

"I'll make it up to you," Adora promises, but Frosta only rolls her eyes.

"It won't be the same."

"I'm sorry."

Frosta stops walking backward and shrugs, finally giving up on convincing Adora and accepting her judgment. "Whatever," she says, stepping out of the way. "Have fun with your girlfriend. Nice matching shirts," she snickers playfully and then takes off down the path to Razz's house in the woods.

Adora looks down at her shirt in confusion and realizes that Frosta's comment must mean that Catra is already here. She breaks out into a light jog, trying to parse out her scent from the heavy smell of all the wolves gathered at the gate, and when she finally does, it sends her nerves flying. She doesn't stop jogging until she reaches the small crowd, trying to peer over everyone's heads and follow the scent.

"Adora, Huntara!" Mara greets them with a grin. "Great! We're all here, then."

"Yeah," Starla says, far too happily. "I think we're good to go."

Adora hears a soft tittering pass between the wolves and shoots them a funny look, but she's still far too distracted trying to find Catra to really care what's happening. She catches a knowing look from Mara as she ushers everyone out of the gate, and then she leans over to Adora and nods toward the tree line.

A short distance ahead, just off the property line of the commune, stands Catra. She's leaning against a tree with one leg bent and her

arms crossed, and when she catches her eye and straightens up, Adora realizes what Frosta meant.

Catra is wearing a black button-up, unbuttoned dangerously low, with the sleeves rolled up to her elbows. Her black pants are tastefully ripped, and she's even wearing shoes for the occasion.

They are, for all intents and purposes, wearing two versions of the exact same outfit.

As Catra moves closer, Adora can see that her shirt is much softer and silkier than her own. It is shifting a bit too liberally over her chest, tucked loosely into her pants with a belt. When her tail swishes behind her, Adora sees that she's attached some sort of jewelry to it, a gold cuff with a small crescent moon charm. Her hair is down and as wild as ever, curling waves framing her jaw and falling down her back. Her face is as beautiful as it always is: wicked angles and dark freckles, with a softness lingering underneath it all.

Adora can't stop her gaze from roaming her head to toe, taking it all in, and she's far too aware that she's staring, but she just can't stop.

"Hey ," Catra says when she finally reaches her , her voice raspy, honey-sweet, and maybe even a little embarrassed. Adora catches one of her ears twitching between the locks of her long hair towards the rest of the pack, lingering nearby and talking amongst themselves.

"Hey ," Adora responds, her brain unable to do anything but repeat what she's been offered.

A small smile creeps at the corner of Catra's mouth like a secret gift just for her , and Adora suddenly wishes that they were going out alone.

"You guys ready?" Huntara calls out a little too loudly , and immediately after comes the sounds of a few giggles and people elbowing each other.

Yeah, Adora *h* wishes that they were alone right now.

*"Y p,"* she calls back tensely, finally ripping her eyes away from Catra's gorgeous face to shoot Huntara a meaningful look. "Go ahead!" She gestures towards the road, and Mara immediately steps forward, clapping and guiding everyone to follow her to the bar. Huntara offers Adora a toothy grin before turning and following, and Adora waits until the group is several paces ahead before she turns to Catra and indicates that they should follow.

Catra simply nods and falls into step with her, and a strangely awkward silence falls over them. Adora searches for something to say, but she's acutely aware that any conversation they share here in the quiet of the night will be overheard by her packmates up ahead, and every topic she comes up with is one that they'll surely tease her about tomorrow.

She glances nervously at Catra and catches her quickly looking away. Catra plays it cool, slipping her hands into her pockets and looking around the street, but the urgency she'd looked away from her with was a dead giveaway. Adora feels her cheeks heat as her ego swells and a gentle smirk draws up her lips. She rips her eyes away from Catra to look out into the night and play it cool, too, following her lead.

"So, have you ever been to Whispering W oods before?" Adora asks lightly.

"Nope," Catra answers, popping the P .

"It' s nice," Adora nods, of fering a small smile. Catra meets her eyes and there's something in them that Adora hasn't seen before, something teasing and curious that makes Adora pause for far longer than intended. "Mostly full of humans, but not the annoying kind."

"There' s a kind of human that *is* annoying?" Catra asks, but she' s smiling.

Adora grins. "I guess it depends on who you ask. They like us there, so no one ever really bothers us."

"Aw, it's full of your fan club?" Catra teases.

"Y... ou think I'm great enough to have a fan club?" Adora flirts.

Catra's face falls and her eyes roll to the sky as she realizes what she walked herself into. "That's *not* what I said."

"But it's what you implied," Adora sings.

"*My* mistake," Catra drawls, her eyes lingering playfully on Adora's face. "I won't make it again."

The bar isn't a far walk from the commune, and they reach it with a few more minutes of teasing conversation. The night is already in full swing inside, with music pumping through the walls and plenty of people filling the place.

Adora's eyes dart back to Catra to ensure she's still willing to do this, but Catra is already watching her with that same dark teasing as before. It's so soft that it seems subconscious, but there's a lingering predatory edge to it that sends Adora's stomach swooping.

Mara reaches the door, and the pack starts filing in. Adora follows them with burning excitement.

Chapter End Notes

Bite down month commences! New chapter next week and every week this month! Give me your best predictions for how this celebration is going to go hehehe <3

(Also I am already behind on replying to comments and will definitely fall even more behind with the quick updates this month, but please know I read every single one and they make

my heart very soft and warm, thank you guys so so so so much!)

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
Tumblr link (some stuff is here)

Fic playlist: playlist is here!

Thanks for reading <3

# bad idea!

Chapter Summary

Things escalate. (Again.)

CW: this chapter contains sexual content. Please note that the fic rating has increased to Explicit to reflect where the story is headed. Enjoy.

Chapter Notes

Title is from bad idea! by girl in red.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The doorman to the Whispering Woods waves at Mara as soon as they're close enough to be recognized, and he lets them in without any trouble, nodding to each of them and only lingering on Catra momentarily out of friendly curiosity.

Adora hangs back a step as they enter, taking up the rear of the group and making sure Catra is a part of it instead of an afterthought. Mara directs them straight to the bar, ordering a round for everyone and chatting happily with the bartender. There isn't enough space along the bar for everyone, so they simply stand as close to it as possible, moving and side-stepping as needed to let other patrons pass by.

A dozen massive werewolves and one average-sized magicat make quite the roadblock, so Adora's stepping out of the way for the fifth time when someone knocks into her particularly hard, and she collides with Catra.

Her hands dart out to grab her before she can even think about it, wrapping around her back to steady her and pull her close to protect her from falling into anybody else.

Catra, full of supernatural reflexes, balance, speed, and *not* near in danger of falling over, simply smirks up at her and giggles.

Adora blushes as she's filled to the brim with the incredibly annoying and impossible urge to kiss her.

"Sorry ," she mumbles instead, pulling her arms back as slowly as she can get away with.

She's expecting Catra to step back to where she'd been standing before, as polite of a distance as they can manage to keep in this cramped space, but she surprises her. As Adora pulls her hands back, Catra follows them, stepping into Adora's space and shaking her head. "Don't worry about it," she shrugs.

Another patron comes slipping through the space in front of them, and as they both lean back to make more room, Adora feels something brush against her leg. She looks down to find Catra's tail twisting in the space between them, gently touching her leg and then flicking away. As the person scoots by and they both move back, her tail circles around Adora's calf and settles there.

It doesn't move again until Mara's passed all their drinks down and they step away to find a table to sit at.

Adora walks a little *too* close behind Catra as they go (to ensure no one knocks into her, obviously). Her tail tickles Adora's ankles with each step, and she feels a little bit like she's already drunk, giddy disbelief filling up her head like it's stuffed with cotton candy. She doesn't know what this new affection means, but she's determined not to fuck it up before she finds out.

Mara finds them a big corner booth they can squeeze into, and Adora (with Catra) gets pushed to the front of the crowd to slide into

the middle of the booth. The rest of the wolves pack in, Mara on Adora's other side and Juliet on Catra's, and by the end, they're all squished together like sardines. Catra's arm and leg are pressed tightly into Adora, and her tail is draped across both of their laps.

Mara raises her beer in a ridiculous toast to Adora as soon as everyone is settled, and Adora prays that Catra interprets her racing pulse as embarrassment from the praise and not a result of their intimate proximity.

Casual conversation breaks out afterward, and Adora's relieved that no one decides to interrogate Catra or say anything unbearably awkward to her. For all their intentional embarrassment before, they're on their best behavior now, including Catra in the conversations but not expecting her to be too active of a participant.

Adora vaguely wonders if Mara threatened them all ahead of time to not be weird.

She still wishes they could be alone, but she knows how these nights go, and they'll likely get some time to themselves soon.

She was expecting Catra to hate this part, if not this whole ordeal, but every time she checks in on her, she looks surprisingly peaceful.

It's actually a little bit worrying.

"Why are you looking at me like that, weirdo?" Catra peers up at her, narrowing her eyes and scrunching her nose a little bit. Adora's close enough to count the freckles dotting her face under the colored lights.

She wants to touch them.

She doesn't.

"I kind of thought you'd hate this," Adora confesses quietly, dropping their conversation below the other ones going on at the table.

Catra's nose scrunches more. "You invited me out to something you thought I'd hate?"

Adora gets a distinct feeling that anything she says will be the wrong answer, so she hesitates.

Catra cracks a grin at her silence and lets her off the hook. "Why did you think I'd hate this?" she asks instead.

"I just." Adora shrugs and looks around. "I didn't really think you cared for being around this many people. You don't really seem to like them."

One of Catra's fangs glistens in the lights as she laughs. "I don't," she nods, "but everyone here is alive. It feels nice."

"Oh," Adora says intelligently. "Good," she says, because she's not sure what else to say, and then, "I'm glad you came."

Catra's smile softens, and she opens her mouth to answer right as Huntara's voice booms over the music.

"Alright, everybody, it's DANCING TIME!"

Half of the wolves whoop loudly, and they all start piling out of the booth, jostling each other and laughing as they head towards the mass of moving bodies. Mara notices Adora staying put and offers her another knowing smile before doing her best to herd the rest of the pack out to the dance floor.

"Not a dancer?" Catra asks, shifting slightly to face Adora better, but not enough to pull away from her.

Adora hesitates and then answers honestly. "I just didn't think you'd want to."

Catra raises an eyebrow. "You're being very presumptuous tonight."

“Do you want to?” Adora presses, raising her own eyebrow. “Be surrounded by sweaty, annoying humans that are brushing all up against you?”

Catra shrugs nonchalantly, the slightest hint of a smirk teasing on her lips. “It might not be the worst thing in the world.”

Her tail slips down Adora’s leg a little bit, and Adora’s met with a vivid image: her and Catra moving together on the dance floor, pressed even closer than they are now, bodies filled with excuses to touch and hold each other, faces forced close together enough to share the same air.

Adora swallows. “Yeah, maybe not.”

Catra sets an arm on the table, turning her hand palm up and looking at Adora with a question in her eyes.

Adora does not need to receive this offer twice.

She grabs Catra’s hand and pulls her from the booth perhaps a bit too eagerly, but Catra’s fingers wrap tightly into hers, and she follows her with a laugh. Adora weaves carefully through the throngs of people, shouldering them liberally to make room for Catra behind her, and she searches for a spot for them on the dance floor.

She can see the pack dancing wildly in one corner, with far more emphasis on fun than finesse in their movements, and a few people around them are laughing and dancing with them. She purposefully heads away from them, finding a space in a crowd of humans that couldn’t care less who they are or what they might do.

Adora pulls Catra into the space with her and spins around, grinning down at her. Catra takes up her other hand so she’s holding them both and starts to move, pulling her hands back and forth and bopping to the music. Adora follows her lead easily, the giddy disbelief returning and filling her entire body.

She’s dancing with Catra. She’s dancing. With Catra. She’s dancing with Catra!

The music changes and the crowd around them starts moving a little faster, and they speed up to match them. Catra is grinning up at her with delight she’s never seen before, her eyes vibrant and her fangs gleaming. Adora knows her own grin must be so wide it looks unhinged by now, but there’s no dampening it. She feels like she’s living in a dream.

The rest of the crowd disappears for the next few songs, fading into static in the background as Adora’s focus converges on Catra. She moves like a flame, following her own rhythm and warming Adora from the inside out. The lights flicker over her body and illuminate her in a spectrum of colors, and she looks gorgeous in every single one. Every so often, she’ll laugh, and even with the music booming, Adora can pick it out above everything else. She feels warm and happy and thinks she could survive in this moment forever.

At least until someone trips into Catra and sends them colliding together, and Adora tastes something even better.

Catra presses into her to get away from the stranger, her tail winding around Adora’s thigh to stay safe, and Adora’s arms wrap tightly around her in a protective hold. The person is gone within seconds, but when Adora loosens her grip to let her go, Catra doesn’t move away.

Her hands reach up and wrap around Adora’s biceps, stroking her shirt sleeves as their gazes meet. There’s something heavy in Catra’s eyes that Adora can’t decipher, and as she tries to, Catra’s hands slip down the length of her arms until they’ve found her hands. Instead of pushing them away, she pulls them back into her, guiding them onto her hips and nodding softly at Adora. Her fingers flex involuntarily, testing to see if Catra is actually real underneath her touch, if this is actually allowed, and when the test proves true, Adora’s mouth runs dry.

Before she can say something and mess it up, Catra turns around and starts to move, her hands resting over Adora's to keep them on her and her hips rolling backward until they brush against hers.

Adora is pretty sure she's having an out-of-body experience.

What the *fuck* is happening?

Catra leans back into her, pressing the entire length of her body against Adora's front as she rocks her hips from side to side and pulls Adora along with her. Adora is following helplessly, her movements clumsy and confused, desperately trying not to ruin this before she can process it.

Catra is dancing with her. Catra is *grinding*. With *her*. Catra is dancing *with her*.

Finally, her brain catches up with her body. Her hands tighten over Catra's hips instinctively and Catra's head falls back in response, resting against Adora's collarbone. Adora makes the mistake of looking down at her and gets an absolute eyeful from her open shirt, the angle revealing perfect handfuls of soft cleavage and the sharp planes of her stomach, more of her body than Adora's ever been able to see before. She fights the overwhelming urge to do something with this new information and thinks that this might be the sweetest torture to ever exist.

Her body is suddenly burning with unrealized arousal, and her hips are again falling out of rhythm with Catra's. Every out-of-sync brush of Catra's ass against her sends another shockwave through her, and it gets even harder to catch up. She wraps a strong arm around Catra's hips, trying to hold their bodies together, but Catra responds by reaching up and back to wrap a hand around the back of Adora's neck, and when her nails scratch over her skin, she's a fucking goner.

Adora's head falls forward, resting against Catra's while her fingers dig into her hips. She gives up trying to follow her, feeling every

touch between their bodies like a reverberation through her bones, and it's all she can do just to breathe and try to keep it together .

Fuck, she wishes they were alone.

She wishes she could kiss her.

She wishes she could touch her.

She wishes she could be sure she isn't reading this horribly wrong.

Catra shifts, pulling back just enough to turn around and face Adora, and Adora squeezes her eyes shut. If she gets another glance down her shirt, she will undoubtedly do something she regrets. Catra presses into her and continues to dance, and the way their hips slot together is somehow even more erotic when they're facing each other.

"You okay?" Catra asks, and she sounds strangely breathless herself.

"I'm fine," Adora replies honestly , not opening her eyes.

"You're not very good at keeping rhythm," Catra teases, her voice playful and her breath hot on Adora's neck. Adora doesn't have to look to know she's smirking.

"I do better with instructions," she says without thinking, taking a deep breath to calm herself and instead discovering that her own arousal is not the only one she can smell.

"You want me to tell you what to do?"

Adora's eyes snap open, heat shooting down her spine and straight into her core. Her vision focuses on Catra's face, just below hers. Her eyes are dark and tempting, and there isn't a hint of a joke within them. Her lips are straight, parted, and she can feel their chests brushing against each other with every heaving breath. Catra's heart is pounding just as quickly as hers is.

She means it.

Adora licks her lips and watches Catra track the movement with a predatory look in her eye. "I think we should"—

"Go home?"

"Yes."

Adora grabs Catra's hand and reluctantly steps away from her, using the space to take a composing breath before starting to weave through the crowd. She gets close enough to the pack to catch Starla's attention and motion that they're leaving, and Starla offers her a wicked grin and makes a shooing motion towards the door.

Escaping before anyone else can notice them and get a smart remark in, Adora pulls Catra closer to her to guide her safely through the crowd and out the front door. Catra, for her part, sticks close to Adora and entertains her eager and borderline desperate speed with only a few affectionate giggles and no complaints.

When they finally break out into the cool night air, Catra takes over, directing them quickly down the shortest path to her apartment and settling her hands over Adora's arm to be sure she doesn't lose her.

*

It takes them far too long to make it to Catra's apartment on the opposite side of town.

There is too much time spent walking, leaving the cool night air too much time to surround them and calm down their burning bodies. The night is too quiet, at first inviting for their heavy thoughts but eventually bearing down on the silence between them like a weight instead. Adora continues to follow her eagerly the entire way, but

Catra can hear and smell her anticipation slowly fading instead of building. Catra's own happy bliss from being surrounded by so much human energy and life dulls with each step, and by the time they finally reach her apartment door, Catra is filled with doubt.

They were clearly seconds away from *something* on that dance floor, something that neither of them wanted to happen with an audience. But it wasn't like they'd actually said what it was or what they wanted to happen. How far they wanted it to go. What the hell was Catra supposed to do now? Let Adora inside and then ask if she wants to fuck on the island or in her bed? What position does she want to do it in? If she just wants to kiss her chastely for the first time *ever* and then turn right around and head home? She doesn't think any of these conversations will go over well, no matter how turned on Adora smelled at the bar.

She lets them in and flicks the light on, kicking off her bar boots while Adora shuts the door behind them. She thinks about offering her a drink, but all she has is water, and Adora already knows she's welcome to get it for herself. This is definitely no time for snacks, but Catra simply doesn't know what to do with herself. She's staring at the kitchen helplessly when Adora speaks up for the first time since they left Whispering Woods.

"Do you want to bite me?"

Catra whirls around, finding Adora lingering by the couch and twisting her hands together. She can smell a hint of anxiety in the air, drifting above the lingering arousal in the room. Adora swallows nervously, her beautiful neck twitching, but her eyes are full of the same pleading that Catra saw early that morning. Begging her to read through her words and to understand what she can't get herself to say, and this time she does.

*"Yes."*

Adora immediately sits down in the center of the couch, obediently waiting for her. The air changes the second Catra steps forward,

charging with electricity and tension. Adora is watching her with a heat she's only seen slip through a handful of times, and it makes her hair stand on end. The pull between them they'd had back in the bar returns more intensely with each step, and by the time Catra reaches the couch, Adora is already reaching out for her.

Her hands hover around her waist as Catra climbs into her lap, but Catra isn't having any of that. She grabs Adora's hands and puts them firmly on her body, granting her permission to touch. She watches as Adora's nostrils flare and her jaw tenses as they make contact. She doesn't look away even once, eyes locked onto Catra's while her large arms wrap around her waist and pull her in as close as she can. The heat radiating from them adds to Catra's growing flames.

Catra brushes Adora's ponytail over her shoulder and slips her fingers inside her shirt collar to push it aside. It moves easily with how open it already is, and Catra doesn't even attempt to hide her appreciative look at how the fabric shifts and catches against Adora's breasts.

Adora's breath quickens as she watches Catra watch her, and for a moment, Catra wants to devour her whole.

She offers her a wicked grin and then positions herself over the soft spot between Adora's neck and shoulder, pausing to breathe in and fill her head with how ready they are once again. Adora nods, answering the unasked question, and Catra meets her skin.

Adora's head falls back as soon as her tongue makes contact, licking a short and thick path over her intended spot. As soon as she finishes, she goes over it again, savoring the warm, salty taste of her skin and the way Adora clenches her jaw shut to try and stay silent. Catra wraps a hand around the back of her neck, holding her close and still, and she can feel Adora's slamming heartbeat against her thumb. It matches her own, screaming in her chest and threatening to break free.

Her teeth scrape against Adora's skin in a tease, slow and steady, and a broken noise escapes Adora's mouth. Catra is on fire.

Something takes hold of her, some monster rising from the heat in her core and the hammering in her chest, and she closes her lips onto Adora's skin in an open-mouthed kiss instead of a bite. She scrapes her teeth over the spot again and then pulls back. She leaves one more kiss over the place where she would have bitten her and moves up her neck instead, leaving another kiss and then another, and then licking her way up the column of her throat. A melody of a moan escapes from it, meant just for her , and her fingers tighten instinctively. She locks onto a soft spot just below Adora' s jaw and sucks.

Adora whimpers around a broken moan, and Catra feels the sound in her bones. It's a call she cannot deny. She releases her skin with a pop and gently licks the area before pulling back enough to find Adora's eyes.

Her pupils are blown out, seized with a delirious hunger that Catra' s never seen before, and as soon as she is within reach, Adora surges forward.

She catches her lips clumsily, desperately, and it is happening.

She is kissing her.

She pushes into her urgently, no finesse in the way their teeth knock and lips stick. She tastes like she smells: smoky and sweet and salty and laden with heat. Electricity crackles through Catra's veins, her entire body buzzing with it as Adora attempts to swallow her whole, and she's never felt so alive before in her fucking life.

Catra's hands wrap around the back of Adora's head to steady her and redirect their motion to deepen the kiss, but Adora groans and the sound reverberates into Catra's mouth, and all hope of graceful kissing is lost. She pushes back like she's trying to crush their two bodies into one, and Adora only encourages it.

Her hands roam up Catra's back and then down again, and the warm, firm motion presses their heaving chests together, and any semblance of sanity that Catra had left is now completely gone. She kisses Adora wildly, wrapping her arms around her neck and rising up to feel the weight of her breasts drag against her own.

One of them growls and the other returns it, mouths locked together and refusing to part for anything. Adora slides her tongue against Catra's and bites and suckles on her lips, and it is so much clumsier and more endearing and downright erotic than anything Catra's imagination has ever been able to come up with. It's every feeling that drinking her blood is, every nerve in her body burning up and begging for more as something deep inside of her feeds, and she's savoring every last drop that Adora will give her.

Adora wraps her arms around Catra tightly enough that her fingers brush the side of her breast, and the tease sends Catra slamming back down onto Adora's lap and wrenching her arms off of her just to shove her hands back onto her chest. Adora groans loudly into her mouth and complies immediately, warm palms engulfing Catra's tits and fondling them without reservation. Her touch feels so much better than Catra's own ever has, unpredictable and desperate and always so tender. Her thumb brushes a nipple, and Catra's fingers dig into her hair, searching for something to cling to as her core pulls.

She tries to trace a path down Adora's chest, but Adora won't move her stupid arms, refusing to abandon Catra's breasts for even a second to receive equal treatment. Catra tries pulling on her shirt instead, but Adora tugs gently on her nipple and bottom lip at the same time, and Catra loses her ability to do anything but gasp and buck into her lap, desperately seeking friction between her legs.

Adora's hands finally find something worth leaving her chest for, shooting down to her hips and dragging her off to the side. One thick thigh moves between hers and flexes against her core, and Adora's hands guide her as she grinds down against it once, twice, three times, a grateful moan ripping from her lips. The widespread pressure is just what she needed. Adora returns her moan with a

growl as her fingers dig into Catra hard enough to bruise, and Catra can smell how vividly she is enjoying this too.

Knowing how much Adora is affected nearly sends her right over the edge, a vibrant spark building inside her body and threatening to fire off her release. Catra knows that Adora wanted to kiss her, intended to kiss her, but this can no longer be considered kissing. Catra is dangerously close to pushing this into something far more than what was implied by Adora's offer, and she finally breaks their lips apart to address it.

"Adora"

Adora openly moans, attaching herself to Catra's neck and pulling her down on her thigh even harder.

"Adora," Catra tries again, but even she has to admit that her voice is too breathless and full of passion to be indicative of what she wants. Adora makes a noise of agreement and nips Catra's neck, rocking her thigh into her, and Catra is throbbing.

She grabs a fistful of Adora's hair and tugs, but Adora only groans loudly and bites her harder. Fuck.

"Stop," she finally manages to get out, and Adora's ministrations freeze.

After a moment of hesitation, she lets go of Catra's neck and pulls back, fingers loosening on her hips and concern invading her hungry expression.

"I just," Catra starts, trying to suck in air to compose herself and instead only breathing in how fucking wet they both are. "I'm"… *Close* dies on her lips as she realizes Adora likely knows, can undoubtedly smell it as well, and she reframes her statement. "I just want to make sure this is what you want."

Adora is breathless, too, breathing hard and huffing hot breath onto Catra's lips. Her concern shifts to confusion. "Isn't this what *you* want?" she asks.

Catra's eyebrows furrow, searching Adora's face for understanding. Her confusion only grows with every beat of silence that passes between them, and a horrible thought creeps into the back of Catra's mind.

"That's not what I asked," she says carefully.

Adora returns her searching look, lips pulling down at the corners. "Do you not want this?" she asks, pulling her hands away from Catra's hips.

Cold rushes into the spaces where they were, matching the growing chill inside Catra's chest.

"What do *you* want, Adora?"

Adora stares at her, confusion fading into an expression Catra can only describe as helpless. Her mouth moves silently, faltering as she searches for words, and her eyes turn big and round.

Catra waits.

And waits.

And she *waits* for Adora to come up with an answer, but she doesn't.

*What do you want?* Catra repeats, her voice stronger and more filled with fear. Her adrenaline is pumping with an entirely different feeling now, filling her body with an icy dread that spreads and spreads as the silence stretches on.

One three-letter word is all Catra needs for Adora to produce.

But it never comes.

"I don't." Adora finally manages, shaking her head. She searches Catra's face like she might answer this for her, but she doesn't. She can't.

She does not know what Adora wants, but it is suddenly clear that it is not her.

She is so fucking stupid.

She climbs off of her and steps away, barely able to keep looking at her. "Get out."

"What?" Adora says, leaning forward. Her hands are still limp on the couch on either side of her, palms face up and empty.

"Get out," Catra repeats, shooting a hand out to point at the door .

"Catra –" Adora starts, confusion and fear competing for control of her face, and Catra can't take it anymore.

*"Leave!"* she roars wildly.

Something in Adora's expression breaks. She gets off the couch and trips her way to the door, eyes never leaving Catra's. They're confused, borderline distraught, and she looks like shattered glass.

She looks how Catra feels.

She opens the door, and without another word, she leaves.

As soon as Catra hears her reach the bottom of the stairs, she breaks into a million pieces.

---

Two hours after Adora leaves her apartment, she gets a text.

*sorry .*

Catra stares at it hollowly for two long minutes before deciding to reply.

*fine*

Immediately, the speech bubble pops up to indicate that Adora is typing. After a couple of seconds, it disappears. Then it comes back, lingers for fifteen seconds, and then it disappears again.

It comes back one more time.

It disappears one more time.

Catra watches it sporadically come and go for a full five minutes before she just shuts her phone off and throws it under her bed.

When she turns it back on three hours later, there's still no answer.

Chapter End Notes

I've been planning this arc out and looking forward to this climax since I came up with the story, and I'm SO excited to have finally reached it. Can anyone guess what the next scene will be!? Next chapter next week <3

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
Tumblr link (some stuff is here)

Fic playlist: playlist is here!

Thanks for reading <3

# All I Wanted

Chapter Summary

Adora comes to a realization.

CW: discussion of the Necrosis and related fatalities

Chapter Notes

Title is from All I Wanted by Paramore.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora has been staring at her phone for hours.

*Do you still love her?* taunts her from her screen, two tiny words that ask so much more of her than what she can answer.

She doesn't *know* what she's sorry for. For fucking up, because she clearly did, but she doesn't know how. She doesn't know what she did wrong.

Every time she closes her eyes, Catra's face haunts her, crumpled in anger and sadness and cutting disappointment. She keeps replaying it all in her head, the kisses, the touches, the rising of their flames into a wildfire until Catra suddenly cut it all off with a *stop*. She runs through everything she did, everything she *said* and nothing adds up.

So she keeps her eyes open and stares at her phone, praying that she will figure it out if she just thinks about it hard enough.

*Hey* Mara's strong, gentle voice comes from the trail, and Adora looks up to find her standing several paces away in running clothes

and looking at her with an incredible level of concern.

Adora locks her phone and drops her eyes, straightening up against the fallen log she's perched on. She fled to the forest after walking around town for an hour, hoping the familiar shadows and smells would offer some sort of support to her as she tried to figure out what the hell had happened. Eventually, she sat down and decided to try and make amends with Catra over text, but her quick reply left Adora stupefied. She knew she wanted a specific apology, wanted to know that Adora understood, but the problem was that she *didn't*.

She's been sitting on that log trying to figure it out since.

"What are you doing out here?" Mara asks, walking over and visibly taking in her outfit, the exact same one she was in last night.

"I—" she tries to start, but her voice breaks immediately. Tears spring to her eyes, but she squeezes them shut and shakes her head. Her knuckles grip her phone so hard that they turn white.

"Hey, hey," Mara soothes, sitting down beside her and immediately wrapping an arm around her shoulders. She pulls her into her chest and rubs over her arm, shushing her. "What happened?"

The words bring forward a choking sob, and Adora buries her face in Mara's neck as the tears begin to fall. She tries to speak, but all that comes out is another sob. Trying to put it into words makes her feel like her heart is ripping apart all over again. It hurts worse than any change ever has.

Mara engulfs her in a tight hug, tucking her into her body and gently rocking her like she used to when she was younger and smaller. "Take your time," she reminds her. "Don't forget to breathe."

Adora nods, taking in a deep and rattling breath. It helps. She relaxes into Mara's body, trusting that she's got her, and tries to find her words.

"I fucked up," she finally manages.

Mara makes a noise of sympathy and tightens her hold.

"I..." Adora tries to find a place to start, but she can't. "I fucked up, and I don't even know how, so I can't make it right."

Mara nods into her, rocking them a few more times and then carefully pulling back. "Tell me what happened; we'll figure it out together."

Adora nods, wiping at the tears that continue to stream down her face, and trying again. "I thought we were doing something that she wanted. I thought she was enjoying it. But then she told me to stop, and she asked me what *I* wanted? In the middle of it? And so I said that I thought she wanted this, but she just kept asking me what I wanted, and then she kicked me out. And I don't know what I did; I don't know how I hurt her. So I tried to apologize, but she asked what I was apologizing for, and I don't *know*, so I don't know how to answer her and..." Adora squeezes her eyes shut again, balling up her fists in frustration. "I just *don't know*."

"What did you say when she asked what you wanted?" Mara asks her quietly.

Adora shakes her head. "Nothing."

"Adora..." Mara's voice is full of emotion, and Adora opens her eyes to see her lips tight and eyes shining. "Why? What do you want?"

Adora shakes her head again, her throat closing as she looks at Mara. "It doesn't *matter*," she chokes out. "It's not *about* what I want; it's – I just, I could *do* this for her. I thought that's what she wanted; I thought she wanted me to do that. I don't understand."

Mara's face falls, her eyes shutting and her mouth turning down in a vicious frown. Adora has never seen Mara truly angry, and she worries that this is what it will finally look like.

"What?" Adora asks, fear shaking her voice. She's fucked up again, hasn't she? She's hurt Mara now, too. "What did I do? I'm sorry."

Mara looks up at her with dark eyes full of pity and shakes her head. Her jaw works, and her hands reach up to hold the sides of Adora's face, wiping at her tears and cradling her.

"You didn't do anything," she says, but her distraught voice says otherwise. "This one's on me. This is *my* fault."

Adora starts to protest, but Mara stops her with a tragic smile.

"I always tried my best with you," she starts, and the words sink into Adora's gut like a fist. "But I always feared it wouldn't be enough."

Wait, *what?*

"You deserved so much more than I could give you when I found you. More than the pack could give you. You deserved a real mother, a real childhood. Not this terrible responsibility hanging over your future. Not a leader to report to and study under. We needed to rebuild, but you just needed a family."

"You *are* my family," Adora interjects, confusion and heartbreak swirling inside her like a hurricane.

Mara's face is twisted as she tries to hold back tears, but a smile breaks through. "I know, Adora. I love you so much," she adds, thumbs smoothing over Adora's wet cheeks as her own tears begin to fall. "And I wish you could have had a normal life. I wish I could have given that to you."

Adora shakes her head, still not understanding, and Mara nods. She knows.

"This sense of duty that you carry, the weight that this title rests on your shoulders with it, changes you. It changed me. It's so easy to

lose yourself to;to forget yourself when your responsibility is so much bigger."

She releases Adora's face to wipe her own tears away, taking a deep breath and then taking up Adora's hands. She holds them tighter than she ever has, as if she can fix everything if she just squeezes hard enough.

"I was in love too, once. A long time ago."

Adora's dark eyebrows converge. Mara rarely ever speaks about herself or her life before she adopted Adora, and she never ever speaks about things that once were but aren't anymore.

"We were young,"she continues, "just a little younger than you now, and the first wave of the Necrosis had just swept through. We were changing amidst it, trying to find control among the chaos. I had already been chosen for the She-Ra line. She figured out the full moon transformations before I did, and she did her best to try and help me catch up. She taught me what to do and how to stay sane throughout it. When we finally got our voluntary transformations on the new moons,she got sick that same night. The second wave was upon us, and she was the first one to go."

A tear escapes and slides down Mara's cheek, but her voice remains strong and steady. Determined.

"I loved Light Hope so much, and I never got to tell her. There was always some duty to perform, some responsibility to uphold. There was so much that I thought was more important back then."Her eyes close with guilt. "I'm sure she knew how I felt;I was terrible at hiding it, but I never *did* sure. I never voiced it. My regret over that still keeps me up at night."

She opens her eyes to look down at their hands, pulls them into her lap, and squeezes them again. "Life is never a sure thing. It is precious and fleeting, even when you live as long as we do.

Sometimes the universe is very cruel. There is no time to be scared, especially of yourself or what you might want."

Mara looks up at her, and the heartbreak in her eyes brings tears to Adora's.

"You are *allowed* to want things, Adora. You're allowed to want whatever you want, and you're allowed to go after it. You're worth *so* much more than what you can give to other people. You deserve love, too, and you deserve what you want."

Mara's words sink through her skin and run through her veins. They tug at her thoughts, prod at her heart, and Adora feels like she is standing at the edge of a cliff.

Is it true? Does she deserve it? Does what *she* wants matter?

Is she really allowed to want that?

*Just because you want it doesn't mean you should have it.* Catra's voice echoes through her head. *But what if you do?*

Mara lets go of her hands and reaches for her chin, tipping her face up to look at her. "What do *you* want?" she asks, and the words are like a speeding train that shoves her right off the cliff.

There is only one answer in her mind, one beacon of desire and hope and light, and only one thing she is rushing to the ground to meet.

She jumps to her feet. "I have to go."

Mara's face splits into a grin, and she leaps up and engulfs her in a hug. "Yes, you do."

"Thank you," Adora says, squeezing Mara hard enough to crush her. "I love you."

"I love you too," Mara says, squeezing back just as hard before pulling away and nodding at her. "Go get her."

Adora runs.

*

Catra stares at her phone, her text still unanswered, and resists the urge to crack it in half. It's not like it would do any good—it won't make Adora want her—but it might make her feel better. The ghost of Adora's smell still lingers thick in the air, glued to the couch and her body. She'd changed her clothes to try and alleviate it, but it was stuck on her skin and in her fur, and with the taste of her still vibrant in her mouth, Catra knew there was nothing to do but accept her suffering.

She can't believe she let herself get so close to Adora when she knew it was a bad idea. When she knew how it could end. How stupid could she have been to misread Adora's confession so badly? To think she could want her. She'd had her on a fucking platter, whimpering and wanting right there on her lap, and she still couldn't answer the fucking question. She couldn't come up with a single response. And then she tried to apologize because she obviously upset Catra, but she couldn't even tell her what she was sorry for. She couldn't tell her if she's sorry for not being able to respond or for not wanting her, for kissing her, or just for getting to know her in the first place.

How could Catra be so fucking stupid?

Whatever it is that Adora does want, it's obviously not her or anything that she could offer.

Adora doesn't want her.

Not like she wants Adora.

Her stomach twists and her fist tightens enough that a crack splits across her phone screen. She releases it with a scream of frustration and kicks it underneath the couch and out of sight.

She jumps up to start pacing again when a noise outside catches her ear.

Someone is stomping up the steps, the rhythm irregular like they're skipping some, and the volume loud enough that they clearly don't care who they might be disturbing. Catra's fur bristles, thinking of whatever stupid drunk human must be returning home at this hour, but then the slapping steps land outside of her door, and someone starts rapidly knocking.

She hears the heartbeat just before they speak, and her own heart stops.

"Catra!" Adora's voice calls, strangled and urgent. "Catra, please, please let me in!"

Her heart revives itself just long enough to lurch into her stomach, and her gut churns with embarrassment and dread. Of course she couldn't just resolve this over text. Of course she would show up and make this as painful as possible for Catra. She wishes she could go hide under her blankets and pretend she isn't home, but she knows there's no use in hiding from Adora.

"Catra!" she calls again, muffled with how close she's gotten to the door. "Please!"

Catra walks over on shaking legs, her arms and tail wrapping around to hold herself. "Go away," she says at a normal volume, more than sure Adora can hear her. She cannot bear to do this now.

Adora sighs loudly in relief, and Catra hears a gentle thud that must be her resting her forehead against the door as the knocking ceases.

*Catra*, she says, and the tenderness in the way her voice caresses her name sends Catra's heart swooping with foolish hope. "Please let me in. I know what I did; please let me apologize."

Fear fills Catra's body like bits of shattered glass inside of her veins, ready to shoot out and rip her to pieces at any moment. She is terrified to hear the truth of what Adora wants to apologize for. She tightens her hold on herself, sure that she will fall apart if she lets go. "You could have just texted me back," she manages to mutter, determined to not let her in and make the same mistake twice.

"No," Adora says vehemently. "No, I couldn't have. I have to tell you this here, please."

Catra can hear it in her head, Adora apologizing for not wanting her, not liking her, explaining what she really meant when she said she was in her pack. Explaining what she really wants and how it's not her. She can imagine how her sweet voice will carry those destructive words, and she knows she cannot handle hearing them out loud. Especially not while looking at her face.

"I don't want to hear it, Adora—"

"It's you," Adora interrupts, her voice heavy and desperate. "I want you."

Catra's heart stutters. She stares at the door, waiting for something more that will tell her that she's misheard, that Adora did not just say the exact words that she needed to hear. She waits for the rug to be pulled out from under her feet, for the punchline at the end of the joke to come. She waits for the glass to burst from her veins and destroy her.

She waits, and she waits, and she *waits*, but it doesn't.

Heart fluttering dangerously, she considers that maybe she did hear her correctly. Maybe Adora did truly just say that and mean it.

“Please let me in,” Adora begs, and Catra’s foolish hope breaks her.

She steps forward and opens the door, and there’s Adora, still clad in the same clothes as last night. They’re slightly disheveled now, wrinkles crawling over the creases and folds of her starched shirt, but she looks just as beautiful as she did when Catra kicked her out. Her blue eyes are filled to the brim with the same careful relief that Catra feels fluttering around her chest, and baby hairs stick up around her head like a golden halo. Her scent floods the apartment immediately, reinvigorating the hollow, haunting smell her departure had left behind, and it makes Catra’s heart ache.

She can hear Adora’s heart beating loud and steady, thumping its familiar rhythm, and it reassures her in a way that nothing else could. For a moment, they just stand there, just a stride apart on either side of the doorway, and stare at each other. Adora’s affectionate gaze gets softer the longer she looks at her, and the gentlest hint of a smile plays at her lips.

Catra’s heart has climbed into her throat.

“I know what I did wrong,” Adora says, her voice much gentler than before.

“Adora, you didn’t do—” Catra starts, but Adora cuts her off with an advancing step.

“No, I did. And I know what I did, and I know why, and I need you to understand.”

Adora has stepped forward into her orbit, her gaze turning intense and determined, and Catra cannot deny her gravity. She swallows and nods tentatively, moving out of the way and scraping her nails against her arm.

Adora shuts the door and takes a deep breath, looking down at herself and shaking out her hands. She blows her breath out and

nods to herself, and then looks up to meet Catra's eyes. Remorse paints itself across her face.

"I didn't tell you what I wanted because I didn't think that it mattered. I didn't understand why you were asking. I... didn't understand that I was *allowed* to want something like this."

Catra cannot breathe. She feels like Adora is holding a knife to her heart, and Catra is frozen with her hands on Adora's wrists, caught between pushing the hilt away or helping her shove the blade in deeper. "Something like what?"

"Like *you*," Adora gestures towards her, stepping closer. "Like a life with you. I didn't think I deserved to ask for that, to... want more than what you might want to give. Frankly, I still don't, but I understand now that *this* is what you wanted to hear. Why you wanted to know."

Catra can't manage any words, just staring at Adora and trying desperately to believe that this is really happening.

"I want *you*," Adora repeats, closing the gap between them. Her breath is hot on Catra's face, and she can hear Adora's heart speeding up to slam against her chest like it's trying to burst right through her ribs to reach her. Catra's heart responds to it, beating in perfect rhythm. "I want a life with you, a future with you. I want to *be* with you in any and every way that you want me to be. I'll take anything. I just want to be with you, all the time. I just want *you*."

Catra feels like her breath is trapped in her lungs, stuck beneath her frantic heart. It takes everything she has just to get three words out:

"Say it again."

"What?" Adora asks softly, dark eyebrows converging.

"Say it again," Catra pleads, despising how desperate her voice sounds.

"I want you," Adora answers carefully, as if she's not sure if that's what Catra wants to hear. What she *needs* to hear.

Catra nods. "Say it again."

"I want you," Adora repeats, her voice stronger and her face lowering towards her.

"Again," Catra whispers, her throat aching and eyes prickling with tears.

"I want *you*," she whispers back, her voice soft and dangerous. Her face stops inches above Catra's, eyes skipping between hers and willing her to believe her. Searching to see if she does.

She is so close to believing, but she is terrified.

Her face turns up to meet Adora on its own, reaching for her in spite of the turmoil churning inside of her. "Why the change of heart?" she asks, her voice no louder than a ghost in the wind.

Adora draws even closer, or maybe Catra does, but now they are sharing the same air. "Not a change of heart," Adora shakes her head slowly, refusing to take her eyes off Catra. "Never a change of heart. I feel the same way about you now that I felt last night, that I've felt since…*for*," Adora lets out a humorless chuckle, "for a really long time now. I just didn't think I was allowed to feel that way—that there was any reason that you might feel the same. What have I ever done to deserve you?"

For a long moment, Catra can't say anything, her mind and body reeling with this confession. Adora's words rattle inside of her head, echoing and getting louder and louder each time. They grip the doubt and the dread and the fear inside of her and rip it to shreds until there is nothing left but the truth, solid and steady as it holds her.

She feels two hot tears roll down her cheeks, hope blossoming around her heart. "You're such a fucking idiot."

Adora laughs loudly, and it is the sweetest sound that she's ever heard. It's a sound she'd like to hear for the rest of her life, and one she realizes she might actually get to.

"Yeah," Adora nods, her grin turning manic as tears threaten in her eyes too. "Yeah, I am."

Her admission only sends more tears falling from Catra's eyes, and Adora's face swims in her vision as she tries to blink them away. She reaches up to wipe at them, but Adora's hand catches hers softly and stops it.

"Can I?" she asks, and Catra is nodding before she's even finished the question. Whatever Adora wants, she can have. She is hers.

Gentle fingers find her jaw, curving around it and then tracing up to her cheeks to wipe her tears. When they're gone, they trace their way back down and then cup the sides of her face, holding her close.

"You don't have to do anything to deserve me," Catra whispers. "You just have to use your fucking words and tell me that you want me."

Adora nods, eyes shining. "I do. I want you. I want everything about you. I want everything we've done together and so much more."

Catra's heart swells to twice its size, and she stretches up, catching Adora's lips in a tender kiss. Adora bends to meet her halfway, and a thousand unspoken words pass between them. Catra guides them, keeping it soft and pouring everything she feels inside of herself into it, and Adora accepts and returns all of it. Her long fingers trace the edges of Catra's face as they kiss, and when they finally break apart, Catra turns her head to press a kiss into one of Adora's palms.

"I want you, too. I like you so much," she risks confessing into her hand, her heart twisting shyly in her chest even with all of Adora's declarations.

She peeks up at Adora in time to see a dazzling smile spread across her face. "I like you too so much," she agrees eagerly.

Catra cannot stop a playful snort from escaping her, and Adora returns it happily. The two of them fall into a bout of giggles, staring at each other with an unbridled amount of hope and affection.

"Can you stay today?" Catra asks.

"I'll stay until you ask me to leave," Adora answers, far too seriously for the question.

Catra ignores her blushing cheeks and rolls her eyes, reframing the question. "How *big* can you stay?" she asks instead.

Adora lowers to her, resting their foreheads together and leaning in until their lips are brushing. "Forever, if you want me to."

Catra presses her lips to Adora's hard, unable to resist the untamed devotion in her words. She tilts and opens up to her, and she returns the kiss reverently.

Catra gives into her game and pulls back just enough to speak. "What about She-Ra? The pack?"

"The pack loves you," Adora insists, and the drag of her lips over Catra's drives her just as wild as the words do. "I'm sure they'd understand. They'd probably even be willing to move over here so that I don't ever have to leave this room if that's what you want. Or you could come with me and move in there. I could probably get Juliet to give me her room; it's time for me to move soon anyway. I'll definitely have plenty of room once I move into Mara's room. Or we could probably just get one of the bungalows now, so many of them are empty, and we'd have lots of privacy. It's completely up to you."

Catra's chest tightens with affection as Adora teases her with ridiculous possibilities of their future together. "And what do *you* want?"

Adora's arms wind around her waist possessively, reeling her in until Catra can feel her warmth surrounding her entire body. "I just want to be with you. I don't care where. I never want to let go of you again."

Catra chuckles, but the open affection is sending her pulse racing. "I think that might get kind of difficult eventually," she teases.

Adora shakes her head, lips sticking to Catra's and her nose squishing against her cheek. "I don't care. Nothing is going to keep me away from you, not as long as you want me here."

"Promise?" Catra asks, and her voice is fragile as glass.

*Fine* *Bite* Adora swears, sealing the oath with a kiss.

Chapter End Notes

IT'S TIME TO ENTER THE ROM COM ERA! WOO! It's been such a long road, I'm so glad we finally got here. Let me know your favorite part of this chapter below, and what you think will happen next! Your only hint is that we're ending bite down month with a bang... ;)

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
Tumblr link (some stuff is here)

Fic playlist: playlist is here!

Thanks for reading <3

# Anyone E se

Chapter Summary

Catra and Adora both finally get what they want.

CW: this entire chapter is explicit sexual content. The whole thing. All of it. Enjoy.

Chapter Notes

Title is from Anyone Else by PVRIS.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Promise?" Catra asks, and her voice is fragile as glass.

"Promise," Adora swears, sealing the oath with a kiss.

Adora's kiss smears along the edge of her mouth, and it isn't enough for the sacred devotion in her voice.

Catra grabs Adora's jaw and pulls her down roughly for a proper kiss. She stretches up, and Adora supports her, bending to her and pulling her close until their bodies are pressed together. The weight of Adora against her is suddenly too much and not enough, and she needs more. She licks into her mouth desperately.

A rough growl escapes from Adora's throat, and the air around them changes instantly. It's charged with electricity and heat, leaving their chests heaving as the fire builds between them. Catra's hands slip from Adora's jaw down her neck, dragging along her skin and reveling in the wild beat of her pulse. One hand abandons her neck to carve down her chest, following her bare skin lower and lower until

she hits the buttons of her shirt, the heavy curves of her breasts hugging either side of her hand.

Adora makes a noise into her mouth, and her own hands burn a path from Catra's waist up the length of her ribs, fingers digging into her like she is barely holding herself back. "Do you, uh," Adora starts, breaking the kiss and swallowing hard. "Would you"—

"Want to continue what we started last night?" Catra supplies heatedly, and Adora nods furiously.

"*Yes*. Yes, fuck, yes." Adora presses a searing kiss against her lips and bends down, strong arms wrapping underneath Catra's thighs and lifting her effortlessly. She wraps her legs around Adora's waist tightly and kisses her back, demanding her attention and leaving Adora to navigate the apartment blindly.

Adora makes no note of complaint, humming into her mouth and dragging her hands up the back of her thighs onto her ass. Her fingers sink in, kneading the muscle and tissue and edging dangerously close to Catra's core. She's so flushed with heat she feels like she's burning alive. One of Adora's fingers skitters over her apex on accident, and Catra moans uncontrollably, the sound ripping from her, and Adora trips.

She makes a noise of apology as she recovers, refusing to break their kiss just yet, and abandons Catra's ass to reach out behind her and find a surface, any surface, to stabilize them against.

Finally, she encounters the kitchen island, knocking her thighs into it and setting Catra atop it. She finally pulls back, sucking down air, and reaches a hand up to cradle Catra's curls and brush them out of her face.

"Where can I touch you?" she asks, and the gentle promise laced in her words leaves Catra stifling a whimper. Adora's fingers brush the soft spot behind her ear, and she leans into it, encouraging the touch. "I should have asked you last night, but I"—

“Anywhere you want,” Catra cuts in. “[illegible]”

Adora does not let her finish. She dives in, stealing the words from her mouth and the breath from her lungs. Her fingers caress the spot behind her ear until Catra melts into her, turning to putty in her hands. Adora kisses her urgently, eagerly, and carefully, keeping their lips locked and savoring every lick and bite she takes. Her hands begin to descend, trailing an aching path of flames down her shoulders, arms, and fingers, then dropping to her knees and dragging their way back up. Her thumbs carve into her thighs, running teasingly close to her center as they drag up and over her hips. The heat of her palms is blazing even through Catra’s clothing, and she is molten lava by the time Adora’s hands finally reach her chest and cup around her breasts. Her touch is slower than last night, less desperate, but no less heated.

She breaks their kiss, moving down to suckle on Catra’s neck as she rolls a hard nipple between her fingers. Catra does a pathetic job of holding back a moan.

“Where can I kiss you?” Adora whispers against her throat, and Catra does moan this time, her core twitching with a desperate fantasy.

“Anywhere you want,” Catra repeats. She would feel ashamed of how absolutely wrecked she already sounds if not for the renewed eagerness with which Adora begins to urgently trail kisses down her neck.

Catra feels like she might explode, trying to come to terms with the fact that not only does Adora want her like this, wants her in her hands and on her tongue and keening against her body, but she is [illegible] her like this. She is taking what’s hers. What has been hers. What Catra hopes will always be hers.

Adora reaches the top of her shirt and continues without interruption, pressing hot, open-mouthed kisses against the fabric. She presses one over her heart and then dips down to mouth over her breast.

Catra's hands fly up and into Adora's hair, ripping her hair tie out and digging her fingers into her golden waves. Her nails scratch against her scalp, and Adora moans, the sound vibrating her skin even through her shirt, and then she looks up.

Their eyes lock, and Adora's are so hungry and desperate and willingly obedient that Catra thinks she could come from that sight alone.

Her hands tug her hair harder of their own volition, unintentionally pulling her mouth from her chest. Adora takes the opportunity to drop her hands to the hem of Catra's shirt and slip underneath it, fingers spreading wide over her hips. "Can I take this off?" She sounds just as affected as Catra does.

Catra nods violently, but as Adora starts to straighten up and lift her shirt, she stops her. She takes a handful of Adora's shirt and pulls her in with it. "This too," she orders.

Adora nods resolutely and presses a kiss to her lips, abandoning Catra's shirt to take off her own. Catra doesn't know if she rips it off or if she can really undress that quickly, but by the time she breaks the kiss and looks down, Adora's shirt is crumpled on the counter beside her.

She barely has time to appreciate the skin revealed to her before Adora is pulling her shirt over her head, but once that's dropped to the counter too, Adora pauses.

Catra watches her abdomen muscles ripple and her breasts swell against the flimsy excuse for a bandeau still containing them as Adora sucks down heaving breaths. Catra doubts Adora will let her now, seeming dead set on showering Catra with her attention before she accepts anything for herself, but Catra resolves to lick every inch of Adora's skin before the day is over.

Adora is still hovering before her, hands set on the counter to either side of Catra's knees, and when Catra looks up to see why she's

stopped, Adora's eyes are burning into her bare chest.

"You okay?" Catra teases lightly, feeling herself flush with equal amounts of embarrassment and arrogance.

Adora surges forward to kiss her, and despite the firm pressure she meets her with, her lips are shockingly tender. "You are *so* beautiful," she whispers into her mouth before starting an agonizingly slow path of kisses down her throat.

Catra squirms, the praise and sudden reduction in speed and attention leaving the space between her thighs aching and wet. She's just about to tell Adora she needs to speed up when her mouth latches onto one of her tits, and all that spills forth is a moan instead.

Catra can do nothing but look down and watch as Adora scrapes her teeth and tongue along the underside of her breast. She looks up at her as she licks a thick path up and over one nipple, then closes her lips around it and sucks. The dark heat in her bright eyes tells Catra this is something she's thought about doing before, has wanted to do before, and is loving doing now, and that realization sends Catra's hips bucking helplessly into Adora's torso.

She pulls Catra closer to the edge of the counter and switches her attention to the other side, lavishing it equally and bringing her hand up to massage the first.

Catra's hips roll again, jerking against Adora's abs and seeking relief that is just out of reach, and she's powerless against the sounds spilling out of her throat. Adora's mouth is sending sparks through her body, and the growing heat is becoming dangerous.

"Ah—" she manages to get out, her tone a warning.

Adora meets her eyes once more, and it is almost too much to look at, too fulfilling of a sight to see. Her words fail her, unable to finish

the warning, but it must be clear on her face because Adora finally releases her skin and pulls back.

And then she moves lower, pressing a hot kiss to the top of her stomach and quirking an eyebrow up in a question.

Catra thinks she might pass out.

She squeezes her eyes shut as Adora shifts even lower and kisses her again, trying desperately to maintain control over herself. Every kiss sends another wave of wet heat rolling between her legs, and she is quickly losing her grip.

"Are you sure I can"—

"*Yes*," Catra groans.

Adora laughs into her skin, hot breath puffing, but she sounds just as weak as Catra. "You're not even going to let me finish my sentence?" she asks.

Catra bites her lip, resisting the urge to confess that if Adora finishes her sentence, *she* might finish as well. "The answer is *yes*," she says instead.

"I want to say it," Adora complains, nipping the spot below her belly button.

Her core is blazing, Adora adding more fuel to the fire with every movement, and Catra realizes she is wrecked no matter what. Whether Adora says it or doesn't, whether she makes it down between her legs or just keeps toying with her up here, she's a fucking goner. It's already too late for her. So why not give Adora what she wants?

"Fine," she gasps.

Adora presses a soft, tender kiss to the space just above the waistband of Catra's leggings and asks:

"Can I eat you out?"

Catra's jaw clamps shut over the moan that tries to escape her , her thighs locking around Adora's body and trying to desperately find her friction *some* . She feels Adora's fingers digging hard into her hips, and she'd be embarrassed about the way it just makes them roll again with even more ferocity, if not for the desperate *fu* she hears escape Adora's mouth.

*"Ye s,"* she barely manages to get out, but Adora does not need to be told twice.

She wraps her fingers into the top of her pants and pulls immediately, and Catra opens her eyes to help her lift her hips and get them off. Cool air rushes in as Adora follows them all the way down her legs until they can be discarded on the floor, and Catra is all too aware of how viciously wet she is by the time Adora returns. There is a second where fear skips through her mind: fear of being too much, being too obvious, being too open. Letting what she so desperately *wa* to be seen so vividly.

But then Adora wraps her warm arms underneath her thighs, presses a tender kiss to the soft inside of one, and grins up at her from between her legs, and the fear is replaced with broiling heat and tender affection.

"I have no idea what I'm doing," Adora confesses, her tone proud and confident despite her words, "so let me know what you like?"

Catra nods furiously, not trusting herself to speak as she learns what she'd hoped: that the two of them will be figuring this out together. Excitement, relief, and an undeniably possessive affection spark in her chest.

Adora presses another kiss to the inside of her legs and then another, switching sides and creeping closer to her apex, and Catra grows increasingly confident that Adora will not need to have even the slightest clue as to what she's doing. She's so worked up already

that she feels like even one small blow of breath could send her flying over the edge.

Adora does not blow on her. Instead, she stops just before it and takes it in, studying it like a broken cabinet or a flickering light that needs her assistance. Catra twitches under the attention, impatient, and Adora lifts one hand off the top of her thigh to reach for her. She winds through her curls and pulls her apart, and then licks a hot path right up her center.

Catra gasps, her claws digging into the counter and thighs clamping around Adora's head like earmuffs, locking her into place. The sensation is far too much and far not enough all at once, and she needs more.

Adora's gasp breaks into a laugh, open-mouthed against her, and Catra's head falls back with a loud whine.

Adora's free hand digs into the meat of her thigh to pull it away just enough to return her freedom of movement, and once she has it, she licks her again.

She twitches with the contact, but Adora keeps her thigh from crushing her, and when she finishes her second lick, she closes her mouth and swallows.

"You taste so fucking good," she says, her voice as reverent as the look in her eyes, and there is nothing Catra can do to stop the loud whimper that escapes her. She is barely hanging on.

Adora takes the noise as encouragement and dives back in, her eyes slipping between Catra's face and her dripping heat. Adora's tongue is just as unpracticed as it is when she kisses her, but what she lacks in finesse, she makes up for tenfold in confidence and quick learning. Her licks are all soft and steady, not abating in pressure as she tries a few different paths, watching Catra until she finds one she likes and then switching to vary her speeds until Catra nods once more. Her method is inexperienced but careful and

thoughtful, and Catra is overwhelmed by it. Every stroke leaves her burning higher and brighter, and she is already so close.

Once her licks have left her panting, Adora closes her lips around her and sucks. Catra cries out, pushed to the edge of her precipice. Her claws leave marks in the counter, and Adora makes a qestioning noise against her , asking if it was too much. Catra can do nothing but shake her head and growl, thighs tightening and hips searching for the feeling once more. Adora obeys and sucks again a little harder, and Catra is flying.

Heat rushes from her core to spread through her entire body, washing over her like a cresting wave, and she curls around Adora as it does. Cries release from her chest as she trembles, and Adora answers her, humming into her, and nothing else exists. It is her and Adora and the warmth running between them;it is all she wants.

She begins to come back to herself, and her body loosens, thighs relaxing and her hands falling behind her to keep herself sitting up on the counter.

Adora pulls back, lips popping off her wetly, but it’s too soon. She still wants so much more. She’s not done yet.

She reaches out before she can stop herself, fingers sinking into Adora’s hair and pulling her back into her. Her legs wrap tightly around her head again, heels digging into her back, and Catra forces her eyes open to try and convey what she wants with more than desperate movements.

It is unnecessary.

The second her hand and legs force Adora back to her core, a lengthy groan escapes her mouth. She returns to her work with a new ferocity, and her eyes are dark with a desire and a promise that sends Catra’s head spinning.

A few aftershocks roll through her body and send her hips twitching into Adora's face, her hand tugging her hair. Adora matches her moan for moan through them, her eyes pleading. As Catra finally comes back to her body, she starts to understand.

She carefully scrapes her nails over Adora's scalp, enough to warrant a moan but not enough to cause damage, and then wraps her fingers into her hair and pulls. "Is this what you want?" she asks, her voice low and raspy.

Adora moans loudly in affirmation, nodding against her and then grabbing her hips and urging them forward. Catra rolls into her, testing, and Adora follows her motion and moves against it.

Catra hisses, twitching with excitement as she understands what Adora wants. Adora raises an eyebrow at her, checking in, and Catra nods. *Yes*.

She readjusts her grip on Adora' s hair, grabbing her silky waves as tightly as possible without risking ripping them out when she comes, and rolls forward into her mouth. Adora moans again and meets her with a wide-spread tongue, and they are off.

Catra bucks against her tongue hard and fast, unable to be patient and deny either of them what they want so badly. Her hand tugs Adora's hair as she holds her close, and by the time Catra has found a consistent rhythm, Adora is whining and moaning louder than she is. Her fingers dig into Catra's thighs hard enough to bruise even her strong skin, and when Catra takes a deep breath, she understands why.

Adora is still mostly clothed, her bra clinging to her chest and her jeans buckled tightly around her hips. She has not received any friction, barely any touches to her entire body, but her scent fills the air as if she's the one being fucked over the edge right now. It is so thick and heavy that she must be close herself, must be absolutely drenched, and the knowledge of how far gone she really is just from

touching and tasting Catra nearly sends her over the edge the second time.

Catra slows her hips, unable to stop her thrusts completely but slowing enough to be able to speak, and she meets Adora's eyes as she looks up at her questioningly.

"Do you want to touch yourself?" Catra forces herself to ask before she can overthink it, and Adora's eyes cloud with hunger.

She nudges Catra's thigh and tries to pull back, and Catra lets her move away enough to speak.

"Tell me to," she asks, and her voice is quiet, an insecure shyness creeping over the thick desire her tongue moves with.

The words shoot heat up Catra's spine. She *does* want her to tell her what to do. She had been partially joking when she said it last night, using the perfect opening just to tease her and see what she would get from it, but it's not like it's something she doesn't want. And Adora on her knees, begging her to use her and clearly getting off on it, and now asking her to tell her what to do? That's an opportunity she's not turning down.

"Touch yourself," she orders.

Adora presses a searing kiss just left of her center and obeys, dropping a hand from Catra's thigh down to her own legs. Catra can't see what she's doing from this angle, but she knows she's listened when Adora's eyes squeeze shut and her jaw closes. Her bicep flexes as her arm works, and Catra watches Adora breathe heavily for a few more seconds before she opens her eyes and presses another kiss to Catra's skin.

"Inside your pants," Catra says, getting greedy, and Adora groans.

She drops her other hand out of sight, and Catra listens to her belt unbuckling and her denim shifting as she does what she's told. Catra

smells her as she hits the air, sharp and sweet and salty, and she whimpers in time with Adora.

One hand returns to Catra's hips as the other begins to work, and Catra doesn't have time to ask what Adora wants next before she's nipping Catra's inner thigh and then starting to lap at her center again. A wild moan rips from her throat as she takes control of Adora's head again and resumes fucking her face. Adora moans back, her shoulder matching Catra's pace, and it doesn't take long before they're both lost to it.

Catra speeds up to a punishing pace. With the sounds of Adora's moans breaking around her movements and her hand slipping around her wetness egging her on, Catra very rapidly climbs to another peak. She thrusts against Adora's tongue hard, chasing it, and the second Adora catches her in her mouth and sucks, she's gone.

She curls around her again, trembling harder than the first time, and this time Adora does not stop. She sucks and licks everywhere she can reach, her tongue and lips and nose and chin making a mess of her. Catra rides through wave after wave, bucking into her and squirming away and rolling her hips at an erratic pace, and Adora follows her the best she can. Adora's moans seem to grow as Catra starts to slow down and come back to herself, and when she sees Adora start to desperately lick her clean as she comes to a stop, she understands.

She lets her lick her as much as she can handle, still twitching and tender, and then digs her hand harder into Adora's hair and pulls her away. Adora meets her eyes, begging and hungry, and it's not even a question if she'll say it for her .

"Come," she whispers, and Adora falls over the edge with her .

An erratic cry rips from her throat before she turns and sinks her teeth into Catra, muffling her voice with the meat of her thigh. Her eyes squeeze shut, her shoulder muscles strain, and the wet noises

rising from her pants are absolutely filthy. She moans and gasps into Catra's skin, never releasing her bite as she works herself through it. The sight is so much more beautiful and desperate than Catra ever could have hoped it would be. Her hand works for a long time before it gradually slows, her groans breaking into whines and whimpers before finally dying out. She sucks down air, pulls her hand from her pants, and opens her eyes.

Catra watches as they blink slowly at her leg, coming to, and then suddenly they widen, and Adora unclenches her jaw and pulls back.

She stares at the mark she's left, two bright maroon crescents against Catra's dark skin, and her face fills with horror.

"*F*  I'm so sorry," she says, voice hoarse and eyes distraught as she turns to look up at Catra. "I'm *so* sorry, I didn't mean to"—

Catra lets go of her hair and grabs the back of her neck, dragging her up before she can finish her apology and pressing a demanding kiss to her lips. She tastes herself on them, and it shoots through her veins like lightning, waking everything back up and setting it on fire all over again. She urges Adora to open up to her, and when she does, she sets to licking her slick off of Adora's tongue and lips and then pulling back to lick over her cheeks and chin. Adora wraps her arms tightly around her hips and follows her mouth, trying to catch her lips with her own again, but Catra resists until she's licked her clean and can't taste herself anywhere anymore. Adora groans into her mouth when she finally grants her entry again, and she doesn't let her pull away until Catra wraps a hand loosely around her throat and pushes her back, dragging her bottom lip between her teeth as they separate. A wet whimper escapes Adora's mouth.

Catra lets her lip go and drops her forehead against Adora's, brushing her nose across her cheekbone. "Do *not* fucking apologize," she says, still out of breath.

Adora is breathing just as hard and pulls back just enough to meet her eyes. Her face is torn with hope and insecurity, and her voice

comes out fragile. "You liked that? It was okay?"

Catra cannot help but press another burning kiss against her lips, one hand wandering up through her hair to gently rub soothing circles into her scalp. "I *loved* that," she corrects, and when one side of Adora's mouth quirks up with a tentative smile, a grin bursts over her own. "Why the *fuck* didn't we do that sooner?"

Adora laughs, the tension in her shoulders releasing, and she shakes her head. "Cause I'm a fucking idiot," she says, and Catra is helpless against her once more.

She presses kiss after kiss to her lips, her cheeks, her nose, her temple, whispering over and over to her as she goes. "Yeah. You are. You are."

Adora straightens up to her full height, and Catra pulls back. "Bed?" she asks, searching Adora's face for how she feels.

Adora nods, pulling her jeans up to rest on her hips again so she can walk and scooping Catra up before she can protest. "More? Or cuddle time?" she asks, steering them towards the bedroom.

Catra's grin turns wicked. "*Both*," she affirms, "if you want. Then lots of cuddling. You have a promise about never letting go of me to make good on," she reminds her.

Adora nods, bumping their noses together and matching her grin. "Sounds perfect." She dives in for another kiss, and Catra grants it, pressing into her and savoring the heat rolling off of Adora's skin onto hers. Her hands trace down her neck and shoulders, and she scrapes her nails down her muscles. Adora makes a noise into her mouth and tugs her impossibly closer, crushing their chests together. Catra worms a hand between them just far enough to grab Adora's bandeau and yank it down, and then all of their skin is touching, and it is so much better, so much *better*, than she imagined. Adora must think so, too, because she groans at the contact and slams Catra into her bedroom door a little *too* hard to be intentional.

“*F*  , let me,” Catra starts, reaching blindly for the doorknob, but Adora recovers and steps back.

“I got it,” she insists, cradling Catra against her and then raising one leg up and kicking the door.

It flies open, shooting around its hinges and hitting the wall with a shattering *B*  . Both of them jump, pulling away from each other to twist and see the damage.

Catra laughs first. “Holy *sh*  , Adora.”

The door is hanging diagonally of  f of its hinges, ripped almost completely down and lodged into the wall beside it by its knob, which has broken through the sheetrock and is the only thing still keeping the door even slightly upright.

“*I*  Adora rushes to say, her voice filled with panic, and Catra laughs even harder. She looks back at Adora and takes in her wide eyes and pale cheeks, and puts a gentle hand on either side of her face.

“I expect you to,” she says, leaning in and pressing a sweet kiss against her lips. “But right now ,” she kisses her again with more heat, “I do *n*  fucking care.”

Adora returns the kiss, raising a doubtful eyebrow. “I just *s*  your door.”

Catra flicks her tongue over her lip and nods. “Don’t get any ideas about the rest of the apartment when I tell you this, but that was *h*  fucking sexy.”

Adora tries to kiss her, but she’s grinning too widely to manage it. “You think I’m sexy?” she asks proudly , her voice a little too disbelieving for what they’ve just done.

"I think you need to put me down on the bed and let me show you why what I think of you," Catra answers.

Adora obliges.

She sets Catra down much gentler than she handled the door, guiding her down and leaning over her onto the bed with one knee.

Catra smirks up at her soft touch and kind movements and then grabs her by the shoulders and forcefully rolls them over until she's on top. Adora's hands wrap protectively around her as they go, and when they land and Catra bends to start kissing along her jaw, Adora spreads her hands wide and drags them along her body slowly. Her touch is directionless, surrendering to Catra's lead, but it's still appreciative and warm. It stirs tender blossoms inside Catra's chest.

"What are you okay with?" she asks, in between pressing soft kisses along her jaw. "What do you want me to do?"

Adora hesitates, trying to search her face.

"Tell me," Catra encourages, pulling back to look at her. "I want to touch you how you want me to."

"I...want you to do what you want to do," Adora replies, shrugging gently and dropping her hands down to the bed.

Catra frowns, sitting down on Adora's waist just above the top of her jeans and her pulled-down bandeau, and looks down at her with scrutiny.

Adora's eyes follow her movement and linger on where their bodies make contact, Catra's thighs and ass sticking to the skin of her abdomen, her still-damp core just millimeters away from touching her as well.

Her tail swipes behind her as she hears Adora's breath quicken and her heart speed up as she looks at her, chest stuttering with the

movement. It takes all of Catra's resolve not to tilt forward, lathing her tongue over Adora's skin and granting their meeting between her legs.

*"Be* she growls softly, her warning tone aimed at both of them.

It takes Adora a long moment to finally drag her eyes away and up to her face, and her expression is adorably confused.

"I'm asking you what *you* want. What *you* like," Catra reminds her, as sternly as she can manage.

It takes Adora another second to catch up, but when she does, she shakes her head. "No, I meant," she pauses, eyebrows furrowing as she searches for words. Her cheeks flush as she finds them, and her eyes fall bashfully from Catra's face back down to her body. "It gets me off to get you off. *Only*," she rolls her eyes and chuckles quietly. "What turns me on the most is seeing *you* enjoying what we're doing."

Catra's pretty sure her heart is going to burst long before they're finished with each other today. She can feel it battering against her ribs, threatening to break right through and find Adora's. She leans forward, fingers wrapping behind Adora's neck to pull her up and meet her in a soft kiss. Her hips tilt forward to reach, and Adora's hands come up, massaging into her thighs and pulling her center down on her. A gentle groan passes between them as Catra's warm shine meets Adora's hot skin, and it takes a lot of effort for Catra to lower a hand to Adora's chest and pull back.

"I'm enjoying *the* we're doing," she says, smiling at the tender affection Adora meets her eyes with. "But I can lead if you want?"

Adora nods quickly, returning her soft smile.

"Anything of f-limits?" Catra asks, forcing herself to pull back and sit up.

"No," Adora shakes her head, fingers smoothing up her waist and one hand sliding around to brush the base of her tail.

Catra shifts her posture to hide the squirm that rises from her touch, but there's no helping the way her tail lays over Adora's arm and offers itself up to her. Her smile tilts into a grin, and her fingers smooth down the length of her tail, winding around it and sending a shiver up Catra's spine.

"Do you still want me to tell you what to do?"

Adora's hand freezes, the grin wiping right off her face and hunger growing in its place. She nods. "A little bit, yeah. It helps me remember that this is okay. And," she drifts off, releasing Catra's tail and digging her fingers back into the fuzzy skin of her waist. "It's *so* hot," she breathes.

Arrogant excitement spreads through Catra's body, growing from Adora's touch, and a wide smirk draws over her lips. She leans down again, unable to resist the temptation. "Is it?" she asks lowly.

Adora nods, eyes darkening as Catra lowers towards her. "Yeah."

"Good," she says, stopping just before she reaches Adora's lips. "Kiss me."

Adora meets her with the same uncontrollable eagerness she kissed her with last night, like she's tasting water for the first time after wandering lost in the desert. Like she's feeling sunlight on her skin after a lifetime's existence in the shade. Like she's been suffering her entire life and just discovered her salvation.

Catra loses herself to it, completely forgetting that she's supposed to be leading. She falls into Adora's gravity, soft in her hands and hungry on her lips, and gives generously to every piece of her that Adora asks for. It's not until Adora's hands slide up her spine and pull her body down to meet her completely that Catra remembers her earlier goal.

Adora doesn't let her pull away easily, chasing her lips and nipping at one when she realizes she's losing. Catra loves the chase, the ardent reluctance to let her go, and she gets a little high off of it.

"Got you," she purrs.

Adora's pupils blow out.

Her breath hitches, her fingers tighten, and Catra feels her heart slam forward with such a force it vibrates through both of their bones. A rolling wave of arousal hits the air and Catra grins victoriously, dipping to lick over Adora's pulse point and taste its erratic speed.

"I guess I'll save that one for special occasions," she teases.

Adora tries to huff, aiming for gently offended, but all it sounds like is a desperate exhale. Her hands shift up Catra's back, and her jaw works, opening slightly and closing again, but she never manages to come up with a response. Catra licks down her throat, feels her swallow hard, and then sinks her teeth into her neck.

Adora cries out, giving up the game of playing coy and surrendering to her control. Catra moves carefully, taking care not to actually break the skin as she drags her teeth over to her shoulder and calls her blood to the surface. She won't break it, not now, not until they can have a level-headed conversation about it, but she knows how deeply Adora enjoys it.

She licks across the path her teeth had taken, soothing her skin and teasing herself with the taste of Adora's sweet blood just underneath it. It flirts with the desire still burning inside of her and fills her with hot flames. When she reaches her throat again, she shifts down, licking into the hollow and leaving a trail of bites along her collarbone.

"Take your pants off," she orders, and watches with satisfaction as Adora's jaw tenses and her hands rush to obey. They stroke along

the back of Catra's calves as she pushes all of the remaining clothing on her body off of it and down her legs, and once it's all been kicked to the ground, Adora's hands fall to rest at the soft crooks of her knees. Her desire hits the open air deliciously, feeding Catra, and she presses a praise-laced kiss to her skin.

"Tell me if I do anything you don't like," she says against her skin, her tone caught between a request and a command, and Adora nods willingly. Her hands shift up into Catra's hair, winding between her curls and stroking gently.

Catra makes a noise of appreciation and slides lower, her skin tingling where it sticks to Adora's, and continues her teasing. Adora sweeps her hair out of the way and keeps playing with it, leaving her a free range to do as she pleases. She licks over her skin, bites into her muscles, leaves kisses on her bones. She follows Adora's whimpers and the song of her blood, lingering wherever it calls her strongest. She can smell Adora growing wetter with every lick, and when she reaches the curve of her chest and bites into it, Adora squirms underneath her .

Her eyes are squeezed shut, bottom lip pulled into her mouth, and her head tilted back in enjoyment.

Catra slips her hand around the heavy underside of her breast and pushes it up to meet her. She memorizes every inch of bouncing supple skin and pert nipple she's only been allowed glance at before and vows to show Adora *exactly* how much she's wanted this.

She teases bites across her skin, and licks over each of them, carving a path that spirals all over her breast and ends in the center. She reaches a hand up to lavish attention on the other one and keeps going until she's tasted everything and Adora's moans are slipping through her bitten lip.

She's got one of Adora's nipples caught between her lips and her thumb circling the other when Adora finally breaks and gasps out a desperate request.

Catra pauses her ministrations, the words sending a dangerous spike of heat between her legs. She tears her eyes away from Adora's skin to look up at her face. Adora looks down as soon as she feels her stop, and she looks wonderfully wrecked. Her cheeks and neck are flushed, lips twitching, eyes pleading.

Catra licks over her nipple and lets it go, pillowing her cheek down against her chest. "It won't stay ," she says carefully , making sure they're on the same page. Adora's body will heal too fast for any mark Catra makes to linger.

Adora's eyes close momentarily, something like frustration flickering across her face. "I know ," she says, and she sounds disappointed.

Catra presses a soothing kiss against her hot skin. "I'll do it," she offers, "I just want to make sure you "—

"I know ," Adora whimpers, shutting her eyes tighter . "I know , I just — I w "—

She cuts off with a desperate growl, gritting her teeth. Catra gets the impression that she knows exactly what she wants to say, exactly what she wants, but she can't get the words to come out.

Catra sets another gentle kiss on her skin and slides her hand up her chest, wrapping around her neck and stroking softly over her tense jaw . It seems to help, her muscles loosening, but the words still don't come out.

Catra gets up, pulling herself off of Adora to move until she can kiss the other side of her jaw and lay back down over her . "Tell me," she encourages, and Adora's bottom lip trembles.

"I wanttoto feel like I'm yours," she whispers, like it' s something forbidden. Something not allowed. Something Catra might not want.

like she has no idea what the words do to her.

Without warning, Catra digs her teeth into Adora's neck, barely restraining herself from drawing blood. She bites down hard and sucks until Adora cries out a moan, writhing beneath her. Her fists tug on Catra's curls as she lets go of her and shifts, shoving her knee between Adora's legs and rocking up against her as she bites at her jaw. Burning slick coats her thigh as she moves, dripping out of Adora and making a mess on both of them, and Catra feels out of control. She's sick with power and hunger, lost in a tidal wave of devotion that she never imagined she'd deserve.

"You are mine," she whispers hotly, urgently, like if she doesn't say it fast enough, she might miss her chance. Like it might not be true anymore. "You are *mine*."

The cry that rips from Adora's chest when Catra rocks into her again is desperate and high, and her hands slip from Catra's head to her neck, urging her to come up for a kiss. She catches her lips as soon as Catra offers them, but the kiss is clumsy, breaking around her gasps.

Catra abandons her lips to lick across her cheek and then over the shell of her ear. She tugs gently on the lobe and then reminds her, "You're mine."

The noise that falls out of Adora could be best described as a sob, and it reverberates through Catra's bones. She rubs against Adora again, faster, and Adora's hands curl around her hips.

"I'm close," she warns, stifling a moan, and Catra nods.

She keeps moving as she snakes a hand down Adora's body, tickling her waist. "Show me what to do," she asks, and Adora answers her with a groan.

She covers Catra's hand with hers, engulfing it and twisting their fingers together, and Catra lifts herself off Adora to give them room.

Adora sinks their hands between her legs confidently, and when she guides their fingers into her wetness, Catra feels her own rush forward to match. An electric satisfaction she's never known fills her as she follows Adora's movements around her folds and watches her unravel.

Adora's moans get louder as they work, her body squirming below her, but even as she urges Catra's fingers to work faster, they don't hit her peak. She doesn't fall over the edge, doesn't fly away, doesn't lose herself.

Something is holding her back.

"What do you want?" Catra urges, keeping her steady pace. Adora's hand twitches and then pulls away from hers, curling into a fist over her hip. She opens her eyes, vision flickering down Catra's body and back up, and she swallows.

"Can I touch you?" she asks, only half of her words actually carrying volume. "I think it might — *hm* , might help."

Catra nods quickly , shifting her knees a little wider and not even attempting to hide the wetness starting to drip down her leg. "Always."

Adora seeks her out and curses when she finds her, fingers slipping against her faster than she intended. The touch breaks Catra into whimpers, and she drops from holding herself up with her hand to leaning on her forearm, lowering herself until she can meet Adora in a messy kiss.

Their arms bump against each other as they both start to move faster, and what should have been a beautiful moment of mutual giving quickly devolves into a passionate competition. A competition Catra has a head-start in and is determined to win.

She shifts lower, playing dirty and making Adora's upward angle more difficult, and sinks her teeth into the skin just above her heart.

She feels its beat in her teeth, matching the throbbing pulse underneath her fingers, and growls. Adora tries to shift, choking down a moan and trying to find a better angle, but Catra sucks her skin hard enough to mark, and all Adora can do is throw her head back and cry as her climax finally comes.

She shudders and bucks wildly into Catra's hand, hips lifting and whole body quivering as it runs through her. She abandons Catra's legs and wraps her arms desperately over her shoulders instead, clinging to her as her body blazes. Catra kisses everything she can reach, whispering encouragement, and Adora answers her with unintelligible sounds.

When she finally comes down, her head falls back tiredly, and her hand moves to stop Catra's. After a moment, she uses Catra's fingers to rub down slowly, pushing the last few lingering twitches out, and then she pulls them up and slips them into her mouth.

Her tongue curls around them, cheeks hollowing as she sucks them clean, and her eyes are dark and mischievous when they finally open again.

Catra watches, every flick of her tongue reminding her how capable it is and pouring more fuel on the fire still raging inside of her. When Adora finally pulls her fingers out and returns her hand to her, she brings her own hand up and repeats the entire process, sucking them into her mouth and coating them wetly. Catra rests a hand on either side of Adora's head, watching every move with predatory attention, and waits.

When Adora's satisfied, she pops her fingers out of her mouth and reaches back up between Catra's legs, granting her again the touch she's been missing.

"You don't have to finish me," Catra says, though the whine that follows it undermines her words. "This was supposed to be Adora's turn.

I want to,” she argues back, and that’s that. Who is Catra to deny her what she wants?

She is already close, pent up from Adora’s body and sounds and desires. She can see her mark purpling over Adora’s heart, sinking into her skin, and it feeds the possessive hunger inside of her. Adora’s fingers roll over her peak and tease at her entrance deftly, much more practiced and nimble than her tongue was, and it’s not long before Catra’s falling back to her forearms and resting her head against Adora’s. She pants broken moans into her ear, hips quivering and rocking in the air, and Adora nods and murmurs encouragement. She catches a “*yes*” whispered into her skin, and it immediately grants her the release that she’s been chasing.

She knows she makes some sort of noise, but it all fades away, muffling against her ears like she’s underwater. The only sounds that reach her are their heartbeats, thumping a steady rhythm through her body, guiding her like a call and response as the waves come. Adora brings her through all of them, each softer than the next, and when she’s finally satisfied, she pulls her hips away and collapses onto Adora’s chest.

Adora pulls her in before she can do anything, wrapping her strong arms around her and shifting her up to shower kisses over her neck and shoulder. Catra makes the only noise she can manage, a pathetic attempt at a grateful whine, and Adora answers her with a noise of agreement.

She strokes a careful hand down Catra’s spine and brushes over the base of her tail, and Catra nuzzles furiously into her neck.

“*Fuck*” she says intelligently.

An unrestrained giggle bubbles up from Adora’s chest. “Yeah, we did,” she says, and Catra can hear the grin in her voice.

She lifts her hand without looking and brings it down in the approximate space of Adora's face, landing over her mouth and one eye and giving her a gentle push for the stupid joke.

Adora laughs happily, claiming Catra's hand with hers and pressing kisses all over her palm. "Done?" she asks unnecessarily.

Catra tries to tuck into her body further, but her limbs are too heavy and lazy in the afterglow to cooperate. She nods, nosing Adora's skin. "For now," she mumbles.

*"For now,"* Adora amends. Her hands smooth back up Catra's body and move her, rolling them just enough to cradle her head and lift it up. Catra lets her, leaning into her touch and peeking at her curiously.

Adora smiles, the movement soft at the corners of her mouth and bright in her blue eyes. The same devotion that filthied her voice earlier fills her face now, but it is soft and tender and grants Catra a blooming hope inside her chest.

Adora leans in and touches their lips together, a soft and undemanding pressure, not asking for anything but the sheer enjoyment of being able to do it. Catra presses back, offering the bloom from her chest up to Adora for the taking, and she accepts it with the softest of licks.

She pulls back, tips her forehead to rest them together, and breathes her in.

They can be done, for now.

They have forever.

Chapter End Notes

Thank you thank you THANK YOU everyone who's read this 🥺 the reception for this fic has been completely ridiculous and I'm SO grateful for all the comments and kudos, they mean the world. I hope this chapter made the slow burn of this fic more than worth it;it was super fun to write!

This is the last update of "Bite Down Month," but it is NOT the last weekly update I'll be doing! This fic is going to continue updating weekly until it's finished (just a few more weeks). PEASE send your gratitude for the quick updates to my beta reader, who has been working their ass off to edit these chapters in time <3333

See you next week!

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
Tumblr link (some stuff is here)

Fic playlist: playlist is here!

Thanks for reading <3

# Lovesong

Chapter Summary

Adora stays over.

CW: this chapter contains explicit sexual content, but other things also happen!

Chapter Notes

Title is from Lovesong by The Cure.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Even after she wakes up, Adora's pretty sure she's still dreaming.

The afternoon sun is streaming into the room, beaming in from behind the curtains and slipping through the cracks of space that they don't cover. There's a soft orange glow to the light that bathes the room in a gentle gold, evaporating the dark shadows that come at night and adding a dream-like haze to everything.

And it must be a dream;she must still be lost in the fog of sleep, because she is curled around Catra, both of them tucked under the blankets in the center of the bed and still naked.

She closes her eyes again and tucks her face back into Catra's hair, breathing her in and willing this dream to last as long as possible. Catra's finger twitches as she sleeps, and it's that that makes Adora realize they are holding hands, fingers intertwined and tucked under Catra's chin, and this is not a dream.

This is real.

The steady beating of Catra's heart is real, the shifting of her side as she breathes deeply is real, and the soft tail wrapped possessively around her leg is real.

An overwhelming urge to wake Catra up and kiss her silly surges to the forefront of Adora's mind as she remembers that she is allowed to do that. The only thing that stops her is the knowledge that she will be able to do that whenever Catra wakes up, anytime today and anytime tomorrow, and that if she stays quiet and still, they can stay in this moment together right now.

She stays quiet, allowing herself one soft press of her lips to Catra's shoulder before nuzzling back into her and relaxing. She decides that she'll stay there until Catra wakes up on her own, using this time to breathe her in and memorize her and remind herself that she's allowed to, and she does.

It takes Catra a long time to wake up, but waiting for something has never been easier. Adora's memorized the smell of her hair, the feeling of her fuzzy limbs against Adora's bare skin, and the slight pattern her ear twitches in when she dreams. She's memorized the number of freckles on her shoulder, stripes on her arm, and the angle at which her head tucks over Adora's arm, and for the first time, she gets to memorize how she looks when she wakes up.

Her nose twitches first, then her cheek, then a sweet, sleepy groan rumbles out of her chest before she readjusts, tucking their joined hands tighter under her chin and curling up a little smaller. Several seconds later, she seems to realize the same thing Adora did, running her fingers over her knuckles and blinking slowly awake.

She drags their hands out so she can look at them, twisting her fingers around Adora's and watching them with an indiscernible look. She examines Adora's hand for a long minute before lacing her fingers between hers once more, and when Adora closes her fingers, Catra squeezes.

She rolls over, blinking sleepily up at Adora. A smile crawls over her lips, soft and pretty, and Adora's heart flutters. She wants to kiss her.

She does.

Catra welcomes her but lags a step behind all of her movements, still half-asleep and with no fear of losing out. She tastes like sleep and catnip, and Adora leaves an extra kiss on either edge of her mouth before letting her go.

She communicates with an unintelligible mumble, closing her eyes and tucking herself into Adora's chest. Adora chuckles and pulls her close, rubbing a hand over her shoulders and down her back.

"Good morning," she says quietly.

Catra speaks into her chest, lips dragging over her skin, and it takes Adora a long moment to focus enough to process her words. "How long have you been up?"

Adora shrugs gently, pressing a kiss to the top of her head. "A while," she answers honestly.

"Have you just been watching me?" she asks, teasing scrutiny making its way into her sleepy voice.

Adora snorts. "A little," she answers honestly again.

"You weirdo," Catra quips, but she presses closer and drapes her leg over Adora's hips, tail winding itself around her ankle.

"*You* weirdo," Adora reminds her, rolling backward and pulling Catra on top of her.

Catra grins and scoots up, tucking into her neck and nodding. "*My* weirdo."

The words stroke Adora's heart like a kiss, sending it soaring. Warm excitement spreads through her body, filling her from head to toe and

making it impossible not to squeeze Catra closer and sneak a kiss onto her cheek.

Catra presses one back along her jaw, warm and sweet, and then snuggles into her. "Go back to sleep," she orders. "It's not time to get up yet."

Adora tightens her hold on her and settles in, content to stay like this forever if that's what Catra wants.

Unfortunately, her stomach has other plans. It gives her away with an abnormally long and loud growl.

Catra snorts loud enough to match, her entire body jostling with the movement. "What? You didn't eat enough this morning?"

Adora grins, nosing into her hair and nipping at her neck. "I could always eat more," she responds honestly, another kind of hunger awakening inside her as her tongue remembers Catra's electric taste.

Catra laughs, a sweet soft noise, and tilts her head to give Adora more access. "I might break your jaw if I take you up on that offer."

Adora licks over her neck, Catra's words already stoking a fire in her core. She remembers the feeling of Catra's thighs suffocating her, her hips relentlessly rolling against her tongue, and she can't think of a better sacrifice. "It'll heal," she answers.

Catra lets her lick along her throat once more before threading her fingers into her hair and gently guiding her away. When Adora pulls back, she's smiling coyly. "Down, girl. There's some food in the fridge for you."

Catra's words tickle her brain. "You bought me fridge food?" she asks, remembering how adamantly Catra had stopped her from opening the fridge the first, last, and only time she tried.

Catra's cheeks darken with what can only be a blush. "That's what I just said, isn't it?"

Adora grins, diving in for a kiss. "Wow, you really do like me."

Catra shoves her face away, but she's laughing. "No comment," she says, pushing off of Adora's shoulder to sit up and stretch.

Adora watches her unabashedly, enjoying every second of being able to be near her and look at her and not having to guard her feelings. When Catra's done stretching, Adora sits up too and leans in halfway. Catra catches her chin and tugs her the rest of the way down, kissing her meaningfully and conveying the confession she's too shy to admit now.

She brushes their noses together and then pulls back, a smile dancing on her lips that is so small that it must be subconscious. "Come on," she directs and then climbs out of bed.

Adora follows slowly, eyes trailing the total expanse of Catra's body as it's revealed to her and eventually catching on her leg when she sees it. It's mostly hidden, tucked in high on the inside of her thigh and only showing when she moves a certain way, but there it is.

The mark from Adora's bite.

She really hadn't meant to leave it – hadn't meant to bite her at all, much less that hard – but Adora can't honestly say that she completely regrets it. Frankly, if what Catra said was true – that she shouldn't apologize and she loved *it* of it – then she doesn't regret a single fucking part of it. The hot thrill that runs through her when she sees that the mark is still bright and bruised is selfish and possessive and a little bit ugly – but maybe that's okay. Maybe it's okay to feel those things about Catra. Maybe she doesn't have to be scared of them.

Her eyes skip down to her own chest. It's bare. Her mark is gone, just as Catra warned her it would be. She pulls a bit at her skin to

ensure it's not tucked up too high on her chest to be seen, but it's not. The one on her neck is certainly gone by now, too. Disappointment tugs on her heart, the foolish hope that there might still be *some* sort of evidence left on her body being blown out for good. Her eyes skip back to Catra's legs, everything they did that morning replaying in her head, and a new hope blossoms that maybe her healing is a good thing. Maybe it gives her a constant excuse to need Catra to re-mark her if she wants to.

Catra stops in front of her closet and starts digging through it, looking for something to put on, so Adora sets to finding her own clothes. She catches a glimpse of the bedroom door as she does, and it looks even worse in the afternoon light than it did in the morning.

She'll have to fix that later.

Her jeans and underwear are kicked half under the bed, and she pulls them out with a grimace. Huntara's shirt must be around the apartment somewhere, but she doesn't really want to put last night's bar clothes back on. But, of course, she wasn't expecting to stay over. And she isn't going to leave until Catra gets sick of her or Mara needs her.

*Aw*. Shit, she should text her so she knows that everything worked out.

Catra giggles from the other side of the room, and when Adora looks up, she's put on a sheer bralette and some bike shorts and is watching her stand there and hold her clothes like an idiot. She catches her eye and smirks, and then turns back to her closet. "I think I might have something that could fit you, but I make no promises. You never returned the clothes you borrowed."

She didn't.

She meant to, of course, but they smelled so much like Catra and her apartment, and then Adora learned they were probably Scorpia's and got upset, and *then* she learned that Scorpia and Catra weren't

dating, so it didn't really matter how they ended up in Catra's apartment, they had been given to her by Glimmer, and then Adora ended up back at the first problem: that they smelled like her and her apartment and she didn't want to return the only piece of Catra that she'd been allowed to take home.

But now, if they were really doing this, if this was okay... maybe Catra would let her keep some things here. And maybe she could take some more things home, even if they didn't fit her.

Catra re-emerges from the closet with a dark red and black flannel shirt and chucks it at Adora's face. She catches it and holds it out, and it looks the appropriate size to be fashionably large on Catra and to *maybe* fit over Adora's gigantic arms. She tries it on, and with a gentle amount of force, it fits.

She grins victoriously, Catra's smell enveloping her, and moves to flex arrogantly but immediately feels the fabric grow tight across her shoulders. No flexing, then, unless Catra gives her the okay to rip this into pieces.

Catra's still watching her with a dumb, giddy little smile, though, so she buttons a few of the lower buttons that will close and then turns around. The uneven hem dips low enough in the front to *just* cover her up, but she can feel the back brushing over and definitively *not* covering the entirety of her ass cheeks. "I think it fits," she calls over her shoulder, wiggling her lower end just a little.

A happy giggle escapes Catra's mouth, and she follows it up with a quick whistle. "Oh, I think it's *perfect*," she purrs.

Adora throws a wink over her shoulder, welcoming the spike of excitement inside her at Catra's words, and wiggles her way out to the living room. She hears Catra trail behind her and skips to the fridge, grabbing the handle in one large hand and then pausing. She checks behind her and quirks an eyebrow. "I can open it now, right?"

Catra's cheeks seem to darken slightly, and one of her ears twitches, but that's the only reaction her question brings forth. "Yeah, dummy," she rolls her eyes.

Adora smiles and yanks the fridge open wide, surveying what they have for breakfast options.

There isn't much food inside, but there's enough. A carton of eggs, a package of cheese, a weirdly healthy brand of sandwich bread. There's some butter and random condiments inside the door, and at the back of the bottom shelf is a row of five glass bottles with a weirdly bright red liquid inside. Adora gives the fridge a sniff, and the brightness makes sense; they smell almost like blood but wrong somehow, and it must be some sort of fake blood or blood-adjacent drink for vampires. Adora shrugs and returns to the top shelf, scooping all of the food out and balancing it precariously in her arms. She spins around to put it down on the island and finds Catra on the other side, watching her with a strange look.

"What?" she asks, carefully setting everything down.

Catra blinks and then shakes her head slightly. "Just, um, there's uh, there are some frozen sausages or whatever too, in the freezer."

"Oh," Adora says, spinning back around. She shuts the fridge and opens the freezer, and sure enough, there are some frozen sausages or *bacon*, sitting in the exact middle of the otherwise completely empty space. "Wow. You really went all out for me."

"Don't get used to it," Catra growls playfully. "You're buying your own groceries if you're staying here."

Adora sets the sausages down and grins widely at her, heart jumping. "So I *am* staying here?"

Catra's eyes narrow, but her tail lashes with excitement, giving her away. "I'm *not* moving in with the wolves," she asserts.

"That's fine," Adora breathes, her grin so wide it's almost difficult to speak. "You don't have to. I mean, She-Ra's supposed to live on the property, but it'll be years, if not *decades*, till Mara steps down and, I mean, there's plenty of housing *on* the property if you ever wanted to move, or I mean, I was serious about the bungalows, we wouldn't have to share with anyone if we didn't want to, or I mean, *you* could live there, and I could live in the main house if you didn't want to live *with* me, which I guess I'm just assuming, but"—

"Adora."

Adora snaps her mouth shut.

"Breathe," Catra reminds her, and she sucks a gallon of air down.

"That feels better. My point is," she starts again, "the pack loves you, and I—*just* I—*am* happy wherever you're happy. Wherever you're happy with me being, I mean. For now."

Adora's heart is pounding at her almost slip-up, but the corner of Catra's mouth tugs up a little as she folds her arms. "Well, I have a promise from you that you're not leaving until I tell you to, and I haven't told you to yet," she threatens.

Adora's heart soars. "*Yeah*. Yeah, I'm not, I—*oh*, Mara!"

Adora starts, running back to the bedroom and digging around in her jeans for her phone. She doesn't find it, so she heads back into the living room and scours the floor. "Do you know where my"—

"Phone is?" Catra finishes, holding the offending device out and leaning casually against the island. Huntara's shirt and her own discarded clothes are crumpled in her other hand, and she's smirking. "I think you kicked it under the counter this morning."

Adora chuckles sheepishly, cheeks flushing with more heat at the memory than embarrassment, and she takes the phone gratefully. "Thank you."

She texts Mara that everything worked out and she's not sure when she'll be home, and then turns back to get breakfast started. Catra directs her to where everything is, and before long, she's got everything cooking nicely. Catra stays on the other side of the island, leaning onto the counter and watching her, and she wishes she was a little closer, but it's probably for the best. Just remembering this morning and knowing what's allowed now while she feels Catra's eyes on her is distracting enough; if she was close enough to touch, there would be a very high risk of ruining breakfast.

"So, the *plan* loves me?" Catra's voice drifts over, high and teasing.

A smirk cracks over Adora's face, happy Catra feels okay enough with her almost slip-up to tease her about it. "Of course they do," Adora offers, opting for a casual answer and peeking over her shoulder. "They know how happy I am with you."

Catra's quirked eyebrow falters, and for a second, a strangely emotional expression passes over her face. But then she narrows her eyes and scrunches her nose, and it's gone. "I don't have to wear some stupid jacket now, right?"

Adora scoffs, but she turns back around as she feels a bit of heat start to creep up her neck. "No, of course not."

"Why does it sound like you're lying?" Catra presses carefully, and Adora's cheeks flush.

"I'm not!" she says honestly, but even she can hear that her voice has gotten too high in pitch to be believable. She clears her throat and tries again. "I'm *not*; you don't have to wear any jackets."

She pushes the eggs around in the pan and waits for Catra to say something, anything, but too much time passes, and she doesn't. Adora sneaks a look over her shoulder, just a small one, but it's a mistake.

She sees Catra see her, and in that moment, a wicked grin grows over Catra's perfect lips. "Aw, *did* you," she croons, her face twisting in mock sympathy. "Do you want me to wear *your* jacket?"

Adora's sure her entire body is now the color of a tomato. She whips back around and moves the pans around the stove a little too aggressively. "*No*," she lies.

Catra laughs, high and squeaky, and it eases Adora's embarrassment just a little bit. At least she's not mad about it.

"Tell me about it," Catra requests, her voice a bit more serious. "It seems like you've thought about this before."

Adora shrugs, reluctant to admit just how *long* she's thought about it. "Just, y'know. They're important to us. They show everyone who we are, so…"

"You want everyone to know who I am?" Catra supplies, voice even. "To know that I'm yours?"

The accusation sinks into Adora like lead, dragging her limbs down and slowing her movements. She *knew* she had asked for too much this morning. She knew *she* was too much. She knew this wouldn't be something Catra wanted.

Adora turns, an apology poised on her lips, but Catra's expression stops her. She's not mad, not even apathetic; her lips are parted and her mismatched eyes are glittering devilishly. She looks *excited*.

Her gaze softens as she takes in Adora's tense face and shoulders, and she leans farther across the island, practically laying on it and giving Adora an eyeful. She makes it impossible to forget how she'd been poised on that island just this morning, with Adora buried between her legs and licking her way to salvation.

"Yes, or no?" Catra asks, and her voice is gentle.

Adora swallows, her tongue heavy, and manages: "Yes."

A smile spreads over Catra's face, exposing her fangs, and it becomes difficult to swallow for another reason entirely. "So you want me to wear it around town?"

*Yes.* Adora nods.

"Anywhere else?"

*Yes.* Adora hesitates.

Catra nods slowly, encouraging her. *It's okay.*

"At home," she forces herself to say, no matter how clumsy it comes out. Catra wants to hear it, so she'll tell her. "At home, too."

Catra quirks an eyebrow, waiting. Adora's not done, and she knows it.

"With." Adora squeezes her eyes shut, shoving the words out however they'll go. "With nothing else on."

She waits for Catra to say *something*, waits for her to chastise her or tease her or tell her she doesn't want that back, but nothing comes. She squeezes her eyes shut tighter, face burning, and prays that the ground might swallow her up.

"Did you bring it with you?"

Adora's eyes snap open to find Catra watching her with a dangerous heat. Her lips aren't turned up; her eyes aren't lit with amusement. There isn't a trace of a joke anywhere in her words, and Adora realizes with a rush of blood that she isn't making fun of her at all.

She's serious.

"Uhhh," Adora answers intelligently, desperately trying to remember if she brought it and to stop imagining how Catra would look wearing

it. *Will* look wearing it, if she means what Adora thinks she means. "Uh, I… *sh*," she realizes with a sinking heart. "No, I didn't."

Catra frowns, drawing back and straightening up. "Bring it next time," she orders, and Adora nods furiously, unable to form any words with her dry mouth. "And Adora?"

Adora pauses, clinging to every word.

"The food's burning."

Adora spins around to see that yes, the food *is* burning, and she frantically shuffles the pans around and turns the stove off. She hears Catra stifle a giggle behind her, but as she digs through the food with her spatula, it looks like most of it is still salvageable.

"Food's done!" she announces unnecessarily, and Catra snorts openly.

Despite being gently burnt, it's all still pretty good. That, or Adora's just ravenous. She eats most of it at Catra's tiny kitchen table, wolfing it down with the same ferocity she always eats with, and Catra humors her by eating a little bit and teasing her about the burnt edges. It is sweet and easy and so domestic, and it is more than Adora has ever allowed herself to want. It is more than she ever thought she could deserve or even entertain the thought of.

Catra is perfect. She is everything she has always been, every sharp edge and soft, sweet center, except she is so much happier. She is so much brighter. Adora wants to bask in her light for the rest of her life.

"I think Shadow Weaver messed with my head," Adora says quietly, eyes scouring Catra's smiling face and memorizing every inch of it.

Catra's eyebrows converge, eyes painting with confusion. "What? Why?"

Adora shrugs helplessly. "How else could I ever forget you?"

Catra's cheeks darken, and she rolls her eyes with a huff. "Ad—"

"I'm serious," Adora insists, leaning forward. "I know we were kids, but it doesn't make any sense otherwise. What you mean to me, I—" she breaks off, voice filling with emotion. "I wouldn't have forgotten that. We must have known each other."

"We did," Catra confesses quietly, dropping her eyes to stare at the dark wood grain of the table. Something twitches in her jaw. "I… remembered. Some."

Adora's heart jumps, fear and curiosity spiraling together. "What?"

Catra shrugs. "We knew each other—we were friends. I guess. It didn't last long."

"What happened?" Adora presses.

Catra is staring into the table, hard, and something flickers across her face that looks far too much like pain for Adora. She suddenly does not care at all about hearing what happened.

"Weaver," is all Catra says, and it is all she needs to.

Adora slides a hand across the top of the small table, easily reaching Catra's side. It draws her vision up until Catra is looking at her, and then she obliges and slips her hand into Adora's.

She squeezes it as soon as she can, tangling their fingers together and holding onto her tightly. "It doesn't matter," she tells the both of them, shaking her head. "Forget I asked. It's in the past; it's over now. I don't care."

Catra's mismatched eyes dart away from her, something growing in them as her lips press together and twist into a frown. "There's something else I should tell you."

Adora turns their hands to stroke a finger along Catra's knuckles and nods.

"I don't," Catra starts, and her voice is heavy with a guilt that is all too familiar to Adora. "*Need* to feed. Like other vampires. I don't… *even* don't. It doesn't take *blood* to keep us alive. Just energy, just being around people that are alive can be enough. Especially if they're powerful. Blood is easier, but we don't *need* it. And *I* don't even need the energy to survive. It's not fun without it, but it won't *kill* me."

Catra peeks up, checking to see if Adora understands where she's going, but she doesn't. Why is Catra acting like this is a secret?

"I know," Adora says, confused and quiet.

Catra opens her mouth to continue and then stops. "Wait, what do you mean you *know*?"

"I," Adora shrugs, unsure. "I know all of this."

Catra looks baffled, so she continues.

"After the first bite, I did some research," she admits, a blush creeping up her neck. "I wanted to know why I had the… *addiction* … that I had. I didn't find much about that, but I found a lot of information about vampires and a little about hybrids, and I figured that was the case."

Catra blinks. "And you still let me feed off of you?"

"Of course," Adora shakes her head, not understanding at all why that would matter. "You still enjoy it, right?"

Catra nods warily.

"And so do I, and it's the only way I had to be close to you, so why would I have stopped you?"

Adora knows her blush is blazing across her face, but when Catra blinks away glistening tears, she doesn't care at all. She rubs her fingers along Catra's wrist, and Catra smiles.

"You can be close to me however you want, dummy," she says, her voice wet.

"And *you* can feed off of me however *you* want, *huh*," Adora returns, tilting her head. "You know what it means for me to be able to give to you. The *how* doesn't matter to me."

Catra doesn't reply, still blinking back tears, but she takes Adora's hand with both of hers and presses it to her mouth, kissing along her knuckles and holding her fingers. When she pulls back, Adora turns her hand and reaches, and Catra settles her cheek into her palm. For a minute, they hold each other steady, and then Adora slowly draws back.

"Speaking of, are my tools still here? I believe I have a door to fix."

Catra laughs and then nods. "Yeah, they should be. Let's clean up, and then we can see how horribly you fucked that door up."

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It turns out the answer is *pretty*.

The top hinges are almost completely dislodged, the bottom ones half-on at best. The drywall the doorknob smashed through is unsalvageable, the doorknob dented, and a cracked indent in the wood right at kicking height makes it *very* clear what happened to the door.

Catra takes one look at it over Adora's shoulder and snorts, spinning and dropping onto the end of the bed just a few feet away. "That's

going to take you *a* night."

"No, it won't," Adora protests, even though she's not too sure of that. She looks down at her tools, just a bag of the basics she'd brought for miscellaneous tasks, and shrugs. "I can't fix the wall with what I have anyway. I'll have to come back for that."

She hears Catra blow out a breath and scoot back, reclining on the bed. "But you can fix the door?" she asks, her tone skeptical.

Adora surveys the door, definitely worse for wear, and tries not to cringe. "I can put it back together enough that it will open and close until I can get you a new one," she offers.

Catra makes an unimpressed noise, and Adora looks over to see her stretch up to grab a pillow. She puts it under her head, gets comfy on her back, and then quirks an eyebrow at Adora. "Well? Get on with it."

Adora snorts, her eyes flicking down Catra's body, catching on all the places her scant clothes leave exposed and remembering what she feels like under her hands. "Are you just going to watch?"

"Watch my pants-less girlfriend try to fix my door that's totally and *optionally* busted because she couldn't wait even another second for me to open it *properly* because she wanted to have sex with me, *right* *now* badly?" A smug grin splits over Catra's face, and her words shoot down Adora's spine and pool hot in her core. "*Yeah*. I'm going to watch this and enjoy every second of it."

Adora rolls her eyes, trying to play off the heat climbing up her body, and tries to roll up her sleeves. It's easier to reach with the cuffs unbuttoned, but each roll just makes them tighter, and they're already so tight that she doesn't make it very far at all before she has to stop. She briefly contemplates just taking the flannel off, making it much easier for her to move around in general, but she can feel Catra's gaze on her like burning sunlight, and she thinks that

stripping would actually make it harder to get this task done, if not impossible.

Doing her best to ignore Catra, she inventories what she has in her bag, makes a plan, and then sets to it. Only a few giggles drift over as she tries to gingerly separate the door from the wall it's made a home in, but every time she bends at the waist, the noises turn much more suggestive. She manages to free the door without causing any extra damage and shoots Catra a triumphant grin, only to find Catra already watching her with a dark heat. She returns the smile, and her eyes rake over Adora's body, and it leaves her skin tingling dangerously.

She's not sure how she expected Catra to do while she fixed the door, but it wasn't this. She's all too aware of how vulnerable she is just to Catra' s eyes on her and how blatantly obvious it will be if she gets aroused from this alone. She knows these feelings are welcomed now, allowed and even encouraged, but it's still brand new, and she doesn't want to be overzealous about any of it and make Catra uncomfortable.

Thankfully , that's not a concern she has to worry about for long.

She's balancing the door carefully and adding new screws to the top hinge when the soft noises begin, teasing little whimpers, and Adora is sure that Catra is making fun of her. Messing with her, in one way or another, as she appreciates the view that she must be getting while Adora faces away from her and reaches up. She refuses to give in and look at her until she's changed two of the screws and is reaching down for more, flexing a little extra on the way just for fun. She grabs the screws and sneaks a peek at Catra, and then promptly drops them and her jaw .

Catra's eyes are half-lidded, freckled cheeks dusted with a blush, and her bottom lip half caught between her teeth. Her arms are crossed over her chest, and both hands are cupping and teasing at her breasts. As Adora stands up to watch, one clever hand leaves

her chest and descends slowly, slowly, *sblw* to the space between her legs.

Adora's mouth runs dry.

Those noises were *not* jokes, after all.

She stumbles forward, legs moving on their own accord, but as soon as Catra sees her, her eyes flash, and she pulls her hand away from herself. *No,*" she says.

"But"—

"Finish," she orders, nodding at the door still hanging limply behind Adora.

Adora barely spares the door a glance, eyes glued to Catra and her capable, decisive hands.

"I'm enjoying my show," Catra explains, shrugging into the blankets. "If you want to participate, then you need to finish your work before *I* finish." She says it simply, as if it could be that easy, and Adora doesn't know how Catra knows *by* how to drive her wild, but she has never been more grateful that she does.

There is nothing like competition to bring out Adora's best.

Catra raises an eyebrow just a touch, checking in, and if Adora's replying nod is far too eager, she doesn't care at all. She watches Catra's hand slip back between her legs and cup herself, just holding it there, and she vows for that to be her hand before long.

"Go on," Catra instructs, and Adora returns to her work with an unhinged ferocity. She snatches up the screws she dropped and moves as quickly as possible, taking out the broken ones and replacing them with the new ones. It was tedious before, having to go one by one to keep the door balanced, but now that she can hear

the soft rustling of Catra's clothing behind her and knows exactly what it means, it has become excruciating.

A stifled moan splits the air and ricochets through Adora's body, shooting wetness between her legs and making her drop everything in her hands. She fumbles for them with a curse, and the moan turns into a giggle that turns into a whimper, and Adora has never needed *#g* as much as she needs to fix this fucking door.

She tries again, working quickly but carefully , refusing to turn around for anything. Her fire is blazing, her entire core filled with lava, and her imagination is running wild with the sounds she's hearing. She knows if she turns around and sees what's really happening, what Catra is trusting her to witness, she will lose all control and ruin their game entirely.

She makes it through a couple more screws okay and finishes the top hinge, dropping to the bottom one with a fury. Catra makes a noise that sounds like disappointment and makes Adora's heart flutter with victory, and she moves as quickly as her hands will let her.

Despite the disappointment, the sounds behind her increase, the shifting of clothing and breathy gasps speeding up. The sound of a waistband snapping echoes through the air, and Adora considers how much she really needs to do to consider the door fixed. She decides that as long as she can forcefully close it, it will count.

She drives the last screw head into the frame as Catra whines loudly, and Adora scrambles up to grab the door and swing it closed. Her swing is more of a slam, reminiscent of how they ended up in this mess in the first place, but it closes without breaking again, and that is the best victory Adora can ask for.

She whirls around and takes in the scene before her;Catra' s hand is buried inside her pants, moving furiously, her other hand holding her chest firmly and her tail dancing beside her. Her mouth is open,

panting, and her mischievous eyes are staring Adora down. Daring her to claim her victory.

She does not wait.

She climbs desperately onto the bed, hands searching up Catra's legs until they find her hips and then yanking her closer. Catra laughs, but it dies in her throat as Adora presses an urgent kiss to her stomach and then pulls her hand from her pants, wasting no time in licking the slick off of her fingers.

Catra's taste fills her mouth and sends a rush down her spine, and she can't help the moan that rises out of her chest.

Catra pulls her fingers away to grab her by the jaw and drag her up to kiss her viciously. Adora's barely gotten a chance to kiss her back before Catra's hands are clawing at her shirt, forcing the buttons apart and shoving it down her arms. Adora pulls it off the rest of the way, throwing it off the bed and scooping her hands underneath Catra to pull their bodies together. Catra wraps her limbs around her and deepens the kiss, sucking on her lip and then licking into her mouth. Her fingers drag down Adora's back, leaving trails of fire in their wake as they blaze toward her ass and squeeze her cheeks. Adora is swept up in it, entirely consumed with the roaring sensation of feeling Catra all around her and against her, and when she rolls her hips up, Adora can do nothing more than answer by pushing her into the mattress and driving her hips down.

The angle isn't right, but Catra moans anyway, and the way her claws dig into Adora's skin makes her realize that her enthusiasm may be worth more than she thinks. She slides her hands down to her hips, fingers catching the top of her shorts as she tries to shift for a better angle to try again, but Catra shakes her head with a desperate noise and orders, "Off."

Adora pauses, not sure what she means, but Catra spells it out for her by unwrapping her legs and lifting her hips up as much as she can. Adora pulls back enough to dig her fingers into her waistband

and drag her pants down her legs, Catra taking over once they're past her knees and kicking them off. Her vibrant smell hits the air and fills Adora's lungs, and her desire makes her feel delirious. She returns to Catra, caught between taking charge to take her bralette off, too, or waiting for further instructions, and Catra takes advantage of her pause.

She pushes her shoulders and rolls them, diving in for another kiss and then tangling their fingers together. She pulls back and sits up, bare hips resting over Adora's, and it's all Adora can do to not thrust aimlessly up against them.

Catra grins and pulls her hands close to her face, eyes hungry as she twists and turns Adora's wrists. Adora doesn't understand the pause —Catra's seen her hands a million times by now —but she's clearly enjoying herself, so she doesn't interrupt. After a thorough examination, Catra presses a kiss to the back of one hand and then licks down her forearm with attention that leaves her skin tingling. Catra holds her arm carefully and leans down, licking a path from the inside of her elbow over her bicep and up to her shoulder. Adora doesn't know what's happening but she feels like melting gold, supple and bright and willing.

"You are so fucking hot," Catra whispers into her neck, following the praise with a kiss, and the words spread over her skin with a flush. The whimper that escapes Adora's lips is uncontrollable.

She feels Catra's lips twitch against her skin, probably sliding into a smirk, and then she speaks again. "I love your hands," she confesses quietly, but not shyly. "And your arms."

Hot pride swells in Adora's chest, and she reaches for her blindly, desperate to touch, but Catra's hands find hers first. Their fingers tangle together, and it's not enough, Adora's heart singing and hungry, but then Catra shifts up and licks at the lobe of her ear.

"I get so wet when you hold me," she whispers, and this time it is shy. The words are soft and rushed, almost embarrassed. Before

Adora can respond, Catra's hips push down on hers with more weight, tilting into her. Adora feels burning wet heat against her skin, and she thinks she's going to lose her mind.

Some sort of desperate whine escapes her as she reaches for Catra's body again, needing to touch and please her like she needs to breathe, but Catra's fingers tighten over hers.

"I'm not done yet," Catra says, nosing into Adora's neck. She presses another burning kiss to her throat and then raises their joined hands over Adora's head.

It's a vulnerable position, exposing, but their fingers are still twisting together, and Adora has already offered Catra her life. There is nothing she can take that Adora is not already begging to give her.

Catra licks a wet path up her other arm, moving slowly from her shoulder to her wrist and keeping their hands knit together the entire time. Adora feels something tickling her thighs, and it must be Catra's tail, flicking excitedly from one leg to the other. Catra presses a kiss to the tender inside of her wrist when she reaches it, surprisingly gentle for the heat building between them, and then another kiss to each palm.

And then she lets one of her hands go and takes the other, tucking some fingers down and pulling other fingers up, and sits back just enough to meet Adora's eyes. As soon as she does, she sucks her fingers into her mouth.

Catra's tongue is hot and wet, and with every coating of saliva she grants her fingers, Adora feels a rush of wet heat between her legs. She doesn't know which part of her is wetter by the time Catra finally releases her and fixes her with a grin.

"Do you"—

Adora surges up and swallows the rest of Catra's question, uncaring what it is and already knowing that the answer is yes. Whatever it is,

*yes*, she wants it. *Yes*, she needs it.

Catra growls into her mouth, and she only nods, refusing to break their kiss. Catra wraps a hand around the back of her neck and pulls her up until they're both sitting and she's straddling her lap. She releases Adora's neck and reaches blindly for her hand, her fingers sliding to cover Adora's own wet ones and pull them close, and then suddenly, they're spreading into her hot folds.

Adora tries not to groan too loudly, surrendering control of her own hand as Catra uses it to touch herself, but she is already so wet that Catra didn't even need to lick her fingers first. Adora releases her mouth to suck a spot against her neck, shifting her focus to the pattern that Catra's guiding her hand in and memorizing the rhythm and pressure. Once she's got it down, she nods, nipping at her jaw, but instead of letting her take over, Catra shifts her fingers down and slips them inside of herself.

She's like molten lava, soft and burning around her, and Adora doesn't mean to bite her neck, but she can't stop herself. The desperate, possessive monster that claws its way into control whenever she gets close to Catra has taken hold of her body, encouraged by Catra's trust and passion and maybe even her own hungry monster. As Catra begins to move her fingers out and then back in, agonizingly slowly, a faint whine escaping her mouth, the monster's familiar feeling settles into her chest.

That feeling that she needs this, that she is meant for this. That every purpose she's been prophesied to be destined for was nothing but a dirty lie because nothing else has ever filled her like this. She has never wanted anything the way that she wants Catra. She has never needed anything the way she needs to give to her. It feels integral, inseparable from her being, woven through every single part of her.

And it occurs to Adora that maybe this isn't really a monster at all. Maybe it is a monster in the same way that *they* are monsters. Monstrous by definition, monstrous by Otherness, monstrous by the

fear others hold for them. But in practice, in heart and in blood, nothing less than divine.

Catra speeds up her fingers, nodding against the top of her head, then tucks her thumb against her and draws a similar pattern as before. Adora listens attentively, licking over the spot she bit and working her fingers purposefully until Catra finally lets go of her hand and wraps her claws around her upper arm instead. She fondles her flexing muscles, soft palms stroking and sharp nails scratching, sending a hot and appreciative wave through Adora's core.

Soft noises begin to rise from Catra's throat, a special siren's song, and Adora keeps pace. She pulls back to look at Catra and lifts her other hand to tug at one strap of her bralette. Catra nods immediately, face flushed and eyes dark as she pants, and Adora slips the strap off and dives to meet the new skin bared to her.

It makes the angle of her arm a little awkward, stooping to suck Catra's tit into her mouth, but her wrist is strong, and she feels the moan it brings forth ring inside her head. One of Catra's hands tightens over her biceps, and the other comes up and digs into her hair, holding her steady as she lavishes attention and appreciation over her skin. And then, Catra begins to move.

She tilts her hips down as Adora's fingers move upward, meeting her a little bit deeper. She pulls back as Adora does and then meets her again, harder, and then she begins to move in earnest. She drives Adora's fingers into her, pressing into her touch and fucking herself on it, and the noise that rips from her throat pushes Adora from delirious into a deranged state of bliss. She feels high and full and in love.

Catra's hand tightens to a death grip in her hair, and the pain brings a whole new wave of pleasure to her body. She moans against her skin, and Catra returns it, nodding, thrusting against her. *β*
*gg* Catra begs, too far along to make it an order.

Adora's wrist is cranked, her arm straining and muscles burning as she tries to keep her pace steady and movements careful against Catra's wild hips. The pain it brings wraps into the pain in her scalp, turning into something new and delicious and chosen, and she couldn't stop even if she tried. So she does as she's told.

Catra begins to unravel just before her precipice, her rhythm too fast to be accurate. Adora wraps her free arm around her hips, just tight enough to steady her and keep her close. Catra lets go of her head to wrap her hand around her other arm till both claws are digging into her muscles. With the extra support, Catra drives herself down a few more times and then cries out.

She bucks against Adora's hold, shudders into her mouth, and pierces Adora's skin with her nails. She soars, clinging to Adora lest she fly away, and Adora drinks every piece of it down. She lets Catra press into her hand when she wants to and stays near when she doesn't, she licks the flush from her chest and neck, and she keeps her close and safe as she comes down. She feels her own high follow Catra's, peaking as she shudders and fading with satisfaction as she turns boneless in her arms. Adora pulls her hand away carefully, smoothing up her side and keeping her upright, and Catra wraps her arms heavy around her neck and tucks their cheeks together.

Adora listens to her breathe, feels her heartbeat slow, and cradles her gently until she stirs.

The first thing she does is seek out Adora' s lips, nosing over her cheek until she finds them with her own, and the kiss she presses against her is searing and tender and gracious. Adora returns it easily, appreciatively, and rests their foreheads together.

"*F* you're really good at that," Catra whispers, and Adora grins brilliantly. She has never been so proud to have so much experience working with her hands before.

"So are you," she agrees, and Catra snorts af fectionately.

Catra's hands slide down her shoulders, and she pulls back, twisting her arm up and looking at it with concern. Small spots of blood dot the muscle where her nails broke the skin, and she leans over and licks a path across it. Her tongue is warm, and the feeling that sweeps over her with it is like a micro-dose of when she feeds, a sliver of ecstasy and purpose after the tidal wave's worth they just shared.

"M' sorry," Catra apologizes quietly as she moves to lick over her other arm, and Adora shakes her head and tightens her grip around her.

"Don't be. I loved it."

Something shines in Catra's eyes when they meet hers, something more than just humor and affection, and Adora thinks she can taste it when she kisses her again.

She tugs gently as she leans back, and Catra follows her until they're lying on the bed. She rolls them to the side and bumps her nose against Catra's, stroking careful fingers up her spine.

"Can I hold you?" she asks, her divine monster craving to just be.

"Of course," Catra tucks into her, bumping under her chin and intertwining her tail with their legs. "You have to make good on your promise," she teases.

Adora tugs her as close as she can, wrapping completely around her and pressing kisses against her wild curls. "I do," she says quietly, breathing Catra in until her whole body and being is filled with her.

"I will."

Chapter End Notes

I'm not crying, you are!Honeymoon rom com era time <3 Let me know your favorite part!

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
Tumblr link (some stuff is here)

Fic playlist: playlist is here!

Thanks for reading <3

# Dog Years

Chapter Summary

The next full moon arrives.

CW: this chapter includes a description of a werewolf transformation. There are also references to sexual content.

Chapter Notes

Title is from Dog Years by Maggie Rogers

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora twitches, fingers tightening over Catra's back and knee knocking into her legs.

Catra ignores it.

A few seconds later, Adora shifts imperceptibly, trying to move her shoulder without moving her arms, and then stills.

Catra ignores it again.

A full minute goes by before Adora moves again, hips pulling away slightly and straining until a soft pop sounds in her back and Adora lets out a little sigh of relief.

Catra snorts, peeking one eye open. "Better?" she asks.

Adora looks up from where she's tucked into Catra's chest and winces. "Yeah, sorry."

Catra shakes her head, smoothing her hands over Adora's back and up her shoulders. "Is it time?" she asks, refusing to accept the

unnecessary apology.

Adora buries her face back against her and nuzzles in before letting out a soft groan of complaint. "No. The moon can fuck off."

Catra laughs as the words huff hot onto her skin, and she kisses the crown of Adora's head. "Sooner it starts, the sooner it's over," she offers.

Adora pulls her closer and peeks up again, her soft lips drawn down into a pout this time.

Catra scoots down so she can kiss her, light and sweet, and offers her a better deal. "The sooner it's over, the sooner you'll have lips to kiss me again."

Adora stretches to meet her again, more firmly but just as sweet, and gives in. "Fine," she grumbles as she rolls away and sits up. Her shoulders hunch as she sits and sighs; the pain must be spreading through her already.

Catra sits up behind her and edges the open sleeve of her muscle tee aside to kiss her shoulder. She can taste the change rising from within her, even through her skin, the power beginning to flood her body. Adora inclines her head towards her, and she slips another kiss onto her cheek, and then climbs off the bed and drags Adora with her.

"Come on, I don't need you tearing up my bed," she teases.

Adora meets her eyes with an arrogant grin as she follows her out of the room. "*You're* the one that ripped your sheets," she reminds her.

Catra narrows her eyes playfully – she loves that Adora loves that memory, and she loves it too. Still, she can't let her get *too* cocky about it, or she'll start a competition to see how many things she can get Catra to destroy as she pushes her over the edge.

This apartment will not survive that competition.

"And I don't need *you* ripping my mattress to shreds," she says politely, pulling Adora past her new bedroom door and into the living room. She checks that all the curtains are closed and then fixes Adora with a softer, more affectionate look. "Time to get ready?"

Adora frowns like she's going to protest, but then a shiver runs through her and she gives up the argument. "Yeah, it's time."

Catra offers her a soft smile and then sits on the edge of the couch, giving her room to prepare.

Adora returns the smile and starts undressing, pulling her sweatpants off and tossing them onto the couch next to Catra. She reaches for her shirt next and then pauses, catching Catra's eyes combing down the length of her legs appreciatively.

She's seen them many times over the last week and a half ~~-~~every single day that Adora's been over, in fact, but she hasn't been over every single day. She's gone home a few times, for clothes and family and to help others with their work, and she spent the last several days at the commune with the agreement that she would come for the full moon and then stay several days after that. They haven't talked more about either of them moving yet ~~-~~too big of a commitment to be nailed down so early ~~-~~but Catra's made it abundantly clear that she wants Adora around as much as possible, and Adora has yet to pass on anything but understanding around that idea from her pack.

She only arrived an hour or so ago today, making sure she let Catra sleep in before she arrived and disrupted her normal schedule, and as soon as Catra had opened the door, she'd dragged her off to bed to cuddle while she still had hands instead of paws.

Still, this isn't a sight she thinks she could ever get tired of.

A sly grin spreads over Adora's face, and she drops the hem of her shirt back down. "Enjoying the view?" she teases.

"Always," Catra says with conviction.

Adora's grin gets bigger, and she starts to play with her shirt, almost like she's doing a little dance. "Want a show?" she asks, wiggling her eyebrows up and down.

Catra returns the grin and leans back to settle into the couch before nodding. This is an offer she could never turn down. "Give me your best," she agrees, and that's exactly what she gets.

Adora begins to striptease, but in the *best* professional and *most* ridiculous sense of the word. She pulls her shirt up a little and then shoves it back down again to cover herself, making a scandalized expression. She starts to pull it up again and waggles her eyebrows some more, and it is so dorky and endearing that it's surpassed ridiculous and circled all the way back to sexy, and Catra doesn't know if she's ever been so in love with her.

She finally pulls it over her chest and then rips it the rest of the way off, swinging it above her head and whipping it right at Catra's face. Catra catches the shirt and makes a show of sniffing it all over, soaking in her scent, and Adora winks at her as she starts to play with the band of her sports bra. Catra can feel the grin on her face as she suppresses a laugh, equal parts genuinely affectionate and deliriously predatory, and she dumps the shirt next to her to lean forward and watch.

Adora moves slowly, teasing the underside of one tit and then the other, winking with alternating eyes at a quickening pace until she's basically just blinking. Right before she lifts it up, she whirls around coyly. She lifts it over her head, tangles it up in her arms, and then something cracks and she drops to her knees with a shout.

Catra's beside her before she's hit the ground, ripping the offending garment off and freeing her arms. She can smell the change in the

air, thick and crackling, and she cradles her to her chest.

"F Adora hisses, twisting to rest against Catra and suck in a deep breath. She tries to stretch her back out, but another wave of pain hits her, and she crumples with a whine.

"Maybe another time," Catra says sympathetically , helping her sit up and finish undressing before the change hits completely.

"B another time," Adora nods determinedly , catching one of Catra's hands and pressing a kiss to it before rolling onto all fours. Catra follows her and smooths her hands over her back, rubbing softly.

"Let it come," Catra says, remembering how much talking helped her last time. "Don't fight it. You know how to do it now, and I'm right here."

Adora nods, dropping her head and sucking down deep breaths. Catra continues soothing her with gentle touches and words, and then it arrives.

A growl rips from Adora's chest, immediately followed by a wave of cracks and pops that shudder through her body, and then her skin begins shifting. Fur sprouts from her shoulders and rolls like a slow wave over her body, her torso and limbs elongating and reforming themselves as it goes. Her body snaps as it always does, and the pain draws forth whimpers as it always does, but the transformation is moving through her with a purpose that it has not had before. Her arms and chest and back are nearly completely changed by the time the wave rolls to her hips, and as her bottom half begins to transform, her head turns too.

Her body is transforming with cohesion this time, an order of operations to the process that is vastly different from the chaos of her previous transformations. She is clearly still in pain, gritting her teeth and growling and whimpering as her body breaks and heals, and the sounds fill the apartment, but she never seems lost to it. She

never turns to Catra with fear in her eyes. She keeps her head down and her focus high, and it moves with the most ease and pace it ever has on a full moon.

Her body shudders, and she shakes it out, panting, and looks down at herself.

It's over.

She looks up at Catra, still petting her back, and her tail whips with a ferocity as it begins to wag. Catra smiles at her, which must be the confirmation she's been waiting for, because she launches herself at Catra.

She almost knocks her over, shoving her head into her chest and then wiggling the length of her body against her as her tail smacks Catra's side over and over again. Catra laughs and tries to corral her into a hug, but Adora just spins around and shoves against her again, too excited to be contained.

Catra waits until she slows down a bit and then wraps her arms around her in a trap, holding her close so she can scratch her shoulders and kiss her head and rub her ears. "That was *so* good," she croons, and Adora lets out a happy, warbling whine.

The growing ease of the full moon transformations means a growing awareness of Adora's human consciousness when she's a wolf, and Catra pulls back to find her eyes and figure out how much she can understand now.

Adora meets her gaze with a giant smile and a lolling tongue, still panting with excitement.

"How much do you understand me?" she asks.

Adora sneezes, staring at her with bright and focused blue eyes.

"That doesn't really tell me anything," she teases, fairly certain Adora is almost completely aware and in control.

With only a growl as a warning, Adora lunges forward, *head*, knocking Catra to the ground and licking a thick, warm, slobbery path up the side of her face.

Catra shrieks, shoving Adora off her, but Adora lunges again, licking her hands as she tries to push her away. Catra kicks out a foot instead, shoving her furry butt to the side, but Adora spins and licks her knee before she can pull it away. Adora pounces, and Catra grabs her, rolling and gently grappling with her until she gets both her hands around Adora's muzzle and can force it far enough away that her tongue can't poke out and reach any part of her again.

Adora pauses, head forced up at an odd angle in Catra's hands and eyes trained on her face. Catra stares back, keeping her fingers locked and narrowing her eyes.

"I was *going* to give you couch privileges," she threatens, the offer now rescinded with Adora's slobbery behavior.

Adora lets out the loudest whine she can in her position and pulls back, eyes turning tragic. She looks like Catra stepped on her paw and didn't apologize.

Catra lets go of her muzzle with a warning look and sits up to shrug. "That's what happens when you don't behave."

Adora answers her with a growling bark directly in her face, and then she circles around behind her and shoves her head between her shoulder blades.

"Ow!" Catra exaggerates, pushing Adora away and getting up.

Adora shoves into her calves and she moves away again, turning around to face her girlfriend-turned-wolf. She looks up at her with a confusing expression, what Catra can only assume might be

arrogance if she was a human, and then bows her head and shoves Catra's thighs.

Catra realizes what she's doing a split second before she hits the cushions, and she laughs as she falls onto the couch. Adora bounds up the moment she does, falling into her lap and smothering her there so she can't get up. She barks happily, and Catra wraps her arms around her neck, but her fingers bury into her fur and scratch her playfully.

"Asshole," she says, not a drop of malice in her voice.

Adora makes a howling noise that can only be described as an agreement and gives Catra's forearm a tiny, non-slobbery lick of affection.

Catra kisses the top of her head and settles them in for the night.

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Adora's change back is quick. It bursts from her chest like the change into did, but the wave rolls with more confidence and speed. It seems to hurt less, just a little, and Adora growls more than whines as it works its way through her. She leans into Catra's touch for affection more than support, and she even seems to respond back to some of her directions and praises as she goes.

When it's finally over, when her skin is her skin again, and she has hands and feet instead of paws, and hair instead of fur, she makes a noise of relief and falls gratefully into Catra's lap.

Catra pulls her close, fingers skimming soothing patterns over her sweaty skin, and she dips her head to press a kiss to the back of her shoulder. "Good girl," she whispers.

The loud, racing thump of Adora's heart that follows that praise is unmistakable, but when she rolls onto her back in Catra's lap to look up at her, her expression is fixed into a warning glare. Catra quirks a teasing eyebrow at her, daring her to say something, and after a long stare-off, Adora huffs.

She rolls again, this time tucking her face into Catra's stomach and curling around her. "Don't tease me," she pleads tiredly, her breath warm through Catra's shirt.

Catra laughs and reaches for her head, threading her fingers into her hair and scratching gently. "Fine, I'll save it for later," she promises.

Adora makes a pleased noise and nuzzles into her, pressing a kiss to her shirt in lieu of her skin.

Catra lets her lay there for a few more minutes until her breathing steadies and her heartbeat returns to its usual rhythm, and then she abandons her hair to touch her shoulder. "Come on, let's shower before you pass out for the day."

Adora stills, careful ears catching her specific wording and pulling back to peek up at her. One eyebrow rockets high on her forehead, and excitement glitters in her eyes. "*Us?* You mean both of us?" she asks, voice just slightly restrained from overflowing with hope.

Catra fights the blush that threatens to spill over her cheeks, trying to meet Adora's eyes with confidence. It was an idea she'd had a couple of days ago, an idea she was sure Adora would enjoy, but it wasn't something they'd discussed, so nerves racked her insides all the same. "*In* a shower," she clarifies, eyes narrowing gently. "You need to rest before I get you all riled up."

Adora grins, wide and bright and beautiful, and grabs the hand tickling her shoulder to kiss it warmly. "Too late," she jokes, before sitting up and pressing an equally warm and loving kiss to Catra's lips.

Catra chases her when she pulls away too soon, but Adora's tired limbs are eager as she stands up and grabs the hand she kissed to drag Catra toward the bathroom. A few excited giggles pass between them as they shove into the small room, and Catra steps forward to turn the water on. The shower is tight and really not intended for more than one person, and when the spray hits the narrow glass walls and begins to heat up, it becomes clear that this will definitely *not* be the most comfortable shower either of them has ever had.

Catra turns back to Adora, hoping she won't mind, and Adora heatedly kisses her concern away the second she's within reach. The only thing she pulls back for is to check that it's okay before she starts taking Catra's clothes off, and as soon as Catra grants her permission, Adora's lips return to soothing her worries.

They're a little slower than usual, still eager but almost sluggish. When Adora's fingers move clumsily as they drag Catra's shirt off, she realizes her body is likely not only exhausted, but also now unaccustomed to being human again after spending all night as a wolf.

But Adora seems delighted to be doing this, lips tugging into a smile as she kisses her, so Catra lets her take her time and just enjoys it. Her hands are soft and hungry, tracing the curves of her body as she rids it of her clothes. Catra doesn't think she will ever get tired of the achingly reverent way Adora touches her.

Once her clothes are gone, Catra pulls away to put her hair up so it doesn't get too wet. When she's done Adora wraps her arms around her and presses close to continue kissing her, her naked skin meeting hers and radiating warmth, and Catra starts walking them slowly back into the shower.

It's not the most graceful entrance, the door too narrow for the two of them to move through together, but Adora clings tight to her and refuses to let go until they both make it inside, and the spray of water hits them right in the face.

They both break apart with a laugh, jerking away, and Adora reaches over Catra's head to push the noze down and out of the way.

With that, they have more freedom to move, and Catra turns them until Adora is closest to the new stream of water. "Get wet," she instructs, reaching for the soap.

Adora snorts, and a few giggles escape her as she leans back into the water and lets it fall over her body. "Already am," she jokes, waiting for Catra to look back at her before skimming her eyes down Catra's body and wiggling her eyebrows.

Catra narrows her eyes as Adora runs her fingers through her hair, working the water into it and grinning her stupid grin, and she tries to be as discouraging as she can while they're both naked and wet and standing chest to chest. "We're going to sleep after this," she warns.

"Sure we are," Adora agrees, grin too wide, but Catra doesn't miss the way it falters as she suppresses a yawn.

Catra grins back, knowing she's won, and reaches up to pull Adora down to meet her. Her lips are warm and wet, droplets of water falling off her nose onto Catra's as she kisses her, and Adora's arms dampen Catra's still-dry back as they wind around her.

"We can do whatever you want when we wake up," Catra promises when she pulls away, and Adora nods happily.

They switch places, Catra stepping into the spray as Adora shuffles out of it, and Catra soaps up her hands and then works them over Adora's body. Adora's eyes leave hers to watch the water cascading down her body, flickering from one place to the next, and they hold her with the same fierce and tender amazement they did the first time she saw her naked (and all the times she's seen her since).

The dangerous and delicate bloom Catra once held with careful hands inside of her chest has burst into a rose bush in the last week

and a half, ever since Adora promised that she would stay and then did. She can feel it grow every single time Adora looks at her, every time she catches the open affection and reverence she holds her with and no longer tries to hide, and all of the vines tangle together inside of her and threaten to burst forth. She doesn't know where they'll go if they do, doesn't know how her body is containing all that has already grown, and she doesn't know how to express any of this to Adora.

But she thinks that sometimes when they kiss, she can taste the same roses on her lips.

Catra runs her hands up Adora's hard, muscled arms and then down her soft, weighty chest. She gathers more soap and spreads it across her thick abdomen, and steps closer to wrap around and reach her lower back. When she starts to move downward, Adora lifts a leg, trying to help her, and Catra swats at it. Adora's done enough tonight;it' s her turn to be pampered.

Catra bends, taking the soap with her, and flicks her eyes up to meet Adora's as she settles between her legs. She sees something flash in Adora's eyes ~~-m~~aybe excitement, maybe a warning ~~-a~~nd winks at her.

A protesting whine escapes Adora, and Catra laughs as she smells her arousal seep into her scent as it mixes with the soap and the steam and fills their space. She presses a promising kiss to her thigh before soaping it up, perhaps spending a little too long massaging her muscles, and she watches Adora try to decide if it's better to watch Catra touch her or not watch at all. She cleans her feet and then finally rises, giggling as Adora lets out a breath of relief. She tells her to spin, determined to turn her sweaty, aching body into a warm, soapy monster, and spends careful attention on her backside. Her tattoo has been finished, filled out and shaded and freshly healed after tonight's transformation, and Catra traces the lines gently with soap.

When she’s finally done, she surrenders the soap to Adora to clean her face herself, then lets her rinse it clean.

When she's done rinsing, Adora reaches for the shampoo bottle, but Catra catches her hand, and Adora quirks an eyebrow.

“You’re going to wash my hair, too?”

“Unless you don’t want me to,” Catra answers.

Adora hesitates, like it’s a trick question. “How are you going to reach?” she asks, and it’s not unkind, but it is teasing.

“You’re going to get on your knees for me,” Catra answers sweetly, and she watches victoriously as Adora’s eyes darken with obedient hunger.

But instead of dropping down, Adora steps forward, pressing against her and crowding her up to the glass wall. Catra feels it against her back, a sharp, surprising cold against the heat they’ve built up, and it only adds to the shiver of excitement that runs through her as Adora’s face bends to hers.

“We are doing this again,” she says, water dripping from her chin to Catra’s collarbone and cutting a teasing path down her chest, “when I have my energy back.” Her words are determined, dominant, but her voice gives her away as it wavers with desire, and her threat becomes a plea.

“Obviously,” Catra snaps, insecurity dissolved into arrogance.

Adora catches her in a kiss before she can say anything else, lips full of desire and promise and rose petals, and then shifts out of the stream of water and drops to her knees.

She presses an open-mouthed kiss below Catra’s belly button, tongue leaving a warm path that stokes the heat between her legs,

and then she makes a show of pulling back and taking in the wonderful view that her new height awards her.

Catra rolls her eyes, attempting to belay the lust growing inside her for a time when they can actually do something about it, and grabs the shampoo. She'd picked up some specifically for Adora's hair type a few months ago, in case she ever wanted to shower here, and it's been used several times since. She pours some out, and the moment she begins to work it into Adora's scalp, she gives up all pretense of teasing Catra and sinks into the feeling. Her eyes slip shut, her lips part in a sigh, and she leans heavily into Catra's touch.

Catra works slowly, savoring this rare moment of Adora letting her take care of her and doing everything she can to help encourage Adora to let her do this again another time. When she's worked all over her scalp and built up the lather as much as she can, she guides Adora back into the stream of water, rinsing it well. Adora peeks her eyes open after, expecting Catra to be done, but she can't help herself. She wants it to go on longer.

"One more," she whispers, and Adora's eyes slip peacefully closed once more. She repeats the process, working the shampoo into another gentle lather and memorizing every soft noise of relief that Adora mumbles. When she finally runs out of excuses to keep going, she turns to the conditioner, caring for Adora's long mane the best she can, and once that is exhausted, she finally relents.

Adora opens her eyes, smiling up at her the soft way she does when they wake up together, and she presses a tired, clumsy kiss to her hip. The gentle attention has only pushed her further towards sleep, and Catra can see that she's fading fast.

She pulls her up, grants her the kiss she asks for, and then steps back into the water stream. Adora looks interested, blinking like she's trying to wake up more, and reaches out.

"Can I do anything for you?" she asks, and her voice is heavy with fatigue.

Catra smiles and shakes her head, reaching for the soap and moving considerably faster on herself than she did on Adora. "Just watch me," she says.

"Always am," Adora mumbles, voice quiet and soft like she's uttering an oath, and Catra is overflowing.

She washes herself with Adora's gaze holding her, caressing her as tenderly as the water spilling over her body, and by the time she's done, she's flushed with much more than the temperature of the water.

She turns the water off and drags Adora from the shower, wrapping her in a towel first and then drying herself off. Adora moves slowly, half-awake at best, and Catra helps her after she's finished. Adora smiles in thanks and then gathers her towel back up around her shoulders, reaching out with the edges and then snatching Catra up and bundling her inside with her.

It doesn't work as well as she intended. Adora's body is already too big for the standard-sized towel, and the length of it is not nearly long enough to fully wrap around Catra as well, but it's clumsy and adorable, and the urge to pepper Adora's neck with kisses afterward is irresistible.

Adora hums and drops the towel altogether, gathering Catra up instead, and closes her eyes. "Can we sleep like this?"

Catra's not sure if Adora means naked or standing upright in the bathroom, but she's amused enough to find out that she simply agrees. Adora makes a delighted noise and pries her eyes open, looking for the door and then nodding.

Without warning, she snatches Catra up and shoulders the door open hard, clearly no lessons learned from the bedroom door incident. Catra wraps around her and looks behind her, not trusting Adora's sleepy, stumbling feet, but she manages to make it all the way into the bedroom and up to the bed without incident. She falls

into it as soon as she sees it, both of them bouncing lightly with the impact, and Catra helps her crawl up to the top and burrow under the covers.

She doesn't settle until Catra's tangled up with her, limbs too interwoven to tell whose is whose, and bodies pressed too closely to have any points of separation.

Catra pulls back slightly, mouth opening to tease Adora, but when she looks at her, she's already snoring.

Catra smiles and tucks in against her chest, a steady heartbeat drumming its promises over and over, and follows her off to sleep.

Chapter End Notes

I think my teeth rotted while I wrote this, it's so sweet. We're so close to the end y'all...see you next week :') <3333

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
Tumblr link (some stuff is here)

Fic playlist: playlist is here!

Thanks for reading <3

# I Want To Be With You

Chapter Summary

Adora attends family dinner.

Chapter Notes

Title is from I Want To Be With You by chloe moriondo.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora tightens her ponytail again, staring at herself in the mirror and ensuring everything is in place.

Her favorite shirt, the pink button-down with the patterned moons, is tucked securely into her nice pair of jeans. Her hair is perfect, her ponytail and gentle poof secure, and her face, body, and teeth are freshly cleaned. She's run out of things to check over, but she still lingers in the bathroom, staring herself down and trying to remember that this isn't an interrogation;it is just dinner .

Catra had invited her to family dinner at the estate. A family dinner would have been nerve-wracking already, but family dinner with her girlfriend's adoptive family, who also just happens to be the family in charge of the entire town and the people Adora will be working with in the future when she's She-Ra is so much worse.

Catra had assured her multiple times that it wasn't a big deal Glimmer already knew her , Angella already liked her, and Micah always loves everyone but it was a big deal to Adora. The last two weeks with Catra have felt like a dream, an impossible fantasy, and she is still waiting for the other shoe to drop. She is still waiting to fuck this up somehow, to do something to wreck this fantasy beyond repair, and for Catra to wake up and just leave her .

But every time Catra does wake up with her, she just pulls her closer and stays put.

It's confounding.

Adora sucks in a deep breath and straightens out her shirt again, and then nods to herself. If she can make it through tonight without fucking this up, then maybe she can start to believe that there is no other shoe dropping.

She turns to the door just as it creaks open, and Starla's head pops in.

"Are you *stil* in here?" she asks incredulously, looking Adora up and down. "It's been, like, twenty minutes."

"That's not that long," Adora defends, feeling her cheeks flush as she strides over and pulls the door open to move past her.

Starla snorts as she moves out of the way and turns to follow her. "I've never seen you take longer than five minutes to get ready," she accuses. "If you even *tak* the full five."

Adora rolls her eyes and turns towards her bunk to grab her shoes, only to find Frosta lounging on her bed.

"Can I have your bunk when you move in with your girlfriend?" she asks, fully unprompted.

Adora feels her face shift from a soft pink to a ripe scarlet, and she snatches her sneakers out from underneath the bed with a little more force than is necessary. "It's been two weeks, Frosta. I'm not *going out*."

"Why not?" Frosta shrugs, crossing her feet and getting more comfortable on Adora's mattress. "You're over there all the time."

Adora opens her mouth, but no sound comes out, her brain stumbling on how to explain to an eleven-year-old that even though

Adora is over there all time – even though she's brought over a bag of clothing and taken a few pieces of Catra's clothing back with her to nuzzle into on the nights they can't be together – actually moving in with her would be a completely inappropriate step to take at this point in their relationship.

"It's complicated," is what she lands on, because it is.

Adora has food at Catra's apartment now, fresh food in the fridge that will go bad if she doesn't go back and eat it, clothes waiting to be worn in the closet, and a heavy key to the front door in her pocket so she can get in when Catra's at work or asleep. She spends as much time as she can over there, straddling an awkward schedule as she tries to balance her time between Catra's waking hours and the pack's daylight ongoings, but things are still too new and precious to verbalize figuring out a way to do this permanently. They haven't said more about Adora actually moving in or Catra possibly moving closer to the commune since the afternoon that she fixed the door, and Adora is afraid too nervous that trying to figure out the details of their future will bring the other shoe she's been fearing raining down on them to bring it up herself.

But Catra invited her to family dinner, so that has to count for something in securing their future together.

"Are you guys in love?" Frosta asks.

Adora balks, dropping one of her shoes and looking at Frosta like she's out of her mind. Adora knows the honest answer – knows it in the beat of her heart and the thrum of her blood. But she also knows it's much too early to voice it, and she cannot imagine why Frosta would care to know this.

"Why do you want to know if we're in love?" she asks.

"You smell like her now," Frosta shrugs, looking at Adora like she's the one that's out of her mind. "People that are in love smell like each other."

A loud snort escapes Starla, still lingering behind Adora and watching this spectacle, and Adora's cheeks heat again, this time surpassing scarlet and turning to a violent purple.

Her mouth opens and then closes as she tries to come up with some sort of response to that, but when nothing comes, she gives up and plops onto the floor, putting her shoes on as quickly as she can.

Haughty pride and deep embarrassment swirl together in her chest, making it very difficult to determine how she actually feels about this insinuation. On the one hand, there's an undeniable delight in knowing that Catra's smell is sticking to her and that hers is sticking to Catra. It is a satisfying relief that they're still together even when they're apart. That they're still each other's even when they're alone.

On the other hand, Adora knows *exactly* why Catra's scent is so mixed up with hers, and while Frosta might not yet be old enough to know the most common reason why people that are in love smell like each other, Starla sure as hell does. The entire rest of the pack that's been smelling her every time she comes home does, and the teasing she's been enduring because of it is mortifying, even if it's nice to know that they're happy for her and not at all taking issue with who she's found that happiness with.

Frosta is still looking at her expectantly by the time she's finished tying her shoes, and she stands up and dusts herself off carefully.

"We like each other a lot, yes," she concedes, pointedly ignoring the second snort that falls from Starla's mouth. "You'll have to talk to Mara about the bunk."

She doesn't mention that there are plenty of *other* bunks to choose from if Mara decides she can move in, because she knows Mara will say no. Frosta's still too young, and Razz still needs a companion. And she knows Frosta will insist that she doesn't just want any bunk. She wants Adora's, which is equally annoying *and* flattering.

Frosta sits up and frowns, crossing her legs. "When is your girlfriend coming over? Can I meet her? Why does she smell so weird?"

Adora sighs. "She's a hybrid, so her scent is mixed, and I—I don't know."

Adora knows she's welcome to bring Catra over any time, but she's a little more than concerned about actually doing it. The pack was on their best behavior at the bar, but that was before they'd actually gotten together. If their teasing of Adora on her own now is any indication, they would be ruthless in Catra's presence.

So, she's been waiting until she's sure that Catra actually likes her enough to not be chased off by her rambunctious family to bring her around them again.

"I have to go," Adora apologizes before Frosta can get in any additional questions and reaches out to ruffle her hair. Frosta dodges it and smacks her hand away, annoyed, and Adora grins at her. "Be good," she warns.

Frosta rolls her eyes good-naturedly and lays back down, nestling into Adora's bed.

Adora rolls her eyes back and leaves the room, Starla following her to the stairs.

"You know she's been napping in your bed, right?" she asks, stopping at the top and quirking an eyebrow up.

Adora chuckles and nods. She'd smelled Frosta's scent lingering around her bunk and figured she was either hanging out there or stealing her clothes when she wasn't around. Or both. "I don't mind," she says honestly, pausing as well.

Starla shrugs and nods. "When are you going to bring Catra by, then?" she asks instead, eyes dancing with mischief.

Adora fixes her with a glare and takes a step down the staircase. "When you all promise me you'll behave if I do."

Starla *tsks,* shaking her head. "You want the impossible," she says, moving back toward the bedroom.

Adora offers a reasonable shrug, then waves goodbye to her and skips down the stairs. As soon as she steps off them to head to the door, multiple whistles carry over from the kitchen.

She stops, knowing she'll have to talk to them before she can get out of this house and on to dinner, and turns to follow the noises.

Huntara, Juliet, and Mara are sitting at the table, papers scattered around as if they were talking business before and then moved on to just hanging out without cleaning up. Huntara is tilting her chair back, arm extended over the empty chair beside her, and she's taking in Adora's outfit with far too much joy. Juliet is leaning forward, resting both arms against the table and grinning at her. Mara is sitting normally and observing her calmly, but Adora doesn't miss the smirk playing at one corner of her lips.

"Heading off to meet the family?" Huntara asks, waggling her eyebrows far more than is necessary.

Adora hits her with the best glare she can muster, knowing that every single person here knows exactly where she's going. "*Yes.*"

"You look nice," Juliet offers, nodding approvingly at her shirt.

"Yeah," Huntara agrees, sticking one of her thumbs up. She'd only given Adora a little bit of shit when she returned her once starchy and cleanly pressed shirt all wrinkled, but she'd been pleased to see there wasn't any blood on it.

Mara nods, offering her a genuinely kind smile.

"Thanks. Did you guys need something? I don't want to be late."

Huntara lets out a puff of air and sets her chair back onto the floor on all four legs, leaning forward with a wicked expression. "When is she coming over for family dinner here?" she demands.

Adora rolls her eyes to the sky. She would have snuck out the bathroom window if she'd known she was going to face all of this trying to leave. "We don't even *do* family dinner," she replies, and they don't. There are enough of them that they usually eat in shifts, whoever is hungry first cooking something up and sharing it with whoever else is home. It's rare that anyone ever eats alone, but it's even rarer that the entire pack sits down and eats together.

Huntara makes a face like she's offended. "That's because no one's bringing their girlfriends around!"

Adora holds her tongue from replying that that's because no one else *has* a girlfriend and frowns. "I need to leave."

Huntara frowns back at her, but Mara interjects before they can continue.

"Have fun, Adora," she says in a warm, gentle voice that matches her smile. "Send Angella and Micah my regards."

Adora nods dutifully, adding it to her mental checklist, and then turns to leave.

"*And*," Mara continues, catching her before she steps away.

Adora pauses and looks back at her.

"Bring Catra over some time," she requests, winking.

Adora shoots her an affectionate glower and then escapes from the house before anyone else can get the chance to stop her.

*

Catra waits for Adora outside, half because it's a nice night and half because she doesn't want to risk her running into anyone else inside the estate without her.

It would probably be fine, and everyone would certainly be kind to the future She-Ra. Still, only half the estate is actually up to date on their relationship status. The half that does know knows far too many embarrassing stories about Catra to be trusted alone with her new girlfriend.

Her *girlfriend*.

Catra doesn't know when the novelty of that phrase will wear off, but she kind of hopes it never does.

Her girlfriend's scent wafts over to her on the wind, and a couple of seconds later, she appears, far down at the end of the street. Adora immediately spots her, the only person standing outside the large house in the twilight, and Catra sees a big, stupid grin spread over her face.

She speeds up from a purposeful walk to a light jog, staring Catra down as she gets closer and closer, and Catra watches her the whole way. It's utterly ridiculous at first, way too much distance between them to warrant Adora *going* over, but the eagerness is brilliant on her face, and her muscles are flexing, and hey, who is Catra to not enjoy the show?

Adora slaps to a stop immediately in front of her, golden ponytail swinging and blue eyes electric. Her shirt is loud and ridiculous and looks stupidly good on her. She's beaming and breathless despite not breaking a sweat, and Catra already wants to jump her.

"Hey," Adora says, voice far too soft and joyful for someone who literally just saw her yesterday.

"Hey yourself," Catra teases, turning her face up towards her .

Adora's eyes skip faithfully to her lips and then back up again, but she doesn't lean down to meet her. She hesitates, eyes skipping down once more and lingering, but she still doesn't take what's hers.

"Uh," she mumbles, bright eyes darting towards the house and then back to her. "Can I "—

Catra rolls her eyes and reaches up before she can finish, wrapping a hand around the back of her neck and tugging her down to meet her. Adora comes without a fight, and when their lips touch, she sighs into her mouth and melts around her.

What was supposed to be one greeting kiss quickly fades into another and then another, and several minutes go by before they finally come up for air.

Catra grins, heart singing like she's flying, and slips her fingers into Adora's.

"Maybe no kissing right in front of my family ," she suggests, knowing that they obviously don't know yet how to kiss just once and be done, "but I don't care if anyone sees from afar ."

Adora nods, something excited and emotional dancing in the light of her eyes, and squeezes Catra' s hand.

Catra squeezes back and then drags her along to go inside.

The estate is huge and bustling, a meeting place for the council, an archive for the town, and a home for the chancellor's family and any guests they might entertain all rolled into one, but Catra's been roaming the place since she was ten and she knows exactly where to go to get to the dining room while seeing as few people as possible.

But, of course, that route takes them right past the library.

And, of course, it's right as they're passing the double doors that they fly open, and Scorpia comes tumbling out.

She almost barrels right into Adora, the three of them avoiding the collision by pure reaction, and Scorpia reaches out with her pincers in an immediate apology.

"Oh man, I'm so sorry! I wasn't looking where I was going. Are you okay? Wait — *Adora*!" she cuts off with an excited question. She looks Adora up and down and then notices Catra hovering behind her shoulder. Her eyes double in size, and she looks between the two of them, a grin slowly climbing over her cheeks, and Catra's heart knots.

She'd never found time to hang out with Scorpia since she'd dropped off her jacket, but she had called her at one point and confessed that she and Adora were friends and that she'd been helping her out on the full moons.

Scorpia, knowing how difficult and rare it was for Catra to make acquaintances, much less *friends* she wanted to *spoil*, had been exactly as over-the-top about it as Catra had expected. She hadn't had time to call her in the last two weeks to update her about how things had escalated, with Adora consuming all of her free time, but now it was clear she wouldn't need to. The wolf was out of the bag.

"Hey , Scorpia," Catra interjects before Scorpia can take control of the conversation.

"*Gosh* , hi Catra!" she gushes, her eyes practically shining with excitement as they continue to dart between the two of them.

"Hi, Scorpia," Adora chimes in, clearly a little confused but no less friendly because of it.

"*Eep*" Scorpia breathes carefully, like she'll break something if she says it too loud.

Catra watches another flicker of strange confusion fall over Adora's face and sighs, realizing the best way out is through.

"We're, uh," Catra winces but forces herself to continue. Scorpia deserves to know, and Adora deserves to hear Catra tell her. "We're on our way to family dinner."

For as overwhelming and clueless as Scorpia can sometimes be, she deserves a lot more credit than Catra gives her. There are many times when she understands what isn't being said—what Catra can't bring herself to say—and she's always delighted to hear what she can manage and then piece together what she can't. Scorpia's known her long enough, befriending her as a teenager when she first started studying in the town's archives, that she knows *exactly* what family dinner is and what bringing Adora along must mean.

Maybe she knows it a little *too* well, because her eyes actually brim with tears, and she surges forward to scoop them both into a bone-crushing hug. It's impressive that she can even wrap her arms around Adora's frame, much less squish Catra into her hold as well, but she manages to do both. She blubbers something unintelligible at them, and Catra reaches her tail up, the only free part of her, to brush against Scorpia's leg in what she hopes is a soothing manner.

She hangs onto them for nearly a full minute. Catra searches for Adora's eyes to send her an apologetic glance, but when she finally finds her, Adora's cheeks are blushing a deep pink, and she looks far more happy than embarrassed or annoyed.

Scorpia finally pulls back and sets a pincer on top of either of their shoulders, looking at them with shining eyes. "I'm so happy for you guys," she whispers, and the genuine emotion in her voice digs into Catra until her own tears are threatening.

Catra scoffs to cover it up, blinking rapidly and attempting to roll her eyes. She plays it off until her voice feels steady enough, and then she says, "Thanks, Scorp."

Scorpia's mouth opens to certainly say something else emotive and even more embarrassing, but the library doors swing open once more and cut her off before she can.

A tall man in a cropped white oxford shirt emerges from them with a stack of books in his arms, and he stops short when he sees all of them gathered just outside the doors. The three of them turn to him, and his eyes skip between each of them, a hesitant but amused smile spreading over his face. "Are you guys throwing a hallway party without inviting me?" he teases.

"Hey , Bow," Catra rolls her eyes again, smiling back at her sister 's long-term crush. "How go the studies?"

"Studious. How goes the bar?"

"Boring."

Scorpia watches their exchange with a tight and overeager smile – her expression when she's desperately trying to keep her mouth shut over something she's excited about.

Bow turns to Adora politely and shuffles his books around so he can reach a hand out. "I'm Bow ," he of fers with a smile.

"Adora," she returns, engulfing his hand with hers and giving it a firm shake.

"Adora!" he exclaims with excited recognition, and Adora nods tentatively.

Catra cuts a look at Scorpia and finds her wincing with guilt. Of *course* she told Bow about Adora.

"I work in the archives with Scorpia," Bow of fers in explanation. "She told me about you."

Adora nods, but Catra can see that there's a sliver of nervousness to it. "All good things, I hope," she jokes.

"Oh, *h* Great things!" Bow nods, throwing a hand up in reassurance. "She said that "—

"W e're going to family dinner," Catra cuts in, desperate to stop Bow before he recites whatever embarrassing thing Scorpia told him that Catra had told her about Adora. Catra's known Bow about as long as she has Scorpia, and while they're not exactly friends, Bow definitely knows what a big deal it is for Catra to let anyone new into her life, and he is just as much of a sucker as Scorpia. She' s sure that he ate up whatever Scorpia blabbed about with lots of excitement.

While her intrusion provides the interruption she hoped for, it also makes Bow's eyes double in size and form the same heart-shaped sparkles that Scorpia's are reflecting. *Fi* he echoes, and she can see where this is going.

*"Y p,"* Catra says shortly, stepping up and grabbing Adora's hand as her patience finally runs out. "And we're running late. So. W e need to go. Bye, guys!"

Scorpia and Bow both excitedly grin at them, stepping off to the side to let them pass. Catra offers them a quick smile and drags Adora onward, not stopping as her girlfriend twists away to call out a more polite goodbye.

Adora willingly follows her away from the library and down the next hall, and only once they're at a safe distance does Catra slow her pace and loosen her grip on Adora's palm.

"Sorry about that," Catra bristles, trying to focus on the weight of Adora's fingers between hers to calm down. She thought Adora would like seeing her tell people, knowing that Catra wants them to know, but what if it was too much?

Adora squeezes her hand, and it helps. "Don't be, it was "—

Adora's voice cuts off as an all-too-familiar shimmery popping noise echoes through the hall, and one very annoying little sister appears

in front of them.

"You're running late," Glimmer starts, crossing her arms over her chest and fixing Catra with a haughty look.

"Sorry," Adora starts, "that's my fault—"

"So are *you*," Catra cuts her girlfriend's apology off, shooting a glare at her sister. This is the last thing she needs.

"No, I was on time, and mom sent me to go find you."

"We got held up at the library," Catra grumbles.

"I know," Glimmer retorts and then cringes.

Catra narrows her eyes. "And you waited to pop in and be annoying until we left the library?" Normally Glimmer would take any opportunity to jump into a situation that involved embarrassing Catra.

"No," Glimmer obviously lies, and it gives her away.

"Were you *waiting* for Bow?" Catra asks outrageously.

"No!" Glimmer lies even louder.

She's been dancing around asking Bow out for years—she knows she's more than welcome to bring him to family dinner as well, but she hasn't because she claims she *doesn't want to help*. Catra's been telling her that *not* asking him out *is* ruining their friendship, and every time she sees them interact nowadays (or *avoid* interacting), she's proven right.

"You have a *problem*," Catra accuses.

Glimmer narrows her eyes. "Mom and Dad are waiting for us."

"Then get out of the way," Catra snips.

Glimmer sticks out her tongue, but she moves aside, falling into step with Catra as she pulls Adora along beside her. Adora trots along obediently, watching the two of them curiously but not attempting to break the silence that falls over them.

Glimmer watches them as well, her eyes darting from one to the other and then back again. The stress knotting in Catra's chest had returned with Glimmer's appearance, and it continues to grow steadily with each step they take under Glimmer's watchful eye. Catra cuts her a glare, and she cuts one back, but when Catra turns away again, Glimmer leans in and looks at her profile carefully.

*"Hey!"* Catra snaps, whipping her head towards Glimmer and startling her.

Glimmer recovers quickly, and her expression is wicked. "Are you *into* her?" she asks with absolutely no prelude.

"Glimmer!" Catra responds, shock overtaking her before she can even think of a proper response. She feels Adora turn to look at her as well, and heat crawls up her neck.

"*Oh my god*, you are!" Glimmer exclaims, wide eyes flashing to Adora and then back again. "Does mom know?"

*"Shut up!"* Catra shouts, her entire body flooding with embarrassment. She can feel Adora hovering behind her, their secret that doesn't need to be a secret at all but *is* one anyway now spilled across the floor in front of them, and she is *going* to commit a murder.

"Holy shit," Glimmer laughs, completely unafraid of Catra's anger. Her eyes flicker up to Adora over Catra's shoulder, and her mouth tilts up in a happy, almost sweet smile. "Aw, Catra. You really do like her."

Catra's pretty sure that if she could spontaneously combust into flames from humiliation, she would. She's never hated Glimmer

more than she does right now.

Of *one* Adora knows that she likes her ~~she~~ she was knuckle deep inside of her just yesterday ~~but~~ but exchanging affections in the sweet peace of their alone time and having her little sister screech it down the halls of her parent's home were two very different experiences.

"If you don't stop talking," she starts, feeling Adora's presence behind her like a weight on her chest, "I'm going to tell Bow that you like him."

Glimmer gasps dramatically, her soft smile wiping off her face and getting replaced with a sour glower. "You wouldn't."

"I *will* if you don't shut the fuck up," Catra offers.

"What? Scared your girlfriend will know that you like her?" Glimmer looks over Catra's shoulder and winks.

"That's it, I'm telling him!" Catra insists, turning on her heel and starting back towards the library.

"No!" Glimmer yells, reaching out to grab a fistful of the back of Catra's shirt and part of Adora's arm and teleporting them out of the hall. They pop back into existence just outside the dining room, and Catra swivels back around with a threatening look.

Glimmer releases her hold on both of them and glares back before turning around and swinging the doors to the dining room wide, finishing their argument with a finality.

Catra peeks at Adora for the first time since Glimmer appeared, stomach twisting at how she may have taken Glimmer's horrifying shenanigans, but her worry is all for naught. An affectionately arrogant smile is blazing over Adora's face, and her eyes are so filled with happy emotion that they actually look a little teary.

Adora steps closer as Glimmer leaves, and they hesitate on the threshold, and she drops her voice low so no one else will overhear them. "*You don*

Teasing is woven through all of the words, but there's a weight to them as well that comes from knowing that Catra's letting everyone else know how she feels and that she isn't trying to deny it.

"That's *so* embarrassing for you," Adora finishes, her smile twisting into a manic smirk, and Catra wishes desperately that they were alone, so she could make her eat her words and then show her *exactly* how much she likes her.

Maybe even how much she loves her.

But she can't do that here.

So she settles on shoving her instead, knocking her backward with a well-placed shoulder and a sharp grin. "It's even more embarrassing that you like me back, asshole," she quips.

Adora's expression fills with an affection that sends Catra's heart racing, and the only thing that keeps her from saying fuck it and pressing her up against the wall anyway is the voice that rings out and interrupts them.

"*Catra*! And Adora, finally!"

Micah emerges from the dining room with a bright smile and wide arms, and he grasps Adora's hand the second she presents it to him.

"It's SO wonderful to meet you," he emphasizes, looking up at her and shaking her hand vigorously.

Adora chuckles and tightens her hand to shake back, and Catra barely contains herself from yet another eye roll at the over-exaggerated expression Micah makes at feeling Adora's strength.

“*Wow*, what are they feeding you kids over in the pack?” he jokes and then releases her hand to reach over and give Catra a one-armed hug.

She obliges and watches Adora’s eyes soften a little as she jokes back, “Lots of protein shakes, sir.”

Micah smiles and ushers the two of them into the dining room, shaking his head just slightly. “Please, just Micah.”

Adora nods, but before she can say anything else, the doors are closing behind them, and Angella is standing up from her seat at the table.

The dining room is far too big for their small family, meant for entertaining guests or carrying on meetings throughout mealtimes, and Catra guides Adora past the empty majority of the table over to the corner that they are all situated around. Micah resumes his position behind a chair, and Catra sees that they’ve rearranged for the evening, fitting Adora’s spot beside her so she isn’t forced to be the odd one out on the end.

A small lump makes its home in the back of Catra’s throat, and she chokes it down.

“Adora,” Angella greets civilly, “lovely to see you again.”

Adora pauses to bow her head. “Chancellor,” she greets.

“Where was *my* fancy greeting?” Glimmer mutters under her breath, only loud enough for Catra and Adora to pick up.

Angella scoffs loudly. “Please, Adora, this isn’t a council meeting. Angella is just fine.”

“Right,” she nods, “sorry. Angella. Mara sends her regards to you both,” Adora motions to Micah as well.

"But not to me?" Glimmer remarks quietly yet again, and Catra turns on her with a glare.

"Shut up," she groans.

"Glimmer," Angella cuts in, more than used to Glimmer keeping her smart remarks at a level only audible to her sister. "Please. We have a guest."

Catra can tell that Glimmer is just barely containing herself from making another annoying remark, so she cuts her a superior expression and then turns to catch Adora's eye.

She still looks nervous, scared to make the wrong move, but Catra can tell that her and Glimmer's easy cadence is helping her relax. It probably reminds her of her own faux siblings, if the way her packmates acted at the new moon ceremony is anything to go on.

She offers Adora a soft smile, and Adora returns it immediately, a tiny bit of tension slipping out of her shoulders.

"Thank you, Adora," Angella returns, and then she motions for everyone to be seated.

As soon as they settle in, Micah starts with the questions, asking about what Adora's going to do with her life as if it isn't already decided and checking in on the new wolves. Catra can hear an overwhelmed edge in Adora's voice as she starts to answer them, but she also seems happy to be asked ~~-d~~determined to answer them correctly.

And she does, because with Micah, there are no wrong answers, and there's no end goal except getting to know her and making her feel like part of the family.

Because she already is.

Because Catra chose her.

Adora's hand is out of reach, so Catra flicks her tail over, skimming the top of Adora's leg and catching her attention. Adora drops a hand to her lap to twist her fingers around the soft fur in a familiar pattern that warms Catra from the inside out, and she glances over.

Catra can see the concern in her eyes worry about doing well here, and Catra nods. She's doing brilliantly, and even if she wasn't, it wouldn't matter.

It doesn't matter how many smart remarks Glimmer throws at them, or how awkward her friends are in finding out that they got together. It doesn't matter if her faux-mother is too formal and her faux-father is too casual. It doesn't matter if Adora answers every single qestion they ask right or wrong, because Catra' s already made up her mind.

Her heart already belongs to her.

Adora catches her nod, and a gentle, relieved smile crawls up her face. Her eyes shine with something deep and raw, and her thumb rubs over the tip of Catra's tail absently.

She feels the caress in her bones, and she thinks that she knows what it means. She thinks Adora must know how she feels, must know that she's family, must know what she's trying to say. And she thinks Adora must be saying the same.

Adora's heart belongs to her, too.

Chapter End Notes

Holy shit. I can't believe this is the last chapter. Thank you all so much for the ridiculous amount of love and support you've shown this story and myself. It means the world and all of your sweet comments and re-reads and tweets made it so easy for me to stay in love with this story and give it the attention it

deserves. I'm in disbelief and dismay that it's over nowbut I am delighted to say that it's not *by* over.

I'll be doing a series of extras for this universe -deleted scenes, future scenes, etc., all the scenes I have in my head that didn't fit into this main story. They won't be published on any sort of schedule, but will continue to be written indefinitely on the side while I work on other things!I have lots of ideas I'm really excited to write out, and some already written that will arrive after me and my beta take a well-deserved break. Most of the ideas are smut but a few aren't, so if there's anything you'd love to read from this universe, please let me know in the comments!If anything sparks my muse, I'll add it to the list.

Make sure you subscribe or bookmark the series this fic is now in so that you don't miss out when I publish an extra!

Thank you all so much for reading <3333

Fic Art: Twitter link (most everything is here)
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